

The Roman Empire of Ammianus



John Matthews

The Roman Empire of Ammianus

John Matthews

Son of a Greek nobleman, Ammianus Marcellinus (c. AD 330 – after AD 391) fought in the Roman army and wrote a history of the later empire which ranks among the works of the greatest classical historians. From a lifetime's experience and extensive travel throughout the Roman world, Ammianus wrote vividly of an empire of wonderful richness and diversity. Now, in the first comprehensive assessment of Ammianus to appear in more than four decades, John Matthews examines the historian's work against the background of his contemporary world.

Beginning with a survey of Roman history as Ammianus himself saw and experienced it, Dr Matthews describes an empire where Germans ruled in the army's high command, bishops exerted growing influence in the cities, and eunuchs held political office. He follows Ammianus's accounts of battles and sieges, of conspiracies and civil wars. He examines the historian's vivid character studies and moral judgments, his social satire and learned digressions. And he explores a range of topics for which Ammianus is a chief source: the office of emperor and his functions in government and war, Roman social relations, and contemporary views on religion. A concluding chapter addresses historiographical questions regarding the composition, structure, and cultural identity of the historian's work.

continued on back flap



Digitized by the Internet Archive
in 2022 with funding from
Kahle/Austin Foundation

The Roman Empire of Ammianus

The Roman Empire of Ammianus

John Matthews

DG
316.7
.M38
1989

The Johns Hopkins University Press

KBS Baltimore

First published in 1989 by
The Johns Hopkins University Press
701 West 40th Street
Baltimore, Maryland 21211

© 1989 by John Matthews

All rights reserved. No part of this publication
may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or
transmitted, in any form or by any means, electronic,
mechanical, photocopying, recording or otherwise,
without the prior permission of the publisher.

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Matthews, John, 1940—

The Roman empire of Ammianus / John Matthews.

p. cm.

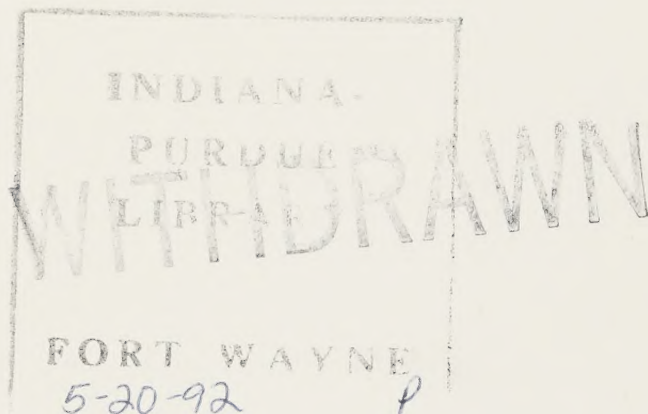
ISBN 0-8018-3965-3

1. Ammianus Marcellinus. *Rerum gestarum libri*. 2. Rome—History—
Empire, 284-476. I. Title

DG316.7.M38 1989

937'.08—dc20

89-45756
CIP



Printed in Great Britain

6-10-92

Contents

Preface	ix
List of illustrations	xiv

Part One. Res Gestae

I	Introduction	3
II	Ammianus and his History	8
	(1) The political setting	8
	(2) Composition	17
III	Ammianus and Constantius: Civil Dissension and Foreign War	33
IV	North-East Frontier	48
	(1) The satrapy of Corduene	48
	(2) The siege of Amida	57
V	The Young Ammianus: Social and Cultural Setting	67
VI	The Rise of Julian	81
VII	Julian and the Philosophers	115
VIII	The Invasion of Persia	130
	(1) Historical perspectives	130
	(2) Historical geography	140
	(3) Ammianus and other sources	161
IX	Legitimacy and Usurpation: Jovian to Procopius	180
X	Valentinian and Valens: Sex, Magic and Treason	204

Part Two. Visa vel Lecta

XI	The Office of Emperor	231
XII	The Character of Government	253

XIII	The Practice of War	279
XIV	Barbarians and Bandits	304
	(1) Farmers: Alamanni and Goths	306
	(2) Nomads: Huns and Saracens	332
	(3) Rebels: Isaurians and Moors	355
	(4) Conclusion: Ammianus and his sources	376
XV	The Physical Environment: Town and Country	383
XVI	Social Relations	404
XVII	Religion and Philosophy	424
	(1) Divination and <i>daimones</i>	424
	(2) Christianity in Ammianus	435
XVIII	The Roman and the Greek	452
	Notes	473
	Bibliography	554
	Index	572

To my friends

Think, when we talk of horses, that you see them
Printing their proud hoofs i' th' receiving earth;
For 'tis your thoughts that now must deck our kings,
Carry them here and there, jumping o'er times
Turning th' accomplishment of many years
Into an hour-glass; for the which supply,
Admit me Chorus to this history....

Shakespeare, *Henry V*

If personality is an unbroken series of successful gestures....

Scott Fitzgerald, *The Great Gatsby*

To most of us the movements of the soul are so mysterious that
we seize upon events to make them explicable.

William Cooper, *Scenes from Provincial Life*

Preface

It is twenty-five years, almost to the day, since, at the very beginning of my career as a graduate student of late Roman history, I first began to read Ammianus Marcellinus: a space of time that already reaches more than half-way back to the publication in 1947 of Edward Thompson's pioneering book, *The Historical Work of Ammianus Marcellinus*. To the insight and sturdy vigour of this book, and to the attentive reading of Ammianus that it inspired, I and others owed our realisation that, in some of the best and most rigorous undergraduate courses in Classical history and civilisation available anywhere in the world (I am not thinking only of Oxford), we had failed completely to make the acquaintance of one of the greatest of Classical historians. It is a realisation that has remained with me. To this day I recall the sense, visible in the expressions of those to whom I declared my interest, that this was an author of eccentric taste, dubious style and outlandish appeal, of whom they had heard but whom they were not themselves expected to read. This being so, and considering Thompson's then very critical opinion of Ammianus' style, it was a surprise to find quoted with approval, in the preface to the third and final volume of J. C. Rolfe's Loeb edition of Ammianus (despite its faults, another original and far-reaching influence), Ernest Stein's judgment of the historian as the greatest literary genius the world had seen between Tacitus and Dante, unmatched among historians in his power to move the reader's heart. Such a leave-taking was a clear advance upon that of Gibbon, whose better-known regret at parting from his 'accurate and faithful guide' was tempered, if that is the word, by distaste for 'the vices of his style, the disorder and perplexity of his narrative' and, in another passage, for 'his love of ambitious ornaments [that] frequently betrayed him into an unnatural vehemence of expression'. Still more remarkably, it appeared that Stein had declared Ammianus to be as a historian, in his greater objectivity and wider horizons, the superior of Tacitus himself. This was a substantial claim, for had not Gibbon described Tacitus as the greatest of philosophic historians, whose writings would instruct the last generations of mankind? And then there was Otto Seeck, who in a standard reference article set against Ammianus' admitted shortcomings an unrivalled ability to portray human character that set him in the front rank of historians of any age.

Whatever one made of these opinions (and they should give pause to think), it was obvious that, on the most practical level, here was a source for late Roman history that, to one undertaking research after study of

the great Classical historians, seemed, as he still seems after twenty-five years, the best possible introduction to a new age. After the relative tidiness of the early Principate, what was remarkable about the late empire was its wonderful richness and diversity, and its refusal, based on a massive and varied documentation to which the careless schematism of some modern literature seemed totally antipathetic, to be readily categorised. Here was a writer prepared to make sense of this age in the relatively familiar terms of the Classical historian, with the repertoire one was used to – high politics, conspiracies and civil war, battles and sieges, social satire and moral judgments, learned digressions, vivid portrayals of character, a multiplicity of names and places – together with much that one was not – eunuchs in politics, Germans in the high command, bishops in the cities, frank despotism and religious bigotry. Criticise as one may Ammianus' opinions and choice of emphasis, it is hard to imagine a writer more responsive to the issues and personalities of his time, and hard to think of a topic on which, however peripheral to his own preoccupations, he does not make some contribution to our understanding.

Much has happened in twenty-five years, and it is now possible to say that Ammianus is merely a relatively, rather than an almost totally, neglected author. The annual survey of published literature compiled in *L'Année Philologique* still registers, in the six issues from 1981 to 1986, over three times as many titles on Tacitus as on Ammianus Marcellinus, whose own near-parity with Sallust must be set against the fact that his surviving text is more than three times as long as that of his Republican predecessor. Yet it would be misleading for a modern preface simply to echo the pessimism of Thompson, who in 1947 thought that it would be no exaggeration to say that for every reader of Ammianus there would be a thousand readers of Sallust, Livy or Tacitus. Thompson's then justified complaint about the absence of good editions and commentaries of Ammianus is happily becoming superseded, at the same time as it is coming to be understood that adverse reaction to Ammianus' style has more to do with the adoption of unsuitable criteria than with any true perception of the literary art in decline. The last generation of international scholarship has produced a wealth of articles and monographs on selected aspects of Ammianus' work, particularly historiographical and concerned with Ammianus' attitudes and his literary procedures: an impression will be gained from the Bibliography at the end of this book. Much of this literature is very good; I have learned a great deal from it, and tried my best to do it justice. Yet there exists no general account of Ammianus that attempts to respond both to his qualities as a historical writer and to the sheer range of subject-matter actually encompassed by his text. This book is therefore an attempt to represent to a modern – I hope, not entirely specialist – readership the qualities of Ammianus as a historian of his own age (what he wrote about earlier ages is unfortunately lost). In doing so, I admit to the shortcomings inherent in my lack of 'inside knowledge' of some of the

subjects I have touched. I have in these cases made an honest attempt to master and to present fairly the relevant literature. If in the process I have sometimes achieved a tone of contrived erudition rather than true understanding – I hope on occasion to have approached the latter – then I may at least claim that this is also true of Ammianus himself.

The book is much longer than I intended when I began. Much of the expansion has taken place during my last few years of work, as the sheer volume of acquisition, and my enjoyment of the subject, overwhelmed the elegant, slim volume I originally planned. I am confident however that I have not overwhelmed my subject, and I am far from having said the final word. Nor would I wish to: I hope above all that my book will serve not to inhibit but to enlarge discussion of Ammianus and the late empire, and that it will encourage a wider appreciation of one of the most splendid monuments of ancient literature. There is less excuse for ignorance of Ammianus than there used to be, with the appearance in 1986 of a fine Penguin translation, by the late Walter Hamilton, of the greater part of his text.

The structure of my book reflects the two elements in the title. In Part One, 'Res Gestae', Ammianus' work and career are combined in a survey of the history of his time as he saw and experienced it, narrative chapter alternating with excursus in a manner intended to reflect his own. In this earlier part of the book, Ammianus figures prominently, as participant in and observer of events. His personal role diminishes after this early phase of intensive involvement, and the last two chapters of Part One (IX and X) follow the history to its conclusion in 378 with only the most intermittent participation from the historian. Although they are intelligible in their own right, the reader will understand these chapters better (and appreciate how derivative they are) if he also equips himself with a text or translation of Ammianus. Part Two, 'Visa vel Lecta' (cf. Amm. 22.8.1), consists of a series of descriptions of a range of topics for which Ammianus is a chief source, and on which his views are of interest. These chapters are arranged in groups, connected thematically or in sequence: XI–XIII present the office of emperor and his functions in government and war, the last of these leading (in XIV) to a description, considerably enlarging on the text of Ammianus, of the main foreign, and some internal, enemies of the Roman order. From here Chapter XV, on town and country, leads to XVI, on social relations in Ammianus, and this in turn to a discussion of the historian's attitude to matters of religion. These two chapters draw the attention progressively back to Ammianus himself, in a fashion that begins to mirror on an intellectual plane the more circumstantial emphasis on the historian in the earlier chapters of Part One, and the concluding chapter (XVIII) recapitulates and addresses in a more fully developed historiographical dimension questions of the composition, structure and cultural identity of the history that are raised in formal terms at the beginning of the book (II).

Each chapter can, I believe, be read independently, though better in the context of the book as whole, or at least of its immediate neighbours.

Essential references to Ammianus himself, and to some other named sources under discussion, are given in a standard form in the text of the book. More elaborate references, and all supporting argumentation, are presented in the notes. These are placed at the end of the book, in the belief, supported by enquiry, that non-specialist readers of books by Classical historians often find extensive notes at the foot of each page an impediment to the continuous reading of the text that I wish to encourage. (My original intention, to reduce the notes to the barest and most essential minimum, I abandoned as impracticable, unhelpful, and unjust to the modern literature that I had read.) This arrangement has also allowed me to write some more extensive notes and bibliographical essays, rather in the nature of small appendices, of a length that would be obtrusive if they were to compete with my main text for room on the page.

Beyond this explanation of its structure, my book must speak for itself, but I cannot end without a few words of thanks, formally expressed but with real warmth, to the friends and colleagues who have given me so much advice, help and encouragement. Substantial parts of the book were read at various stages, and with great benefit from their comments, by Jill Harries, Peter Heather, David Hunt, Benjamin Isaac, Myfanwy Lloyd-Jones and David Potter. I have also been helped on many points of understanding by Miguel Alonso Núñez, Norman Austin, Sam Barnish, Glen Bowersock, David Braund, Sebastian Brock, Averil Cameron, John Casey, Helena Cichocka, Brian Croke, Alanna Emmett Nobbs, Jacques Fontaine, David Graf, Alan Hall, John Hind, Christopher Kelly, Cathy King, Doug Lee, Wolf Liebeschuetz, Sam Lieu, Christopher Lightfoot, Neil McLynn, Fergus Millar, Dominic Rathbone, Judith Rice, Geoffrey de Ste Croix, Sacha Stern, Sir Ronald Syme, Roger Tomlin, Michael and Mary Whitby, Tony Woodman. Many of these and other scholars, notably Antonio Baldini, Timothy Barnes, Philip Bartholomew, J. den Boeft, Rita Cappelletto, André Chastagnol, Yves-Marie Duval, Garth Fowden, Frank Gilliam, Raban von Haehling, D. den Hengst, Ramsay MacMullen, David Mattingly, Valerio Neri, James O'Donnell, Edgar Pack, François Paschoud, Guy Sabbah, Robin Seager, Anne Sheppard, Joachim Szidat, Hans Teitler and Andrew Wallace-Hadrill, have generously sent me copies of their published work on Ammianus and related topics. I particularly thank Siegbert Prawer for a breadth of enthusiasm in the pursuit of scholarship that invigorates all whom it touches, and for his interest in my work on Ammianus; and my wife and daughters, Elaine, Helen and Julia, for their patience and humour when I have from time to time disappeared altogether, so it must have seemed, into the world of the fourth century.

I owe a constant debt to the great academic institutions in which I have been lucky enough to work, and to the scholars and administrators who give them life: particularly to my colleagues at the Queen's College, Oxford, to the Institute for Advanced Study at Princeton, and to the many friends I made there and at the Department of History, Philosophy and Politics at Macquarie University, New South Wales, in 1980 and 1981;

and to the Librarian and staff of the Ashmolean Library at Oxford. Thinking especially of the academic and personal adversities faced in the present climate by colleagues in less fortunate and more vulnerable University departments than my own, I have appreciated, and never taken for granted, the ease with which I have been able to seek advice, the encouragement that comes from the ready presence of sympathetic colleagues and the sense, which is essential to the pursuit of serious academic interest in any area, that one's work has its place and is respected; not to mention the facility with which, in the Ashmolean and Bodleian Libraries, I have been able to consult almost every book or article that I could reasonably consider necessary: very few trails indeed have had to be abandoned without a result. I have gained tremendous enjoyment and benefit over the years from the late Roman graduate seminars that are now an established part of the Oxford scene in ancient history, and also from my undergraduate pupils, from Queen's and many other colleges, whose lively minds have provided me with constant challenges, and with the assurance that, if history is not communication, it is nothing.

I am grateful to Colin Haycraft, who encouraged me to write a slim book, waited patiently and after many years cheerfully accepted a fat one; to Deborah Blake for seeing it through to publication; and to Pat Lloyd for receiving without visible impatience the constant, restless and no doubt often pointless revisions that have been involved in its development, and returning them to me in beautiful, clean drafts which I could revise all over again. And to the Oxford historians in whose company I have worked, Sir Ronald Syme and Fergus Millar, my thanks for long friendship, for all that I have learned from their work and example, and for their sustained conviction of the truth and validity of the historian's profession. That conviction I share with them, and all of us with Ammianus. It is far from obvious to me that a civilised society can do without it.

Oxford
1 October 1988

J. F. M.

Illustrations

Maps

1. The Roman East	42
2. The city of Antioch	73
3. Julian in Gaul, 356–60	82
4. Seleucia and Ctesiphon	142
5. Julian in Mesopotamia	150
6. The territory of the Alamanni	307
7. Gothia and the Roman Danube	319
8. Isauria and its neighbours	356

Figures

1. The Emperor Constantius	232
2. The Face of Battle (1)	289
3. The Face of Battle (2)	292
4. Herding and hunting in southern Russia	338–9

Chart

The rise of Julian, 359–62	102–3
----------------------------	-------

Part One

Res Gestae

CHAPTER I

Introduction

I went and came, my brethren, to the bier of the defiled one
and I stood over it and I derided his paganism.
I said, Is this he who exalted himself
against the living name and forgot that he is dust?

For a time in the high summer of 363 a Christian priest, Ephraim of Nisibis, could look down from the walls of his ancient city to see an army encamped on the plains below.¹ For inhabitants of the cities of northern Mesopotamia it was not an unfamiliar sight, often repeated during a quarter-century of active warfare between the eastern and western powers that disputed their territories, as they and their predecessors had disputed them since time immemorial. Roman armies advanced by these cities to engage the Persians in the north-eastern corner of Mesopotamia that was their regular theatre of conflict, or to repel Persian invasion directed across the Tigris to strike at the Roman cities of Osroene and Syria. Persian armies, their progress measured by the fires which marked the advance of raiding parties, were viewed with sombre anxiety by the inhabitants of the cities, as they wondered for how long their defences would sustain a siege, speculated how soon a Roman field army might arrive to relieve them, or watched them pass on their way for some other immediate object of hostilities. In a recent invasion in 359, the Persian king Sapor II had passed by Nisibis without attacking it, as he made for Amida to the north-west, captured and sacked after a siege of seventy-three days and the loss, it was said, of thirty thousand Persian fighting men. Between the death of Constantine the Great in 337 and 350, Nisibis had been besieged no less than three times, the river Mygdonius (the Oued Jaghjagha) being on the third of these occasions diverted by massive earthworks and dykes to form a lake around the city in order to undermine the city walls and expose them to attack. These events too were described, with much vivid circumstantial as well as rhetorical detail, in the hymns of Ephraim – waters lapping round the city as it stood there like a beleaguered Noah's Ark, the sudden collapse of dykes, the breaching by the floodwaters and the repair overnight of a section of the city walls, Persian elephants sinking in the mud, Sapor leaving disconsolate after his third unsuccessful attempt to take the city.²

Now, in 363, circumstances were different. The army outside Nisibis was the Roman army of the Emperor Julian, not advancing on Persia but

already defeated there and now pausing in its retreat, safe on what was still for the moment Roman soil. Julian himself had been killed in a skirmish, after turning back from the Persian capital of Ctesiphon unable to attempt its siege. In the fields of Nisibis, Ephraim could stand by the emperor's hearse, escorted back to Roman territory by his army in a sort of bizarre parody of a funeral procession. Julian's death had left his hastily chosen successor, Jovian, in the position of having to treat for terms in order to secure the safe departure of the harried Roman army from Persian territory. The Persians had seized their opportunity, demanding the cession of a large tract of northern Mesopotamia, including the cities of Singara and Nisibis itself, all the fortified sites in the region and five satrapies, or semi-independent principalities, along the upper Tigris. Observing the strict letter of his agreement, Jovian refused to allow his men to enter Nisibis, but kept them encamped outside, in spite of the pleas of the inhabitants that they should not be unprotected. Their resentment burst out in the retort of an envoy who came from the city to present to Jovian the 'crown gold' due to an emperor on his accession – a normal civic duty, which in the circumstances had acquired an only too obvious irony: 'And so, emperor,' said the envoy, a leading citizen of Nisibis, 'may you be crowned by the other cities of your empire!' His anger is not surprising, for a Persian commander and garrison arrived to take possession of Nisibis, which was to be handed over empty. Its people were evacuated, to be re-resettled in other Roman cities (Ephraim went to the famous Christian city of Edessa), and the Persian standard was run up on the citadel:³

the banner which was sent from the East wind
the Magian took and fastened on the tower
so that a flag might point out for spectators
that the city was the slave of the Lords of that banner.

It was a pitiful scene, as weeping families were parted from their homes with whatever they could carry, and for the Roman government a moment of humiliation not endured in living memory.

Somewhere in the midst of that army which Ephraim viewed from his city walls and walked among was a young officer from Syrian Antioch, who after service in both east and west had joined the Persian campaign of Julian, witnessed its failure and shared the painful retreat across the desert. In the magnificent history which he brought to completion at Rome a quarter of a century later, Ammianus Marcellinus described his and the army's experiences, presenting the surrender of Nisibis – Persian flag and all – in language as intensely emotional within its own conventions as that of Ephraim, and sparing no words of condemnation for the emperor whom he considered responsible for it.⁴ On this point Ammianus differed sharply from his Christian counterpart. Against all reason and justice, he attributed to Jovian's action in treating with the Persians the blame surely more properly deserved by the emperor whose overwrought ambition and impulsive death had made acceptance of their terms inevitable. The extent of Ammianus' misjudgment will become

clearer when these events are discussed later in this book (Chapter IX). We can understand, however, why Ammianus, and others of his mind, viewed the situation as they did. For them, much more was at stake than the acceptance of military defeat. The death of Julian was nothing less than the death of their hero, and a fatal blow to their hopes that the Roman empire might be renewed upon the principles of an earlier age. Turning from the Christian religion of the house of Constantine in which he had been brought up, and espousing the cause of the ancestral gods, Julian had thrown the energies of his short reign into the restoration, by legislation, inducements and personal example, of the traditional civic, religious and cultural practices of the Roman empire. How far he might have succeeded had he lived longer is a question which fascinates historians – and rightly, for it exposes deeper questions about late Roman society and the nature of its acceptance of Christianity. In the summer of 363, however, the question would have seemed bitterly ironic. The failure of the Persian campaign and the death of Julian meant the end of his attempt to restore the traditional religion, as surely as they meant the end of his attempt to restore the traditional military practices of the Roman empire in its confrontations with its ancestral enemy.

If he were to be successful, Julian should have returned to the Roman empire with the title 'Conqueror of Persia' (*Parthicus*) to which he aspired, and the prestige of a great foreign victory to put behind his religious and cultural policies. But the fates were not in his favour. The emperor lay dead under the Mesopotamian sky whose omens against the campaign he had ignored, and had been succeeded by a Christian emperor. After Jovian (who died the next year), the brothers Valentinian and Valens, then Valentinian's son Gratian, and particularly Theodosius I, made emperor after the death of Valens at the battle of Hadrianople in 378, brought with them a further generation's government in favour, and ultimately in aggressive support, of Christianity. These same years saw Ammianus himself progress from his vigorous youth of the time of the Persian campaign, to late middle and early old age. To Ammianus at sixty, looking back in his imagination from late fourth-century Rome to Mesopotamia, across a generation of Christian government to a pagan emperor, the death of Julian and the scenes before Nisibis must have seemed very distant. It would be surprising if he had viewed these events with an unchanging eye, or if his reactions had remained fixed and unaltered as the person and reign of Julian receded ever further into the past, behind another twenty-five years' tumultuous political events and further entrenchment of the Christian order.

The evolution of Ammianus' personal attitudes over these years is as fundamental an aspect of his interpretation as a historian, as it must remain in all but the most hesitant terms beyond the reach of his reader. This is not because Ammianus is an evasive writer. He is in many respects the most self-revealing of ancient historians, as he describes in great detail his role during his active years both in east and west, and alludes from time to time to his later travels in the time between his

departure from the army in 363 and his arrival at Rome about twenty years later. He is by no means sparing of his personal reactions to the events and situations which he describes, and he expresses his moral and political views with force, sometimes with prejudice and not always consistently. He allows the time and place of his writing to appear quite precisely, and he says much – little of it favourable – about the nature of the society in which, as a late arrival at Rome, he found himself. Indeed, the prominence that Ammianus allows himself as a participant in his own history is one of its most interesting features. It is important too in defining the historiographical tradition in which he is best understood, and in answering the question why he turned to the writing of history. Yet for all this, little is known of the precise milieu in which Ammianus – the historian, not the military officer – moved. He remains obstinately unattached. He does not belong to any particular intellectual or social circle of which we know, nor, with a single exception discussed below, does any other writer mention or address him by name.⁵ Any literary influence exerted by Ammianus on other writers of the age is extremely difficult to establish. On the best possible showing, it is severely limited, and involves an author and a work of which Ammianus himself would not have approved, namely the collection of second- and third-century imperial biographies, mixed in value and obscure in intention, known as the *Historia Augusta*.⁶ Later, Ammianus is cited by the grammarian Priscian, writing in the early sixth century at the eastern capital of Constantinople. Interest among eastern literary circles in the last great Latin historian of the Roman empire is not surprising in that period, when Constantinople was full of western emigrés and others with an interest in Latin literature, and Latin itself still had an important role, at least as a ceremonial and official language, at the imperial court; but that Priscian's citation, on a not uncommon point of orthographic interest, is chosen from Book 14 of the history of Ammianus has long been taken to suggest that this was already in his day the first book available to him.⁷ The oldest manuscript of Ammianus is a ninth-century text originally from the monastery of Fulda in Germany, copied from a slightly earlier manuscript from Hersfeld, of which only six leaves now survive. If this is a tradition of descent independent of that known to Priscian, then the loss here too of the first thirteen books would indicate that the history was already incomplete when it was transmitted to Constantinople at some time in the fifth or early sixth century. The situation does not suggest that Ammianus, for all his apparent contemporary success, retained a wide readership, even in the generations immediately after his own day.⁸ We note with frustration the manuscripts, numbered in hundreds, of the fifth-century Christian apologetic historian Orosius, of which a round twenty precede the tenth century – such representation of a writer whose qualities as a historian, when compared with those of Ammianus (and even when not compared with them), are an embarrassment to the profession.

Much can be learned of Ammianus from his own writing, and from the

study of the political, social and geographical milieux in which he moved, and this book is concerned as much with the Roman empire of his day, as Ammianus saw it, as with the historian himself. But it is right to begin with the single item of direct external evidence for the life and work of Ammianus himself. This will take us at once to the time and place at which the history was nearing completion, the city of Rome in the time of Theodosius, around the year 390. Ammianus is looking back at the reign of Julian and his own active career at a distance of more than twenty-five years since that dreadful day at Nisibis, and more than thirty-five since his first appearance as a participant in his history. It is between these poles of attraction that Ammianus' interpreter must be prepared to move in his imagination – between his career as a young man and the recollections of the retired soldier, between the Middle East in which most of this active career was pursued and the ancient capital of the Roman empire in which he determined to settle in order to complete his history and, not least important, between the Greek language of his eastern background and the Latin in which he chose to write. The reader of this book should try to bear all these aspects in mind. Of all ancient historians, Ammianus deserves to be treated, not as the unreflecting spokesman of set ideas, to be neatly encapsulated by bland statements about social class and upbringing, but as the living product of tensions of time, place and memory.

CHAPTER II

Ammianus and his History

(1) The political setting

For a man to visit Rome and live there quietly, attending its famous teachers and admiring their eloquence, is an enviable privilege. That such a man should undertake literary composition, offer it to the public of that incomparable city and be acclaimed the equal or superior of the great writers of the past – this puts Rome herself in his debt and enhances the honour both of the visitor and of his own city and compatriots. For it is the mark of a distinguished citizen to glorify by his achievements the place from which he comes.

Around such sentiments did the late Roman literary world revolve. They came in this instance from the aged sophist, Libanius of Antioch, as he wrote to a fellow-citizen who was winning just such a reputation at Rome by giving readings from his newly-composed historical work.¹ Libanius' letter was written late in the year 392, and the name of the successful historian from Antioch was Marcellinus. The identity of Libanius' correspondent as Ammianus Marcellinus is inescapable, and the letter makes it possible to reconstruct in some detail the political and social setting in which Ammianus' work was nearing completion.

Libanius mentioned in his letter that he had been told of his compatriot's fame by men returning to Antioch from Rome, an apparently casual remark that could turn out more helpful than it seems. In the summer of the previous year, the Emperor Theodosius, after suppressing rebellion in the west and restoring legitimate power there, had brought his army and court back to the eastern empire. On 19 June 391 the emperor was still at Aquileia in north Italy, ready for his journey through the Balkans to Constantinople, but by 18 July he had already reached the eastern capital of the Roman empire.² From here, his supporters would over the next months scatter farther afield, pursuing their various employments and interests in the eastern provinces. There were no doubt other visitors from Antioch to Rome in these years, who might upon their return have brought back news of a fellow-citizen there. Other reasons for a visit can easily be imagined, and some are known; on one occasion for instance, just a few years later, a delegation of city councillors from Antioch passed through Rome on its way to Spain, to acquire horses to show at public games in their city (Symmachus, *Ep.* 4.62). But if Libanius' informants had after all returned with the emperor from the

campaign in the west, they would have been able to bring news to Antioch in the course of 392. The historical readings of which they informed Libanius will in this case have taken place not actually in 392, but earlier. They could be ascribed to the more general setting of the presence of Theodosius and his court in the west, which had lasted for almost three years from the late summer of 388. It is natural to think of the emperor's official visit to Rome in June 389 and to locate Ammianus' readings in that year or the next, when the court, as other sources such as the letters of Symmachus show, was in constant and close contact with Rome. Ammianus sometimes affected a certain modesty about his achievement as a historian, but he would not have persisted in such work without confidence in his abilities. Nor do historians write without any conception of their possible public, and Ammianus would have shown a distinct lack of opportunism if he had failed to exploit the presence of Theodosius and his courtiers to bid for the audience which they offered for the first major history of Rome to appear in Latin for nearly three hundred years. Senators, on Ammianus' own account, lacked interest in such things, and it may be that visiting imperial courtiers offered the prospect of a more receptive and more open-minded audience: possibly Ammianus put on his readings with them in mind rather than the parochial, ill-educated senators – though not all were like this – whom he so effectively exposed in his digressions on Rome.³

On any account, Ammianus was living at Rome, to adapt one of his own metaphors, during a period of rapidly turning fortunes.⁴ The usurper Maximus, proclaimed in Britain in the summer of 383, had crossed the Channel and put an end to the young emperor Gratian. Settling at Trier, Maximus had opened diplomatic relations with an imperial court at Milan headed nominally by the even younger Valentinian II, and with his colleague Theodosius at Constantinople. He hoped, with some reason based on their previous acquaintance and military service together, and perhaps also their common Spanish origin, to win Theodosius' acceptance, but with only transient success. After a moment of recognition in 386, by summer 387 diplomatic relations between the usurping and legitimate regimes had collapsed. Valentinian abandoned Italy to Maximus, and went to Thessalonica to meet Theodosius and, with the help of a dynastic marriage to his sister Galla, secure his help. By the following year Theodosius was ready to undertake the campaign to the west. Once Theodosius had moved against him, Maximus offered little resistance. After two military setbacks, he was surrendered by his own men to Theodosius and executed at Aquileia (28 August 388). Theodosius pressed on to Milan and was established there by 10 October, sufficiently confident to extend clemency to those who, from bad luck or judgment, had opposed him.⁵ Among those forgiven for their indiscretion was the leading orator and Roman senator of the day, Q. Aurelius Symmachus, who had acted as senatorial envoy to Maximus' court and there delivered a panegyric. An emperor should know the difference between active support of a usurper and the satisfaction of ceremonial requirements

such as the delivery of official orations; but there were certain appearances to be kept up, and Symmachus had to excuse himself for his panegyric to Maximus before receiving Theodosius' pardon (Symmachus, *Epp.* 2.30-1). If, as one writer claimed, Symmachus had been obliged to seek asylum in a church of schismatic Christians and owed his pardon to their bishop's intervention before Theodosius, this would have doubled the embarrassment of one who was not only the leading senator of his day, but, since his unsuccessful petition of 384 for the restoration of the altar of Victory to the senate-house, the most prominent spokesman for the ancestral religion. But the unsupported word of an ecclesiastical writer on such a matter cannot be taken as authoritative.⁶ Symmachus' restoration to favour, and the consulship which he held in 391, are more convincingly put down to the influence of a powerful friend at the imperial court – Virius Nicomachus Flavianus, the emperor's quaestor and praetorian prefect, and himself some sort of historian. He was the author of a work entitled '*Annales*', which he consented at the emperor's request to dedicate to Theodosius. Unfortunately the content and quality of these *Annales* are unknown, and their relevance to Ammianus Marcellinus is at best insubstantial. Theodosius is reported to have liked history, particularly that of great figures of the Roman Republic (*Epit. de Caes.* 48.11f.); perhaps it was to these, rather than to contemporary history, that Flavianus' work was devoted. He and his friends, including Symmachus, are known for their work as editors of Livy, especially the earlier books of that voluminous author.⁷

All these events fell beyond the terminal point of Ammianus Marcellinus' history, and he had nothing to say of them. Nor, for whatever reason, did he find occasion to mention Symmachus. This is interesting, for the orator's father does figure occasionally in events described by Ammianus, and it would not have been impossible, had Ammianus felt obliged to him, to have contrived a reference to the younger and more famous man; Q. Aurelius Symmachus had been senatorial legate to the court of Valentinian in 369-70, and proconsul of Africa in 373.⁸ Ammianus did, however, take note of another supporter of Maximus, his prefect of Rome Julianus Rusticus. Rusticus had made a brief appearance in Ammianus' history in events of the year 367, when he was the favoured candidate of a group of Gallic officials at the court of Valentinian I in the event (as seemed quite likely at the time) that the emperor should die (27.6.1f.). In later years, wrote Ammianus in that context, Rusticus governed Africa – he was Symmachus' predecessor as proconsul – with savage violence: a facet of his temper which he was obliged to suppress as prefect of Rome through fear of the 'tyrant' under whose uncertain regime he held the office. The 'tyrant' was Magnus Maximus, and Rusticus' prefecture of Rome, during the tenure of which he died, can be placed in 387/8. He had risen to these heights, pronounced Ammianus, in the absence of worthy candidates.⁹

Ammianus was living at Rome during Julianus Rusticus' prefecture of the city, and knew what (and whom) he was writing about. It was by no

means the only occasion on which he briefly mentioned the later careers of personalities who occurred in his narrative – no doubt (in most cases) for their own satisfaction, and for the benefit of those to whom they were known at Ammianus' time of writing; perhaps, also, because he happened to know them himself. Whatever the reason, these allusions, as we shall see in the second part of this chapter, are helpful to the reader of Ammianus in providing points of reference for the period of time between the latest events described in the history, in summer 378, and its publication about twelve years later.

Ammianus was at Rome, also, for another, more auspicious occasion in these highly eventful years. On 13 June 389 Theodosius himself entered Rome to celebrate his victory over Maximus, on one of those, now rare, occasions on which the ancient capital received its emperor in a personal visit. A panegyrist from southern Gaul, Pacatus, evoked the setting in a speech delivered before senate and emperor, recalling some of the most striking moments (*Paneg. Lat.* 12, ed. Galletier): the emperor's reception by senate and people, his conduct at ceremonial processions, his visits to the great monuments of Rome and to the private residences of senators.¹⁰ It is an attractive notion that one of Ammianus' most famous pieces of writing reached its final version with Theodosius' State Visit in mind: this is his description of the triumphal entrance to Rome of the Emperor Constantius more than thirty years before, in 357 (16.10.1ff.) Constantius' procession, like that of Theodosius, came into Rome along the Via Flaminia as if lined up in battle array, along roads crowded with people who had come from all parts to see the display. The emperor sat motionless as a statue, moving his face neither to right nor left, not spitting nor wiping the sweat off his face or nose (he must have been incredibly hot in his ceremonial regalia), nor even allowing his head to shake when his carriage jolted on the road. Around him were the ranks of imperial household troops, their figured standards billowing in the breeze – or, as Ammianus wrote with a brilliant touch of imagery that will be pursued later, 'hissing' like the dragons whose images appeared on them.¹¹ Acclamations swelled and echoed all around, before which Constantius showed himself majestically imperturbable.

There is no need to assume that Ammianus was here deliberately and in direct fashion referring to the entry to Rome of Theodosius in 389. He included such criticisms of Constantius' conduct as could hardly have been made so directly of Theodosius. Moreover, the language and the actual forms of ceremony are by their nature conventional and apt for repetition. Ammianus, who in his life had seen many an imperial 'adventus', could have composed his account of Constantius' visit some years before that of Theodosius took place. Yet if he were giving readings from his work in or soon after 389, it would be perverse to deny the impact of this passage in relation to the more recent visit. In reading Ammianus' account of Constantius' reaction to the public monuments of Rome, we may even have a glimpse of Ammianus' own sentiments, as he first set eyes on the wonders of the city which, for his later years, he made his

own. Wherever Constantius looked, he saw a wonder to surpass the last, his amazement conveyed by Ammianus by hyperbole piled on hyperbole to a point touching the absurd: the temple of Capitoline Jupiter, superior in magnificence as divine things are to human; baths as big as provinces; the Colosseum, its summit scarcely visible, so high it was; the Pantheon, like a lofty, rounded city district in its own right; the columns of Trajan and his successors, with imperial statues surmounting them and spiral staircases inside, leading to platforms from which one could view the city. Most impressive of all was the Forum of Trajan, a work (wrote Ammianus) unique in the world, never to be surpassed by the hands of men, a marvel even to the gods (16.10.15). Constantius' declaration that if he could not rival the Forum he might erect there an equestrian statue of himself to match that of Trajan, was countered by an associate, the Persian exile Hormisdas, with a suitably clever remark – or perhaps it is just *ben trovato* for this wily Oriental: the emperor should first order to be built a stable to compare with this – if he had the power.¹² The horse that he had it in mind to make might then range as widely as the one he saw (16.10.16)! In the end, Constantius was content, after long deliberation, with the raising of an obelisk, the description of which Ammianus deferred to its proper place in his text (17.4.12-23). In all this, Ammianus is clearly looking beyond the factual circumstances of Constantius' visit, to give an image of Rome such as would impress itself on any observer.

What must be appreciated from the outset is the depth of penetration of the ideals of Rome into the mental outlook of this Greek from Antioch. Not that the present realities of the city matched the ideals. About to embark, in a passage near the beginning of the surviving part of the history, on a scathing description of the manners of the nobility and people of Rome, Ammianus invited his readers to consider why it should be that whenever his narrative turned to Rome, there was nothing to tell but of 'riots, drunkenness and other such common matters' (14.6.2). In Ammianus' view, this was the contribution of a frivolous minority to the life of a city, whose incomparable greatness was enshrined in its history and institutions. It is particularly notable that Ammianus puts himself forward at this moment as one writing for outsiders. He addressed his remarks to such foreigners ('peregrini') as he might be lucky enough to have as the readers of his book; '*mirari posse quosdam peregrinos existimo haec lecturos forsitan, (si contigerit)...*' (14.6.2).

It is beyond belief that Ammianus could write like this without recalling his own position as a foreign visitor to Rome. He touched on the experience of a newcomer to the city only a few sentences later in his digression, in which he reflected on the reception of such a stranger as he first approaches the houses of the great men of Rome. You are then greeted with such an amazing display of concern, he wrote, 'that you regret not coming to Rome ten years before'; '*miraberis ... summam virum tenuem te sic enixius observantem, ut paeniteat ob haec bona tamquam praecipua non vidisse ante decennium Romam*' (14.6.12). This interest is however not repeated at later visits, when you are likely to be

treated as a total stranger or, if ultimately invited to dinner, find yourself placed at table below gamblers, charioteers and fortune-tellers (6.14). The air of grievance in this passage may be deceptive, for it is influenced by an old tradition of satire on the moral unworthiness of the great and their failure to recognise honest virtue. More revealing may be the informality of the address in the second person, with its invitation to the reader to imagine himself in the situation pictured by Ammianus. Had not Ammianus himself once regretted 'not coming to Rome ten years before', only to find his initial reception not borne out by the outcome?

Pursuing the same theme, Ammianus recalled the occasion when, at a time of a severe food shortage, foreign visitors had been expelled from Rome, including those men (and they were few enough) who were there for the pursuit of liberal arts. At the same time, attendants of mime actresses and any who could masquerade as such were kept in the city, together with three thousand dancing girls with their trainers and supporting troupes. Allowance must again be made for some rhetorical exaggeration, but this does not weaken the force of Ammianus' remark that the event in question had taken place 'not so very long ago'; 'haud ita dudum' (14.6.19). The famine, and the expulsion of visitors which it occasioned, were well-known events, mentioned by other writers, and appear to have taken place in 383 or, perhaps better, 384.¹³ Symmachus regretted the necessity of the expulsion in a letter dated to one of these two years (*Ep.* 2.7). Ammianus, as a visitor to Rome and as a student of the liberal arts, fell on both counts within the categories of those whom he said were expelled at that time. To explore the suspicion that he was himself among those made to leave the city, we must turn back to an earlier phase in the historian's career, and in particular to his movements since his retirement from active military service some twenty years before his arrival at Rome.

*

In the summer of 363 the broken army of Julian had endured its retreat from Persian territory to the safety of the Roman empire. After the traumatic surrender of Nisibis, Ammianus returned with Jovian to Antioch, marking his arrival with an account of the portents seen there (25.10.1ff.); but when, in mid-winter, Jovian pressed on towards Constantinople (10.4ff.), Ammianus seems not to have been with the army but to have stayed behind at Antioch. The use of the first person with which he marked his arrival there ('Antiochiam venimus', 10.1) does not recur in the succeeding narrative.

For the next two decades, Ammianus was able to travel, to explore, to seek out witnesses of events whose testimony he would add to his own experiences in order to write a history of his times. As he explained in the preface to Book 15, he recorded as faithfully as possible what he was old enough to have witnessed himself and what he could learn by the close questioning of participants in events.¹⁴ Ammianus' movements in these

years can be picked out only intermittently, from allusions inserted from time to time into his narrative. He had been to Greece, or at least to the Peloponnese, for he had seen at Mothone in Laconia the wreck of a ship cast two miles inland by the tidal wave caused by a major earthquake in 365. Ammianus had seen the stranded vessel while ‘passing through’ (‘transeundo’) on a journey, its hulk gaping apart from long decay; ‘diuturna carie fatiscentem’ (26.10.19). At Alexandria, the same disaster had landed ships on the roofs of houses; although Ammianus did not specifically say so, there is no reason to doubt that he had been told of or seen this phenomenon during a visit there. He described Alexandria in a long digression, with particular attention to its great temple, the Serapeum, and to the intellectual life, especially in medical studies, which still flourished there (22.16.7ff.). In all likelihood, Ammianus passed by Alexandria in order to gain access to the upper Nile. He introduced a digression on Egypt by referring back to previous discussions, in the lost books, in which he had described at length many things he had seen there; ‘quarum notitiam ... digessimus late, visa pleraque narrantes’ (22.15.1).¹⁵ He observed that the temples and pyramids were among many things ‘worth seeing’ in Egypt (22.15.28), and in the city of Thebes, he recalled having seen obelisks standing and lying around, complete with hieroglyph inscriptions (17.4.6). Later, after an engaging digression on the cunning of the hippopotamus, he reported a speculation of the inhabitants of the region as to where these beasts had disappeared to; they had fled to the land of the Blemmyes, through weariness at being hunted (22.15.24). Ammianus was writing now of the regions around Memphis; it is difficult to imagine a better source for this speculation than the local inhabitants themselves. In such passages, Ammianus stands square as a Greek historian in the tradition of Herodotus – whom he names in this very context (22.15.28); travelling widely, curious in everything he sees, eager for information about it.¹⁶

Ammianus at some time visited the Black Sea. Introducing a digression on the regions of Pontus and Thrace, he wrote that he would set down accurately what he had seen and read of them, ‘visa vel lecta quaedam’ (22.8.1). The digression, like others, bears more traces of what Ammianus had read than of what he had seen;¹⁷ but one wonders whether he had himself set eyes on one of the sights of the Pontus, the Symplegades, or ‘Clashing Rocks’, of the legend of the Argonauts. Since the Argo had passed through the rocks, they had stood motionless and united, their force spent, so that, unless the ancient poets had agreed on the story, no one who now looked at them would believe that they had ever been separated; ‘eos aliquando fuisse diremptos nulli nunc conspiciantium credant, nisi super hoc congruerent omnes priscorum carminum cantus’ (22.8.15). Ammianus is not here being ironic or having a joke: it is rather that, for events of legendary times, poets were, after all, the proper authority.

What cannot be determined is the date of these various visits, their relationship to each other, or the nature of the larger journeys of which

they may have formed part. The 'passing visit' to Laconia will have fallen several years after 365 – but where was Ammianus travelling to when he saw it? and how long does it take for a stranded ship to decay and fall apart? It is clear in any event that Ammianus was in his home city of Antioch in and shortly after 370. He described in dark colours prosecutions of Antiochene notables on charges of magic and treason. The charges arose from a curious affair in which some men had used magic spells to tell the future, and had turned up the first part of the name of a threatened successor to Valens. The letters revealed to them seemed sufficient to identify a Gallic secretary named Theodorus, then working at Antioch.¹⁸ Theodorus was unfortunate enough also to possess links with Julian the Apostate, and in consequence the prosecutions took on the character of a witch-hunt of literary men and philosophers, some of whom had been connected with Julian. In the panic, men destroyed their libraries to avoid the suspicion of possessing books on magic; and in the same passage Ammianus spoke of himself and his fellow Antiochenes as 'creeping around in deathly gloom' while the emperor and his associates used the courts of law to grab men's fortunes and satisfy personal grudges (29.2.4). Among those in danger was a man described by Ammianus as 'our' Hypatius, an individual of calm and noble virtues, who brought credit to his ancestry and to his descendants by his conduct of two prefectures (29.3.16). Hypatius was prefect of Rome in 379, being summoned from Antioch to hold the office, and praetorian prefect of Italy in 382-3.¹⁹ In describing him as 'our' Hypatius, Ammianus was associating himself with the dangers suffered by his Antiochene compatriot, and claiming for his city some of the credit won by his later distinction – much as Libanius laid claim to a share in Ammianus' reputation, won at Rome by the recitation of his history.

It is likely also that Ammianus was at Antioch during the last years of the reign of Valens, when the Goths, pressed on by the Huns and Alans, came up against the Danube frontier of the Roman empire and were permitted to cross it by the emperor. At the battle of Hadrianople, with which this phase culminated (9 August 378), only a third of the Roman army survived the encounter with the Goths. Many generals and officers were killed and the emperor himself disappeared from sight, presumed dead. Ammianus had remarked that the dangers in the remoter Danubian regions tended to be dismissed by the Roman government; because of the distances involved, they were not usually heard of until after they were suppressed, or at least subdued for a time (31.4.3). He might have pondered on this with particular irony when he reflected on the Gothic admission to the Roman empire, for at that moment the emperor was very far indeed from the spot – precisely, in Ammianus' own city of Antioch, at a time when the more pressing danger for the empire seemed to come from Persia. It was only when it had become clear that the crossing of the Danube had gone wrong that Valens came to an arrangement with the Persians over Armenia and left for Constantinople and Thrace.

The episode with which Ammianus actually concluded his history was indeed very close to home. The *magister militum* in the east, Julius, issued orders that the Goths already in service with the Roman armies should be assembled in the suburbs of the cities where they were stationed, in the expectation that they were to receive arrears of pay. The 'wisdom' of Julius' plan was revealed when the Goths, once so assembled, were massacred to a man. The risk that they might join forces with their compatriots victorious at Hadrianople was averted, and the eastern provinces were 'saved from great dangers'; '*orientales provinciae discriminibus ereptae sunt magnis*'. These are the very last words of Ammianus' historical narrative.²⁰ In describing Julius as '*magister militiae trans Taurum*', Ammianus places himself to the west of that mountain barrier between Roman Asia and the Orient, but this is a facet of the literary perspective of his text.²¹ In terms of contemporary experience, the relevance of Julius and his action to the historian's city and region takes on a rather different aspect. Julius is otherwise attested at Antioch (in the writings of Libanius) and active, through the work of a subordinate, in the province of Arabia (*ILS* 773). For Ammianus, it is more or less local history.

Ammianus' attitudes to the disaster of Hadrianople and to the prospects of Roman recovery after it, are not a matter for discussion now, save in one respect. He was composing his history in the time of an emperor, Theodosius, whom he described on an appearance as a young general in the province of Moesia as 'later a most distinguished *princeps*' (29.6.15). Theodosius was raised to the throne in January 379 to repair the catastrophe of Hadrianople. After three years' campaigning, of which only the most fragmentary outlines are discernible, he made an alliance with the Goths, by which they were settled in certain areas of the lower Danubian provinces, with military obligations to the Roman government. The agreement was finalised in early October of 382; before that, on 11 January 381, Theodosius had gained much good will among the Goths by receiving their king Athanaric with honour at Constantinople.²² When Athanaric died after a fortnight, the emperor buried his guest with full honours. Ammianus mentioned the burial of Athanaric early in 381 'with splendid pomp, in the Roman style' – '*ambitiosis exsequiis, ritu ... nostro*' – in the context of Athanaric's first encounter with Valens in the Gothic campaign of 367 (27.5.10). He will have derived his knowledge of the occasion, which fell outside the narrative scope of his history, from those 'participants in events' whom he mentioned in his preface to Book 15 – if indeed he was not himself at Constantinople in 381 to witness the funeral of Athanaric.

Whether or not Ammianus was at Constantinople at this time, it is likely that he was still in the east. He may possibly, though it is not a necessary inference, have visited Thrace and seen one of the battlefields of the terrible years 376-8. From the battle, near the town of Ad Salices by the Danube delta, Romans and Goths had parted on level terms after heavy bloodshed. Those of the dead who were of any distinction were

properly buried, as well as circumstances allowed. The rest were left where they had fallen, to be devoured by the vultures – as was shown ‘to the present day’ by the piles of bones whitening the field; ‘ut indicant *nunc usque* albentes ossibus campi’ (31.7.16). Ammianus’ Vergilian allusion at this point (*Aen.* 12.36) heightens the impact of the scene, lending to his words a touch of epic style without quite presupposing that he had observed it himself. It is not clear how precisely Ammianus intended his phrase ‘*nunc usque*’ to be taken, nor from what present point in time he meant it to be understood, and he could certainly have gained an impression of the scene as well as a mere description of it from someone else who had been there. Yet it is impossible not to wonder whether his description of the battlefield reveals Ammianus’ own acquaintance with it, not too many years after the battle was fought.

It was only after Theodosius’ treaty of 382 with the Goths that the Thracian regions were really safe to visit. Now and in the previous year, bishop Ambrose of Milan noted that communications between Thessalonica and north Italy were broken by the hostile occupation of Thrace, impeding the summoning of a church council.²³ Bishops were accustomed to the advantages of the imperial transport system, the *cursus publicus*, and their more sedate expectations ought not necessarily to be applied to Ammianus, who – as the experiences which he recounted in his history well show – was in his earlier years a man of considerable vigour and enterprise, well able to look after himself. We should be foolish to rule out the possibility that Ammianus visited the Thracian battlefield before the region was safe for regular travel, but it would be more natural to suppose that if he visited Ad Salices, it was after Theodosius’ peace treaty of 382. The Danube delta is not on any normal route from the eastern empire to Rome. We would best assume that, if Ammianus visited Thrace, he would return to Constantinople before embarking on a journey to the west. It would then be a possible speculation, but no more than this, that the ‘passing visit’ to Mothone in Laconia mentioned earlier formed part of a voyage made by the sea route from the east to the Peloponnese and across the Adriatic to Brundisium, before travelling through Italy by the main road to Rome. The alternative route, by land through the Balkans and down into Italy through Aquileia – the route taken by Theodosius’ army in 388 – is an equal possibility; in which case it would be still more unlikely, given the state of the country in the years after Hadrianople, that Ammianus would make the journey to the west before 383.

(2) Composition

It is not much to go on: personal knowledge of Laconia, Egypt and the Black Sea, time spent in Antioch, conjectured visits to Constantinople and Thrace – such things hardly offer the basis for a reconstruction of Ammianus’ life and movements in the years between his retirement from active service and his arrival at Rome some twenty years later.

Ammianus springs into his history in 354 and disappears from it nine gregarious, exciting and well-documented years later; yet even of these nine years almost three, ending in April 363 with the closely narrated Persian campaign of Julian, are void of any personal reference. For his life before this period of active service we must resort to generalised inferences from social background and cultural milieu, after it to the assembling of scattered allusions in some rational order; for the movements sketched in the first part of this chapter are only among many possible sequences of visits and journeys that could have brought Ammianus to Rome in the early 380s. Yet it must on any account be clear that Ammianus came to Rome with much material for his history already collected, his guiding ideas already formed, no doubt with selections of his work already drafted for presentation to some great literary patron, some well-informed politician or socially prominent figure willing to be convinced of his visitor's promise and good faith as a historian and thinking, possibly, of his own commemoration in the eyes of posterity. We can assume that Ammianus did not come to Rome entirely unprepared for the work he had it in mind to do, whatever the disappointment his actual reception there may have caused him.

On the narrowest and least ambitious criterion of good historical writing, that of accurate, plain narrative, there is little in the earlier of the surviving books that Ammianus could in principle not have known and recorded before he came west in the 380s.²⁴ It is clear from allusions in the earliest of these books that Ammianus had described the first years of the reign of Constantius in detail comparable to what now survives. He gives references back to the Persian campaigns of Constantius in the 340s, the visit to Britain of Constans in 343, his overthrow by the usurper Magnentius, and Magnentius' suppression by Constantius in 353. The name is given of the man who had closed the gates of Trier against Magnentius' Caesar Decentius (15.6.4), and a chapter in Book 14 tells of the punishments of the supporters of Magnentius in a tone grimly expressive of the aftermath of civil war.²⁵

Book 14 is otherwise dominated by the bloody regime at Antioch of Gallus Caesar, whom Constantius had installed there while he marched west to deal with the usurpation. The arrest of Gallus and his execution at Pola in Dalmatia formed the dark climax of this book; for the whole narrative, Ammianus will have had little difficulty in finding sources of information in the east for such events of this period as he was not able to describe from actually living in the city which Gallus had terrorised, and from serving under the general ordered to preside over Gallus' courts of law. In the west, the problems of security demonstrated by the rebellion of Magnentius were further shown by the proclamation at Cologne of another usurper, Silvanus, in whose suppression Ammianus took part as a young officer and which he described in Book 15 from his personal knowledge of it. Unable to ignore this repeated evidence of the physical unwieldiness of the empire, Constantius overcame his dislike and appointed his nephew Julian to maintain the imperial presence in the

northern sector of the provincial frontiers: and for the ensuing sequence in Ammianus' history (Books 16-20), the exploits of Julian and Constantius are described in parallel. Ammianus stayed in Gaul for nearly two years (355-7) after the suppression of Silvanus, and so witnessed the achievements of Julian in the first, magnificent, period of his imperial career. To this phase, the more remarkable because it was so unexpected, Ammianus devoted literary skills touching the panegyrical, its climax being Julian's victory over the Alamanni at Strasbourg, with which he concluded Book 16; but the visit of Constantius to Rome in 357 and his subsequent campaigns on the Danube frontier were also narrated fully, and with recognition of their importance.

The danger to the empire now shifted to the eastern frontier, to which Ammianus had been transferred in 357 (before the battle of Strasbourg); and the later part of Book 18 and almost the whole of 19 are taken up with events that he witnessed at very close hand indeed, the fighting on the eastern front and (in Book 19) the siege and capture of the city of Amida. Ammianus was among the besieged, and this part of the history shows his narrative skill at its very finest, and his concentration on his personal experience at its most intense.

In Book 20, the activities of Julian in Gaul and of Constantius on the eastern frontier are balanced, the proclamation of Julian as Augustus bringing to a crisis the relations between them; and 21 describes the open declaration of war on Constantius by Julian, his march against him and Constantius' death, opportune in that it averted yet another destructive civil war, from which it is not likely that Julian would have emerged successful. In this book (and more especially at the beginning of Book 22), Julian's emergent pagan sympathies begin to attract attention, and it ends with another demonstration of Ammianus' literary technique, his obituary notice of Constantius. This is skilfully contrived in its presentation of virtues and vices to make that emperor's merits seem insignificant beside the suspicion, judicial cruelty and civil dissension that clouded his reign.

With Julian as sole emperor, the narrative structure of Ammianus' exposition became simpler, it being possible to devote Books 22-25 to an integrated account of his reign with few interruptions from events in distant parts of the empire; these books of Ammianus' history are more noted for the learned digressions by which he enlarged the scale of a narrative that is rather less expansive when taken in isolation than seems apparent when it is read in context. If, during this phase, certain parts of the Roman empire appear to be neglected by Ammianus, then this was because they were neglected also by Julian, to make room for the greater designs that now appeared. The reign is followed from its early hopes of a renaissance of traditional civic, religious and military ideals, through the doomed ambition of the invasion of Persia in which Ammianus took part, to its ignominious collapse and the emperor's death on the retreat. Jovian, made emperor in Julian's place, had to cede territory to the Persians in order to gain safe passage back to the Roman

empire. It was with the army's return to Antioch, as we saw, that Ammianus left active service, never to return to it. He had followed the campaign like many others of an enterprising and curious nature, and sometimes of less conspicuous military abilities than were possessed by Ammianus. There was always, in these eastern adventures, something of an air of exploration and government-sponsored travel alongside the strictly military objectives which it may (or, as in this case, may not) be possible to identify.²⁶

The death of Jovian early in 364 and the succession of the brothers Valentinian and Valens posed new difficulties of structure and arrangement; for the emperors divided the empire and its administration into eastern and western portions, which they governed independently. Even the proclamation of Procopius at Constantinople in September 365 failed to distract Valentinian from the Rhine frontier to which he had devoted his attentions; and Valens was obliged to repel from his own resources this last resurgence of the dynastic tradition of Constantine the Great. With the usurpation of Procopius, which in the event was easily resolved in Valens' favour, Ammianus filled the latter part of Book 26 of his history, having now, as he had explained in the preface to this book, arrived at the threshold of the present age; 'ad usque memoriae confinia propioris' (26.1.1).

*

Such a bare summary of Books 14-26 of Ammianus' history leaves out much of what is most essential to its special quality and character. It takes no account of the wealth of detail which Ammianus invested in his story, nor of the control of structure with which he organised a wide-ranging narrative covering the Classical and near eastern worlds from the Rhine to the Euphrates and beyond, the proliferation of sub-plots and rivalries that defined the nature of the political life, the importance of individual character, the richness of imagery, and the illustrative role of anecdote. It ignores the breadth of Ammianus' conception of history, as shown especially in the digressions with which he varied his narrative and provided the full context necessary for its understanding. It therefore omits the central part of Ammianus' case to be considered as a Classical historian in the grand tradition. Nor does it touch so fundamental an aspect of his approach as his choice of Latin for a history that, in terms both of his own background and the contemporary historiographical tradition, might more naturally have been written in Greek. Its purpose is limited and strictly practical: to give a working survey of the actual contents of the history, and to suggest that, as far as concerns the plain narrative of these books, there is little in them that Ammianus could not have compiled, annotated and in part drafted in the years before his visit to the west.

Once the decision was made to carry the history beyond the rebellion of Procopius, a visit to the west became however a clear necessity. The

eastern regime of Valens could of course be narrated on the strength of Ammianus' presence there. As we have seen, he felt himself threatened by Valens' prosecutions on charges of magic and treason, conducted at Antioch in the early 370s: he was living there at the time and saw some of his friends and acquaintances fall under suspicion. Equally, if an inference made earlier is justified, Ammianus saw the battle of Hadrianople and its aftermath from the point of view of one living in the east: and he was surely living there when he compiled material for the digression on the Huns and the Alans with which he began the last book of his history. Valens' earlier, successful Gothic war (367-9) and his subsequent involvement with Persia and Armenia around 370 would, equally, have caused little difficulty for an alert enquirer living in the east, and for much of the time sharing residence at Antioch with the emperor and his supporters.

But it was well known that of the imperial brothers it was Valentinian who was the driving force. He had chosen Valens against the implied advice of his associates, and in the division of the empire which took place later in 364 it was Valentinian who nominated the personnel and the military establishment to be assigned to each emperor and chose for himself the western part of the empire. The division of the empire imposed a narrative apportioned between eastern and western events, while the degree to which the parts of the empire were now separately governed would imply that a historian – not that Ammianus would be unwilling – must be prepared to travel in order to gain his information.

The most cursory glance at Ammianus' account of the reign of Valentinian will show that its author must have come to the west to compose such a narrative as he presents of these years. The argument might rest on his descriptions of Valentinian's campaigns on Rhine and Danube, with treatment both of military exploits and engineering works, and his accounts of court life and politics. In these matters, Ammianus far surpasses any other source in accuracy, richness of incidental colour and supporting anecdote. But he ranges far beyond the setting of the imperial court and the enterprises connected with it. He offers, in the most careful detail, two episodes in widely separated parts of north Africa. One of these, which brought the citizens of Tripolitanian Lepcis into dispute with their military governor and subsequently into complex and hazardous diplomatic relations with the imperial court, concludes with mention of a report on the affair submitted to Valentinian's successor by the then proconsul and *vicarius* of Africa (28.6.1ff.). Then, further west in Mauretania, a narrative of military operations against a native rebel names not only individuals but whole regions, towns and peoples in a form suggesting use of documentary sources – perhaps a campaign report or reports which are highly unlikely to have been available in the eastern empire (29.5.1ff.). Ammianus narrated trials for magic and adultery among senatorial circles at Rome – the account balancing that of Valens' prosecutions at Antioch, although the circumstances and nature of the accusations were different in each case.

Ammianus' version of these events (28.1.1ff.) contains details and personal knowledge, not to say attitudes, which are best explained by the notion that he had pursued his enquiries among those affected.

It scarcely needs argument that the quality and detail of Ammianus' descriptions of western events in his latest books (27-31) assume his active presence in the west for the purpose of basic historical enquiry – the pursuit and scrutiny of witnesses, to which he referred in his preface to Book 15 – as well as for the more advanced processes of planning and composition. It now becomes important to determine as closely as we can the time of these more advanced stages of composition, for without this we shall find it difficult to approach the question of Ammianus' evolution as a historian, or to understand the choices of emphasis and presentation with which he finally expressed his conception of his undertaking. Self-evidently the later books, especially those parts concerning the west, will be the more closely involved with this period of final composition, in that Ammianus will have had to wait until his evidence was well in hand before embarking on their writing. It will be more interesting if for his earlier books also, parts of which he could have drafted before he came to the west, Ammianus was in a position to make extensive insertions and revisions at a later stage of composition.

To proceed in order from the later to the earlier books, the prefecture of Rome held under the usurper Maximus by Julianus Rusticus has already been mentioned (p. 10). The prefecture fell in 387/8, being anticipated in Book 27, under events of the year 367 (27.6.1). More substantially, also in Book 27, Ammianus mentioned the death of a notable individual of the time, the senator Petronius Probus, four times praetorian prefect and, after the emperors themselves, the most powerful man in the late fourth-century west. Probus makes several appearances in Ammianus' account of the reign of Valentinian. On the first of these occasions, under the year 368, the historian took the opportunity to provide a portrait of this remarkable figure, a fascinating combination of obsessive personal and family ambition, love of power, and nervous tension (27.11.1ff.; p. 277). Ammianus wrote of Probus that he 'possessed immense power, while he lived': 'potuit, quoad vixit, ingentia' (27.11.2). Now the death of Petronius Probus fell in or very near to 390.²⁷ Ammianus' reference to his death is no trivial or superficial insertion, consisting of a few words only. The whole substantial passage reads like a formal obituary. It is integral to the context, contains measured reflections on the nature of power, and was clearly not made public before the death of its subject. It is of course possible that Ammianus had for years been cherishing his words in anticipation that Probus would die by the time he came to publish his history; best however to assume that the entire passage was written, as it was certainly inserted, in or after 390.

We will find no difficulty in assuming that Ammianus was completing the last five books of his history in the years around 390. So much is implied, not only by references to events of that time such as the death of Probus, but by the practical difficulties of compiling, arranging and

composing a narrative of the reign of Valentinian in the few years since Ammianus' arrival in the west. The same argument applies, with reducing but still considerable force, to the years previous to Valentinian's reign, and to books earlier than 27. Ammianus' knowledge of events before 365 may in essentials have been complete before he came to the west, but that is not to say there were no improvements to make, no new sources to consult, no additional details that might throw light on those years. At the time of the outbreak of Procopius' rebellion in 365, for instance, Valentinian was making for Rheims to take his stand against the Alamanni. Not allowing himself to be deflected by civil war in the east, he sent three chosen agents to secure Africa against seizure by Procopius. Two of them were military officers, one of them well known to Valentinian, the other with experience of the terrain from previous service in the province. The third agent was Neoterius, at that time an imperial secretary (*notarius*), later consul; 'postea consulem, tunc notarium'.²⁸ The consulship was, indeed, very much later, falling precisely in 390. The reference comes in Book 26 of Ammianus' history (5.14).

Book 26 stands, for Ammianus, at the threshold of the present age (p. 204), but the argument can be extended to earlier books. Writing of the Emperor Julian in Book 22, Ammianus related a series of anecdotes about the emperor's behaviour at Constantinople (22.7.1ff.). He processed on foot at the inauguration of the consuls of the year; some praised this, others thought it cheap and affected. Catching himself out in a violation of protocol, Julian levied on himself a fine of ten pounds of gold. When a meeting of the senate was interrupted by news of the arrival of an old associate, the philosopher Maximus, Julian leapt from his seat, ran from the senate-house and led him inside. Ammianus thought this untimely ostentation, unsuitable for a philosopher (let alone an emperor). Finally, two imperial agents came forward with information on the whereabouts of a condemned former praetorian prefect now in hiding, but were rejected by Julian. Ammianus remarked that 'all these events' were witnessed by a visitor to Constantinople, the Roman senator Praetextatus, whom Julian had found there on private business and appointed proconsul of Achaia. Surely Praetextatus was Ammianus' source for these stories – only one of which, the arrival of Maximus, is mentioned elsewhere.²⁹ If so, and if, as is likely though not of course certain, it was at Rome that Ammianus first met Praetextatus, then this passage on Julian will not only reflect a time of final composition for Book 22 in the middle or later 380s, but will provide a secure limit in time for Ammianus' arrival at Rome. To the distress of his friends and the Roman populace, Praetextatus died as consul designate towards the end of 384.

Equally interesting is an episode from Book 21. Marching against Constantius in 361, Julian had encountered at Sirmium Aurelius Victor, an imperial official whom he then summoned to Naissus to receive appointment as governor of Pannonia Secunda (21.10.6). Julian also honoured Victor by the award of a bronze statue in the Forum of Trajan,

for he was not only an imperial functionary but a literary man of note, a historian of the Roman empire from the time of Augustus to 360 – as it turned out the last year of the reign of Constantius. Many years later, wrote Ammianus, Victor was prefect of Rome, an office which can be assigned to 389/90. Aurelius Victor was a person of some interest to Ammianus, less perhaps as a fellow-historian than for what he might tell of the circumstances of Julian's advance upon Sirmium, on which Ammianus was clearly well informed.³⁰ It would be reasonable to suppose that Ammianus knew Aurelius Victor during his tenure of the prefecture of Rome – and that he was a source of Ammianus' information on those events of almost thirty years earlier.

So, to combine these allusions, Books 26 (the consulship of Neoterius) and 27 (the urban prefecture of Julianus Rusticus and the death of Petronius Probus) attained their final form in 388/90 or later. Material for Book 22 became available to Ammianus from Praetextatus in 383 or 384, and for Book 21 from Aurelius Victor perhaps as late as 389. Whatever stage of composition these books had reached, Ammianus was able to make insertions and revisions which were sometimes quite substantial, and to add materially to the information available to him.

Ammianus included at various points of his text accounts of the tenures of office of the prefects of Rome. Whatever his sources for these notices, written, oral, or a combination of the two, Ammianus' access to such material assumes his presence in the west. It is unlikely that even an official record of the prefectures, if it existed (and it does not look as if Ammianus derived his information from such a document), was widely available in the empire.³¹ The first such passage, narrating the prefecture of Rome of Memmius Vitrasius Orfitus in 353-6, comes as it happens in the earliest of the surviving books (14.6.1ff.). It is this prefecture that provided the opportunity for Ammianus' first long digression on the habits of the senators and people of Rome – a digression in which, as was proposed earlier, are reminiscences both of Ammianus' own arrival at Rome and of the expulsion of foreigners at the time of the corn shortage of 383 or 384. Ammianus' remark that the expulsion had occurred 'not so very long ago' ('haud ita dudum') places the final preparation even of Book 14 of the history some few years after 383/4. Again, it is no trivial addition, the insertion merely of a few words with some sort of marginal indication; the allusion is relevant and integral to its context, and in making it Ammianus must have considered the effect of the entire passage in which it came.

It begins to look as if the whole of the surviving part of Ammianus' history reached its final form towards the year 390; that is to say, whatever he had written or drafted earlier, he was able to make substantial additions and amendments at that late stage. This conclusion, scarcely contentious for the latest books (27-31) in view of the extensive information on recent western events assembled in them, seems also to hold for Book 14, as well as for 21, 22 and 26. As to these earlier books, it is true that Ammianus' information was already very full

for events which he had witnessed at first hand or for which he had been able to find witnesses in the east: at the same time, relevant details remained to be gathered from western sources, and some quite emphatic and integral passages (like the prefecture of Orfitus and the advance upon Sirmium) in different ways reflect the historian's later presence in the west. It is possible even to suggest that this applies also to passages in books of the history no longer extant.

Introducing his narrative of the trials for magic arts and adultery conducted at Rome under Valentinian, Ammianus remarked that they were the most dreadful event to afflict Rome in the fifteen years or more since the rebellion of Nepotianus.³² The Goddess of War, he wrote, raged through the Eternal City and laid everything in flames; 'saeviens per urbem aeternam urebat cuncta Bellona' (28.1.1). The uprising at Rome of Nepotianus, a subsidiary event to the revolt of Magnentius, had been suppressed by him in 350. The intensity of Ammianus' comparison must surely owe something to the Roman circles in which he moved when assembling information on the trials conducted by Valentinian's agents. We may infer that in narrating the rebellion and fall of Nepotianus in Book 13 or earlier, Ammianus would have used Roman sources for his information.

Lastly, in Book 16 Ammianus had occasion to describe the support given to Julian before Constantius by the eunuch Eutherius (16.7.2f.; p. 83). The episode prompted Ammianus to reflect on a prodigious fact, the probity and courage of a eunuch. Adding an account of Eutherius' career, Ammianus remarked that he had in old age retired to Rome, where he still lived, secure in the possession of a good conscience, and loved and admired by all classes of men. Ammianus noted a particular gift of Eutherius, his amazing memory; 'immensum quantum memoria vigens' (7.5). Eutherius had served Julian, whose inconsistency of judgment he sometimes corrected; before this, he had attended the Emperor Constans, whose faults, claimed Ammianus, Eutherius would have mitigated had Constans listened to his advice. Still earlier, he had been acquainted with the court of Constantine, for he had been captured as a boy by Armenian tribesmen and sold as a eunuch to Roman traders and so brought to Constantine's palace, where his keen intelligence soon brought him to notice. If Ammianus did not use Eutherius' 'immense memory', not only in his researches on the recent age but on the earlier emperors with whom the eunuch had been acquainted, he would have been guilty of an unbelievable waste of an opportunity. Ammianus is telling us, as directly as he can, that Eutherius was one of his sources. He was therefore in a position during his stay at Rome to gather material on events and personalities of a time substantially before the first extant book of his history, as far back as the reign of Constantine the Great. A eunuch supporter of Julian on Constantine – that would have been worth reading, as Ammianus surely thought it worth hearing.³³

The internal indications provided by Ammianus himself converge therefore with Libanius' letter to him, written late in 392 but referring to

a slightly earlier time, to suggest that the final stages of composition of the history should be assigned to the years up to and shortly after 390. As to how long after 390 the work was completed, only one passage offers guidance. In his digression on Alexandria in Book 22, Ammianus mentioned its great temple, the Serapeum, comparing it to the Capitol, 'by which venerable Rome lifts herself to eternity'; 'quo se venerabilis Roma in aeternum tollit' (22.16.12). He could hardly have written in this way, explicitly comparing the Serapeum with a symbol of eternity at Rome, had he known of the destruction of the great temple by gangs of monks, possibly abetted and certainly not discouraged by the imperial authorities. This catastrophe took place in the summer of 391. If it is assumed that news of the event carried quickly round the Roman world, it is a natural inference that Book 22, in which the allusion occurs, was completed before 392.

There are various possible objections to such a straightforward inference. Perhaps news of the destruction did not carry round the Roman world as quickly as we would have expected. Possibly Ammianus thought it less necessary to revise digressions than he would narrative passages in the light of new information more relevant to the latter. He sometimes seems to apply different criteria to the two forms of writing (p. 389f.), and his words on the Serapeum may have been written earlier and left as they stood in a digression, despite the tragedy of 391. It is not impossible that Ammianus' history came out in instalments, the latest books (say 26-31) appearing after 391, the earlier, including the reference to the Serapeum, before that date. Libanius in his letter to Ammianus expresses hopes of a further contribution from the historian, and his words are sometimes taken to imply that he knew of a further instalment, soon to follow what had already been made public in the recitations of which he had been informed. Perhaps then Libanius anticipated the publication of Books 26-31, beginning as they do with a preface that seems, to some, to hint at a change of approach.³⁴ Yet we cannot be sure that Libanius knew enough about the scope and character of the history to validate this inference. Libanius had learned from his informants of recitations recently given from it. When a work of contemporary history was being presented to the public it was natural to wonder what its terminal point would be, and Libanius may simply have been expressing the polite, or even the self-interested, hope – for he himself was a considerable figure in Antiochene society in the 380s – that Ammianus would continue his story to the present day. Both literary convention and common tact would however advise Ammianus against this, and in an epilogue to the history he firmly assigned the continuation of his work to a new generation of writers (31.16.9).

Ammianus shows that he was up to the year 390 still engaged in compiling material for and at least revising, if not actually composing, parts of the earlier as well as the later books of his history. That these indications converge upon the later 380s, but that none falls after 390, suggests that completion of the history followed closely upon the latest

datable allusion (the consulship of Neoterius) which it contains. In terms of the evidence, a date of publication for the entire work in 390 or 391 remains the most convincing hypothesis.³⁵ It is also perfectly compatible with the letter of Libanius, written at the end of 392 but with information relevant to a slightly earlier time. If, as suggested earlier, Libanius' informants were returning to the east with the court of Theodosius, they had left Italy in the summer (late June) of 391.

*

The lost books of Ammianus pose many problems, not least that of their scale in proportion to what survives. The eighteen extant books cover the twenty-five years from 353 to 378, a ratio (to leave aside complications such as the incidence of digressions and the peculiar narrative intensity of certain books) of less than one-and-a-half years per book. The first thirteen books, covering the period of two hundred and fifty-seven years from AD 96 to 353 at a rate of twenty years per book, present a sharp contrast, made still more acute by the need to allow for the likelihood, argued above from the nature of Ammianus' back-references to them, that the books immediately preceding Book 14 were written on a comparable scale to what now survives. It would be reasonable to assume that the more detailed mode of writing began at least as early as the accession of Constantius in 337. If the expansion began, let us say, at Book 11 (giving a ratio of five years per book in the eventful first half of the reign of Constantius), the first ten books will have covered just over two hundred and forty years, at an average of almost twenty-five years for each book. If the expansion came earlier, for example with the conquest of the east by Constantine from Licinius in 324, the earliest books will have been still more compressed; six books from 96 to 324 would give an average of nearly forty years per book. It makes no substantial difference if we assume a gradual rather than a sudden expansion of treatment as Ammianus' account approaches the range of living memory; the contrast of scale, and therefore of manner, between the lost and the extant books will in any case have been conspicuous. The early books were not much more than introductory to what follows, and Ammianus' history remains in essentials a history of the present age, its nature defined by the methods outlined in the preface to Book 15; the recording of what Ammianus had himself seen, supported by the rigorous questioning of eye-witnesses.

This reconstruction of Ammianus' history has been questioned, and the suggestion made that the whole of the history of which we have Books 14-31 was devoted to the present age, the period from the principate of Nerva to where it began (whether the death of Constantine, or his conquest of the east from Licinius) being covered in a separate lost work of unknown but generous dimensions.³⁶ Introducing a digression on Egypt in Book 22, Ammianus remarks that he had twice before, in his accounts of the reigns of Hadrian and Septimius Severus, given full

descriptions of that country, basing his accounts in large part on what he had seen himself; 'quarum notitiam in actibus Hadriani et Severi principum digessimus late, visa pleraque narrantes' (22.15.1). If we can judge Ammianus' definition of a 'long' digression by reference to those that survive (including the excursus on Egypt in Book 22), then we must take his words seriously; and it is argued that for his accounts of Hadrian and Severus to contain such digressions, the narratives themselves must also have been too substantial to have been comprised in a mere thirteen books from Nerva to 354 (or whatever variation of these proportions is accepted from the previous paragraph). To meet these objections, a separate history was postulated, derived from written sources, to complement the one which we in part possess, based on verbal enquiries and personal experience. It is from a literary point of view an intriguing possibility, for Ammianus, a Greek, could have exploited Greek histories of the second and third centuries in order to make good the deficiencies of the poor Latin accounts of that period that were available; but it is more than this, for it affects our understanding not only of the formal nature of Ammianus' historical writing, but of the sort of individual he was. To the man of action and writer of memoirs, drawing on personal experience, travelling, searching out and questioning eye-witnesses, we must add the literary scholar and man of books, the author of a history quite different in kind from that which in part survives.

It is by no means an impossible image of Ammianus. The combination in a historian of man of affairs and man of letters was familiar to ancient opinion, which indeed expected it. It was designed to ensure that a historian had access to the best contemporary information, to guarantee the authority of the judgments expressed by a man with a general experience of politics and human affairs, and to offer the resources of literary culture necessary for their communication to an educated public – expectations no less relevant to the history of previous ages than to that of the present.³⁷ As for the literary erudition of Ammianus, the surviving books leave no doubt of that.

But there are difficulties with this view of his history. Little can safely be inferred from Ammianus' allusion to the 'long' digressions on Egypt in the books about Hadrian and Septimius Severus. There are no rules as to the 'proper' length of digressions in relation to their narrative contexts, and if there were such rules we could not apply them to Ammianus without knowing how he organised these passages of his earlier books. It is possible, for instance, that his account of the earlier empire was based not so much on direct or continuous narrative as on descriptions of its various regions, no doubt with emphasis on the wars conducted in them. He surely chose the reigns of Hadrian and Severus for his earlier descriptions of Egypt because of these emperors' famous visits to the province, but it does not follow either that the visits themselves or their narrative contexts were described in any great detail. Ammianus writes also of having described Trajan's and Severus' attacks on the desert city of Hatra 'when I digressed on these regions in my descriptions of their

deeds'; 'ut in eorum actibus has quoque digessimus partes' (25.8.5). In all these passages, the scale of the digressions may have been more ample than that of the narrative to which Ammianus took the opportunity to link them, his main purpose being to describe the regions of the empire rather than give a detailed narrative of the political history of the second and third centuries.

Further, when Ammianus refers back to events described in the lost books, he uses expressions like 'as I wrote above', 'as I said before', not seeming to imply that the reader had to look up a separate work in order to find the passages mentioned; and his expressions do not distinguish between the remoter and the more recent of the lost books. He can allude to the Parthian campaigns of Lucius Verus in the second century with the same phrase as that used of the conduct of a Roman general in the 340s ('ut ante rettulimus', 23.6.24; 14.7.7), or an event of the later years of Constantine ('ut dudum rettulimus plene', 24.4.23).³⁸ Moreover, it is sometimes implied that accounts of earlier events given in those books were not very detailed. An important, and certainly interesting, aspect of the reign of the Emperor Maximinus (235-8), the soothing influence of his wife upon his savage character, was described in Ammianus' account of the Gordians, suggesting that he did not assign to Maximinus the separate account one would have thought he deserved (14.1.8).³⁹ His recollection in Book 31 of the wars between Romans and Goths in the mid-third century is so confused in its chronology that it is hard to believe he had described them in any detail before, and he does not mention having done so, referring only to the possibly excessive claims made in unspecified historical works, or in the general historical tradition ('nisi fingunt annales'), as to the numbers of men killed in the sack of Philippopolis (31.5.15ff.).⁴⁰ He appears not to have described earlier the Persian attack on Antioch led by the traitor Mareades in the time of Gallienus, despite the evident interest and significance of that event (23.5.3; p. 170f.). It would be surprising if in a lengthy account he had omitted to mention the ruin of a considerable part of Alexandria in urban disorders in the time of Aurelian, or had said nothing about the execution of Crispus Caesar by Constantine the Great in 324; but he writes of both these events as if for the first time in the extant books (22.16.15; 14.11.20). In referring to Diocletian's introduction of Persian ceremonial to Roman court behaviour Ammianus does not indicate that he had written at any length on that most important subject in his discussion of the reign of Diocletian. He remarks only that 'we have read' that this was the case (15.5.18). Examination of his language in this passage suggests that his source was a standard Latin history of the period used also by the epitomators Eutropius and Aurelius Victor.⁴¹ This is an important point, for in general Ammianus' back-references do not indicate a much wider range of subject-matter, greater knowledge of historical detail, or superior judgment than that of the other sources that we possess. The majority of his references to the history of the earlier period can, where they are not commonplace, be explained in terms of the use of standard

sources like Cassius Dio, Herodian and the Latin history just mentioned. If Ammianus were able to cite a major work of his own on the second and third centuries, we would expect to learn much more from his back-references of what we do not otherwise know, than is actually the case.⁴² It still seems best therefore to regard the early books of Ammianus as little more than a substantial introduction to the history of the present age. An account of the period from Nerva to the death of Constantine in as few as nine or ten books, and even six books from Nerva to 324, would however be fuller than survives in any other non-biographical Latin source available to us.

*

The argument set out in this chapter has been very formal in character and has said little in substantive terms about the intellectual and literary character of Ammianus' history. This is deliberate, in order not to allow the interpretation of our author to be influenced at the outset by subjective impressions, but first to set out as neutrally as possible the objective framework within which his work evolved. For the present, certain possibilities may be stated briefly, if it is remembered that they are provisional statements only, subject to revision as we become more familiar with the actual content and manner of the history.

First, if Ammianus was able at a relatively late stage of composition to make significant additions to his material, not only as relevant to the history of his own day but also to that of earlier periods, then it is possible that his opinions also, as he set them down, are an expression of what he thought at the time of final composition rather than an array of unrevised attitudes from different periods of his life. Perhaps this should be put more cautiously: Ammianus had the opportunity to express himself more carefully if he felt that his earlier views were very different from what he now thought. What this implies for our understanding of Ammianus' historical perspectives is illustrated by the reflection that when he completed his work his opinion, for example, of the Emperor Julian was informed by the passage of nearly thirty years since Julian's death. Ammianus' admiration for Julian – modified, as we shall see, by criticisms of a disquieting accuracy – must be seen in the context not only of his acquaintance with the emperor as a young man but of his advance through the middle years of his life to the verge of old age, and of the demonstration in time of the failure of Julian's ambitions and the rejection by the emperors, and by Roman society at large, of his ideals. These are two variable factors – in Ammianus himself and in the society around him – that must not be ignored as we read his text.

Second, the process of the final composition of Ammianus' history – if by this we mean the gathering of the last of the information required, its arrangement or insertion into a planned overall design, and the presentation to the public of a definitive literary version – may for the entire work have been relatively short. It is impossible to calculate how

much preliminary writing and planning a historian may do before he reaches this stage, and obvious that much of Ammianus' material (especially in the digressions) was the product of many years' reading and annotation.⁴³ It would be absurd to imagine that no drafting was done in this period, the development of historical style requiring of all things time, practice, the willingness to experiment and to discard the unsuccessful. The Greek historian Cassius Dio noted that he had spent ten years collecting material for his history of Rome from the earliest times to the death of Septimius Severus in 211, and a further twelve years composing it (72.23.5).⁴⁴ Now, there are from every point of view many differences between Dio and Ammianus Marcellinus. Dio's planning was affected by the fact that contemporary history continued to be made after his originally envisaged terminal point and during the twelve-year period of composition, and that he attempted, as he had promised, to keep abreast of it. Ammianus stopped his narrative in 378. The question of continuation beyond that point did not arise, though he had no doubt begun writing before it, and his plan was not subject to revision in the same way or on the same scale as that of Dio. He would have to allow for the discovery of more material than he had expected to find, and may have changed his mind as to the emphasis he would give to certain subjects (the battle of Hadrianople, carrying the total of books to thirty-one rather than a round thirty, is an obvious possibility), but he was not liable to be overwhelmed by an ever-increasing flood of current events down to the actual moment of writing. Further, on the assumption made here that the earlier part of Ammianus' narrative did not constitute an entirely separate work but was contained within the thirty-one attested books, the proportion of contemporary to earlier historical material was very much higher in the case of Ammianus than in that of Cassius Dio. Given these different patterns of their works, it is only by the crudest of calculations that one can reduce the twelve years spent by Cassius Dio 'composing' his eighty books to the time required by Ammianus to compose his thirty-one; but the result, something of the order of five years, would be consistent with the indications set out in this chapter, suggesting a period of final composition beginning later than 383/4 and ending in 390 or very soon after that date. One could allow Ammianus longer, on the grounds that it is more difficult and takes more time to write history from primary sources than from books, but five years may not be a gross underestimate of the time taken for composition within a framework devised, and attitudes evolving, over the preceding twenty years.

Third, if Ammianus was engaged in composition in the later 380s, and prepared then to make substantial additions and insertions to material he had assembled earlier, then certain literary influences postulated in his evolution may also have exerted themselves relatively late. We do not know when he decided to extend his account back from his own day to begin with the accession of the Emperor Nerva in AD 96, nor why he chose that date precisely. Nor – another way of putting the same question and

an obvious answer to the second part of it – do we know when Ammianus became aware of the earlier Latin historical tradition to that point, as represented by Tacitus and Suetonius. Their contemporary, the satirist Juvenal, and Suetonius' successor as a historian, Marius Maximus, are mentioned by Ammianus in unflattering terms in his digression on the intellectual tastes of late Roman senators (28.4.14); of Suetonius and Tacitus themselves, not a word. Perhaps they were mentioned and their influence put on record in an early book now lost, but, on the arguments presented above, these early books do not seem central to Ammianus' historical conception. Given the dominance in the surviving books of recent eye-witness material, and the likelihood that this was true also of the immediately preceding books as far back as Book 10 or 11 if not earlier, it is not clear that the decision to start at AD 96 need have been of more than formal significance. One might choose it because it happened to be the point at which Tacitus and Suetonius ended, thereby asserting a certain continuity in the tradition, but it seems at least possible that the influence of these writers, and so Ammianus' standing in the Latin historiographical tradition, were secondary to a decision to write history originally conceived in rather different terms. Ammianus' acquaintance with Tacitus, if taken as proved (as it may not be) by the parallels of expression detected between them, does not seem to provide more than touches of stylistic colouring, with no apparent intention to evoke in any systematic way the substance or moral purpose of his predecessor's work.⁴⁵ If Tacitus were in any more profound sense Ammianus' model, his writing would be more remarkable for opportunities missed, than opportunities taken, to show it. The influence of Sallust is far more pointedly relevant, and it is to Sallust, if indeed to any single author, that we must look in considering the broader issue of Ammianus' conception of the 'dignity and character' of Roman history.

There is little to be gained at present by pursuing these reflections, whose purpose is merely to indicate the formal conditions within which Ammianus' work should be considered. In order to do justice to the substance of Ammianus' intellectual and literary evolution, we must try in more empirical terms to identify the origins of his decision to write history and to define the manner of writing that it entailed. To this theme my final chapter will return, after the description of Ammianus as participant in and observer of the Roman empire of his day that is the real subject of this book. We may start by looking in closer detail at his earlier life and career, beginning with his experiences as a young officer under Constantius and at the social and cultural milieu in eastern, and Antiochene, society from which he came.

CHAPTER III

Ammianus and Constantius: Civil Dissension and Foreign War

The first extant page of Ammianus' history plunges the reader into a sentence of a length and complexity entirely typical of Ammianus, and into an atmosphere of military and political crisis equally typical of the reign of Constantius.¹ No break is apparent from what has preceded, nor any expansion of scale, only a brief reminder of the point reached in the story. The context is the aftermath of the rebellion of Magnentius, and in particular of the battle of Mons Seleucus, after which Magnentius committed suicide (10 August 353). The war is over, the participants exhausted, but the clamour of trumpets is not yet quieted, nor the troops dispersed to winter quarters (14.1.1). The subject now changes abruptly. With dramatic effect as telling as the metaphor with which he makes the transition, Ammianus turns to the regime of Gallus Caesar at Antioch and judicial atrocities committed there; these were the 'strong blasts of raging fortune' afflicting the east, as the rebellion of Magnentius had the west (14.1.1-10). Diversions follow on the Isaurians and Saracens, divided, geographically as in sequence, by a Persian raid on Mesopotamia (14.2-4); but immediately Ammianus brings his narrative back to the west, it is to tell of the inquisitions conducted in Britain and Gaul to root out and punish the supporters of Magnentius (14.5). It was above all the suspicion of treason, wrote Ammianus, that stirred Constantius to anger and laid him open to the influence of his associates, who by bloody insinuations ('cruentae blanditiae') built up incidental events into matters of state security and persuaded the emperor that the well-being of the whole world hung, as it were, by the thread of his personal safety: 'velut filo pendere statum orbis terrarum' (14.5.4).

Constantius' suspicion of political dissent, and his dependence on supporters who exploit his weakness to further their own ambitions, are central themes in Ammianus' judgment of this emperor. The intensity of his narrative of Constantius' inquisitions in Britain and Gaul is deliberately heightened by the implied comparison with the regime of Gallus at Antioch. But it is not enough simply to explain the whole affair as a product of the emperor's personal character. In his previous book, Ammianus has narrated a serious rebellion in the western provinces. Political dissension was not a figment of Constantius' brooding

imagination or his supporters' invention, but present reality. Political trials were the least to be expected, with torture, death sentences and exiles, and false as well as true accusations their normal counterpoint. For those involved, it was an unpleasant time in which to be living, but the emperor was not alone responsible for that.

Ammianus' presentation of the atmosphere as one of suspicion and uncertainty, and of the emperor's character as the main cause of it, was however a true reflection of his own experience. If the civil war had thrown into doubt the loyalty of Constantius' western provinces, the conduct in the east of Gallus Caesar had proved far from reassuring. Early in 354, Ammianus' superior, the *magister equitum* Ursicinus, was recalled from Nisibis by Gallus to take part in investigations into treason pursued at Antioch.² Someone, it was not known who or for what purpose, had ordered a cloak of imperial purple from the dye-works at Tyre. Employees in the workshops confessed under torture to preparing also a purple tunic; and a letter was found from a Christian deacon to a weaving factory at Tyre, asking for a job, of an unspecified nature, to be hurried along. The deacon was tortured to the point of death but revealed nothing. Others were executed, including an orator from Emesa in Syria and a Cilician philosopher, together with the provincial governor of Phoenicia and his son, an imperial official (14.9.1-9). The orator and the philosopher were cases of mistaken identity, their informer (now dead) having meant to incriminate two managers of arms factories with the same names (14.7.18).

This was the authentic stuff of treason trials in the Roman empire. But there were serious issues behind these messy allegations. The provincial governor's son had been sent by his father-in-law to Mesopotamia, to find out from the troops there whether incriminating messages had been received from Gallus Caesar, suggesting that he might be aiming at imperial power for himself (14.7.19). The father-in-law was the late praetorian prefect, Domitianus, another recent victim – if he was not also an agent – of the suspicions that attended Constantius' relations with his Caesar. On his arrival at Antioch, Domitianus had snubbed Gallus and threatened to cut off his supplies, but had been lynched by Gallus' soldiers (7.16).³ The delicacy in the situation lay in the fact that the prefect was an agent of Constantius, sent to Antioch specifically to restrain Gallus' behaviour and to induce him, if possible, to return to the court in Italy (7.9). It is likely too that Domitianus' enquiries among the soldiers in Mesopotamia were made on Constantius' instructions. In his investigations at Antioch, Gallus was enquiring, consciously or not, into the intelligence activities of Constantius' own agents in the east. From a western point of view, suspicion of treason fell upon Gallus Caesar.

Ursicinus, who on Ammianus' account took a reluctant part in the proceedings at Antioch, was described by the historian as a man of war, a soldier and a leader of soldiers, ill at ease with disputes at law and outclassed in cunning by those with whom he was now associated (14.9.1). At the trials, Ursicinus was the mere shadow of a judge

(‘*imaginarius iudex*’), surrounded by court attendants who had been told in advance what was required, and by secretaries who wrote everything down and took it straight to Gallus (9.3). One can well understand Ursicinus’ action in writing ‘secret letters’ to Constantius, in the hope that an intervention from him might do something to restrain his Caesar (9.1f.). Ammianus took the view that Ursicinus should have been bolder in justifying his conduct to Constantius, for his participation in the trials, seen from the west, was highly suspect. He was caught in a most difficult conflict of loyalties. He had no choice, short of declaring rebellion against his immediate master, but to obey Gallus’ summons to come to Antioch; while, taking the broader view of his situation, it is unlikely that Ursicinus or anyone else had a true impression of the extent of Constantius’ intelligence operations in the east. But on any account, as *magister equitum* and – so it seems – presiding officer at the trials, Ursicinus carried some responsibility for the sentences inflicted after the hearings. Ammianus himself regarded the sentences as no better than judicial murder (9.5f.).

It was no doubt Gallus’ conduct of these investigations which finally brought Constantius to the conclusion that he must be removed – by direct methods where indirect ones had failed. The arrest and execution of Gallus are narrated by Ammianus with an intensity and sense of atmosphere which it would be pointless to attempt to match (14.11.1-24). For the development of Ammianus’ own career, the attitude of Constantius to Ursicinus is a more fruitful line of enquiry.⁴ Again, Ammianus’ interpretation is made to hang on Constantius’ character, in particular his obsessive fear of conspiracy. He is said to have been convinced that, with Gallus once removed, Ursicinus would be likely to make his own bid for power – he was popular and well known in the east, and possessed two active and able sons, whom he might use to support his claims as a rival (11.2f.). He was therefore replaced for the time being by another general and summoned to Milan for ‘consultations’ with the emperor. Ammianus went with him, the party travelling with all possible speed by the imperial transport service (11.4f.). Only after Ursicinus’ departure was Gallus removed from Antioch, stripped of his support and placed under arrest, and finally executed at Pola in Istria (11.20ff.).⁵

Ammianus’ portrayal of the events which he witnessed under Constantius, and indeed of the general character of his reign, was influenced by considerations of a rather personal nature. First was his close relationship to Ursicinus, to whose staff he had been assigned, with implications that will be considered later, by imperial commission; ‘*cui nos obsecuturos iunxerat imperiale praeceptum*’. Then, there was the atmosphere of suspicion and tension in which this phase of Ursicinus’ career was enveloped. This, as we have seen, was not simply a matter of the invention of the emperor and his associates, although it certainly allowed scope for this, but of the actual situation of the time – with civil war only recently suppressed in the west and growing doubts as to the intentions of Gallus Caesar.

To this extent, Ammianus' explanation of the political climate as the expression of Constantius' obsessive and easily intimidated temperament is less than just. But given the nature of Ammianus' involvement with Ursicinus, a 'just' assessment of Constantius would be more than we could reasonably expect. Beyond the immediate circles of those openly involved in rebellion, the detection of political dissidence is at all times a question of interpretation, of the constructions placed by others upon the attitudes and intentions of those suspected. As Ammianus admitted, Ursicinus might have done more to put himself on the right side of Constantius' opinion in the matter of Gallus' trials at Antioch, and it takes little imagination to suppose that there were men at court who would welcome the opportunity to remove a long-serving general in favour of some other candidate, one perhaps closer to themselves and a possible source of political favour. Whether, in the prevailing atmosphere, Ursicinus survived or fell might depend less upon any objective assessment of his attitudes than on the interpretation of them put about by some such individual or group in the emperor's entourage, and on Constantius' response to it. If Ammianus' view of Constantius' behaviour and mentality is a less than dispassionate analysis of the situation, it is a true reflection of Ursicinus' and so of Ammianus', standing in it.

At Milan, the position of Ursicinus was indeed no less precarious than before. After the arrest and execution of Gallus, he became the object of accusations of treason, to which the emperor was receptive (15.2.1). Ammianus portrayed his patron as courageous and firm, but saddened because his previously numerous friends had begun to leave him for men of more promising influence. He alleged a secret plot to seize Ursicinus from the company of the soldiers and assassinate him; all was ready, claimed Ammianus, but at the last moment the plan was postponed by the emperor's intervention (2.5). The allegation is untestable and need not be taken very seriously; yet, again, it vividly reflects the anxious state of mind of Ursicinus and his protégé as they awaited the resolution of the emperor's uncertainty. At this point, Ammianus compared Ursicinus to Domitius Corbulo, the general of the early empire who, after defending Nero's provinces loyally and with care, was killed on his instructions. With the reservation that Corbulo was not executed but forced to suicide by Nero, the parallel is a close one. Corbulo, like Ursicinus, had achieved his renown on the eastern frontier of the empire and was involved with political dissidence, if at all, only indirectly and by association.⁶

By process of natural insinuation, the suspicion at Constantius' court came to involve Gallus' half-brother, Julian, who was in danger of falling victim to the machinations of Constantius' advisers and was brought to Comum near Milan; suspected because he had seen Gallus Caesar on his doomed journey through Constantinople, but defended by the Empress Eusebia, Julian was allowed to leave for academic studies at Athens (15.2.7f.). Meanwhile the governor of Pannonia Secunda was brought down after indiscreet conversations at a dinner-party at Sirmium

(3.7-11). Ursicinus waited on at Milan while the emperor went on a campaign in Raetia against the Alamanni, but in the late summer of 355 was unexpectedly given the opportunity to restore his standing.

The opportunity arose, ironically, from yet another rebellion in the west. The *magister peditum* at Cologne, Silvanus, became the object of an immensely complicated plot at Milan involving letters forged above his signature, on paper from which the rest of his handwriting had been erased (15.5.3f.).⁷ The plot, set up by various minor officials and – so rumour had it – the praetorian prefect of Gaul and others in the highest state offices, was uncovered by enquiries at Milan undertaken at the insistence of Silvanus' Frankish colleagues there. The forgeries were incompetently done and easily detected, but in the meantime Silvanus, embroiled in suspicion and knowing the times, embarked upon rebellion as his only means of defence; it was a case of suspicion actually bringing about what was suspected. Ammianus' narrative conveys vividly the speed and tension of subsequent events (5.17ff.). News of the proclamation arrived at Milan one evening, and a council of state was summoned. The high officials hurried along to the palace at the second watch of night. The discussion in the consistory, at first confused, in time brought hesitant, then more confident mention of Ursicinus as a man equipped by military experience to undertake the suppression of Silvanus, and unjustly under a cloud of suspicion. He was sent for and introduced into the consistory. It was a difficult moment. Beginning a speech of self-defence, Ursicinus was checked by the emperor's mild rejoinder that this was no time for recrimination, the necessity of empire requiring unanimous and decisive action before any more harm could develop (5.20).⁸

As to tactics, it was decided that Ursicinus should go to Cologne pretending to know nothing of the proclamation, but that he had simply come with letters appointing him to succeed Silvanus. With him was sent a group of tribunes and ten *protectores domestici*, and they were to handle the situation in the light of what they should find. Ammianus (and, no doubt, Ursicinus) could not help thinking that, behind all the talk of Ursicinus' abilities and loyal service, it was really in Constantius' mind that he would in any event get rid of one of his dangerous subjects, Silvanus or Ursicinus (15.5.19). It was a natural reflection, but unfair, for it takes no account of the immense problem facing Constantius if Silvanus should succeed in establishing his regime.

Ammianus himself was one of the ten *protectores* in attendance on Ursicinus (15.5.22). He had little hope of returning alive from the mission. Each member of the party thought only, as he measured out the long journey to the north, of his own prospects of survival. In somewhat contradictory fashion, Ammianus also claimed that all reflected, as they travelled, on Cicero's sentiments on the relief brought by the restoration of good fortune after bad (5.23). One would imagine that this is a touch that occurred to Ammianus later, as he looked back on his experience.⁹

The arrival of the party at Cologne brought no improvement in their

prospects. It was evident that Silvanus was popular there, and that unless Ursicinus and his men employed the very greatest circumspection they were liable to be condemned and executed 'under a single proclamation'; 'constabat nos omnes sub elogio uno morte multandos' (15.5.26). The whole situation was beyond their control; 'cuncta nostris conatibus altiora' (5.24). Yet, given time, stealth might pay off. Under guise of friendship and sympathy with Silvanus, Ursicinus' men tested the loyalty of his supporters. While Ursicinus was honoured and dined by Silvanus, sharing treasonable confidences on the state of the empire and their own frustrations, soldiers from the Bracchiati and Cornuti were found ready, for money, to attack Silvanus early one morning, haul him from the Christian chapel where he took refuge and kill him (5.31).¹⁰

Ammianus, no doubt reflecting Ursicinus' opinion, expressed admiration for Silvanus. He was a general of distinction who had supported Constantius loyally, as his father, a Frank called Bonitus, had supported Constantine. Like Ursicinus, Silvanus had received less recognition than his services merited. Men of lesser deserts were raised to the consulship, while Silvanus – again, comparison with Ursicinus is implied – unjustly suspected of disloyalty, was forced into it. Yet Ammianus had no comment to make, no scruple to express, on the manner of Silvanus' suppression. Having with Ursicinus successfully performed Constantius' commission, he wrote of the outcome with detachment, as merely a question of expediency and efficiency. Viewing their accomplishment in this light, they had indeed done very well.

Even after the suppression of Silvanus, the incorrigibly suspicious emperor complained to Ursicinus that the Gallic treasuries had been interfered with (15.5.36). Ammianus asserted that no one had touched them, and, in any event, Ursicinus was instructed to succeed Silvanus as commander-in-chief of the Rhine armies, and retained that command after the arrival of the new Caesar, Julian, appointed by Constantius late in 355. His position was somewhat anomalous. Since his recall for consultations at court, Ursicinus had neither been relieved of nor promoted from his post as *magister equitum* in the east, where a deputy, Prosper, held office as *comes* until he should return (14.11.5). In 356, Ursicinus received a successor, Marcellus, in Gaul, but again was instructed to remain there until the end of the campaigning season (16.2.8). In fact, he was in Gaul for eighteen months, until the early summer of 357 (16.10.21), and Ammianus was with him for all that time.

Ammianus recalled aspects of his stay beyond the Alps, some of them surely from personal experience. He mentioned inscriptions which he had read on the mythical origins of the country (15.9.6). He had apparently seen the remains of Aventicum (Avenches), 'now a deserted city, but once of some distinction, as its half-ruined buildings demonstrate to the present day' (15.11.12). A description of the decayed walls of Augustodunum (Autun) need in itself owe nothing to personal knowledge on Ammianus' part, though it is likely enough that he had been there (16.2.1). Other allusions prompt more speculative inferences. Ammianus

narrated at one point an accusation of treason which arose out of an opulent dinner-party in Aquitania, 'such as are very often given in those parts' (16.8.8). Perhaps the reputation of this part of Gaul for wealth and elegance, expressed in its many literary productions of the fourth century, explains Ammianus' information on this matter. But it might be simpler to believe that he had some personal knowledge, having himself been to such parties. A common stereotype, rather than personal experience, was presumably behind another of Ammianus' livelier pictures, that of the enraged Gallic housewife entering the fray in support of her man, baring mighty arms and levelling blows 'like a catapult' (15.12.1)!¹¹ Gauls in general, Ammianus went on, are loud and threatening in manner, even when in good humour, but they are proud of their appearance and one will rarely see a Gallic man or woman, however poor, in ragged or dirty clothes. Again, Ammianus thought of Aquitania as particularly bearing out the truth of this remark (15.12.2).

*

Ammianus witnessed in Gaul the first phase of Julian's achievement as Caesar, which he believed to be even more remarkable than what followed later – above all, because it was so unexpected (16.1.5). But he did not himself see the climax of this phase, the battle of Argentorate (Strasbourg) at which Julian's army routed the confederation of Alamannic tribes led by king Chnodomarius; for, by then, Ursicinus, still attended by Ammianus, had at last been relieved of his command in Gaul and allowed to take up his appointment in the east. Constantius had just completed his visit to Rome, from where, on 29 May 357, he departed to march to Sirmium by way of Tridentum (Trento), in the valley of the Adige. It was to Sirmium that Ursicinus was summoned, to resume his commission as *magister equitum* in the east. The more senior of his companions were promoted to independent commands of their own. The younger members ('adolescentes'), among whom Ammianus classed himself, were directed to stay with Ursicinus 'to perform whatever public service he should assign to us' (16.10.21). Relations between the Romans and the Persian king had recently developed in the light of the latter's difficulties with the rebellious eastern regions of his empire. The praetorian prefect of the east had judged that it might be possible to use the moment to conclude peace, and it was with this in view that Constantius sent Ursicinus, the best known of his generals on the eastern frontier, to resume his service there.

At the beginning of 358, the Persian king was still occupied with rebellion in the east. But he heard of Constantius' interest in a settlement just as he had resolved his difficulties there. Guessing that the emperor would not have made overtures unless he were himself in difficulties, Sapor was inspired to write aggressively to Constantius, demanding the return of his 'ancestral dominions' in Mesopotamia and Armenia. There was little Constantius could do, in the exchange of letters whose general

purport is recorded by Ammianus (17.5.1ff.),¹² other than inform him that the usurpations in the Roman empire were suppressed, utter some sort of warning and meanwhile try to delay the Persians' preparations (5.15). But an embassy, the first of two that were sent to achieve this, returned unsuccessful (14.1f.).

After these diplomatic skirmishes, which occupied the summer of 358, events began to move very quickly. During the winter, Sapor was assembling his army, and preparing supplies and equipment for an offensive into the disputed provinces. At this time Ammianus, still no doubt with Ursicinus, was at Samosata, a strategic crossing of the upper Euphrates (18.4.7). Even at this distance, Ursicinus was not safe from his enemies at court, 'night and day banging away at the same anvil', who were still portraying the general as a threat to the emperor's position; chief among them was the eunuch Eusebius, annoyed with Ursicinus because he refused to make over to him his house at Antioch (4.3). Ursicinus therefore received his recall to court, where he would be more exposed to his enemies, and less likely to rebel. This was Ammianus' explanation; in fact, Ursicinus was recalled to replace Barbatio as *magister peditum* in the west. Barbatio had just been beheaded for treason, and Ursicinus' recall to serve near the emperor should undoubtedly be construed as a promotion, as indeed Ammianus states; 'dignitate adficiendus superiore' (6.1). It also seems evident that, once at court, Ursicinus should have found it easier, not more difficult, to defend himself against the attacks of rivals there.

Ammianus claimed that, far from being taken from the Persian front, Ursicinus should have been assigned to it, even if he had to be summoned from the ends of the earth (18.6.1). Nor did he think much of Ursicinus' successor Sabinianus, of whom he wrote with hearty dislike as a cultivated and well-heeled old gentleman, but obscure and quite unfitted for matters of war (5.5):¹³ small in stature and narrow in mind, he could scarcely tolerate even the noise of a banquet, let alone battle (6.7). But Ursicinus obeyed the summons and set out on the long road west, turning aside the decrees and acclamations of cities trying to retain him as their protector (6.2); in such apparently spontaneous, but in fact calculated, expressions of sentiment by local communities, one gains some idea of the danger which an emperor might feel from a long-serving and popular general in a particular region (below, p. 405). The party had not far passed the Bosphorus when yet more letters were received from Constantius, instructing Ursicinus to return to the eastern front. This mandate was received by Ursicinus at the river Hebrus in Thrace (the Maritza, in European Turkey), and after some baffled hesitation he obeyed it (6.5-7).¹⁴ To Ammianus', and presumably to Ursicinus', disgust, Sabinianus was left in office. Ammianus again saw this as an attempt to undermine Ursicinus, since if the Persians were repelled Sabinianus would be given the credit, and Ursicinus disgraced if they were not (6.6); but this view ignores the different military functions to be filled by the two men.¹⁵ Ursicinus was to take local measures for frontier defence,

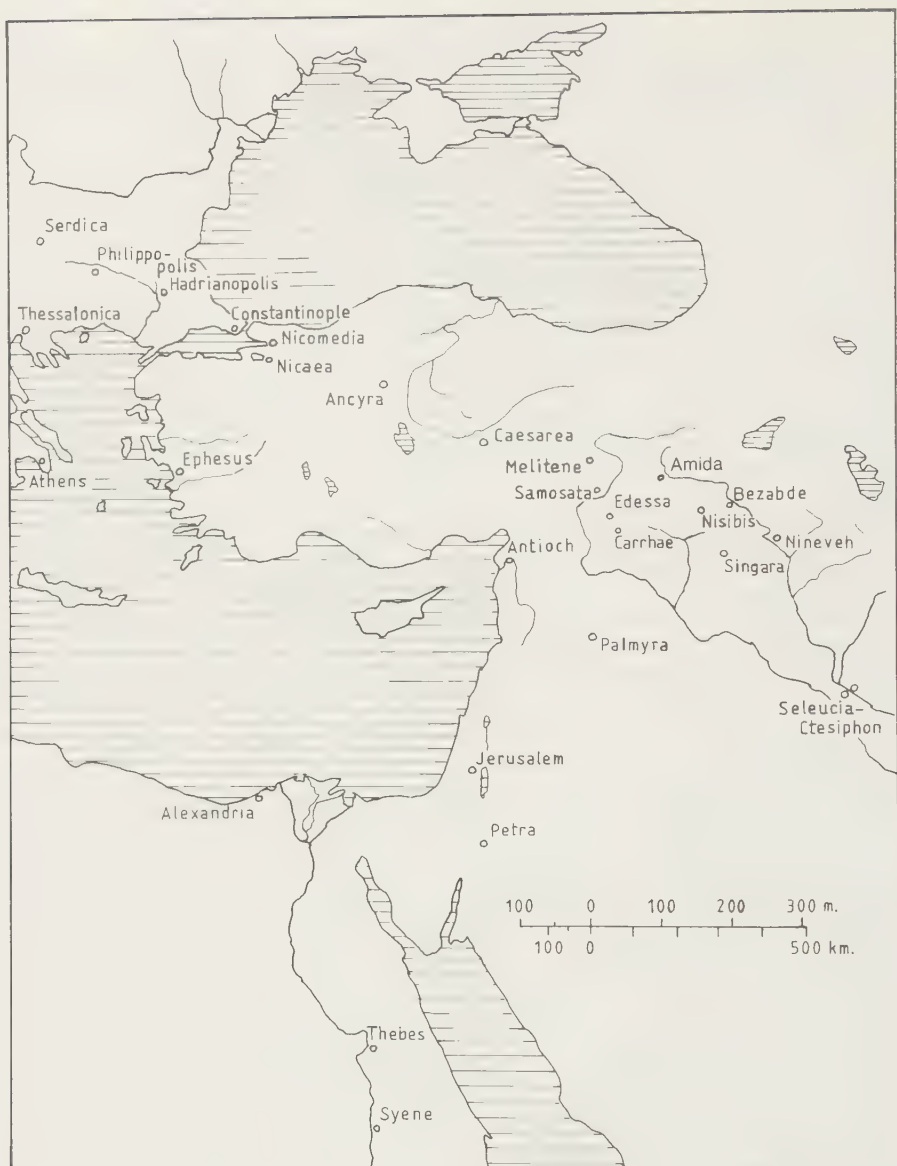
Sabinianus to manage the larger deployments and to preserve intact the main body of Constantius' army in case a major engagement with the Persians had to be fought (cf. 19.3.2).

Nor were Constantius' changes of plan as wilful as they seemed to Ammianus and Ursicinus. The situation in the east was developing very fast, and the government had to respond to its changing phases as well as it could at the considerable distance – over 1,500 miles – at which it was placed from the scene of action. Just at the time that Ursicinus was recalled to court, a Roman from Syria, named Antoninus, defected to Persia with intelligence on Roman military dispositions. Received with delight at the Persian court, Antoninus encouraged Sapor's intention to attack the Roman provinces. It was the intensification of Sapor's preparations in the light of the intelligence brought by Antoninus that prompted Ursicinus' re-assignment to the Mesopotamian theatre of war. That he should have received notice of this re-assignment in what were to him such puzzling circumstances is a measure of the time needed by a government in the west to receive information from the eastern frontier and to react to it by sending instructions to participants who were nearer the sources of information than was the emperor himself.

Returning east, Ursicinus left Sabinianus to his slumbers at Edessa and rode to Nisibis to prepare it for a siege. Events were indeed developing rapidly, for the first stages of the invasion had already begun. From the walls of Nisibis, fires could be seen burning in the country as far as the Tigris: Persian raiding parties had crossed the river and were on their way (18.6.9). Ursicinus left Nisibis and pressed on to make arrangements elsewhere. Two miles from the city, the party encountered in the road a little boy, wailing because his mother, distracted by terror of the enemy and hurrying to get to the safety of the city, had lost him. The boy was well dressed and apparently came from a good family; so Ammianus was detailed to take him back to Nisibis. He rode with the boy to the city walls and put him down inside a postern gate. Persian raiders were already surrounding the city, and Ammianus did not want to get caught up in a siege, so he galloped off to catch up his party. Slipping pursuit, he saw Ursicinus and his party resting at a weak fortification called Amudis, their horses put out to graze around it.¹⁶ He warned them of the Persians' approach by waving his cloak in the air and joined the party, which hurried on, Ammianus and his now weary horse keeping up with difficulty (6.13).

Night came and with it a full moon, and the group was confronted by an open, treeless plain; so they employed the classic device of fixing a light to a pack animal and driving it off in another direction as a decoy. Only this stratagem, thought Ammianus, had saved them from capture. Pausing only to seize, interrogate and put to death a Roman soldier (a Gaul from Paris) who had deserted to the Persians and was sent back by them as a spy, Ursicinus and his followers reached Amida (18.6.16).

Here, Ammianus' narrative takes on still more of the air of an



Map 1. The Roman East.

adventure story. Scouts returning to the city brought with them, hidden in a sword-scabbard exactly as recommended by Frontinus three centuries earlier (*Strat.* 3.13.5), a ciphered letter from the second group of ambassadors whom Constantius had sent to the Persian court (cf. 17.14.2). The envoys of the Greeks, ran the message, given by Ammianus in a Latin version of a presumably (once deciphered) Greek original, had

been sent away, perhaps to their deaths; 'while that aged king, not satisfied with the Hellespont, will join bridges over the Granicus and Rhyndacus and invade Asia with many peoples. He is by nature prone to anger and very cruel, and is urged on and provoked by the successor of Hadrian, a Roman emperor of former times'. Unless Greece took care, the message ended, she was finished and her funeral rites sung (18.6.18).

Ammianus recalls that the cipher was found very difficult to understand – an observation that sounds more surprising than it should, partly because Ammianus has already given the text and its interpretation when he makes it. The message in the scabbard was written in symbols ('notarum figuris', 18.6.7) which, even when deciphered, yielded a second code describing the present situation by allusion to a historical parallel that was not totally obvious, and indeed has only recently been fully interpreted.¹⁷ The message attests favourably the historical culture of its senders, as well as some optimistic assumptions on their part as to the culture of those to whom it was sent. It should have been enough to baffle the intelligence, though it would no doubt have raised the suspicions, of any Persian who intercepted it and managed to get any sense from its coded symbols; and it may be that even Ursicinus and his advisers did not appreciate every nuance. It referred, not as one might suppose to the great invasion of Greece by Xerxes in 480 BC, but to the invasion of the Roman province of Asia by King Mithridates VI (Eupator) at the beginning of the third Mithridatic War in 74/3 BC. Mithridates, not Xerxes (or Alexander the Great) was the 'aged king' of fierce temper who would bring many foreign allies against Asia (Appian, *Mithr.* 69-71). Beyond this point, and even without understanding all the historical allusions of the message, it was relatively easy to interpret Mithridates' objective 'Asia' as the Roman province of Syria, and a matter of basic historical knowledge to identify the 'successor of Hadrian' as Antoninus, who had deserted to Persia and was now supplying Sapor with the military intelligence he was using in the preparations for his invasion. As for the 'bridges over the Granicus and Rhyndacus', Mithridates would have crossed these rivers in his march from the Hellespont to Asia: they were identified by Ursicinus and his aides with the Anzaba (the Greater Zab) and the Tigris. Sapor was therefore intending to cross both the Greater Zab and the Tigris, presumably (to make the double crossing worth while) at some distance above the confluence of the two rivers. Even if this were correct (and it might not be), much remained open. The Persians might take a line along the hills of Sinjar, passing the city of Singara, where Constantius and Sapor had fought a drawn battle in the 340s, and then – with difficulty – march north-west to Nisibis or Carrhae: they might, on the other hand, follow the Tigris another forty or fifty miles upstream, crossing it somewhere south of Bezabde and then marching into the Roman empire along the flank of the Tur Abdin. For a general concerned with local defence, these alternatives made a considerable difference. It is true that raiding parties had reached Nisibis; but who could tell what was happening meanwhile at Singara?

To try to verify and put more precise detail into their information,

Ursicinus and his colleagues devised a plan to send Ammianus himself on a spying mission to the satrapy of Corduene in northern Mesopotamia. It happened that the governor, or satrap, of Corduene was known to Ammianus. His name was Jovinianus – at least this was the name he assumed on Roman soil, since he had earlier been sent to Syria as a hostage, and was there filled with such a love of liberal studies that he wished for nothing more than to return to the Roman empire (18.6.20).¹⁸ He is described by Ammianus as a young man, ‘adolescens’, and so was the same sort of age as himself; and Ammianus’ recognition and warm reception by Jovinianus after his journey to him ‘through trackless mountains and precipitous passes’ in the company of a loyal centurion, may suggest that the two men had known each other quite well. It is an obvious conjecture that they had been educated together at Antioch (below, pp. 55ff.).

Jovinianus provided his visitor with a discreet native guide, with whose help Ammianus reached a vantage point in the mountains from which, he wrote, even the smallest objects were visible at fifty miles’ distance, ‘if only the eyes were keen enough’ (18.6.21). Ammianus waited there for two days and on the morning of the third saw what he had come for: the entire country filled to the horizons with the vast army of the Persian king, as he led it over the Zab and past the site of ancient Nineveh against the Roman empire (18.7.1). The array seemed to Ammianus to put to shame the boastful legends of the Greeks on the invasion of Xerxes, who in the famous story had counted his troops by corralling them in batches of ten thousand. The total of that army, so counted, was alleged to have come to a million and seven hundred thousand men (Herodotus 7.60ff.). Ammianus’ literary flourish – this is of course what it is – may seem extravagant, but it is how one might expect to find conveyed to an educated Graeco-Roman public an impression of the sheer scale of the threat now facing the east Roman empire.

Ammianus judged that the army would take a full three days to pass over into the Roman empire. He had also established, as the ciphered message had indicated but despite Roman fears to the contrary, that the Persians were in fact taking a more northerly route rather than crossing the Tigris directly – below its junction with the Greater Zab – by a single bridge of boats (18.7.2).¹⁹ He therefore allowed himself to rest a little and be entertained by Jovinianus – the two men doubtless recalling in their conversations old times together at Antioch as well as matters closer at hand. He then returned to Ursicinus, who immediately sent fast dispatch-riders with orders to the military and civil governors of Mesopotamia to evacuate Carrhae and clear the country people off the land. The Romans set fire to the grasslands to deprive the Persians of fodder, and sent detachments to fortify the west bank of the Euphrates with manned fortifications, palisades and artillery (7.6).

So Ursicinus pursued his instructions to supervise the local preparations for war, while Sabinianus remained inactive, conducting military exercises among the graveyards outside the walls of Edessa ‘as if

he had made peace with the dead' (18.7.7).²⁰ Meanwhile, the Persian army had after crossing the Tigris skirted the hills (the southern edge of the Tur Abdin) to avoid the scorched plains, and passing Nisibis without attacking it turned further to the north; they had learned that the Euphrates was in spate and must be crossed higher up. Sapor was evidently still directing his invasion against the cities of northern Syria. Ursicinus countered this by making for Samosata, with the intention of breaking the bridges at Zeugma and Capersana (8.1), but he was frustrated at the outset of this manoeuvre by the failure of a recently arrived Illyrian detachment, set to guard the road near Amida. Ursicinus and Ammianus found their party surprised by Persian cavalry, and were forced to fight their way out of it. At the beginning of the skirmish, which went on for half an hour (8.7), Ursicinus and the renegade Antoninus actually met and, in a curiously ceremonious scene, exchanged words; at the end of it, more Persians arrived, and the Romans had to meet their danger as best as each man could, fighting in scattered groups right up to the steep banks of the Tigris (8.9). Some fell in and were drowned, dragged down by their armour or pulled under by the current. Others got away and made for the mountains. Ursicinus himself escaped with a tribune and a single attendant.

Separated from his party, Ammianus looked around him and saw a *protector* struggling up, with an arrow in his thigh. It was Verinianus, also named as one of the party sent to suppress Silvanus at Cologne and so an old comrade of Ammianus (15.5.22). Ammianus stopped to help him but was again threatened by Persians and made his way alone towards Amida. Verinianus is not mentioned again nor is his fate described, and it does not look as if Ammianus waited to see what it was. Rushing frantically towards the city, he joined crowds of others, Romans and Persians, all struggling to reach the higher ground where Amida stood. Only a single approach to the city was open – a narrow track, further constricted by artificial obstructions placed there precisely to prevent easy access.²¹ All night they waited without moving, so closely packed together that corpses were propped upright, unable to fall: in front of Ammianus, a hideous companion, a soldier with his head split from top to bottom by a ferocious blow from a sword and gaping apart, but standing there like an upright post or tree stump.²² Above, the defensive artillery thundered and howled, hurling its missiles over the heads of the refugees as they huddled below the city walls. So Ammianus edged his way into the city through a postern gate. Inside, too, he found great crowds; the Persian attack had happened to coincide with an annual fair, and thousands of the country folk had come to the city as innocent visitors. Here it was the confused noise of human voices that Ammianus recalled, of people wailing for their dead, crying with pain from their wounds, calling out for their families, lost in the narrow, crowded streets (8.14).

When Ammianus came to describe the siege of Amida, it seemed to him, in a memorable expression, that the city and its region had attracted to themselves the sufferings of the entire Roman world; '*Romanae rei totius*

aerumnas intra unius regionis... ambitum' (19.1.4). It was left to face them without much help from the Roman authorities. Despite Ursicinus' complaints, Sabinianus refused to commit his forces to the relief of Amida. Perhaps he was right to do so, and he was certainly fulfilling the letter of his instructions from Constantius not to risk his forces in a major engagement before the emperor himself could reach the scene (3.2). In any event, it seems unlikely that, had he sent 'all his light-armed troops' to Amida, as Ursicinus suggested, these forces would have had much impact on the huge Persian army around the city. Ammianus should have reminded himself, as he set out his judgment on Sabinianus' behaviour, that he had compared this army to the hosts of Xerxes (18.6.23).

Ammianus' description of the siege of Amida, and of his own part in it, is one of the high points of his history (indeed, of all Latin historical writing), and is discussed in detail in the next chapter (IV.2). After more than two months, the defence of the city finally yielded to the Persian attack. Ammianus, seeing the end as the Persians overran the defences, slipped out (in a masterpiece of under-statement as well as cunning) as he had entered the city, by a postern gate.²³ After more adventures, he came with his two companions to Melitene. There he found Ursicinus, whom he accompanied back to Antioch: he had thought that he would never see it again (19.8.12). Among the defenders of Amida, the count and tribunes in charge of the defence of the walls were crucified by the Persians, and the *protectores* were led off into captivity, hands bound behind their backs (9.1). Ammianus must have found this out later. Had he stayed in the city, he would have been among them – and our knowledge of late Roman history would have been immeasurably the poorer.

Sapor's anger is easy to understand. The siege of Amida had detained him for seventy-three days, diverted him from his main object and cost the lives of thirty thousand soldiers (19.9.9). On the Roman side Constantius, stunned by the loss of the city, appointed two senior officers to enquire why it had happened. For Ammianus and Ursicinus, the reason was obvious. Sabinianus had been implored by Ursicinus to send help to Amida, but had refused from inertia and envy, and was therefore to blame for its loss (20.2.3). As we have seen, this was not a balanced assessment of the situation, and it took no account of Sabinianus' instructions from Constantius. Ammianus was certainly entitled to ask himself what more he personally could have done, but that is not quite the same question.

By this time, Constantius had returned from the west to Constantinople to take on the Persian threat at close hand (19.11.17),²⁴ and Ursicinus had joined him to assume his appointment as *magister peditum* at the imperial court, held over since his temporary reassignment to the eastern frontier. He had clearly not so far been held responsible for the loss of Amida; but now he felt that the commission of enquiry was against him, in refusing to see the obvious and accept his denunciations of Sabinianus. Placing the blame, as he was inclined to, with his personal

enemies and especially with the eunuch Eusebius, Ursicinus demanded that his case could properly be heard only by the emperor in person. This was not unreasonable, but Ursicinus added tactless aspersions against Constantius' advisers, finally proclaiming that if the emperor continued to submit to the judgment of eunuchs, nothing could prevent the total seizure of Mesopotamia the following year, even if he came with an army himself to defend it (20.2.4). His sentiments were conveyed to the emperor. It was enough, and Ursicinus was dismissed.

In 360 the Persians did renew their attack, and Constantius was present to meet them. Yet he was unable to prevent the siege and capture of Singara and Bezabde (20.6-7), and his efforts to recover Bezabde late in the season were cut short by the onset of bad weather (20.11).

It has been suggested that Ammianus remained in active service between 360 and 363, and even that the vividness of his account of the siege of Bezabde shows that he was present under the command of Constantius at the operations there.²⁵ But compared with what precedes, his narrative of this event gives no real indication of personal involvement, and it seems more likely that whatever happened to him – whether like Ursicinus he was dismissed the service, whether he was given some remote, inhospitable posting, or whether he was able simply to recede from view and live for a while in private life out of the public eye – the removal of Ursicinus from active life was the end too of Ammianus' privileged view of contemporary affairs.²⁶ Until the renewal of his ambitions with the arrival of Julian at Antioch and the excitement of the Persian campaign in 363, Ammianus' interest in events was as an observer rather than as a participant. In fact, even taking into account the Persian campaign it is doubtful whether he ever again achieved the familiarity with the highest counsels of state that he had enjoyed in the service of Ursicinus. His partisan commitment to Ursicinus is an obvious consequence of this relationship, while his failure to consider other points of view is a small price to pay for the realism, the living tension and the sense of involvement of this part of his history.

CHAPTER IV

North-East Frontier

(1) The satrapy of Corduene

One of the most intriguing personal episodes in Ammianus' history is his journey to Corduene briefly described in the previous chapter, and one of its most vivid individual moments is the description of his towering view over the plains of northern Mesopotamia to see the Persian army assembling beyond the Tigris. Both aspects merit further reflection.¹ We cannot expect to know exactly where Ammianus stood to get his view. A glance at a relief map will show that in every sector of their northern and eastern limits these wide plains are overlooked by such commanding vantage points. Just such a view as that enjoyed by Ammianus is described by the Englishman Austen Layard, while narrating his journey made in 1849 along the upper Tigris from Redwan (Ridvan) to Nineveh. Layard followed the Tigris through its gorges east of Ridvan, but then diverged from the river and began to climb towards the summit of a ridge from which, he was assured by his guide Cawel Yusuf, they were to 'behold all the world'. His impression when they did so is worth reading, as an echo of the feelings which a similar view must have evoked in Ammianus, and as a telling brief account of the physical geography of northern Mesopotamia:

and certainly [wrote Layard], when we reached the summit, there was about as much of the world before us as could well be taken in at one ken. We stood on the brink of the great platform of Central Asia. Beneath us were the vast plains of Mesopotamia, lost in the hazy distance, the undulating land between them and the Taurus confounded, from so great a height, with the plains themselves; the hills of the Sinjar and of Zakko, like ridges on an embossed map; the Tigris and the Khabour, winding through the low country to their place of junction at Dereboun; to the right, facing the setting sun, and catching its last rays, the high cone of Mardin; behind, a confused mass of peaks, some snow-capped, all rugged and broken, of the lofty mountains of Bohtan and Malataiyah.... (*Nineveh and Babylon*, p. 51)

The hills of the Sinjar, on whose southern slopes, and so out of Layard's (as of Ammianus') view, stood the Roman city of Singara, were a full sixty miles to the south of his vantage point, while the mountains of Malataiyah, or Malatya – Roman Melitene, by the upper Euphrates – were no less than 150 miles to the west. Later in his expedition, Layard

journeyed from east to west along the hills of Sinjar. He travelled along their southern edge, but on one occasion crossed over to the northern side to settle a village feud, and there too recorded the impact of the view which opened up when he came to the summit of the pass:

The Sinjar hill is a solitary ridge rising abruptly in the midst of the desert; from its summit, therefore, the eye ranges on one side over the vast level wilderness stretching to the Euphrates, and on the other over the plain bounded by the Tigris and the lofty mountains of Kurdistan. Nisibis and Mardin were both visible in the distance. I could distinguish the hills of Baadri and Sheikh Adi, and many well-known peaks of the Kurdish Alps.... I have rarely seen any prospect more impressive than these boundless plains viewed from a considerable elevation. (*Nineveh and Babylon*, pp. 251-2)

From the Jebel Sinjar, Nisibis is about sixty, and Mardin eighty, miles – distances which even show as unduly cautious Ammianus' estimate that he could see up to fifty miles from the vantage point to which he was directed by Jovinianus (18.6.21).²

The particular question of where Ammianus stood to get his view of the plains of Mesopotamia is not solved by the comparison with Layard. Layard, after all, produces two different vantage points, from near Findik and from the Sinjar hills, which are very similar in their general effect, and there were others (in a footnote he compares the view from Sinjar favourably with a third, better known view from Mardin).³ It is unlikely that Ammianus was anywhere near Layard's first position just north of Findik, since this was only a few miles across the Tigris from the fortress of Bezabde, still in Roman hands at the time of Ammianus' visit to Jovinianus. He could hardly have described such a location as remote and distant, nor need he have taken quite so much trouble to get there.

In his review of the Persian army massing beyond the Tigris, Ammianus mentioned the sacrifices made by the Persians in the middle of the bridge over the Anzaba, and of their passage by the city of Nineveh; 'postquam reges, Nineve Adiabanae ingenti civitate transmissa, in medio pontis Anzabae hostiis caesis extisque prosperantibus, transiere laetissimi...' (18.7.1). It has often been noted that the sacrifices, which are in fact no part of Persian ritual, can hardly have been seen by Ammianus but were a product of his literary imagination.⁴ No more need we suppose that he actually saw with his own eyes the Persian king at the head of his host, dressed in brilliant attire, with Grumbates, king of the recently rebellious Chionitae, beside him – 'a man of only moderate physical strength and with wasted limbs, but with a certain grandeur of mind and distinguished for his many famous victories' (18.6.22). The figures of Grumbates, and of Sapor himself, were better known to Ammianus from their later appearances before the beleaguered city of Amida (below, p. 61). Yet we should need no reminder that the use of literary artifice to heighten dramatic effect is part of the accepted

technique of an ancient historian. Ammianus' flourish can be recognised for what it is, without throwing his entire account into discredit. If he took back to Ursicinus the information that the Persians had to cross two rivers (the Greater Zab and the Tigris) rather than just one before they could enter the Roman empire (18.7.2), his knowledge, and therefore his viewpoint, must relate to the regions around the Zab.⁵ He must have stood on an eminence to the south of Bezabde and of Layard's vantage point, perhaps an outlying ridge of the mountains of Zakho somewhere north-east of Nineveh.

It is a nice coincidence that Ammianus should have described the Persian king as passing by Nineveh, that 'great city of Adiabene' (18.7.1), while Austen Layard should be confronted by his view of 'all the world' while on his way to resume his explorations in its ruins. It was another of Layard's many strands of interest in northern Mesopotamia to trace the course of one of those confrontations between east and west, of which its plains had seen, and would again see, so many – the route taken by the Ten Thousand Greeks of Xenophon in their retreat from Persia in 401 BC. Both Ammianus and Layard were in their times gazing down onto the very place where the Ten Thousand had paused and decided what best now to do, in the light of their information on what lay before them. They had just passed the ruins of two great cities once held by 'the Medes'. The first of these, Larisa, was Assyrian Nimrud or Khalhu, with its mighty brick walls and stone base, and its perimeter of two parasangs, or six miles (so according to Xenophon; the actual perimeter is 4½ miles). The nearby 'pyramid of stone' on which the local villagers had taken refuge from the Ten Thousand, was evidently the Assyrian citadel, or ziggurat.⁶ The second city, Mespila, was ancient Nineveh, situated at six parasangs (the distance is in fact twenty miles) north of Nimrud (*Anabasis* 3.4.7-12).

The choice which lay before the Ten Thousand, as they paused not far north of Nineveh, was either to retreat westwards, to Lydia and Ionia (that is to say, along the route through northern Syria envisaged by Sapor in 359), or to the north, through the mountains of the 'Kardouchoi' – the Kurdish mountains of Bohtan, whose 'well-known peaks' were viewed by Layard from the distant hills of Sinjar. What Xenophon heard of the inhabitants of these mountains was, to say the least, disconcerting. An army of 120,000 Persians, he was told, had once penetrated their fastnesses and never been heard of again; though sometimes they made peace with the satrap in the plains and then there was mutual contact (*Anabasis* 3.5.16). Xenophon's Kardouchoi were warlike mountain folk, defending their passes fiercely against the intruding Greeks. Yet in the first century AD the geographer Strabo, discussing the territory of the 'Gordyaioi', gives a rather different view of its inhabitants (16.1.24). The Gordyaioi, he wrote, in ancient times called the Kardouchoi, lived near the Tigris and were especially skilled as building engineers and in the operation of siege machinery, and were used for their expertise in the armies of King Tigranes of Armenia. They possessed three main cities, Sarisa (this will be Charich, south of the Tigris in the Tur Abdin), Satalka

(possibly Chattakh or Çatak), and Pinaka. The last of these was a strong defensive position, with three mountain peaks each separately fortified, to produce a sort of 'triple city'.⁷

Sarisa, Satalka and Pinaka were undoubtedly not the only cities, or fortified settlements, in Strabo's land of the Gordyatoi. They were not necessarily the same as the chief cities of Ammianus' time, and it does not help that all cannot be located with certainty. Yet in setting off for Corduene under Ursicinus' instructions, Ammianus must have known, or been able to find out, where he was likely to find Jovinianus, and it would no doubt be to the same place that he returned, to rest and be entertained after his journey of reconnaissance (18.7.1). It is something to be able to visualise it as some sort of city or castle which served as a chief place of Jovinianus' satrapy.

*

Roman occupation of northern Mesopotamia had followed in the tracks of the Macedonians, both civilisations conforming to the conditions laid down by the geography and climate of the region.⁸ Such cities as Carrhae, Edessa, Nisibis, Resaina (later Theodosiopolis) and Singara with their territories represent the possibilities, and the limits, of sedentary cultivation. All are enclosed by the 200mm rainfall limit (isohyet), sufficient to permit the cultivation of cereal crops by dry-farming techniques; although these possibilities are rather more stringently defined by local conditions, and by the reliability of rainfall in an individual year, to which figures based on a sequence of years may not be an accurate guide. Marginal land, both inside and outside the 200mm isohyet, would be cultivated as opportunity arose by transhumant or semi-sedentary Arab tribesmen seizing 'catch-crops', otherwise put to use as seasonal pasture for stock-raising – sheep, horses and, in the more arid zones, camels. The potential for more regular and systematic cultivation of the marginal areas depended also, where the expectation of rainfall justified it, on the active encouragement and stable conditions provided by a political authority, on one side or the other. This was sometimes forthcoming, sometimes not. War between Rome and Persia was doubly prejudicial to the sedentary way of life, for it was an obvious deterrent against the investment of labour required for agricultural exploitation, and, on both sides, offered greater incentives and opportunities for licensed banditry (below, p. 351f.).

Looking beyond the possibilities of agricultural exploitation, the essential condition for urban development was of course the availability of continuous sweet water (whatever surface water is found on the plains is frequently impure and made saline by evaporation). Edessa had its famous sacred pools with their shoals of fish, described by a Christian pilgrim in the 380s (*Itin. Egeriae* 19.7) and still to be seen today – 'nunc usque', as Ammianus would say.⁹ The modern Arabic version of the name of Resaina, Ras el Ain, records the water-point which sustained the

ancient city (*‘ain*, a common element in Arabic place-names, is ‘well’ or ‘spring’). Coins commemorating its settlement under the Severi as a veteran colony of Legio III Parthica show the symbolic act of breaking up the land with the plough.¹⁰ The coins are not literal evidence of agricultural exploitation, but the site would not have been colonised at all had not this been possible, and Resaina is an example of genuine settlement, not simply the upgrading in status of an existing community. Singara, another Roman colony of the Severan period, and a site much fought over in the fourth century, exploited the water catchment of the Jebel Sinjar, at the southern, and more fertile, base of which it stands; south-easterly winds bring up moisture from the Persian Gulf and the marshes of the lower Tigris-Euphrates basin, to fall on the southern side of the range.¹¹ This is a feature rather specific to Singara, for most of the rain in northern Mesopotamia comes in from the Mediterranean to fall on the higher land to the north and east: the tract between Singara and Nisibis is accordingly described by Ammianus as arid and waterless (20.6.9). Nisibis, the key Roman city of the region, was fed by the river Mygdonius (the Oued Jaghjagha) from the catchment area of the Tur Abdin, and could live comfortably on the produce of its fields (devoted in modern times to the production of cotton). At Nisibis as at nearly all cities of the Roman empire it was agriculture which sustained the wealth of its upper class, of which Ammianus provides an interesting example in the person of the renegade *curialis*, Craugasius. He possessed a country estate eight miles from the city (19.9.7; below, p. 387).

From a different point of view, the deliberate burning of the grasslands running along the southern edge of the Tur Abdin between the Tigris and the Euphrates, as reported by Ammianus (18.8.4), is another indication of the nature of the cultivation and possibilities of settled life in the area, good cereal country; to which he adds a comment no less illuminating of the natural history of northern Mesopotamia in ancient times. The fires, notes Ammianus, caused the death of many of the fierce lions which roamed the area.¹² Their habitat was the swampy country (to be seen on modern maps in the depression between Nisibis and Singara), where they live quietly in winter, but in summer are plagued by hordes of mosquitoes which attack their eyelids. Tormented by their bites, they leap into watercourses to rid themselves of the insects and drown, or else scratch out their own eyes in fury. Were it not for this, concluded Ammianus in a fine piece of ecological observation, the whole of the east would be infested by the beasts (18.7.5)!

The limits of the Romans’ influence to the south are shown by their earlier inability to control Hatra, a once important Arab city in the desert beyond Singara; its abandoned ruins were seen by Ammianus during the retreat of Julian’s army from Babylonia in 363 (25.8.5; below, p. 186). To the east of Singara, equally, extended a tract of territory towards the river Tigris, to which the Romans did not lay claim. The direction of their occupation was north-eastwards, where the Roman empire marched with the Tigris in the region north of ancient Nineveh, an occupation

represented by the fortress of Bezabde and supported by their influence over the northern satrapies, of which Corduene was one. When the Romans ceded Nisibis and Singara to the Persians in 363, they had also to give up the fifteen fortified points by which they had controlled this region (25.7.9). It is interesting as further indirect evidence for the agricultural exploitation of the area, that when Ammianus describes the surrender of these fortifications and their occupation by Persian commanders he mentions also the territories attached to them; 'munimenta praesidiaria cum regionibus' (25.9.12). The region formed the Persian province, and in due course the ecclesiastical district based on Nisibis, of Arbaye or Arabia.¹³

It would be banal to describe this as the far eastern frontier of the Roman empire. Equally important, within their local context the satrapies extending along the eastern Taurus towards the Tigris formed a barrier between north and south. Corduene and its neighbours might protect the cities of northern Mesopotamia from an attack mobilised from Armenia, if Armenia should be induced to be disloyal to Rome; or, in different circumstances, if the Persians were to overrun Mesopotamia as they threatened to in 359, the satrapies might protect Armenia against attack from the south. Their status and loyalties were thus matters of great importance both to Roman and to Persian governments.

In the mid-third century, control of northern Mesopotamia had been wrested from the Romans by the reinvigorated Sasanian regime in Persia; but it had been recovered under the Tetrarchs, especially by the spectacular campaign of Galerius in 298.¹⁴ Galerius had redeemed the Persians' capture of Valerian by seizing the harem of the Persian king Narses. In consequence he was able to dictate his terms, which were essentially that the Roman frontier was set at the Tigris, while Rome acquired five principalities in the north. The westernmost of these principalities, Ingilene, was centred on the Armenian fortress of Egil, not far north of Amida. The next, Sophanene, later contained Justinian's fortress of Pheison, or Fis, and three days' journey to the east of this was the Roman city of Martyropolis (Mayferqat), ancient Tigranocerta. Beyond this, the river Nymphios (Batman Sou) divided the satrapy from Arzanene, which in Procopius' day was where Persian territory began; the centre of this principality was the fortress of Arzen. Then came Corduene, where the Tigris turns the eastern limit of the Tur Abdin to run down into the plains of Mesopotamia; and the fifth region was Zabdicene, with its city of Bezabde (Syriac Beth Zabde). The place is described by Ammianus, in narrating its siege by Sapor in 360. It stood on a slight elevation on the banks of the Tigris, fortified by a double wall where the terrain gave less protection. It was defended by three legions and a large number of local troops – 'archers of the Zabdiceni, then loyal to us, in whose territory this town is situated' (20.7.1). To give some idea of the importance of Bezabde, the regular garrison of Amida was only one legion, together with substantial local forces (18.9.3).

Such a formal account of the Tigris frontier of the Roman empire gives

no real idea of the local ambiguities within which it functioned. The frontier won by Galerius, for instance, is said to have lain on the Tigris; yet the five regions ceded to Rome in 298/9 lay largely beyond it. This difficulty is resolved by supposing direct military occupation by the Romans as far as the Tigris, and an area of influence, maintained by alliances, beyond it; some sources do in fact speak of the frontier as standing on the far side of the river, 'supra ripam Tigridis', assuming Roman dominance, if not direct control, of the five principalities to the north. At the same time, it is clear that some parts at least of the five districts came over to the strictly 'Roman' banks of the Tigris. Bezabde itself, standing as Ammianus says 'in the territory of the Zabdiceni', was actually on the Roman west bank; while if Strabo's town of Sarisa, one of the three chief places of the Gordyaoi, can be identified with Charich in the Tur Abdin, then at least the earlier equivalent of Ammianus' Corduene also extended to the Roman side.

A fuller impression of the actual functioning of the frontier zone is given by Ammianus, and by a later Syriac source, in their accounts of the foundation of the city of Amida. According to Ammianus, Amida was established as a fortified place by Constantius, while he was still Caesar – that is, before 337. It had previously been insignificant, but Constantius, to give the neighbouring peoples a secure place of refuge,

surrounded Amida with solid towers and walls, and equipping it with a battery of defensive artillery, made it formidable to the enemy and wished it to bear his own name. (18.9.1)

This last is a puzzling statement, possibly to be explained by confusion with Antoninupolis/Constantina or Constantia (modern Viranşehir) mentioned by Ammianus in the same passage, as another city founded by Constantius.

The Syriac *Life of James the Hermit* describes the same event in more colourful detail. After building Amida, Constantius is said to have come to love it more than all the other cities of his empire, and to have submitted to its control many lands –

from Ris Aina as far as Nisibis, and also the territory of Mayferqat [Martyropolis] and Arzoun [Arzanene] and as far as the limits of Qardou [Corduene]. Because these lands were at the frontier, Persian raiding parties were constantly attacking and plundering them. Tur Abdin was in the midst of these lands, and so the emperor built there two great fortresses to protect the lands against the Persian raiders. He built one of them at the frontier of Beth Arbeye at the summit of the mountain, and the other on the Tigris. This he called the 'Castle of the Rock' [Syriac Hisn Kef], and he made it the chief place of the land of Arzoun....¹⁵

If this is so, Constantius had established forts in and around the plateau of the Tur Abdin, namely Amida, the 'Castle of the Rock', and the fortress in the mountains. As to Amida, Ammianus gives a formal

description (18.9.1ff.), a curious feature of which is that it reverses the orientation of two of the faces of the city. According to his description, the river Tigris washes the southern (it should be the eastern) side, while the eastern (in fact, the southern) side faces the plains of Mesopotamia: presumably a moment of confusion on Ammianus' part when he came later to write up his account of the city, for no one will doubt that he knew it intimately.¹⁶ Ammianus was mistaken, also, in thinking that the Tigris rises close by (18.9.2). To the north, Ammianus goes on to say, Amida looks towards the river Nymphius (true if he means its upper reaches) and the Taurus mountains, and to the west the fertile, farmed country of Gumathena, in which is the township of Abarne with the thermal springs for which it was well known (18.9.2). Abarne is modern Çermik, from the Armenian Djermuk, 'baths'.

Hisn Kef or Kiphas, the 'Castle of the Rock', lies on the south bank of the Tigris about 70 km below Amida. An infantry detachment, Legio II Parthica, is listed there in the late fourth century by the *Notitia Dignitatum* (*Or.* 36.30) under the command of the *dux Mesopotamiae*; it had been transferred from Bezabde, where Ammianus makes it part of the garrison in 360 (20.7.1). The *dux* of Mesopotamia in office at the time of Ammianus' involvement on this frontier, Cassianus, is mentioned on a few occasions by the historian; he receives the orders from Ursicinus to clear the land, evacuate Carrhae and burn the grasslands (18.7.3), is later found stationed at Nisibis (19.9.6) and turns up in 363 to meet Julian's army on its retreat from Persia towards that city, somewhere in the desert south of Singara (25.8.7).

The unnamed 'castle on the mountain' has been persuasively identified with the fortress Rhabdion, and this associated with the name of Tur Abdin itself. Mentioned frequently in Byzantine sources and a site of obvious importance, Rhabdion is surprisingly not mentioned by Ammianus: hence a speculative identification with Ammianus' 'castra Maurorum', equally important but not named by other sources, surrendered to the Persians with Nisibis and Singara in 363 (25.7.9); one name will reflect a Roman, the other an indigenous, form.¹⁷ At the southern edge of the plateau of the Tur Abdin, as Hisn Kef is to the north, Rhabdion does indeed, as indicated by the *Life of James the Hermit*, stand at the southern limit of the district, and later Persian province, of Beth Arbaye.

The eastern culmination of these strong points was Bezabde, besieged and taken by Sapor in 360. The military frontier, so traced, falls on the river Tigris, as the cessions made to Galerius require. At the same time, the frontier runs through and impinges upon native territories whose relationships with Rome, and indeed with each other, are far more complex and changeable than the formal situation may suggest.

In terms of the peace treaty of 298/9, Corduene, the satrapy of Jovinianus, ought to have been subservient to Rome, Galerius having then won it from Persia. But it had slipped away. Ammianus regarded Jovinianus as a Persian nominee – his time spent in Syria had been as a

hostage, evidently to secure the good behaviour of his family or people, and Jovinianus now gave the allegiance of his satrapy to the Persians, as Ammianus makes clear; 'satrapa Corduenae, quae obtemperabat potestati Persarum' (18.6.20). When Julian's supporter Procopius led a division into Persian territory in the great campaign of 363, he was ordered to march through Corduene before devastating Chiliocomum and invading Assyria (23.3.6). At a later stage, the Roman army in their retreat from Ctesiphon by the Tigris route resolved to 'seize' Corduene, and from there make for safety in the Roman empire (24.8.4f.; below p. 159).

In all these situations, Corduene is envisaged as in effective Persian territory; yet this was still not so in formal terms, since Jovian's peace treaty with the Persians made later in 363 involved the surrender to them of Corduene, together with four other 'Transtigritane regions' then in hands of Rome: Arzanene, Moxoene, Zabdicene, Rehimene (25.7.9). Together, as we have seen, they were to constitute the Persian administrative district of Arbaye (p. 53). The 'surrender' of Corduene in 363 is formally incompatible with Ammianus' statement that it already, four years earlier, gave its allegiance to Persia; 'obtemperabat potestati Persarum'. The ambiguities in the position of Corduene can be resolved only by a more flexible understanding of how it and its neighbouring 'satrapies' behaved in their social and political setting.

The status of the northern satraps in relation to Rome is well illustrated by a law of Theodosius addressed to the 'satrap of Sophanene' in 387 (*CTh* 12.13.6). Sophanene was still at that time within the Roman sphere of influence; but it is most unusual to find a recipient of imperial legislation addressed with the Persian title of 'satrap', and the conditions under which he is supposed to offer crown gold (*aurum coronarium*) to the Roman emperor are equally revealing of his special position. According to the law, the gold, traditionally offered by all satraps as a gift to the emperor, was to be paid from the satrap's own resources and not raised in levies from his subjects. It was not a form of taxation – as it would be in a normal Roman province – but a personal gift, after the ancient custom whereby the satraps showed their 'devotion, which is due to the Roman empire'.

Whatever the ambiguities of their status in the Roman empire, the view taken by the Persian king of these 'Transtigritane regions' was quite unambiguous. After the capture of Amida in 359, Sapor had the Roman soldiers recruited from these regions rounded up and killed to a man, with no distinction of rank (19.9.2). The districts from which they came were treated by the Persians as theirs by right, and the service to Rome of the Transtigritani was thus a simple case of treachery. This was however clear only in the context of Persian pretensions to ownership of these regions. In general, it was an area of complex local loyalties that do not always fit into the tidy categories of 'Roman' or 'Persian'. Ammianus' friendship with the satrap Jovinianus was formed, we can assume, in the setting of the literary schools of Antioch. Jovinianus had been educated

there and become a lover of Greek culture, and longed – or so he gave Ammianus to believe – to return to the Roman empire. An eastern source, the Syriac *Life* of a Persian martyr saint, shows Jovinianus in a very different light. He is here found supervising the settlement in the region of Beth Arbaye – as we have seen, the territory east of Nisibis towards the Tigris – of peoples from Arzoun, Beth Zabde and ‘Arabia’ itself, with the permission of Julian the Apostate ‘who then resided at Mahoze’.¹⁸

Mahoze is the Persian capital of Ctesiphon (below, p. 155f.); the circumstances of Julian’s residence in that region hardly seem to permit of his alleged role in Jovinianus’ settlements, and other details in the narrative are confused and self-contradictory (despite the connection with Julian, for instance, the text has Jovinianus already dead at the time of Sapor’s attack on Bezabde in 360, before Julian had come to the east). It is possible that the emperor, if one was involved at all, was Constantius rather than Julian, but if the main outlines of the situation envisaged are authentic – and Jovinianus’ presence at all in the document is evidence of his local prestige – a most interesting picture emerges. Beth Arbaye is an area where sedentary occupation was possible in the terms outlined earlier (p. 51), but one of uncertain political control, more usually inhabited by transhumant groups of tribesmen raising catch-crops and exploiting the pasturage as it was available. In settling this area with peoples from Arzanene, Zabdicene and Beth Arbaye or ‘Arabia’, Jovinianus was exercising pretensions beyond the confines of Corduene, on land that formed part of the territory, if not of the Roman empire itself, then of its clients the Zabdiceni. It is not clear at whose expense or with whose (if anyone’s) permission Jovinianus’ aggrandisement was taking place, but we begin to see Ammianus’ friend for what he was: a local chieftain, whose cultural horizons had been enlarged by his education as a hostage in Syria, respecting a friendship made there by receiving Ammianus and offering assistance for his mission, but sufficiently sensitive to the balance of power on the frontier of the two empires to have carried his satrapy into the Persian sphere of influence without quite losing touch with the Roman, while seizing the opportunity to enhance his own position as patron of peoples beyond the rather flexible limits of his own satrapy. Perhaps one of the motives for his kindly reception of Ammianus was that he, as much as his guest, wished to know the true scale of the Persian preparations; for Jovinianus cannot have been the only local potentate to await with interest the outcome of the invasion of 359 and of the siege of Amida. If it is true that Jovinianus, a young man of Ammianus’ age, was dead by 360, it may even be that something went badly wrong with his calculations.

(2) The siege of Amida

Looking back at the siege of Amida, as it were through the eyes of king Sapor, Ammianus counted it as another instance of the great losses he had sustained in siege warfare against the Romans, citing the sieges of Singara and – more than once – Nisibis (19.9.9).¹⁹ Amida had held him up

for seventy-three days and cost him 30,000 men. If the second part of this information, based though it was on observation, seems doubtful, there is no need to question the first. Ammianus several times states or implies that Sapor's main objectives lay elsewhere – Ursicinus, it will be recalled from the previous chapter, had gone to break the upper Euphrates crossings at Zeugma and Capersana. Antoninus' advice to the king, supported by his commanders, was to the same effect (19.1.3,6), and the reduction of Amida, forced upon Sapor by the refusal of his ally king Grumbates to leave the place without avenging his son's death before its walls (2.1), was a frustrating diversion of the aims of his invasion. The anger obvious in Sapor's treatment of the city and its defenders after its fall can be understood. He had arrived before Amida with his strategic purpose intact and his main options still open to him; when he left the destroyed city it was already the month of October, too late to advance further and time to take his army, captives and booty back into Persia (9.1).

Ammianus' account of the siege of Amida is one of the high points of his narrative and a classic passage in Roman historical writing. Despite this, or because of it, it is easy not to realise that it presents certain difficulties of interpretation, and especially of chronology. Even if, against the natural reading of his text, we take the seventy-three days attributed by Ammianus to the siege to include the two days' marching required by Sapor to arrive at Amida from the captured forts of Reman and Busan (19.1.1), a surprisingly small proportion of the operation is actually covered by his narrative. At the opening of the siege Sapor approaches the walls, evidently hoping that the defenders will immediately agree to surrender, but is shot at and retires in a flurry of disorder (1.5). Dissuaded by his commanders from a wasteful display of anger, he decides to try again. On the second day the Chionite king Grumbates comes up to the city on his behalf, but a skilled marksman picks off his son with a bolt from a *ballista*. Fighting breaks out, but from the next day a truce is observed, culminating in the funeral of the young man with native rites; these ceremonies last for seven days (1.10). After two further days of rest, the Persian army surrounds the city in a massed demonstration of strength, which lasts all day though no attack is made (2.4). The first two assaults come on the next two days, the second of which Ammianus gives as the 'fifth day', counting this from the end of the seven days' truce (2.12).

At the end of the siege, six more days are registered in a similarly careful fashion. They begin with the return of the Gallic troops at Amida from a night attack on the outposts of the Persian camp (19.6.7ff.). A truce of three days is observed, before the Persians press their final assault. This lasts three days (7.1; 7.6; 8.1), and on the third day the city falls (8.1).

Between these extremes, the first fourteen and the last six days of the siege, Ammianus provides only two further episodes relating to its chronological development. A pestilence breaks out, which is settled on

the night after the tenth day of its incidence by a light shower of rain. The episode provides Ammianus with an opportunity, hardly justified by the relative scale of the events in question, to mention Thucydides and other authorities in a short digression on the origins and causes of plagues (19.4.2-7). It was caused, in Ammianus' view, by the decomposition of corpses, aggravated by the torrid heat and the poor physical state of the occupants of Amida (4.1). As to when the pestilence broke out, Ammianus gives little indication, but his attribution of cause would lose its point if the outbreak were long delayed. There were many fatalities in the first two Persian assaults on the city (2.14f.), and the corpses of Romans, as he remarked in discussing the aftermath of the siege, decomposed beyond recognition after four days (9.9).²⁰

The second episode was the occupation of one of the defensive towers of the city by seventy Persian archers, who were installed there by a deserter; he led them to it by way of the hidden staircase linking the city with the Tigris, as Ammianus had observed was the case in all cities of that region that adjoined rivers (19.5.4f.). The repulse of the threat by skilled artillery fire from five small *ballistae* lined up against the tower, and of the assault on the walls which was co-ordinated with the occupation of the tower, took until mid-day (5.8). On the next morning the defenders of Amida could see from their citadel columns of prisoners from the captured city of Ziatha being led away into Persia. This in particular angered the Gallic troops in Amida, who demanded with threats that they be allowed to attack the Persian army (6.3). It was agreed that if they were prepared to wait for a while they might do this, the night sortie being the result.

That the occupation of the tower, a major event in Ammianus' account of the siege, came near its end is indicated by what he had written of the mood and character of the Gallic troops (19.5.2). Raised by the usurper Magnentius but transferred by Constantius to the east because of doubts about their loyalty (18.9.3), they were brave and quick, well-suited to pitched battles but not to the style of warfare in which they were now involved. They made several sorties ('aliquotiens') against the Persians, to no significant effect – as if one man, in the popular saying, were to try to extinguish a burning city with water carried in the palm of the hand (19.5.2). In the end ('postremo') the Gauls were locked inside the city, the gates being barred against them; though their effectiveness as fighters was demonstrated in days to come ('secutis diebus') in their heroic night attack on the Persian camp. Ammianus' indications of time, and his statement that the Gallic troops had made repeated earlier assaults until as a last resort they were confined, suggest that the occupation of the tower and the night attack against the Persians were not far separated. Ammianus presents the night attack, which closely preceded the fall of the city, as being due to the Gauls' refusal to tolerate any more delay after the promise had been given them that they might make an attack ('morarum impatientes', 6.7).

Ammianus' account of the siege of Amida is therefore concentrated on

certain major episodes. He accounts for the first fourteen days of the siege and, with little detail, ten days of pestilence which perhaps ensued quite soon; then, towards the end of the siege, the occupation of the tower, on the next day the sight of the prisoners from Ziatha and, soon after this, the six days leading to the final assaults on the city and its fall. Of Ammianus' seventy-three days during which Sapor was at Amida we must presumably assign some for the thorough sacking and burning of the city at the end of the siege; yet even so, a clear thirty or thirty-five days, occupying the central phases of the operation, remain unaccounted for and there is no episode that can be assigned to any particular part of them.

The omission is not so surprising, in a history concerned with '*res gestae*' – with great deeds, heroic and ingenious exploits, violent emotion and suffering.²¹ It may even reflect reality. Protracted sieges actually were like this, with initial assault and final outcome separated by large tracts of time involving occasional initiatives by one side or the other, and much general preparation and waiting. In two or three passages, Ammianus indicates this less distinctive level of activity. In the first, he describes how 'while the fighting was going on' ('*dum pugnatur*') Ursicinus tried persistently but in vain to persuade Sabinianus – stationed, it will be recalled, at Edessa – to release troops for the relief of Amida. The fighting here referred to was, to judge by the context, in the early stages of the assault, but Ammianus' presentation assumes that Ursicinus' efforts to awake Sabinianus were persistent. Failing in this, he 'often' ('*saepe*') sent scouts to the city, who were usually unable to penetrate the ring of Persian besiegers (19.3.2).

There is also the necessary, and necessarily protracted, preparation of siege works. Ammianus makes a transition from his description of the end of the pestilence, to the 'unquiet Persian's' surrounding of the city by wickerwork mantlets, and the preparation of mounds and ironclad towers designed to overtop the city walls and drive the defenders from the battlements by missile fire from a higher level (19.5.1). While this was going on, though there is no major assault, the city is kept under continuous fire from slingers and archers; it was during this period of light engagements, too, that the Gallic soldiers made their earlier sorties against the Persian forces. At a later stage – immediately before the Gauls made the night attack which ushers in the final assault on Amida – Ammianus again describes the piling up by both Persians and Romans of high mounds to serve as fighting platforms; these were the 'slow works' ('*operibus lentis*'), through which the fall of the city was being devised (6.6). When the Roman mound suddenly collapses during the final assault, Ammianus refers to it with almost proprietorial feeling as 'that mound of our men, built with such long labour': '*diu laborata moles illa nostrorum*' (8.2). This long, unremitting preparation and toil form the essential background, indicated so briefly by Ammianus, to the high points of drama and action that can seem to the reader to dominate his narrative. The siege of Amida, like any other, consisted largely of hard

work and careful preparation, and the anxious waiting for something to happen. This even, relatively unspectacular level of activity is less easy to describe, but Ammianus is careful to indicate its presence.

As we should by now expect of him, Ammianus' account is at all levels full of momentary impressions, presented with an acute sense of their visual impact.²² The view from the walls and citadel of Amida, as the city is encircled by the vast array of Persian arms, the entire landscape reflecting the glitter of weaponry and the glint of the famous armoured cavalry, the *cataphracti* who feature in the first of the final assaults on Amida (19.1.2; 7.4): as Sapor approaches so close to the walls with his escort that his features can be clearly recognised, and hastily retreats when fired on (1.5);²³ the shooting next day of the son of king Grumbates by the skilled *ballistarius* (1.7); the long column of prisoners from Ziatha being led away into Persian captivity, a sight which so angered the Gallic soldiers in Amida (6.1); the dizzying heights of the tower commanding a view of the Tigris over broken, rocky cliffs, from which it was impossible to look down without suffering from vertigo (5.4); and so on. Sometimes Ammianus' remarks go beyond what he could personally have known at the time. He is unlikely to have known positively when he actually saw them that the columns of prisoners were from Ziatha, and Ammianus does in fact take the opportunity to remark that other fortifications also were taken in these same days and their inhabitants, including old men and women, led off into captivity or left with their tendons cut if they could not keep up (6.2). He discovered these details later or could safely infer them, and inserted them where they belonged. Conversely, his description of king Grumbates, inserted in the course of his narrative of his visit to Corduene, may, as we have seen, derive from what Ammianus saw later before the walls of Amida; he thought it worth while to introduce in good time a man whose influence on the course of events was to be so decisive.

There is no need to doubt that Ammianus, like the skilled marksman who took aim and shot him, saw the death before Amida of Grumbates' young son. He would obviously be on the walls with other colleagues of relatively senior rank. One wonders how much Ammianus could actually see of the native burial rites of the prince, his body laid 'ritu nationis propriae' in military dress on a raised bier, surrounded by the effigies of ten young men on litters, sad feasts of soldiers 'per contubernia et manipulos' (a very Roman touch), dances and songs of mourning and the wails of women, compared by Ammianus for his Roman audience with the performance of the cult of Adonis by priestesses of Venus (19.1.10f.). Yet, if the Persian outposts were just beyond a bowshot's range (6.5), perhaps these events after all took place not so very far away, and Ammianus' description contains items of more than circumstantial interest, which are surely the result of observation. The effigies of the ten young men on litters – there would in the original rite have been, not effigies, but young men killed for their master's funeral – were no doubt appointed to serve the dead prince after death, in a funerary practice widely documented,

from the *Iliad* of Homer (the funeral of Patroclus; 23.175f.) and Herodotus' Royal Scythians (4.71f.) to the Fiji Islands, the Kayans of Borneo, the native tribes of Central and South America, the kingdoms of India and China, in fact anywhere that anthropologist has set foot.²⁴ Further, for all its 'Roman' colouring, Ammianus' description of the funeral of Grumbates' son distinguishes the Chionitae in religious belief from the Zoroastrian Persians, whose rite involved neither cremation nor burial (which would pollute the elements) but the exposure of the dead in high places, to be consumed by birds of prey.

These matters merit a few moments' reflection. The Chionitae, coming from the north-east, had occupied the valleys between the river Oxus and the Hindu Kush in northern Afghanistan, and so bordered over the mountains the once powerful Kushans of the Kabul and upper Indus valleys. The Kushans, under the name 'Cuseni' in Ammianus, also fought as vassals in the army of Sapor (16.9.4; 19.2.3); in fact, the distinctive head-dress of their king, with its image of a ram's head, was mistakenly attributed by Ammianus to the Shah of Shahs himself (19.1.3).²⁵ Whether the Chionitae were identical with the settled, law-abiding and honourable people known to Procopius in the sixth century as the Hephthalites or 'White Huns' (*Wars* 1.3.1-7), and whether either really were Hunnish, are difficult questions, debated among specialists.²⁶ Procopius is at pains to point out the great differences in appearance and way of life between Hephthalites and 'regular' Huns, and it is hard to feel convinced that the differences can be entirely explained by changes in lifestyle from the nomadic to the sedentary; on the other hand it is possible that the assemblage of central Asian tribes that threw off the Huns as they became known to the west was actually much more varied in character than Graeco-Roman authors, who only saw part of them, suspected (below, p. 341). Procopius describes a Hephthalite custom whereby upon the death of a noble his living 'friends' or boon-companions, up to twenty or more, were entombed with him, but this again is inconclusive, for it might either suggest the identity of the Hephthalites with Ammianus' Chionitae, or simply reflect the wide diffusion of the funerary practice (*Wars* 1.3.7). Procopius' information on the Hephthalites expresses an antiquarian, somewhat 'Herodotean' spirit, and may not be accurate in every detail for his own day. The ceremony witnessed near Amida already represents a substitution of effigy for actual human sacrifice, while the fact that Ammianus indicates a rite of cremation but Procopius one of inhumation might be explained by a change in time from one mode to the other, or by some local variation of custom within the same ethnic group. Ammianus in any case gives as a fact Grumbates' decision that his son's ashes be taken to his homeland for burial in a silver urn; so, too, he may have had positive knowledge of the advice given to Sapor by his generals not to be deflected from his major objectives in the war by delaying at Amida through mere anger at being shot at (1.6), and of Grumbates' refusal to move from the city before his son's shades were avenged – and those who had killed him were by their

own death reduced to his service in the after-life (2.1). It is a curious posture in which to imagine the shade of Ammianus Marcellinus.

In many details of the actual fighting at Amida Ammianus shows himself as clearly an eye-witness of what he describes, again with that sense of occasion which he can convey so marvellously; as in the first encirclement of the city by no less than five ranks of shields (the largest number he records in any siege that he describes) – the army filling the landscape, it seemed to Ammianus, as far as the eye could reach (2.2), with the Chionitae of Grumbates ranged opposite the wall by which his son had been killed (2.3). The whole day long they stood there immobile and absolutely silent, not a foot being moved nor the whinny of a horse being heard. At evening they withdrew in the same order, to eat and sleep before the sound of trumpets announced that the attack was to begin. Only then does Grumbates cast the blood-stained spear which to the Persians, as to the Romans, consecrated the start of the battle (2.5). The whole occasion is a splendid expression of the ‘ritualistic’ aspects of ancient warfare, Ammianus presenting it in the measured, rhythmic terms of ceremonial so characteristic of Roman, as well as Persian, public life; and he passes with calculated abruptness to the unceremonious brutality of the actual fighting; ‘proinde diffractis capitibus...’ (2.7).

Ammianus conveys the varied sounds of fighting, the blast of trumpets signalling a Persian attack (19.2.12) or raising the alarm in the Persian camp (6.9), answered on the latter occasion by the distinctive tones of the horns (*lituae*) in the city (6.10); the din of the artillery, operated unloaded to confuse the Persian outposts and cover the retreat of the Gauls from their night attack (6.10); the confused clamours of the countrymen of Grumbates’ stricken son, summoning help from the ‘numerous peoples’ in the Persian camp to prevent his body being seized by the Romans. Ammianus’ expression for ‘confused’ shouting – ‘clamoribus dissonis’ (1.8) – is used elsewhere to suggest the diverse cultures and languages of an army of Moorish rebels in north Africa;²⁷ a nuance which, unless it is a mere rhetorical gesture, would respond well to the diverse nationalities comprising the Persian army – notably Albani and Segestani (from Sistan in eastern Iran) and the Kushans and Chionitae just mentioned (19.1.6; 2.3). In the acclamations which accompanied the first (and, no doubt, every other) day’s fighting at Amida, the Romans extol Constantius as ‘Lord of the world and of all things’ (*dominum rerum et mundi*), the Persians praise Sapor in their own language as ‘Saansaan’ and ‘Pirosen’. Ammianus gives the meaning of these words. ‘Saansaan’ is ‘King of Kings’ (Shah of Shahs) – overlord of all the vassal princes of his empire – and ‘Pirosen’, ‘Victor in wars’ (2.11). The latter word provides the first element in the name of a great Mesopotamian city besieged and taken by Julian in 363, Pirisabora or Peroz-Shapur – ‘Sapor Victorious’ (24.2.9).²⁸

Irrationally, it might seem, given the other dangers surrounding him, Ammianus harboured a particular dread of the elephants which formed a regular part of the Persians’ armament. He describes them at the outset of the siege, as their hideous wrinkled bodies lumbered forward, laden

with armed men – a spectacle, Ammianus thought, beyond any other in its dire horror, ‘as I have often explained’; ‘ultra omnem diritatem taetri spectaculi formidanda, ut rettulimus saepe’ (19.2.3). This would have been in the lost books, but Ammianus returns to the subject again in much the same spirit while describing Julian’s Persian campaign (25.1.14), and he is not averse from repeating his sentiments even sooner, during the last assaults on Amida. The attack was joined by the elephants, ‘than whose shrill screeching and monstrous bodies the human mind knows of nothing more terrible’; ‘quorum stridore immanitateque corporum nihil humanae mentes terribilius cernunt’ (19.7.6). Like the elephants of Hannibal, the beasts did not always live up to their reputation; on this occasion, surrounded and scorched by the burning wreckage of the Persian siege-towers which the Romans had destroyed, they backed away and could not be controlled by their drivers (7.7).

Ammianus’ personal involvement in the siege of Amida can be seen at its various levels in his use of the first person to describe his, and his colleagues’ and fellow-sufferers’, experiences.²⁹ The most commonplace of these, needing no documentation, is in his use of the first person to denote the Roman as opposed to the Persian side in the fighting, as in his contrast between the offensive and defensive siege works erected by the two armies (19.6.6). More interesting are the passages in which Ammianus associates himself with the others inside the city, seen at large. The vast Persian forces assembled outside the city, previously devoted to the overthrow of the entire Roman world, seemed now to be directed at ‘our destruction’; ‘in nostrum conversos exitium’ (2.4). All we could now hope for, writes Ammianus, was a glorious end to our lives, and this we strove to achieve – a sentiment repeated a few sentences later (2.13). The heavenly powers had decreed, it seemed, that the miseries of the entire Roman world were to be concentrated within this single region; ‘ut Romanae rei totius aerumnas intra unius regionis concluderet ambitum’ (1.4).

Ammianus sometimes uses the first person to associate himself more closely with the group of officers responsible for the direction of the defence of Amida. The occupation of the tower by the Persian archers, with the co-ordinated attack on the walls, ‘made us uncertain and doubtful which threat to face first’; ‘inter incertos nos et ancipites quibus occurri deberet’ (19.5.6). The work was divided between those who would operate the light *ballistae* brought up against the tower and those who would defend the walls against the attempt to scale them. Here Ammianus writes as one who was involved in the decision, as he does later in describing how the ‘scorpions’ were brought up to oppose the Persian siege-towers with their *ballistae*. This was determined, he writes, after much discussion on ‘our’ part; ‘et tandem multa versantibus nobis, sedit consilium...’ (7.6). Though Ammianus here remarks on the technical difficulties involved in moving the machines to their new emplacements, he is not writing in particular as an expert on artillery, but as an officer

who, being as it happened in Amida, was necessarily involved in planning its defence.³⁰ The Gallic troops confined in the city, he noted, were quick and brave, but inept in 'those arts of war, by which we were encompassed' and indeed rather a nuisance; 'ad eas vero belli artes, quibus stringebamur, non modo inhabiles, sed contra nimii turbatores' (5.2). They could give no help in constructing siege machinery or defensive earthworks but could only make unproductive excursions against the Persian forces. If Ammianus uses the first person here as one of those generally besieged in Amida, in describing what it was eventually agreed to do with the Gauls he again puts himself in the company of those who made the decision; 'inopes nos consilii, et ... ambigentes, tandem elegimus...' (6.5).

As we have seen, Ammianus must have felt a particular sense of anger when he described how the *protectores* captured in Amida by the Persians were led off into captivity, hands bound behind their backs (19.9.2). He comes near to expressing it when he states how the *comes* Aelianus and the *tribuni* taken with him were wickedly ('sceleste') crucified by the Persians. It was through their practical initiative, wrote Ammianus, that the walls had been defended for so long and so many Persians brought to grief; 'quorum efficacia diu defensa sunt moenia stragesque multiplicatae Persarum' (9.2). He was certainly in a position to know at first hand the extent of their skill and enterprise.

The sudden collapse of the Roman defensive mound ultimately opened the way for the Persians to enter the city. Ammianus, seeing its fall imminent, hid with two companions near an unguarded postern gate and, when evening fell, escaped with them from Amida (19.9.5). Ammianus has never, throughout the entire siege, referred to himself in the first person singular; he always associates himself with others, whether the entire population or a smaller group, in the city. At the point of his escape he suddenly breaks into the singular ('evado'), as he used it also in earlier enterprises involving himself as an individual, such as his visit to Corduene, his departure from Nisibis and subsequent experiences when separated from Ursicinus, to his entry to Amida among the crowds of refugees inching their way up the steep path into the city (pp. 41ff.). Narrating the departure from Amida, Ammianus returns to this manner of writing. He uses the first person plural to associate himself with the two companions travelling with him, the singular to distinguish his experiences from theirs, as in their capture of a runaway horse ten miles from the city (8.6f.);³¹ Ammianus gets on to ride, the companions continue on foot. The journey was not without incident and it was to combine speed with safety that Ammianus and his companions made through wooded country for the higher mountains and Melitene; they would thereby avoid the attentions of Persian cavalry, which naturally preferred to operate on the plains. Finding there 'the general' (identified by most commentators as Ursicinus) about to depart, they accompanied him and came to Antioch.

The fall of Amida, as we saw earlier, brought about the retirement of

Ursicinus after his tactless remarks on the emperor's reliance on eunuch advisers (20.2.4f.). It brought a worse fate for the Count of the Sacred Largesses, Ursulus, who, moved by the sight of the ruined city when Constantius came to visit the scene in 360, allowed himself to pronounce on the lack of spirit shown by soldiers, for whose provision the empire's financial resources were gaping asunder – an interesting point of view, which secured his execution at the trials conducted under Julian at Chalcedon two years later (20.11.5; cf. 22.3.7f.). Ammianus deplored the execution, for Ursulus had supported Julian in the difficult times of his Caesarship under Constantius (below, p. 88). He was destroyed without Julian's knowledge and against his wishes, wrote Ammianus, by the resentment of the military ('militaris ira'), mindful of what he had said when he saw the ruins of Amida. Ursulus' remark was indeed unjust to the defenders of Amida, as Ammianus obviously realised. He ascribed it to Ursulus' bitterness, brought on by his grief at the sight of the ruins (20.11.5). So Ammianus reconciled the injustice done by Ursulus to the defenders of Amida, with the injustice done to him at Chalcedon.

Amida was rebuilt. Its strategic position, important before, was still more so after the surrender of Nisibis and the advance of the Persian frontier to the west of that city. The Roman population of Nisibis had to be found new homes, and it is likely that Amida received many of them. It had previously, according to Ammianus, been a city of relatively modest extent: 'intra civitatis ambitum non nimium amplae' (19.2.14). He means not just that it was a small place in relation to the 20,000 souls crowded into it in 359, but that it was made intolerable by the influx of such numbers. The surviving walls of Amida (Diyarbakir), built of forbidding dark basaltic stone, date originally from the sixth century. They represent a Justinianic rebuilding, with some enlargement, of a city whose main expansion in the time of Valens, transforming it from the city known to Ammianus, had taken place after its siege and sack by king Sapor, and in consequence of the surrender to him of Nisibis in 363.³²

CHAPTER V

The Young Ammianus: Social and Cultural Setting

Ammianus' narrative of the Persian invasion of 359 expresses vividly the sense of personal adventure and action which are an essential aspect of this part of his history. At the same time, in ranging with such vigorous effect over this complex and fascinating country between his own city of Antioch and the Tigris, the narrative reveals something of no less interest and importance, the regional and cultural setting of Ammianus' experience as a young man. A single phrase shows how well at ease was Ammianus in the landscape of this theatre of war. Escaping from Amida after its fall to the Persian attack, he made his way with his two companions to a distance of ten miles from the city. He did so, as he wrote, helped by his knowledge of the desert terrain: 'squalentium peritita locorum' (19.8.5).

Seen in a longer perspective, this was a region of ancient and great civilisations, of cultural complexities deriving from millennia of history.¹ The city of Carrhae, which Ursicinus evacuated against the Persian invasion of 359, was Biblical Harran, the home of the family of Abraham. Almost seven hundred years before Ammianus' time, it had been re-founded by the Macedonian settlers of Mesopotamia. Edessa, where the general Sabinianus 'made peace with the dead' (p. 44f.), bore the name of a Macedonian city, and was alternatively known as Antioch-upon-Callirhoe after the abundant, pure springs mentioned in the previous chapter: though it is the original Syrian name, Orhai, which has survived to denote the modern town of Urfa. The great city of Nisibis had been settled by the Macedonians and called by them Antioch-in-Mygdonia. Now known as Nusaybin, the place is mentioned, as Nasabina, in Assyrian records. Batnae in Osrhoene, as Ammianus remarked, had been settled 'by a band of the ancient Macedonians' (14.3.3). At the sites of these Macedonian settlements in Syrian territory, the Romans too had placed their colonies in the second and early third centuries. So Carrhae, Edessa, Nisibis, Singara and other places bore in their titulature the names of the Antonine and Severan emperors, representing Roman control, established in that period, of northern Mesopotamia.

The two great empires of west and east, Graeco-Roman and Sasanian, met over an area in which other civilisations had preceded them both.

Relations between them were fluid and ambiguous, often belying the notion of a fixed frontier. The renegade Antoninus, who had deserted to the Persians with intelligence on Roman dispositions, had formerly been a prosperous trader, later an accountant on the staff of the military commander of Mesopotamia, finally *protector*. In one or all of these capacities, he was a familiar figure in Mesopotamia – ‘very well known in those regions’, as Ammianus remarked; ‘per omnes illas notissimus terras’ (18.5.1). Knowing Latin as well as Greek, he was able to make researches into the military establishment of the empire in preparation for his defection. He escaped by acquiring a farm at Iaspis by the Tigris; it was situated, wrote Ammianus, ‘at the extreme limits of the Roman world’ (5.3). If correctly identified as Isfis (or Hespist), lying by a tributary of the Tigris (the Oued Haltan or Khaltan), it was not far from Bezabde, whose surviving inhabitants were led off into captivity by Sapor after its capture in 360 (20.7.15).² Having acquired his farm, Antoninus installed there his wife and children and visited them frequently to allay suspicion. He then arranged his departure from the Roman empire by being ferried with his family over the Tigris at dead of night: he achieved this with the collaboration of the satrap of the adjacent Persian province, Tamsapor, whom he already knew; ‘et antea cognitus’ (18.5.3).

At a later stage, when Antoninus and Ursicinus met face to face in the strange encounter near Amida described by Ammianus, and Ursicinus denounced him for his treachery, Antoninus responded in a way which in outward manner was already totally ‘Orientalised’ (18.8.5ff.). He dismounted, removed the tiara which he wore as a mark of honour among the Persians, and bowed low, his face nearly touching the ground, to salute Ursicinus, addressing him as ‘patron’ and ‘lord’ and joining his hands together behind his back in ‘Assyrian’ fashion to indicate his suppliant status. Having defended his conduct – or more precisely, as Ammianus says, while still speaking – he slowly withdrew from Ursicinus’ presence, stepping backwards with dignity (‘verecunde retrogradiens’); almost, one might say, as if he were in an Iranian audience-hall. Ammianus, with his late Roman sense of character portrayed in social action and gesture, must have been fascinated by the performance. It was pure theatre from start to finish – which is not to question the more general relevance of Antoninus as an example of that adaptability which characterised social relations and conduct in this frontier zone, between two empires and two cultures. Antoninus, after all, was a former merchant who knew the local Persian satrap. He is as good an example on the Roman side as is the former hostage Jovinianus on the Persian, parading his Roman name and love of Greek culture, while in his capacity as local potentate settling tribesmen from the northern satrapies on the cultivable grasslands of Beth Arbaye.³ There is more here than theatrical declarations or nimble changes of political allegiance, granted that these were involved; the actions of Antoninus and Jovinianus are genuine expressions of the deeper ambiguities implicit in this meeting-place of Graeco-Roman and Iranian empires.

The ramifications in the confrontation are still further complicated by the use among the local populations of a dialect of the Aramaic language, Syriac, throughout the so-called 'Fertile Crescent' which runs from Palestine through Syria and down the Euphrates valley into Babylonia.⁴ This situation is well appreciated, if not always sufficiently emphasised, by historians: well understood too is the fact that direct evidence of it, from Classical Graeco-Roman sources, is very slender. In the early third century the jurist Ulpian discussed the validity of verbal agreements made by parties using different languages from each other, as between Latin and Greek (which raised no problem), or other languages such as Punic or 'Assyrian', that is Aramaic – Sabinus having written that an obligation might be contracted in any language, provided that both parties understood what was said, either directly or through a reliable interpreter (*Dig.* 45.1.1.6). Elsewhere Ulpian allows the validity of 'fideicommissa' expressed in Punic, Celtic or 'the language of any other people' (*Dig.* 32.11 pr.); but such references are like isolated voices in a massive conspiracy of silence mounted by the urban upper classes of the Roman empire against the native hinterland of their cities. Ammianus' compatriot, Libanius, became involved in a dispute over jurisdiction and patronage relating to a community of Jewish peasants which had for generations worked land belonging to his family (*Or.* 47.13). At no point did he ever suggest what must almost certainly have been true, that the peasants spoke their own language, nor should we expect him to have done so; the matter was of no importance to Libanius, despite the social relations and the need for communication with the lower classes implied by the institutions of landowning and patronage. It requires the more open social perspectives revealed in the sermons of the Antiochene cleric, John Chrysostom, or *Lives of Saints* by a writer such as Jerome or, in the fifth century, Theodoret of Cyrrhus, to tell us openly that the common spoken language of the peasantry was Syriac. Chrysostom implies that this situation prevailed immediately outside the gates of Antioch, for he remarks in a sermon how at Easter the city was crowded by Christian peasants who entered it from the surrounding country, speaking a strange language 'though in faith united with us'.⁵ The Syriac language is of course universally reflected in the place-names of the area, even in the immediate neighbourhood of Antioch. Ammianus gives an example which, as it happens, is relatively remote from Antioch, in the Tur Abdin not far from Amida. Describing the settlement, he remarked that its name, Meiacarire, meant 'place of cool waters'; 'cui fontes dedere vocabulum gelidi' (18.6.16). He did not explain, perhaps thinking that his readers would find it obvious (or not thinking about it at all), that the meaning derived not from Greek but from Syriac. What this implies as to Ammianus' own knowledge of Syriac is unclear; it is surely unlikely that a man whose familiarity with the landscape helped him escape from Amida was entirely without acquaintance with the most widespread of the languages spoken in it. On any view of Ammianus' knowledge of Syriac, it is important to recognise the relevance to his experience of the

social dimension represented by the Syriac language, and of the social exclusiveness implied by the failure of Classical sources to say anything about it.

Antoninus, as a once prosperous merchant known throughout Mesopotamia, must have known the annual fair held at the beginning of September at Batnae in Osrhoene. To this fair came just such wealthy merchants, to trade in the merchandise brought there – through Persian territory – ‘from India and China and many other parts, by land and sea’ (14.3.3). The great crowds assembled at Batnae for the September fair of 354 attracted the interest of a Persian commander instructed to raid Mesopotamia at any given opportunity (14.3.1). It is simply not possible that at such a time only Greek and Latin were to be heard in the streets of Batnae; yet when Ammianus wrote of Antoninus that he ‘knew both languages’ – ‘utriusque linguae litteras sciens’ (18.5.1) – it was Greek and Latin that he meant. The context, that of Antoninus’ espionage activities in the east, does not encompass Syriac, but Ammianus’ phrase ‘both languages’ does not consider it even as a theoretical possibility.

It has been well remarked that among the Graeco-Roman upper classes of this region of a Syriac-speaking peasantry there must have been a degree of ‘more or less shamefaced bilingualism’ in Greek and Syriac, as members of the urban elites coped with the practical problems of running their estates while maintaining what another writer has most aptly called their ‘intellectual disdain for the parochial’, that is to say the culture of the countryside.⁶ Whether Antoninus (or Ammianus) did not know Syriac, whether their knowledge of this language happens only not to be recorded, or whether it is simply dismissed as unimportant for their roles as participant in or writer of history, the same observation holds true; that Ammianus’ view of the ‘two languages’ as Greek and Latin was in itself an assertion of social values – the values of culture and administration imposed in successive ages, through the cities of the east, upon a native Syriac hinterland.

In his festival speech in praise of Antioch, the *Antiochikos* (*Or.* 11), Libanius was at pains to present his city as a creation of Alexander and his successors – as a Greek city to which the contribution of Rome was late in its history and peripheral to its true character.⁷ Libanius abandoned his historical survey of Antioch with the fall of the Seleucid kings to Rome, with feeble excuses for omitting what followed: this, he suggested, could be seen all around and needed no exposition. So the Romans themselves need scarcely be mentioned, except to acknowledge the superiority of Antioch over their cities and of Greek culture over their own. Having once seen the lovely suburb of Daphne, its temple, trees and gardens, they will give up their praises of Italy. Antioch may yield to Constantinople in the length of its ramparts, but it enjoys a more gentle climate, civilised customs and the practice of wisdom; if this was a jibe at the new Christian capital, it underestimated the extent to which Antioch too was now a Christian city. As for the claims of Rome, they are outshone by Antioch’s possession of Greek culture and eloquence. As we have seen

(p. 12), Libanius could play a different tune when writing to Ammianus of the distinction won for Antioch by his historical readings given at Rome. That much of Libanius' discourse on Antioch echoes the rules for praising cities found in rhetorical handbooks such as that of Menander Rhetor is not to say that he was insincere in his choice of the genre, and only emphasises further his dependence upon the cultural traditions of the Greek east.

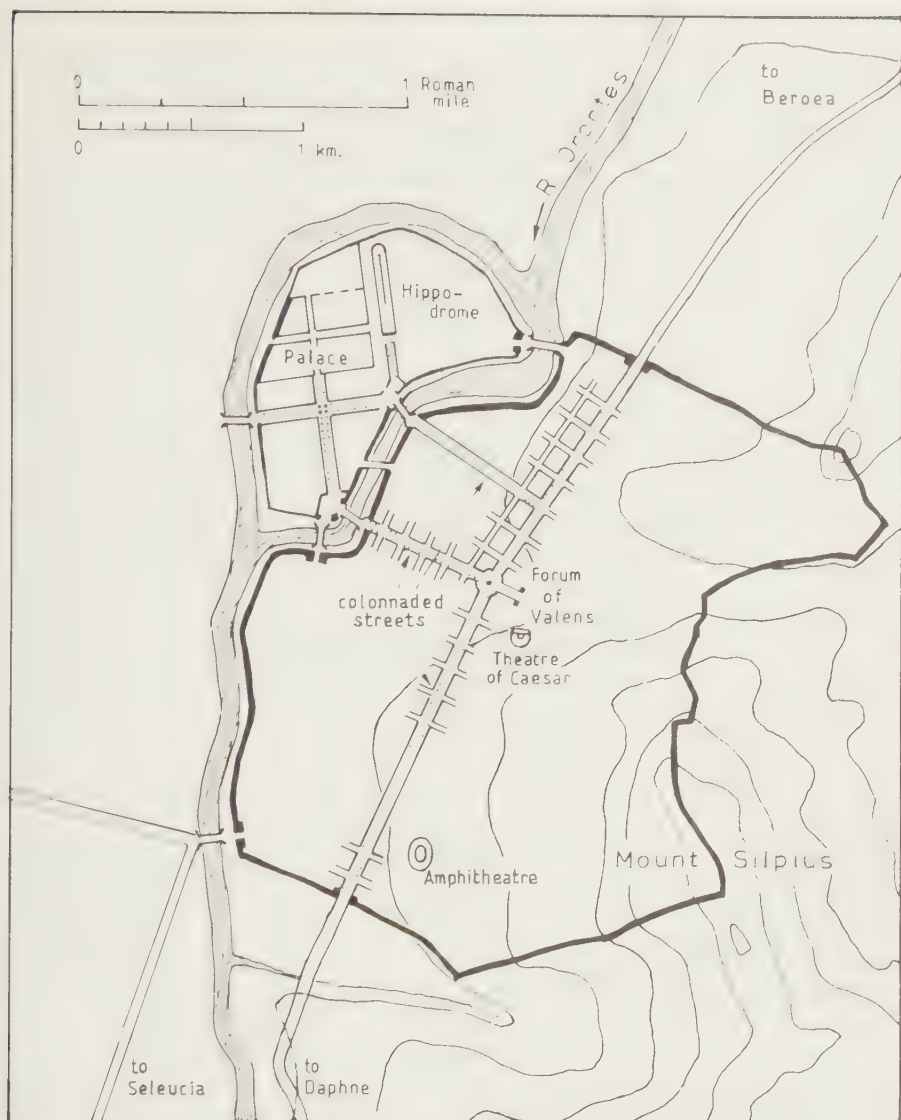
As rhetorician and teacher, Libanius insulated himself from the Latin language and culture, choosing instead, at some cost to his sense of reality, to operate within an exclusively Greek tradition. That he enjoyed the considerable success that he did, is itself a tribute to the Greek conservatism of the eastern provinces, to which a Latin government based first at Nicomedia, then at Constantinople, was a still relatively recent innovation.⁸ In his loyalty to Greek, Libanius did of course represent an ancient and still lively cultural tradition, and one with centuries of history still before it; but fourth-century Antioch offers a far more complex picture than he allowed to appear in the *Antiochikos*. It was a cosmopolitan city, strongly influenced by the imperial court and its agents, and thereby exposed to cultural pressures studiously ignored by Libanius.

The first of these pressures was, precisely, the Latin language. If beyond the gates of the city Greek, the language of culture and education, yielded to the Syriac of the peasantry, within the walls and among the upper echelons of Antiochene society it was Latin that offered the challenge. Latin was the language of the military, and of the civil administration of the eastern empire in its relations with the imperial court. It was recognised that knowledge of Latin was essential for advancement in the imperial civil service. 'Look at this man', wrote John Chrysostom, setting out possible careers that a man might choose; 'he has learned the language of the Italians, and shines in the imperial service' (PG 47.357)! Ammianus mentioned Antoninus' knowledge of 'both languages' in the context of his espionage in the military dispositions of the eastern provinces – for which, again, much of the documentation would be in Latin. In an earlier generation an associate of Constantine the Great, by name Strategius, had assisted the emperor with his enquiries into various religious sects, 'Manichaeans and suchlike' (15.13.2). Called Musonianus at the emperor's behest to commemorate his erudition, Strategius became in 354 praetorian prefect of the east, an eminence which Ammianus attributed to his eloquence in 'both languages'; 'facundia sermonis utriusque clarus' (13.1). With more precise emphasis, it was to his knowledge of Latin in addition to his native Greek that Strategius owed his rise to the highest administrative office in the eastern empire.⁹ Coming as prefect to Antioch, he entered friendly relations with Libanius, who attended him assiduously, composed a panegyric in his honour and pressed tirelessly the interests of justice (Libanius, *Or.* 1.106ff.). This at least is Libanius' version of his friendship with this notable member of the imperial governing class, but there is far

more than this to Strategius' qualifications. He also pursued enquiries into the regime of Gallus Caesar (15.13.2) and opened tentative peace negotiations with Persia (16.9.2ff.).

In his *Antiochikos* (177ff.), Libanius recognised that Antioch was the place from which Persian campaigns were organised and resistance to Persian attacks co-ordinated: hence, of course, the emperors' interest in the city. The Tetrarchic palace stood on the foundations of an earlier such project of the third century, begun but left unfinished.¹⁰ Ammianus had occasion to mention the palace, when describing how the orb placed in the hand of a statue of Galerius Caesar in its vestibule fell off and toppled to the floor; it was one of the ill-omens to greet the Emperor Jovian when he arrived at Antioch on his return from Persia in 363 (25.10.2). Libanius expounded the grandeurs of the palace and its surroundings, which formed a sort of royal precinct on an island in the Orontes on the north side of the city. There the emperors resided while they prepared their wars, bringing to Antioch all the vast impedimenta of their office – 'potestatum culmina maximarum et fortunae principalis insignia thesaurosque', as Ammianus later described them, referring to the presence of Valens at Hadrianople before the fateful engagement with the Goths in 378 (31.15.2). Libanius vividly portrayed the preparations at Antioch for a Persian campaign – the city noisy and bustling, crowded with men under arms and animals for war and transport, with soldiers being taken in gladly to private homes like members of the family (*Antiochikos* 178). How idealised was Libanius' picture is shown by Ammianus' description of the troops brought by Julian for the Persian campaign of 363. Undisciplined, disorderly and drunken, and stuffed with the leftovers from Julian's sacrifices, these troops, the *Celtae* and *Petulantes*, had to be carried through the city squares to their billets to sleep it off (22.13.6).

So the population of Antioch included large numbers of people associated with the imperial government, further swollen at quite regular intervals by the residence there of the emperor with his court and army. The presence of the court establishments of Gallus Caesar in 354 and of Julian in 362 certainly aggravated, if they did not create, serious food crises leading in both cases to public demonstrations, and in the first to considerable violence.¹¹ Even when the emperor was not there in person, the praetorian prefect, and also the civil and military governors of the Oriental provinces had their residences and office staffs at Antioch. All, to a greater or lesser extent, represented links with the Latin government of Constantinople. Of these officials, the *consulares Syriae* enjoyed the closest affinities with Antioch itself and were usually themselves easterners by origin (not that their relations with the city were therefore invariably harmonious). At the diocesan level – intermediate between the *consularis* and the praetorian prefect – there was the *comes Orientis*; on the military side the *dux* of the province of Syria and, above all, the *magister militum Orientis*, who might be found anywhere in the eastern provinces, but whose headquarters and main office staff were at



Map 2. The City of Antioch. Drawn from G. Downey, *A History of Antioch*, fig. 11, with reference also to Downey's sources and to P. Petit, *Libanius et la vie municipale*, 127

Antioch.¹² Ammianus' patron Ursicinus owned a house there – a fact known because, significantly, it was coveted by a courtier, the eunuch Eusebius, who at that moment was far away in the west, at the court of Constantius (18.4.3). Some years later another *magister militum*, Hellebichus, built a fine house at Antioch, together with baths to add to

the numerous such establishments already mentioned in Libanius' *Antiochikos* (220, 244f.). Hellebichus' baths, in the centre of the city, drew men, young and old, from every quarter, wrote Libanius in a letter to the general (*Ep.* 898). It is not clear whether any but the broadest sense can be attached to Libanius' claim that Hellebichus had 'given' these amenities to the people of Antioch; what is clear is the sophist's eagerness to 'enrol' his correspondent – to judge by his name a general of Germanic descent – among the traditional munificent classes of his city.

The office staffs of the governors of the Oriental diocese, the praetorian prefecture, and the commanders of the eastern armies, provided therefore a steady flow of 'honorati' – men of wealth and influence deriving from imperial service – whose presence in the community not only diversified its character but was coming more and more to undermine traditional civic institutions. Libanius complained of the intervention of such men in the judicial process (*Or.* 47); and, while it cannot be pursued here, there was also the increasing influence of the bishop of Antioch, whose partisan use of the judicial prerogatives granted by the emperors was fiercely deplored by Libanius (*Or.* 30.11). In fact, despite Libanius' assertion in the *Antiochikos* of its essentially Greek character, his city was an imperial metropolis, sharing to a less extreme but still considerable degree the fluid, cosmopolitan character of Constantinople. It is against this background that Ammianus' social standing, and his entry into imperial service and career are to be understood.

*

The origins of the rank of *protector* belong, like so much else in the late Roman military system, to the pressures of warfare in the third century, and particularly to the emergence during that time of a mobile field army serving directly under the emperor and moving around with him wherever its services were required.¹³ 'Protectores Augusti' begin to appear regularly in the time of Gallienus (253-268). They were men of tried experience who had risen to the rank of centurion or tribune and were chosen, as their full title implies, to defend the person of the emperor. One such officer made a dedication to secure the safe journey and return of an emperor, probably Gallienus, describing himself as 'protector divini lateris Augusti nostri' (*ILS* 4002). So *protectores* formed in the first instance an élite of officers of known capacity, chosen to serve under the eyes of the emperor himself. In practice, they are often found enjoying a rather more varied existence. They might be detailed to serve on especially important campaigns: so, an inscription mentions the 'special detachments and *equites*, commanders and *protectores*' present in Gaul for Claudius Gothicus' campaign against the rebellious Gallic empire (*ILS* 569). They might serve on the staffs of provincial military governors, and sometimes received promotion to legionary commands and to governorships. This development was a counterpart to the

progressive disappearance of senators from military commands and governorships which is one of the most interesting features of the later third century; *protectores* thereby form a pool of senior officers of equestrian rank, among those qualified to be appointed to these more senior positions. Before his promotion as Caesar in the western empire, Constantius the father of Constantine the Great had been *protector*, tribune, then governor of Dalmatia (*Anon. Vales.* 1.2).

By Ammianus' time, the corps of *protectores* consisted of men from a variety of backgrounds. There were still the real 'professionals', long-serving *protectores* who had won their status by loyalty and industry – men such as Gratian, the father of the future emperor Valentinian. Gratian, from Cibalae in Pannonia, had attracted attention by his physical strength and skill at wrestling;¹⁴ after promotion from the ranks to *protector* and tribune, he became field commander as *comes* in Africa and then in Britain (30.7.3f.). At a less elevated level, Fl. Abinnaeus had served for thirty-three years in the garrison of Upper Egypt when he received promotion as *protector*, having escorted foreign ambassadors to the emperor at Constantinople (*P. Abinn.* 1.6ff.). After three years' service as *protector*, Abinnaeus was then made prefect of the garrison at Dionysias and – once he had secured the appointment against a rival who also claimed it – served out his active years in this employment.¹⁵

At the other extreme, the corps was invaded by sinecure hunters with no military interest or qualifications whatever – for example palatine officials who had advanced themselves by patronage and corruption, and members of curial orders who had set themselves up with letters of honorary appointment so as to secure the tax immunities conveyed by the rank of *protector*. The emperors' legislation reveals their efforts to rid the ranks of these idle incumbents – men who, as one law put it, had 'never seen a line of battle, set eyes on military standards, or carried arms' (*CTh* 7.21.1). Another law, of 393, was inspired by a petition of loyal and industrious *protectores domestici*. They were resentful at the devaluation of the title earned by their strenuous efforts for the emperor if it was given by graft and corruption to men whose only concern was to feather their nest (*CTh* 6.24.5-6).

Mention of *protectores domestici* introduces a distinction of some importance for the understanding of Ammianus' career. The activities of such *protectores* as Fl. Abinnaeus were pursued entirely in the provinces, as often as not in duties resembling police or security work rather than military operations. Such duties involved, as in the case of Abinnaeus, the escort of recruits (*CTh* 7.22.2; *P. Abinn.* 1.9f.), rounding up deserters and vagrants (*CTh* 7.18.10; 22.2), conducting prisoners, convicted or awaiting trial (*CTh* 9.27.3), the inspection of the cargoes of merchant vessels (*CTh* 7.16.3), and of wagons and post-horses, to prevent overloading (*CTh* 7.5.30). Such officers, plain *protectores*, must be distinguished from the more select corps of *protectores domestici*, commissioned in the first instance to serve at the imperial court. While *protectores* fell under the command of the *magistri militum*, *protectores*

domestici were commanded by the Count of the Domestics (*comes domesticorum*). By the end of the century, and presumably before, they were divided into regiments (*scholae*) of horse and foot. Their duties were ceremonial as well as strictly military, and they possessed a particularly resplendent shield device, symbolising their position in the emperor's service. It showed two winged Victories bearing crowns, one to each side of the imperial image, all emblazoned in gold on a purple field.¹⁶

Although they were formally attached to the imperial court, *protectores domestici* could be assigned to specific duties under a field commander such as a Master of the Soldiery (*CTh* 6.25.5). This was exactly what Ammianus meant when he recalled that he had been attached to Ursicinus' service by imperial commission: 'cui nos obsecuturos iunxerat imperiale praeceptum' (14.9.1). The assignment explains Ammianus' attendance upon Ursicinus during the trials conducted at Antioch at the orders of Gallus Caesar (above, p. 34f.), and it continued when Ursicinus was summoned to the west in 355 and Ammianus went as one of Ursicinus' company to suppress Silvanus at Cologne (p. 38f.).

The group assembled for this operation had consisted of some tribunes and ten *protectores domestici* together, though Ammianus does not mention them, with their personal attendants (15.5.22). It was a carefully chosen group, which had to present itself to Silvanus as Ursicinus' escort rather than as a force with hostile intentions, and its members would need to feel secure and at ease with each other; they can most readily be seen as already members of the personal staff of Ursicinus. Among Ammianus' colleagues as *protector domesticus* was Verinianus, named both as a participant in this enterprise (15.4.22) and later, still serving under Ursicinus, in what was surely his final encounter with the enemy near Amida (18.8.11; above, p. 45). Ammianus and Verinianus were among the younger members of Ursicinus' entourage, who were instructed to accompany him on his recall to the eastern front in 357 while the senior members received military commands; 'provectis e consortio nostro ad regendos milites natu maioribus, adolescentes eum sequi iubemur' (16.10.21). This, for Ammianus and Verinianus, amounted to a renewal of their assignment by the emperor to the staff of the *magister equitum*.

The term 'adolescens' is not always employed precisely. Formally, it should refer to the stage between the years of childhood ('pueritia') and youthful maturity ('iuventus'), the time of a man's introduction to public life and his first offices – say, between the ages of fourteen and thirty.¹⁷ It is sometimes used, in specific contexts, to designate men in their thirties and even, on occasions, in their forties; but normal practice, and the force of Ammianus' contrast with 'natu maiores', make it unlikely that he intended to suggest his own age at this moment as more than thirty, and probably even a few years younger than this. 'Natu maiores' is in itself no more precise than 'adolescentes', which is its point of reference in Ammianus' text; but it would be natural to suppose that the appointments received by these senior members of Ursicinus' staff were

assignments of unattached tribunes ('tribuni vacantes') to specific commands held at this rank, rather than to any more elevated employments. The future emperor, Valentinian, was tribune of the second Schola Scutariorum in 363, by which time he was forty-two years old (25.10.9); but his promotion would have looked rather better had he not unluckily been cashiered six years before, when he was already tribune, serving under Julian in Gaul (16.11.6f.). Ammianus' 'natu maiores' one imagines, similarly, as men in their thirties and early forties.

If Ammianus was no more than thirty in 357 – even rather younger – it becomes of interest to ask how long before 354, when he first appears on Ursicinus' staff, he was admitted to the rank of *protector domesticus*.

Admission to the rank of *protector* involved the ceremony of 'adoration of the Purple', a ceremony in which the candidate made obeisance before the emperor and was offered the edge of the imperial purple robe to touch with his lips.¹⁸ In his petition to the emperor to confirm him in the post of prefect of the garrison of Dionysias, Fl. Abinnaeus recalled that he had gone to Constantinople and there been instructed to 'adore the sacred purple from the rank of *ducenarius*' (*P. Abinn.* 1.7f.); the term 'ducenarius', originally indicating the salary of 200,000 sesterces drawn by the holder of the title, normally a procurator, had come for historical reasons to indicate the rank of *protector*.¹⁹ In another case, a letter authorising four *protectores* to draw rations from imperial granaries mentioned how their superior officer, the tribune Fl. Gaiolus, had 'sent them to the sacred *comitatus* to adore the divine purple of the emperors' (*Cod. Pap. Lat.* 267.4ff.). If such relatively obscure officers attended the emperor in person to receive promotion to the rank of *protector*, we can hardly imagine that a *protector domesticus*, about to be deputed by the emperor to serve on the personal staff of the *magister equitum Orientis*, was not required to do the same.

The Emperor Constantius had spent much of the 340s in and around Antioch, constantly beset by the threat from Persia; but his latest residence in the east had been in the late summer of 350, when he was obliged to move west to prepare for the campaign against Magnentius. It is not likely that Ammianus would have attended the emperor after this date to kiss the purple and receive promotion to *protector* and attachment to Ursicinus. If this is right, and if he was thirty or less in 357, then he will have received the rank of *protector* at the age, say, of twenty-two or twenty-three. At that age, he entirely lacked the military experience possessed, for instance, by long-serving *protectores* like Gratian the father of Valentinian, or Fl. Abinnaeus.²⁰ Ammianus' claims were of a different order: like many a well-bred young man in many an army, Ammianus took the high road to officer's rank, entering a fashionable regiment almost from his teens. It may even be that Ammianus was commissioned as *protector domesticus* without serving in the ranks at all; for it is necessary to allow in his upbringing for that literary education shared, and envied, by his friend Jovinianus the satrap of Corduene.

Possession of this literary culture in itself shows Ammianus to have come from the more elevated sector of Antiochene society, since, in a very important sense, the function of this culture was precisely to define an elite against the ordinary run of mankind (as we saw earlier, it effectively distinguished the Graeco-Roman from the Syriac layer of eastern society). If this should seem a doctrinaire assumption, then it may be added that Ammianus himself reveals his social origin, in narrating a well-known episode.

Leaving Nisibis with Ursicinus in 359, Ammianus had been detailed to take a forlorn child back to the city (above, p. 41). Not any child was worth such attention, but this one had a well-bred look and wore a neck-band indicating social rank: '*liberalis formae puerum torquatum*' (18.6.10). The word then attributed to the boy to denote his father's standing, '*ingenuus*' – 'a man of breeding' – is that used by Ammianus to define his own social position. This emerges a little later. Escaping from Amida with two companions at the moment of its fall, Ammianus travelled on foot for a distance of ten miles from the city. By this time, he was very tired – overcome, as he nicely put it, 'by the excessive walking, to which as a man of breeding I was unaccustomed'; '*incedendi nimietate iam superarer ut insuetus ingenuus*' (19.8.6). At this point a runaway horse came into view, dragging the lacerated corpse of its rider, a groom who had tied the halter too firmly to his wrist and so was unable to free himself when thrown (the horse was without saddle or harness, and it appears that the groom should have been leading and not riding it). The animal was tired and easily caught; and Ammianus got on it and was conveyed to some natural springs not far away. With him went the same two companions ('*cum isdem sociis*', 8.7) – men clearly more used to walking than was Ammianus himself! The episode is a telling illustration of distinctions of social rank, revealed with the artless innocence of a man who never questions them.²¹

Ammianus' attachment to the staff of Ursicinus explains both his own highly adventurous personal experiences and his obviously partisan commitment to Ursicinus' cause, both military and political – not to mention his eclipse from the scene at the time of Ursicinus' dismissal (above, p. 46f.). It will not be misleading, either, to look for Ursicinus' influence at the outset of Ammianus' career as it is now taking shape, as the patron of an active young Antiochene of good family in quest of adventure and experience. Ursicinus had been *magister equitum* in the east since 349, and Ammianus' attachment to his service could be seen as an instance of the age-old Roman practice of '*tirocinium*' – the 'apprenticeship' by which a young aspirant to a career in public life would sit at the feet of an acknowledged master to learn the skills and gain some practical experience of what was involved. At the same time, one would imagine that Antioch was full of just such adventurous and well-born young men, and it is worth asking whether Ammianus had a special claim upon Ursicinus' attention.

In other recorded cases of *protectores domestici* commissioned without

long previous service, a relevant consideration seems to have been that their fathers had risen before them in military service. The son of a Master of the Cavalry murdered in 342 was serving as *protector domesticus* twelve years later (14.10.1), and could still be described as a 'young man' in 363 (Libanius, *Ep.* 828). A future emperor, Jovian, was senior officer (*primicerius*) of the *protectores* in his early thirties; he was the son of Varronianus, who had recently retired as *comes domesticorum*. As Ammianus wrote, his father's merits gave Jovian some claim to recognition when he was chosen as emperor after Julian's death; 'paternis meritis mediocriter commendabilis' (25.5.4).²² Presumably the same had been true earlier in his career. If these were especially conspicuous cases of nepotism (that is, of the normal workings of the system), Ammianus' early promotion remains difficult to understand without something like it. Perhaps his father was known to Ursicinus, whose contemporary he would be, as a colleague in military service in the east. A further refinement is suggested by a law issued by Valentinian in 364. According to its terms, sons and other relatives of *protectores domestici* may be enrolled on the lists of the corps while still children and too young for active service, and may even draw rations (*CTh* 6.24.2). It is unclear whether the law initiates a new procedure or regularises an established one. If the latter, then this is a further possible explanation for Ammianus' appearance, at such an early age, as *protector domesticus* assigned to the service of the *magister equitum* in the east. Enrolled in boyhood by a father in active service, he simply presented himself, having reached a suitable age, to assume a commission.

These are conjectural possibilities; but they are based on what seems to be implied by the pattern of Ammianus' military career – that his connection with army circles should go back in one way or another to his father's generation. Some important consequences for the understanding of Ammianus' history may be stated briefly at this point.

First, Ammianus, an 'ingenuus' of Antioch, appears more precisely as a member of the military and administrative class which the imperial service had established there and which had acquired a position of influence in the society of the metropolis.²³ Ursicinus' house at Antioch is a sign of his membership of this class – and incidentally, also of the social aspirations of the court eunuch who was said to covet it (18.4.3). If it be assumed that Ammianus was by descent a native of Antioch rather than from a family which had migrated to the city in an earlier generation, his affinities were still with the court and government establishment there as much as with the strictly 'civic' element in the population (as represented for instance by Libanius): for more than half of Ammianus' early years to the age of twenty, the emperor himself was regularly resident in the city, with the consequences for its social life outlined in the first part of this chapter. Such a perspective might help to explain the complexity of Ammianus' attitudes to the curial class of Antioch and other cities. As a member of a socially well-placed family, Ammianus may have felt a general sympathy with the economic interests of the landed upper class

without wishing to associate himself with every aspect of their situation. In narrating, in so far as he did so, the economic crises at Antioch under both Gallus Caesar and Julian, Ammianus unreservedly took the part of the *curiales* of the city against the imperial authorities (p. 406). On the other hand he more than once deplored the attempts made by the Emperor Julian to impose curial obligations on men who possessed established and proper exemptions. It has often been suspected that as a long-serving officer he possessed them himself.

Second, and of particular importance in considering the style of Ammianus' historical writing, his command of Latin as an instrument of such elaborate complexity will not be his own unique achievement, nor yet a reflection in any narrow sense of the Latin of the military circles in which he moved. Ammianus may have had Latin from boyhood, as a member of a family connected with the Roman administration based at Antioch. His knowledge of it was in that case a natural (if outstanding) expression of the 'cultural bilingualism' discussed earlier in this chapter; of the fluency in Latin as well as Greek which, to those who accepted it, was the particular contribution of the late Roman governing order to the cultural life of the Greek east.

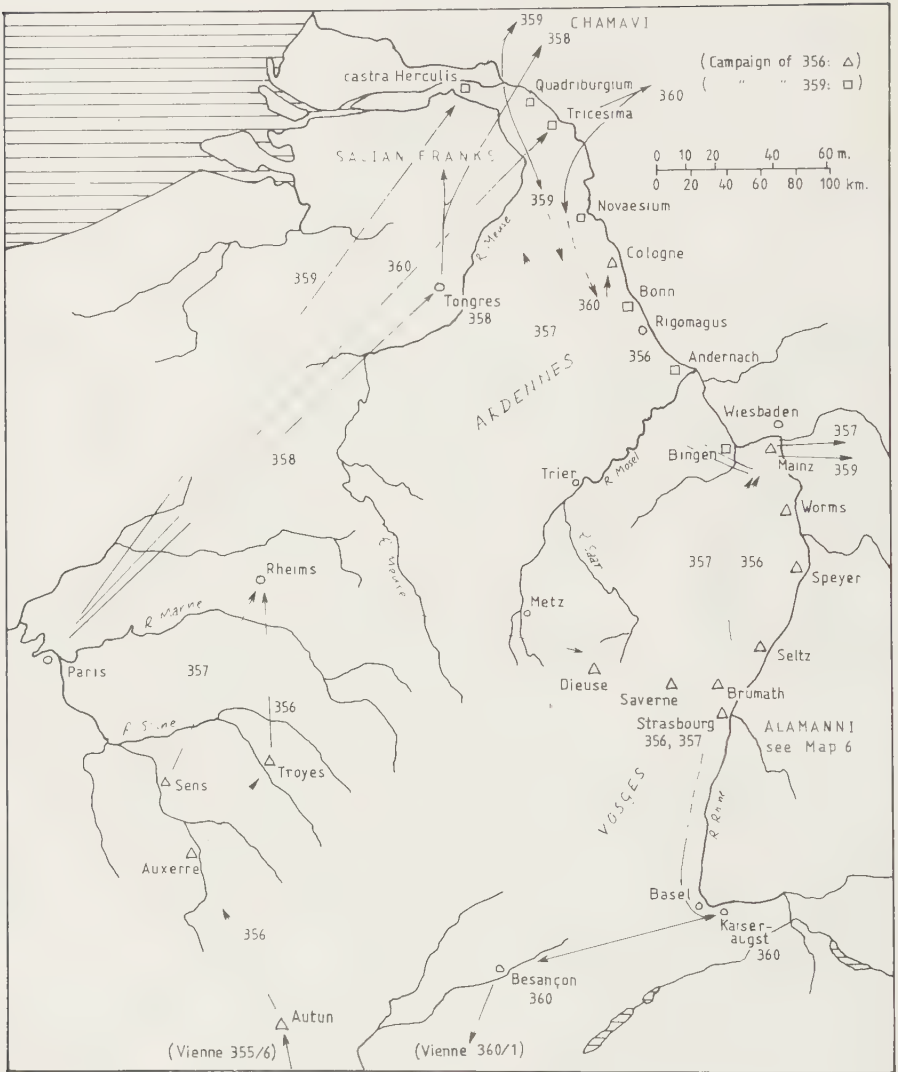
Third, Ammianus' interest in the military history of the previous generation will gain a new depth of perspective. In entrusting to Ursicinus the mission to overthrow Silvanus, the Emperor Constantius was influenced (said Ammianus) by reminders of his service under Constantine the Great (15.5.19). The reported conversations of Ursicinus with Silvanus at Cologne were clearly intended by Ammianus to imply comparison between the two generals, whose services were inadequately rewarded by an ungrateful emperor. Alone among all the generals, complained Silvanus, were he and Ursicinus so despised after their labours for the state (5.27). In summarising Silvanus' character after his assassination, Ammianus again referred to his past services, and in particular to his father Bonitus' part in the civil war of Constantine against Licinius (5.33). These, and other passages in which Ammianus referred to events and personalities of the time of Constantine, would be the more telling if Ammianus' own father were a military officer or government official of the generation of Ursicinus and Silvanus. They would also provide a link between Ammianus' narrative of his own times and his views on the earlier fourth century. With this in mind, we may return to his narrative, moving back a few years to the elevation and the early career, which was witnessed by Ammianus, of Julian Caesar.

CHAPTER VI

The Rise of Julian

After the suppression of Silvanus, Ursicinus had been instructed by Constantius to remain in the Gallic provinces (p. 38). Despite the fact that he still held office as *magister equitum* in the Orient, seconded to the western court first 'for consultations' and then to lead the enterprise against Silvanus, he was in effect to replace Silvanus until some more permanent arrangement was made.¹ In the spring of 356 Ursicinus received a successor, Marcellus, but was directed to remain in Gaul for the duration of the campaigning season, 'ad usque expeditionis finem' (16.2.8). The new Caesar, Julian, was totally without military experience and, loth though he would prove to admit it, needed all the help and advice that he could get.² At midsummer Julian was instructed to join a field army being assembled at Rheims by the two *magistri*, and marched there from Vienne, where he had spent the winter, by hazardous routes leading by way of Augustodunum, Autessiodurum and Tricasini (Autun, Auxerre, Troyes). All these towns he found troubled by a barbarian occupation extending, in his own later words, for 300 stades, or nearly forty miles, west of the Rhine along its entire length to the North Sea. A further band of territory three times that width was rendered unusable for agriculture or grazing, and forty-five cities had been stripped of their defences, not counting the smaller settlements and fortifications that had been taken (*Ep. ad Ath.* 279A-B). Ammianus' narrative of this first march bears out the essential truth of Julian's remarks. The walls of Autun, surrounded by marauding Alamanni, were defended by veteran soldiers gathered there from their homes in the vicinity, the resident garrison being inactive and useless; the route from Autun to Auxerre was beset by danger of barbarian attack, and the inhabitants of Troyes, surprised by the suddenness of Julian's arrival, were at first reluctant to admit him, in case they let in the barbarians milling about their walls (16.2.1-7).

Despite his own presence on Ursicinus' personal staff, Ammianus defines neither the military nor the political role of his patron during the season of 356. It would however be reasonable to suppose that, beginning at Rheims where the field army assembled to wait for Julian, it permitted Ammianus to know something of the recovery of Cologne, achieved at the end of the campaign (16.3.1f.). As for the political scene, the preceding winter was marked by more sinister activities, namely the punishment of the supporters of Silvanus, a leading part in this being taken by the



Map 3. Julian in Gaul, 356-360

infamous agent of Constantius, Paulus known as 'the Chain' because, according to Ammianus, of his skill in 'linking together' criminal accusations; 'ut erat in complicandis negotiis artifex dirus' (15.6.1-4, cf. 14.5.8). Given the role of Ursicinus in the enquiries for treason conducted by Gallus Caesar at Antioch, and his recent part in the suppression of Silvanus, one is led to wonder whether the general may have been associated more closely with the activities of Paulus 'Catena' than Ammianus wished to reveal. A certain elusiveness attends Ammianus'

description of Ursicinus' judicial role under Gallus Caesar, and we may surely assume that the general had some contribution to make to the broader aspects of the restoration of loyalty to the Gallic provinces. The inquisition by 'consistoriani and militares' of one supporter of Silvanus called Proculus is reported with a particularly vivid sense of occasion. A slight, sickly man, Proculus gave grounds for fear that the torture to which his slender frame was subjected would cause him to name names indiscriminately, but he remembered a dream in which he had been forbidden to incriminate any innocent person. Racked to the point of death, he named no one, and even made a good case for the innocence of Silvanus himself.³ Four days before his proclamation, the usurper had made a payment of coin to his troops in the name of Constantius – curious behaviour if he had intended to rebel (15.6.1-3). If Ursicinus were there, Ammianus might himself have witnessed the interrogation.

The following winter, that of 356/7, saw the removal from office of the *magister militum* Marcellus, ostensibly for his refusal to relieve Julian when the latter was trapped for thirty days by the Alamanni in the town of Sens (16.4.1-5). The sequel of Marcellus' dismissal – his recriminations against Julian at the court of Constantius and the Caesar's defence against them – involved the faithful eunuch Eutharius, a presumed acquaintance of Ammianus when living in later years at Rome.⁴ It is likely that Ammianus' knowledge of the scenes at Constantius' court, as well as of the situation at Sens in 356/7, derived from first-hand, or very close to first-hand, information.

Marcellus' successor was Severus, a modest, co-operative man ('nec discors nec arrogans', 16.11.1) with whom Julian established far better working relations than he had with the more temperamental Marcellus – 'strepens et tumultuans, ut erat vanidicus et amenti propior', as Ammianus writes of the latter's appearance before Constantius to denounce his Caesar. Ammianus mentions the appointment of Severus in the same sentence that describes the recall of Ursicinus to join Constantius at Sirmium, to be assigned to the eastern theatre of war with the results described in earlier chapters of this book (III-IV). The dispatch of Severus to Gaul and the recall of Ursicinus took place in June or July 357 (cf. 16.10.20). The regular campaigning season in Gaul began only in July (17.8.1), and Ursicinus and Ammianus took no part in the military operations leading to the victory of Strasbourg over the Alamanni in the late summer of the year; Ammianus was not, as has been asserted, a witness of the battle but derived his knowledge of it from very different sources.⁵ His first encounter with Julian was therefore brief; it covers only the first military campaign of the Caesar, still submissive to the commands of his Augustus, with the first hints of his unsuspected genius for military and administrative action. This aspect of Julian's achievement – his triumphant emergence from the peaceful shades of the academy to the bloody turmoil of war – is given full rhetorical amplification at the outset of Ammianus' narrative of his regime as Caesar (16.1.1-5). In the very first sentence of this narrative, Julian

enters the consulship at Vienne as the colleague of Constantius, already 'dreaming of the clash of battle and barbarian slaughter' (16.1.1). In fact, he had hardly seen an army in his life.

Despite this recognition of the sheer unexpectedness of Julian's achievement after the seclusion of his early years, Ammianus makes no attempt to explore the personality or to explain the rise of Julian in biographical terms, and he says very little of the actual nature of his background in childhood and youth. In this respect as in others, Ammianus differs from those contemporary Greek sources – Eunapius, Libanius, and Julian himself – that form the basis of most modern accounts of Julian and his reign, based on biographical reconstruction with a strong element of speculative psychology.⁶ What to writers in this vein is the formative influence upon Julian's personality, the murder of his father, elder brother and other male relatives in the dynastic carnage that followed the death of Constantine in 337, is in Ammianus' extant books not connected with Julian at all, but adduced as evidence of Constantius' cruelty in his obituary of that emperor. This is compared to the cruelty of Caligula, Domitian and Commodus – as was shown at the outset of his reign, when at one fell swoop he murdered all his relations; 'cunctos sanguine et genere se contingentes stirpitus interemit' (21.16.8).⁷ An obituary notice, which is explicitly a summary of an emperor's reign, need include no back-reference to any specific episode, and we may assume that Ammianus had mentioned the murders in an earlier passage of his work – especially if it was at that point that his treatment began to enlarge in scale (p. 27). In his attribution of the blame to Constantius alone (other views were possible), Ammianus agrees with Julian, in the *Letter to the Athenians* in which he justified his declaration of civil war against Constantius (270C-D). Yet Ammianus' failure to make any reference to the tragedy in any context actually relating to Julian differs markedly from the *Letter to the Athenians*, in which Constantius' responsibility for the murders looms very large in Julian's personality. As he implies in the case of Julian, referring on the occasion of his elevation as Caesar to those 'ancient books', in which one could read how 'the secrets of the mind are revealed by signs of the body' (15.8.16), Ammianus is interested, indeed pre-eminently interested, in character as expressed in action and gesture. He is less concerned as to how and under what pressure from external experience the character itself is formed, and in this respect stands apart from that more philosophical tradition of biographical writing in which the development of character as such was a central preoccupation. The personality of Julian is seen in terms of his conduct as Caesar and Augustus, not vice versa: 'res gestae', not biography.⁸

After the death of his relatives, Julian passed a secluded childhood at Nicomedia and subsequently at the imperial estate of Macellum in Cappadocia,⁹ attended by various guardians and teachers whose diverse influence upon the impressionable boy is a main theme in most modern accounts of Julian. Three men in particular are mentioned; bishop

Eusebius of Nicomedia; the learned George, later a hated bishop of Alexandria; and the Armenian eunuch Mardonius, to whom Julian owed his early love of the classics. Ammianus mentions Julian's sojourn at Nicomedia only incidentally, in connection with the partial destruction of the city by an earthquake in 358 (cf. 17.7.1-8); Julian recognised some people there when four years later he passed through the city, because he had been educated there by bishop Eusebius, his distant relative (22.9.4). He nowhere refers to Mardonius, and in describing the murder of bishop George in 362 (below, pp. 442ff.), had nothing to say of his earlier connection with Julian. Macellum is mentioned once only, as the estate in Cappadocia which Julian left in order to pursue liberal studies in Asia. Ammianus recounts this in explanation of certain charges laid against Julian by calumniators, namely that he had left Macellum without permission and had had unauthorised contact with Gallus Caesar as he passed through Constantinople, and he gives no indication that he had made any earlier reference to the place (15.2.7). Julian was at that time recalled to Italy and lived at Comum near Milan before being allowed to go to Greece, again for the sake of intellectual study (15.2.8). As often, the *Letter to the Athenians* gives more specific details of this period of residence in Italy, notably in Julian's recollection that he lived 'in the same city' as Constantius (not strictly true) for six months and only received a single audience with him, a second being promised but never given; and that when he was sent to Greece he had been on the point of setting off for his mother's estates in Asia but was diverted to Athens when news arrived of the rebellion of Silvanus (*Ep. ad Ath.* 273D). It seems likely that in choosing this relatively accessible place of seclusion Constantius already anticipated the role that awaited his young nephew.

Within a matter of weeks, Julian was recalled from Greece, in the event to be made Caesar, but neither in this nor in the earlier passage does Ammianus even name Athens as the city in which Julian spent this short, and often over-emphasised, fragment of his life. Ammianus' words are less exact, as if what mattered was not that Julian was specifically at Athens, but merely that he was not in north Italy at this time; 'ad Graeciam ire permissus est' (15.2.8), and later, 'ab Achaico tractu accitus' (15.8.1). It is further acknowledged that both in Asia and in Greece Julian was involved in those academic pursuits for which he had a passion; 'liberalium desiderio doctrinarum ... procudendi ingenii causa, ut cupidine flagrabat' (15.2.7f.). Nothing is however said of the intellectual and personal contacts made in both places by Julian, nor of the distinctive character of the traditions of learning, especially in Neoplatonist philosophy, which were prevalent there. The omission by Ammianus of any specific reference to philosophy, particularly striking in the light of our other evidence for Julian's actions in Asia Minor and their later influence upon his reign, again denies us the opportunity to consider at this stage a most powerful influence in the development of Julian's personality.

Ammianus is equally reticent on another aspect of his experience in

Italy that seemed very important to Julian himself. The help given him by the emperor's wife Eusebia in protecting him from the suspicions of Constantius and his supporters is described in the *Letter to the Athenians* and evoked an entire oration in her praise from the grateful Caesar (*Or.* 2 Bidez). Julian thanks the empress for the wedding-gifts bestowed on him on the occasion of his marriage to Helena the sister of Constantius – that wife who, in the words of Joseph Bidez, 'passed like a shadow into Julian's life' (*Vie de l'empereur Julien*, p. 131) – and above all for the 'travelling library' of Classical texts which Eusebia gave him as he set out on his journey to Gaul (*Or.* 2.15; 123D-124D). In Ammianus' account the role of Eusebia is indicated but not explored. She was 'inspired by heaven' to get Julian recalled to Italy rather than leave him exposed abroad to the suspicions of his enemies (15.2.8), and later steadied the wavering determination of Constantius to make him Caesar (15.8.3). After this it comes as a discreditable shock, and can only be an unsupported fragment of court gossip, later to find Eusebia accused of using poison to prevent Helena from bearing a child to Julian (16.10.18). Eusebia's inability to conceive for Constantius was well known, and interpreted by the emperor, it is alleged in the *Letter to the Athenians* (270D-271A), as a punishment for his murder of his relations in 337. It is a sign of Julian's own sense of priorities, that in his *Letter to the Athenians* he omits even to mention in its proper context his marriage to Helena, giving it only a single incidental allusion to explain a later, unrelated event (284C).¹⁰

Ammianus is only in retrospect explicit even about that most significant personal aspect of Julian's early life, his disaffection from Christianity; and again, it forms no part of any explanation of his early character. In a text of late 362 (*Ep.* 111 Bidez; 434D), Julian himself wrote that he had been for eleven years a secret believer in the gods, a persuasion given vivid circumstantial quality by Eunapius' account of the young man's activities, which were indeed not all that secret, in the cities of Asia Minor.¹¹ For Ammianus, looking back from the vantage point of 361, Julian's commitment to the gods derived, without any implication of a conscious apostasy from Christianity, from his earliest boyhood, became more intense as he grew up and finally, on his succession to Constantius, achieved full freedom of expression (22.5.1f.). None of this is directly stated by Ammianus at the time of its occurrence, nor is it put in any relation to the character of Julian. The importance of the theme is made plain not so much by explicit statement as by the steadily more emphatic patterning of Ammianus' narrative. An old woman prophesies, upon Julian's entering Vienne on his first arrival as Caesar in Gaul and before anything has been said of Julian's paganism, that 'this man will restore the temples of the gods' (15.8.22). On the eve of his proclamation Julian is addressed in his quarters by the figure of the 'genius publicus', again telling him to look to the future (20.5.10), and after it he is presented as an expert on dreams and divination, accepts omens and conducts other rites of the gods (21.1.6-2.5). He hides his adherence to the gods by attending church – again, as it happens, at Vienne – to celebrate

Epiphany (21.2.4), and, while on the road to attack Constantius, performs with certain associates rites of divination (22.1.1-3). Despite this steady amplification of Julian's religious character, the issue never displaces Julian's military and political development from the first plane in Ammianus' narrative. Even his open declaration of faith after the death of Constantius and his accession as sole Augustus is preceded, in Ammianus' text, by other transactions of the new reign, such as the accusation and punishment of supporters of Constantius in capital trials held at Chalcedon, and the elimination of waste and ostentation in the palace administration (22.3-4).

Ammianus' narrative of the actual elevation of Julian in 355 is in sharp contrast with the brevity of his allusions to intellectual and religious matters. Here we find a detailed exposition of Constantius' hesitation and motives, resolved in part by the advice of Eusebia, for accepting so uncongenial a solution to the crisis of his reign, together with Julian's presentation to the army and speeches by Constantius – these being dramatically presented in three sections, punctuated by the favourable reception by the soldiers of the proposed elevation and the actual placing of the purple robe on Julian's shoulders (15.8.9; 11). There is a reference to Julian's marriage to Helena, and a full description of his journey over the Alps to Gaul and his reception at Vienne (15.8.18-22). At this point of an already detailed narrative, Ammianus adds a digression on the Gallic provinces, beginning with the allusion to Vergil that neatly balances Julian's Homeric quotation about 'purple death and fate imperious' that he was heard muttering to himself as he was conveyed with Constantius to the imperial palace (15.8.17; 9.1). The Vergilian reference is intended to lift the reign of Julian to a higher level, and, by reminding us of the Italian wars of Aeneas in the second half of Vergil's epic, to define Ammianus' subject also as essentially military. The following book maintains the effort, its prologue comparing Julian to great emperors of the past, with citation of Cicero and renewed appeal to the greatness of its hero, seized from the life of a student and immersed in that of a soldier and general; all this achieved in a fashion that might seem to consign Ammianus' account to the level of mere panegyric, were not everything based on the authentic testimony of true facts (16.1.1-5).

*

It was Constantius' intention on raising Julian to the rank of Caesar that he would act as a figurehead in the Gallic provinces, carrying around the image of the emperor but leaving the civil and military administration in the hands of others. This is the picture presented both by Ammianus and by Julian, who in his *Letter to the Athenians* complains bitterly about the restrictive character of Constantius' supervision. Even after his elevation he was allowed only four slave attendants, in addition to the doctor Oribasius, to whom Julian entrusted the care of his books; and Oribasius' presence was only tolerated because Constantius was not aware that he

and Julian were friends (*Ep. ad Ath.* 277B-278A). Julian mentions with unjustified contempt the guard of 360 soldiers given to accompany him to Gaul, as if it were intended as a field army rather than a personal guard – that ‘comitatus parvus’ which in Ammianus’ narrative escorted the new Caesar from Milan on 1 December 355, accompanied by Constantius as far as the two columns flanking the road between Laumellum (modern Lomello) and Ticinum; ‘ad usque locum duabus columnis insignem’ (15.8.18). Ammianus had seen the place a few months earlier, on his mission with Ursicinus to suppress Silvanus; it is the staging post (‘mutatio’) known as Duriae (modern Dorno) mentioned by a fourth-century itinerary twelve miles beyond Ticinum (Pavia) on the road to Turin.¹² Only upon his entry to Turin on the road that crosses the Alps by the pass of Monte Cenisio and descends into Gaul by way of Modane and Chambéry, was news passed to Julian of the capture of the city of Cologne in Germania Secunda; Constantius had known but suppressed the information so as not to disturb his arrangements, ‘ne parata diffluerent’ (15.8.19).

Julian’s conduct as Caesar was defined by instructions given to himself, and to the generals and other high officials assigned to him; the generals were supposed, as he put it, to watch Julian as carefully as they did the enemy (*Ep. ad Ath.* 277D). The mandate was conveyed to Julian in a ‘libellus’ written out in the emperor’s own hand, ‘as if he were sending Julian like a stepson to University’ (16.5.3) – all things considered, not a bad description of his position. Julian recalls how he begged Constantius at the outset, if he were determined to make him Caesar, to give him exact guidance what he must do and what avoid, in order to make clear where his and his advisers’ responsibilities lay (*Ep. ad Ath.* 282A-B). The emperor even specified, in the only detail preserved by Ammianus of what was evidently a lengthy document, what could be spent on his Caesar’s table. The delicacies that Constantius thought permissible were rejected by Julian in favour of regular soldier’s fare and whatever food was offered; ‘munificis militis vili et fortuito cibo contentus’ (16.5.3). It is a small but not insignificant detail, as Julian acquired not only the taste for a basic soldier’s diet – that was after all not so different from a philosopher’s – but for a soldier’s profession and way of life, to an extent that would have astonished anyone meeting for the first time this intense and over-active young man, characterised more by the excitability of an intellectual than by the steady nerve of a fighting man (15.8.1).¹³

Ammianus’ most explicit statement of the subordinate position of Julian is given in retrospect, when he describes the unjust fate of Ursulus in the trials of Chalcedon (this was the man who had bewailed the fate of Amida and thereby incurred the enmity of the military). Serving Constantius as *comes sacrarum largitionum* at a time when his Caesar was ‘to be held in check by every constraint’ (‘omni tenacitate stringendus’), Ursulus had written to the official in charge of the Gallic treasuries that he was to issue to Julian without question everything he asked for (22.3.7). Julian’s best publicised disputes of authority turn

however on his relations with the praetorian prefect of Gaul Florentius, and similarly involve demarcations of competence, in this case of the *praefectus praetorio* in the fields of taxation and supply. In the most fully narrated of these disagreements, Julian opposed Florentius' instructions to remedy a tax shortfall by extra requisitions, and when the prefect objected to this slight to his authority, showed him by careful calculations that the regular assessment, or 'capitatio', provided more than enough for the needs of the state without the superimposition of extra burdens; 'scrupulose computando et vere docuit non sufficere solum, verum etiam exuberare capitationis calculum' (17.3.2-4).¹⁴ Whatever the force of Julian's arguments, few things can be imagined more annoying to a senior bureaucrat with the explicit endorsement of Constantius, than to be lectured on finance by his novice Caesar. Both sides were obdurate. When the prefect some time afterwards persisted in imposing an additional assessment ('indictionale augmentum'), Julian refused to sign or even listen to it, but hurled it to the ground in contempt. To Constantius, who responded to Florentius' complaint by writing to Julian not to interfere so much ('non agere ita perplexe') as to show lack of respect for his prefect, Julian replied with characteristic directness that the emperor should be thankful to receive even the regular tax from his devastated provinces, without expecting supplements such as no threats of punishment could extort from men reduced to poverty. His point of view was apparently accepted, and Gaul was exempted from superindictions (17.3.5). Julian's actions form part of that radical approach to taxation whereby, according to Ammianus in an earlier passage, the standard 'capitatio' in Gaul was reduced from the twenty-five *solidi* he found there at the time of his arrival in Gaul to seven *solidi* when he departed (16.5.14). Enlarging upon this achievement, Ammianus adds a detail of some general interest in considering the operation of the late Roman tax system. To the end of his life, he states, Julian opposed the giving of so-called 'indulgences' or remissions of overdue tax, knowing that this was simply money in the pockets of the rich, while the poor had to pay in full, immediately and without alleviation (16.5.15). To suggest more precisely how this came about, it appears that the upper classes of the provinces, whom the law made responsible through membership of their town councils for the collection of taxes, exacted the dues from the rural peasantry at the beginning of the 'indictio', or tax assessment period, and then petitioned for indulgences to avoid passing it on to the authorities. The poor were oppressed and the rich became richer, additional taxes were imposed to meet the shortfall, and the cycle was repeated.

Julian also achieved from Florentius what Ammianus rightly describes as an unprecedented arrangement, whereby he was personally entrusted with the administration of Belgica Secunda, on the understanding that no official either of prefect or governor should coerce anyone in the province to pay his tax.¹⁵ Even while doubting the literal truth of Ammianus' statement that the provincials were so relieved that they

actually paid all their dues without reminders before the appointed day (17.3.6), we have to admire the patience of Constantius in striving to reconcile Julian and his praetorian prefect. One hesitates to say the same of Florentius' ceding of Belgica Secunda to Julian, if only because of the suspicion that his purpose in agreeing to the experiment was to provide the Caesar with an opportunity to demonstrate incontrovertible failure. At the very least, it might restrict Julian's opportunities for interference in more important areas of the administration.

Another dispute between Julian and Florentius is described by Julian in the *Letter to the Athenians*. It concerned an arrangement made by the prefect to pay two thousand pounds' weight of silver to the Chamavi and Salian Franks, in return for which they would permit access to the lower Rhine waterways for 600 supply ships from Britain (*Ep. ad Ath.* 280A). Again, Constantius allowed his Caesar some discretion in the matter, for, informed by Florentius of the proposed payment, he wrote to Julian to tell him to make it, unless he thought it totally disgraceful (*ibid.* 280B). This was not simply a formal right of veto with no practical consequences, for its exercise would commit Julian to the alternative policy to that of Florentius, a military expedition. This, the campaign of 358, is described by Ammianus (17.8.2-9.7), and was indeed marked by serious difficulties of supply, Julian having hoped that corn grown by the Chamavi would be ripe for his use but being disappointed by the lateness of the harvest in these northerly regions (17.9.2f.). Despite this conflict with his Caesar, Florentius turned up loyally in the following season, bringing supplies to be stored in the granaries built after the campaign of 358 for the corn shipped across from Britain (18.2.3f.).

*

It was in the sphere of military action that Julian felt himself to be most severely restricted by the controls imposed upon him by Constantius: a situation that it requires little imagination to appreciate from the point of view of Constantius rather than that of his Caesar. To revert to the first season of his campaigns, Julian was instructed to take the field in midsummer 356 with the army assembled at Rheims by Marcellus and Ursicinus, and after the operations described by Ammianus (16.2-3), was required to disperse his troops for the winter, and allowed only a small force for his own protection (*Ep. ad Ath.* 278B). It was when he assigned the majority even of these forces for the protection of neighbouring towns who asked for them, that Julian found himself isolated at Sens (16.3.1-4.3; *Ep. ad Ath.* 278B).¹⁶ If Julian had been given no specific authority so to assign his troops, then Marcellus' complaint to Constantius that the Caesar was wilfully exceeding his powers can be seen to be well-founded (16.7.2). With a cocksureness that is even in retrospect amazing, Julian wrote of the campaign that – after this, the first military expedition of his entire life – he was 'thought to be not at all a serious or talented general' merely because he had shown himself to be

mild and tolerant. The proof of this was that he had resolved not to exceed his instructions or contradict any general unless he saw (from his position of profound experience) that something was being omitted that should be done in a dangerous situation, or something being done that should not be. After meeting disrespect from one or two individuals, he decided to confine himself to the ceremonial role that had been assigned to him (*Ep. ad Ath.* 278C-D). This came from the leader who had marched through treacherous wooded country with cataphract horsemen and 'ballistarii' or artillerymen totally unsuited to the purpose – 'parum ad tuendum rectorem idoneos' as Ammianus says (16.2.5) – and who through excessive haste on a foggy morning had nearly lost two legions to the enemy's superior knowledge of the country (16.2.9f.). Only from that moment, we may infer from Ammianus, did Julian appreciate the dangers of ambush (16.2.9-11).¹⁷

Julian goes on in his *Letter to the Athenians* to assert that Constantius was sufficiently sure of an improvement in the state of Gaul to entrust to him command of the field army in the spring of 357 (278D). This would be surprising on the evidence shown so far, and it may be that the choice of the elderly Severus as *magister equitum* to replace the anomalous joint command of Marcellus and Ursicinus is as much a part of Constantius' decision as any confidence in his Caesar's burgeoning military genius. That Severus, apart from his long experience of war, is described as 'neither contentious nor arrogant' ('nec discors nec arrogans'), might suggest that an improvement in personal relations between Julian and his senior general was expected to avert the conflicts of authority that were already emerging in the conduct of the Gallic administration. Julian, who liked professors, might respect the experience of old age in a general. Every policy has its risks, however, and those inherent on this occasion became clear when Severus, after two seasons' successful collaboration, suddenly lost energy and faded away; 'bellicosus ante haec et industrius repente commarcuit' (17.10.1).

The campaign of 357 was marked instead by Julian's conflicts of opinion with Constantius' *magister peditum* Barbatio – conflicts presented by Ammianus in favour of Julian but which, on closer inspection, may yield a different interpretation (p. 299f.); its culmination was the great battle of Strasbourg in late summer of the year, in which, because of the failure of his co-operation with Barbatio, Julian faced the Alamanni with far fewer troops than they had expected (16.12.1-70). The character of this battle, which drew from Ammianus one of his most elaborate rhetorical compositions, is described in a later chapter of this book (Chapter XIII), but it is worth pausing on a detail that again throws light on the nature of Julian's authority in Gaul, and perhaps also on his military judgment. Having marched to the field of battle, Julian proposed to delay the engagement until the following day in order to give his men time to rest. He was however overruled by his senior advisers, among whom Florentius is specifically named (16.12.14). Severus, who fought in command of the left wing of the Roman forces (16.12.27), must also be

presumed to have formed part of the 'celsarum potestatum assensus' in favour of joining battle without delay. Ammianus has obscured the issue by presenting the decision to fight in the context of the alacrity of the soldiers, inspired by Julian's speech urging caution and a victory on the morrow – as if it were designed precisely to have the opposite effect (16.12.9-12).

Although Ammianus gives due weight to the considerations recommending an immediate engagement (16.12.14f.), this detail is a salutary reminder that the battle, Julian's greatest single military triumph and the event that more than any other transformed his position in Gaul, was fought in circumstances in which he was overridden by his advisers. After the battle Julian's army acclaimed him as Augustus, and although he angrily refused the title ('petulantius milites increpabat', 16.12.64), the event, and the victory that inspired it, conveyed a threat to Constantius as to the standing of his Caesar, from which he would never now be free.

Julian's discontent at the restrictions exercised over him by Constantius' agents appears in a more sympathetic light when we consider the actual identity of some of the men to whose care the emperor entrusted his Caesar. Three of the unpleasant bunch (there were others) are named together in the *Letter to the Athenians* (282B): Pentadius, Paulus, Gaudentius.¹⁸ Gaudentius was a former *agens in rebus* whose information had brought down Africanus the governor of Pannonia Secunda after indiscreet conversations overheard at a dinner-table (15.3.7f., cf. 16.8.3). Promoted as *notarius* and sent to Gaul with the specific instructions to inform on the Caesar's actions (17.9.7, cf. 21.7.2), Gaudentius returned to the court of Constantius and, after the proclamation of Julian, was sent by the emperor to secure Africa against attack by the usurper's forces (21.7.2-4). Paulus 'Catena' is familiar to us. He had sought out supporters of the usurper Magnentius, figured in the trials held after the execution of Gallus Caesar, and played a similar role after the suppression of Silvanus (14.5.6ff.; 15.3.4; 6.1). He was in 359 summoned to the east by Constantius, to conduct trials held at Scythopolis in Palestine on accusations of magic arts and high treason, based on records found at an Egyptian shrine (19.12.1-18; below, pp. 217f.). Pentadius, Julian's *magister officiorum* in 358-60, was earlier implicated as a *notarius* in the inquisition of Gallus Caesar at Pola, and with others conveyed the sentence of execution against him (14.11.21; 23). The only official with whom Julian felt a positive sympathy was Saturninius Secundus Salutius, an elderly Gaul with a distinguished public career and an interest in philosophy, who was removed from Julian's entourage by Constantius because he and the Caesar were friends (*Ep. ad. Ath.* 282C). Julian wrote an essay to console himself on the departure of Salutius (*Or.* 4 Bidez) and, when he reached Constantinople in 361, made him praetorian prefect of the east. In this capacity, Salutius presided over the trials of Constantius' supporters conducted at Chalcedon, at which Florentius was condemned to death in

absence and Paulus 'Catena' burned at the stake (22.3.6; 11).¹⁹ Pentadius, also brought to trial at Chalcedon, defended himself successfully against a charge of complicity in the death of Gallus and was set free; all he had done was take notes of the Caesar's replies to his interrogators (22.3.5). The third of the 'paid sycophants' of the *Letter to the Athenians*, Gaudentius, was later arrested in Africa, brought in chains to the east and executed (22.11.1).

In view of the company he was forced to keep among these agents of Constantius, several of them implicated in the regime and ruin of Gallus Caesar and in the tracking down and punishment of conspiracy by traditional late Roman methods, it is not surprising that Julian should have sought the company of men more congenial to his taste, Greek philosophers and intellectuals. The significance of these men and their interests in the rise of Julian may be left for discussion in the next chapter of this book. The most important of them, the doctor Oribasius, has already been mentioned; Constantius allowed him and Julian to stay together because he did not know of their friendship (*Ep. ad Ath.* 277C), and Oribasius was at Julian's side to the very end of his life (below, p. 182). There was an African named Euhemerus, Priscus, an Athenian philosopher, and the Eleusinian hierophant Nestorius, all of whom Julian had visited him at least for a short time in Gaul. These men were alleged by Eunapius to have plotted the overthrow of Constantius, a claim that may relate more to the supernatural than to the strictly secular means by which Julian came to the imperial power. Ammianus has nothing to say of them, possibly more through distaste than ignorance (pp. 127ff.).

*

The context of Julian's proclamation in 360, in terms both of his own situation and of broader aspects of recent history, makes it a relatively unproblematic event; the surprise would rather have been had it not come about, and the scenario that actually occurred is one among many that might be imagined. In the context of recent history, the sequence of usurpations in the western provinces had established a pattern that might well be repeated. Nothing in the background – Germanic aggression and the need, on the Roman side, for large armed forces, freedom of action among their commanders and sufficient authority in their hands to conduct recruitment, raise finance and negotiate settlements – none of this had changed, and it remained impossible to guarantee that generals who were granted such powers would, or could, be content with them. The history of Gallus Caesar showed the difficulty, even with the most careful constraints, of confining a Caesar's role within the limits laid down for him, while Gallus' fate made clear what lay in wait for a nominee who failed to observe them.²⁰ At the end of Julian's very first campaigning season the general Marcellus had accused him of arrogance and of harbouring designs above his station, while Eutherius was obliged to state in his Caesar's defence that he was a loyal servant,

staking his own life on the truth of what he said; ‘apparitoremque [sc. Caesarem] fidum auctori suo, quoad vixerit, fore obligata cervice sua spondebat’ (16.7.3). Both the asseveration that Julian would be loyal and the force of Eutherius’ oath express the opposite possibility. It would in practice be impossible to limit public recognition of Julian’s successes to those advisers who were responsible for them; while the acclamation of Julian as Augustus after Strasbourg, despite his strenuous refusal of the title, was bound to inspire speculation as to the ultimate outcome, and comparisons between him and Constantius. The emperor’s lack of success in foreign war was too widely believed for such comparisons not to be made and, for all Constantius’ insistence in the protocol of his dispatches that he himself was responsible for the victory, everyone knew that it was Julian who had won it and that Constantius’ general, whatever the explanation, had not even taken the field.

Julian’s own description in his *Letter to the Athenians* of the events leading to his proclamation at Paris in 360 shares much, in general outline and in detail, with that of Ammianus, and there is no need to recount either narrative in detail. However, Ammianus, who presumably knew Julian’s account (though he neither mentions nor shows any sign of having used it), enables us to view the event from a wider variety of standpoints, and with a greater diversity of motives on the part of more participants. In this respect he gives what is by far the most authentic picture of the circumstances.

The crisis broke when Constantius, after his losses at Amida in late summer 359, wrote to Julian ordering the transfer to the east of substantial numbers of his troops – namely the Heruli and Batavi, Celtae and Petulantes of the ‘auxilia palatina’, together with three hundred men selected from the other ‘numeri’ in Julian’s command, and the pick of the Scutarii and Gentiles of the palace guard (20.4.2f.). The instructions were to be implemented by Julian’s *magister militum*, Severus’ successor Lupicinus, and in respect of the Scutarii and Gentiles by an officer of Julian, a *tribunus stabuli* called by Ammianus ‘Sintula’ and by Julian ‘Gintonius’, certainly the same man (20.4.5; *Ep. ad Ath.* 282D). Julian was told to do nothing to oppose Constantius’ orders, which were conveyed to the west by a *tribunus et notarius* named Decentius (20.4.2; *Ep. ad Ath.* 283C).

Enquiries as to motive may begin with Constantius, and with the question whether his need for troop reinforcements was genuine, or part of an excuse to deprive Julian of his military support in order either – to borrow a metaphor from the general Marcellus – to clip his wings (16.7.2), or even to facilitate his removal altogether; the deposition of Gallus Caesar, a constant precedent, had been achieved by progressively isolating him from possible supporters. Introducing Constantius’ request, Ammianus gives both motives but with more weight to the less creditable, adding the stimulus of the praetorian prefect Florentius, who was said to have written to Constantius recommending that troops be withdrawn from the Gallic theatre (20.4.2; 7). It has been argued that

Constantius' motive cannot have been genuine since he could not in practice get the troops to the east in time for their use in the early spring of 360 ('primo vere', 20.4.2) and since in any case his conduct of the campaign of 360 shows no particular urgency;²¹ yet in the earlier context of the loss of Amida Ammianus presents Constantius' need for reinforcements as perfectly serious, without any indication that he doubted it (19.11.17).

Similar ambiguity attaches to the motives of Julian, especially in light of a suggestion that his German campaign of 359 shows a deliberate drawing back from a normally aggressive military policy, in order (it is argued) to provide himself with a secure base for a declaration of war against Constantius.²² It is true that in 359 Julian concentrated on the rebuilding of captured forts and the construction of granaries (18.1.2-6), but he also crossed the Rhine into Alamann territory, in a campaign that does not seem in principle less ambitious than its predecessors. As Julian's campaigns won for him an increasing military dominance, there will in any case have been a shift of emphasis from aggression to consolidation: that is precisely what successful campaigning is meant to ensure. The building of the granaries was a natural product of the campaign of 358 against the Chamavi and Salian Franks, conducted, at Julian's insistence against his praetorian prefect's less aggressive policy, in order to secure access to the Rhine waterway for supply ships from Britain (above, p. 90). The argument that Julian's change of policy indicates his preparation for civil war might be turned by the observation that, if his Caesar's campaign pattern had in fact shifted from one of military aggression to one of consolidation, Constantius might feel the more justified, on receiving reports to this effect from his praetorian prefect in Gaul (cf. 20.4.7), to request the transfer of troops for use in the east.

When Decentius arrived with his orders for the troop withdrawal, any hopes of a smooth implementation of his instructions were thrown into disarray by the fact, which he now discovered for the first time ('nondum compertus', 20.4.3) that Lupicinus, to whom the administration of the task was entrusted, was absent on campaign in Britain. The dispatch of Lupicinus is another factor that has seemed to betray Julian's complicity in an approaching coup d'état.²³ Again, suspicion is one thing, reasoned proof another. Ammianus' introduction of the British campaign gives no indication that there were not sufficient grounds for it – indeed rather the contrary, as he evokes in rhetorical terms the irruptions in the frontier zone of the 'wild nations' of the Picts and Scots (20.1.1). It is unjustified to argue, on the basis of Ammianus' brief description of Lupicinus' first move, a march to London (20.1.3), that he seemed unsure of what he should do, or that his force was excessive for the task in hand. Both his caution and the size of his force might be an indication of the seriousness of the situation and the need to plan carefully the Roman response, and Ammianus indicates that Lupicinus justifiably wished to take the field as quickly as he could; 'ut exinde suscepto pro rei qualitate consilio

festinaret ocius ad procinctum' (20.1.3). His first move is the same as that made, admittedly with more difficulty, by Theodosius a few years later, and the importance of this campaign is not usually underestimated, at least by historians of late Roman Britain (27.8.6-8; 28.3.1).²⁴ The size of Theodosius' force, four 'numeri', was the same as that assigned to Lupicinus (two of the units, Heruli and Batavi, were used on both occasions) and there are no grounds for belittling the seriousness of the latter's task. It was a quite different situation when, after the proclamation of Julian, Lupicinus was isolated in Britain and arrested once he set foot at Boulogne (20.9.9, cf. *Ep. ad Ath.* 281A).

Ammianus presents Julian, not as keeping Lupicinus out of the way, but as lacking his advice, which he sorely needed on the arrival of Decentius at his winter quarters at Paris (20.4.6; 9). This is not an absurd presentation of the position. The 'auxilia' required by Constantius were under the command of the *magister militum* (*Not. Dig., Occ.* 5.160-3), and their removal could hardly be achieved without his knowledge and consent – indeed, we have just seen that of the troops requested by Constantius, the Heruli and Batavi were actually in Britain with Lupicinus. No such formal problem arose with the picked troops from the Scutarii and Gentiles also demanded by Constantius. These units of the palace guard fell under the authority not of the *magister militum* but of the *magister officiorum* (*Not. Dig., Occ.* 9.4-8); this would be Pentadius, whom Julian connects with Decentius and Nebridius (the *quaestor sacri palatii*) in his account of these transactions (*Ep. ad Ath.* 283C). Pentadius may be assumed to have approved the transfer and the tribune Sintula, correctly paying more attention to Constantius' instructions than to Julian's complaints, took them off without difficulty and in the hope of receiving promotion from Constantius, 'spe potiorum erectus' (20.4.5). He brought them back when news of the proclamation overtook him on his journey (20.5.1).

The most difficult question of motive attends the conduct of Julian's praetorian prefect, that Florentius with whom his relations had been so fraught. Decentius' problems on arriving at Paris were in fact even greater than indicated so far.²⁵ Not only was the *magister militum* absent in Britain; Florentius was at Vienne in southern Gaul, ostensibly to organise supplies but in fact, according to Ammianus, because he feared military disorder (20.4.6). The reason for this was that he 'was believed' ('putabatur') to have sent to Constantius a report advising the withdrawal of high-quality troops from the defence of Gaul. His conduct is more intelligible if he had in fact sent such a report and assumed that this would be known, than if he had not sent it but assumed that he would be believed to have done so; in any case, he refused to move from Vienne at Julian's request, even when the Caesar urged on him the public interest, and the duty of a *praefectus praetorio* to stand by his *imperator*, threatening to lay aside the insignia of rank if Florentius did not come (20.4.8). Such an approach was perhaps not best calculated to induce the prefect to rush to Julian's side, but this is not to say that Julian actually

intended to deter him; nor, in view of his mandate from Constantius to supervise his Caesar, was Florentius necessarily obliged to perform every action that Julian suggested to him. Whatever the explanation of his conduct, the result of Florentius' absence was that Julian can again be presented, in Ammianus' as in Julian's own account, not as cleverly keeping the heads of his civil and military administration away from the scene of a conspiracy, but on the contrary, as deprived of the advice from them by which it might have been avoided.

Julian's own actions are at least compatible with his categorical profession, made before the gods, of good faith and innocence (*Ep. ad Ath.* 284B). To the withdrawal of the men from the Scutarii and Gentiles he had made no objection, 'yielding in all matters to the will of his superior'; 'acquieverat Iulianus, potioris arbitrio cuncta concedens' (20.4.4). He allowed himself the observation that men who had been recruited on the understanding that they would not have to serve outside Gaul should not suffer inconvenience, adding his fears that unless the understanding were respected it would prove difficult in future to recruit barbarian volunteers who often joined Roman service on these conditions. Despite his remarks, the troops departed (20.4.4). It was concerning the 'other troops' ('residui') requested by Constantius that difficulties arose, through the absence of the *magister militum* and praetorian prefect; these considerations, Julian's anxieties and the competing claims in his mind of the barbarian enemy and imperial authority, are well set out by Ammianus in a single, concentrated sentence (20.4.6).

In the end, and in the absence of his advisers, Julian decided to comply with Constantius' demands (20.4.9). From this point, the usurpation was under way as surely as if he had refused to obey them. The soldiers had received orders to leave winter quarters when what Ammianus calls a 'famosum libellum' – not a 'famous' or 'notorious' letter but a broadsheet containing unattributed allegations, or 'famae'²⁶ – was thrown onto the ground near the standards of the Petulantes, reciting among much else the grievances already put to Sintula by Julian on behalf of the Scutarii and Gentiles; they were to be compelled to serve abroad, leaving to the mercy of the Alamanni those wives and families whom their first campaigns had liberated – interesting sentiments, coming from mainly Germanic troops (20.4.10)! The contents of the broadsheet were no doubt widely known, but Julian treated it as in effect a formal petition brought in to the 'comitatus' and read; in response to the 'reasonable complaints' which he judged to be contained in it, he permitted the men's families to travel with them by the official transport service (one wonders how Constantius would regard this variation on his orders, when he received in the east not only battle-hardened soldiers but a migratory column of wives and children). Julian, who agrees with Ammianus that only one pamphlet was involved, adds that Constantius' agents pressed on him the need to dispatch the troops quickly, before similar documents could be broadcast among the other units and in order to avoid suspicions of disloyalty in addition to those that were already held (*Ep. ad Ath.*

283B-C). If they really said this, they were behaving like men who saw which way the wind was blowing but still hoped that the situation might be controlled, and Julian himself had given no indication to the contrary. The next step was to decide by which route the troops should go, and it was the tribune Decentius who recommended – according to Julian, against his own advice (ibid. 283D-284A) – to direct them by way of Paris, where Julian himself resided (20.4.11). In another fateful but perfectly innocent step, it was then natural for Julian to receive them when they arrived in the parade-ground outside the city, greeting the men whom he knew (it is important to note that he did not make a speech to their assembled company) and encouraging them to proceed to the court of Constantius, ‘whose power was great and generous, and where their rewards would match their achievements’. As both Ammianus and Julian indicate, this reception by Julian of his fellow-soldiers was customary practice, and there is nothing inherently suspicious about it (20.4.12, cf. *Ep. ad Ath.* 284A). Equally unremarkable in itself, though its consequences were immediate, was Julian’s invitation on the same day to the leaders of the Petulantes to a dinner at which, with no need for treasonable talk, their sense of resentment was intensified. This, we all know, is how usurpation comes about, and Julian is disingenuous in his *Letter to the Athenians* in omitting all mention of the dinner-party while at the same time calling the gods to witness that only in the course of this evening did he have any inkling of what was going to happen (*Ep. ad Ath.* 284B). A significant detail in this part of Ammianus’ account is his implied confirmation that the leaders of the troops, and the soldiers themselves, were barbarians recruited into Roman service. The leaders are described not as generals or officers but as nobles, ‘proceres’, and the ground for their resentment was that they would be separated from their ‘homelands’, ‘terris genitalibus’ (20.4.13).²⁷ This phrase connects with that attributed to Julian himself in referring to the Scutarii and Gentiles led away by Sintula, ‘relictis laribus transrhenanis’ (20.4.4).

The acclamation of Julian as Augustus by soldiers surging at night around the palace, Julian’s demurral, slowly weakening in face of the sustained force of their demands, and his own sense, confirmed by his prayers for a sign, that this was the will of the gods; his raising on a soldier’s shield in the manner of proclamation of a German chieftain and his ‘crowning’ with the neck-chain of a standard-bearer of the Petulantes (20.4.14-18) – all this is a release into action of the accumulating tensions that have preceded. The question remains, whether it was more than this.

Certain elements in the sequence leading up to the proclamation – the broadsheet in the camp of the Petulantes, their reception at the parade-ground at Paris, the dining of their officers – are compatible with, but none actually presupposes, a premeditated conspiracy. What is disingenuous about the dinner-party is not that Julian held it but that he failed to mention it in the *Letter to the Athenians*. There may well have existed, at intermediate rather than at the highest levels of the court and

army establishment, groups of officers who saw the public interest or private advantage in a promotion of their Caesar's interests against Constantius, and who were prepared to exploit to their ends the resentment caused by the emperor's demands. The intellectual friends of Julian had caught the mood when, as will be explained in the next chapter, they conducted their secret rites in order to 'gain the courage to abolish Constantius' tyranny' (below, p. 115). To one of these friends, Oribasius, Julian had already divulged his all-too-explicit dream of the young sapling springing from the roots of a fallen tree, in response to the telling of a dream, the content of which is not imparted, of Oribasius' own (*Ep.* 14 Bidez).²⁸ The similarity between them seemed to Julian to show that both dreams were of the true variety. But this only shows that men were able to see, and to dream about, the obvious. As far as Julian was concerned, the proclamation was less an outcome of conspiracy than of a growing recognition in his mind, as in the minds of others, of what had from the first seemed possible, then likely, and now seemed bound to happen. To this recognition, and to his sense that, just as he owed to them his survival and his successes, so too his prospects for the future lay in the hands of the gods, we may assign the dream and other 'supernatural' experiences reported by Julian that have seemed, to some, to show his explicit designs against Constantius. They are rather to be seen as a projection of Julian's realisation that the inevitable – that is to say the will of the gods – would come about, and an expression of the need to justify to himself and to the public his own part in it.

The following sequence of events is described in similar terms by both Ammianus and Julian, and there is no need to paraphrase it in its entirety. Julian's offer to share power with Constantius, accepting a praetorian prefect of his nomination but appointing all other officials himself, was rejected outright by the emperor, who received Julian's envoys at Caesarea in Cappadocia with undisguised fury, told Julian to be content with his former status and appointed new officials for his Caesar (20.9.1ff.). Of these officials, Julian accepted Nebridius as praetorian prefect but rejected the other nominations in favour of his own (20.9.8). Nebridius' predecessor, Florentius, upon hearing of Julian's proclamation had left Vienne and taken himself with some difficulty to Constantius' court, where he denounced Julian as a rebel 'with many accusations' relating, no doubt, to more than the most recent events. In a gesture both true to his own character and good for public relations ('bene cogitans et prudenter'), Julian allowed the prefect's family, whom he had abandoned in his flight to Constantius, safe conduct to the east using the public transport service (20.8.20-2). Florentius was a little later appointed praetorian prefect of Illyricum, from which office he was uprooted by Julian's lightning advance to Sirmium (21.6.5; 9.4).

Both parties then devoted themselves studiously to their foreign wars, Julian to an expedition against the Atthuarian Franks before returning by way of Kaiseraugst to winter at Vienne, while Constantius renewed his alliance with Arsaces of Armenia and, travelling by way of Amida,

addressed himself, late in the season and without success, to the recovery of Bezabde on the Tigris (20.10.1-3; 11.4-32). With the return of Constantius to winter quarters at Antioch Ammianus ends Book 20 of his history, beginning Book 21 with an ominous reflection. It was ordained, so it seemed, that as long as Constantius engaged personally in war with Persia he was never successful, though his generals sometimes were; in civil war he never failed. There was also the constant reminder of Gallus Caesar, destroyed through his own inertia and the treachery of others (20.11.32; 21.1.2). Inertia was the very last quality one would attribute to Julian, but these were anxious thoughts to occupy his mind at the end of his first year as a free agent, having exchanged Constantius' suspicions for his open enmity. Ammianus presents their implications in Julian's reflections on the coming year. Should he continue to attempt reconciliation with his 'bloody friend', or should he strike first, to gain the advantage of terror in a war in which his forces were so palpably inferior (21.1.1)?

*

The civil war of 360-1 is instinctively seen by historians from the point of view of Julian rather than Constantius: the rising rather than the setting star. That is natural. Not only was Julian the victor in the outcome (historians like a story with a future); to most of them, intellectuals like himself, he is the more attractive character, and, as can be seen from the first part of this chapter, he is articulate and, one must admit, not unpersuasive in his own defence. Seen however from Constantius' point of view, the situation provided yet another instance of the eternal choice with which his reign had confronted him, the choice between foreign and domestic war (cf. 20.9.3).

In making his choice, he was without the counsel of Ursicinus, whose outspoken criticisms of Constantius' conduct of military affairs on the eastern frontier, made early in the year at Sirmium, had already secured his dismissal (20.2.1). With him, presumably, departed Ammianus, whether for some other (no doubt unfavoured) assignment or whether for a spell of private life as an officer without posting (and largely forgotten) remains a matter of speculation: as does the intriguing possibility that, but for the dismissal of Ursicinus, Ammianus could have found himself preparing in 361 to take the field against Julian. Ammianus could easily, through Ursicinus, have picked up an account of Constantius' motives in writing to Julian for reinforcements after the loss of Amida – we have seen that in this context at least, Ammianus took quite seriously the need for reinforcements in the east (19.11.17). He would however rely on others 'versati in medio' for his knowledge of subsequent relations between Constantius and his Caesar: notable among them, again, is the eunuch Euthерius, whose authority might well lie behind Ammianus' knowledge of the rancorous secret letters addressed to Constantius by Julian in addition to the more dignified communications intended for

public circulation. Eutherius was one of Julian's two envoys to Constantius, and the account of their reception at Caesarea is told with a certain terse vigour for which he was probably the source.²⁹ The emperor's white-hot display of anger – 'ultra modum solitae indignationis excaudit imperator' – had scared the life out of them (20.8.18f.; 9.1f.).

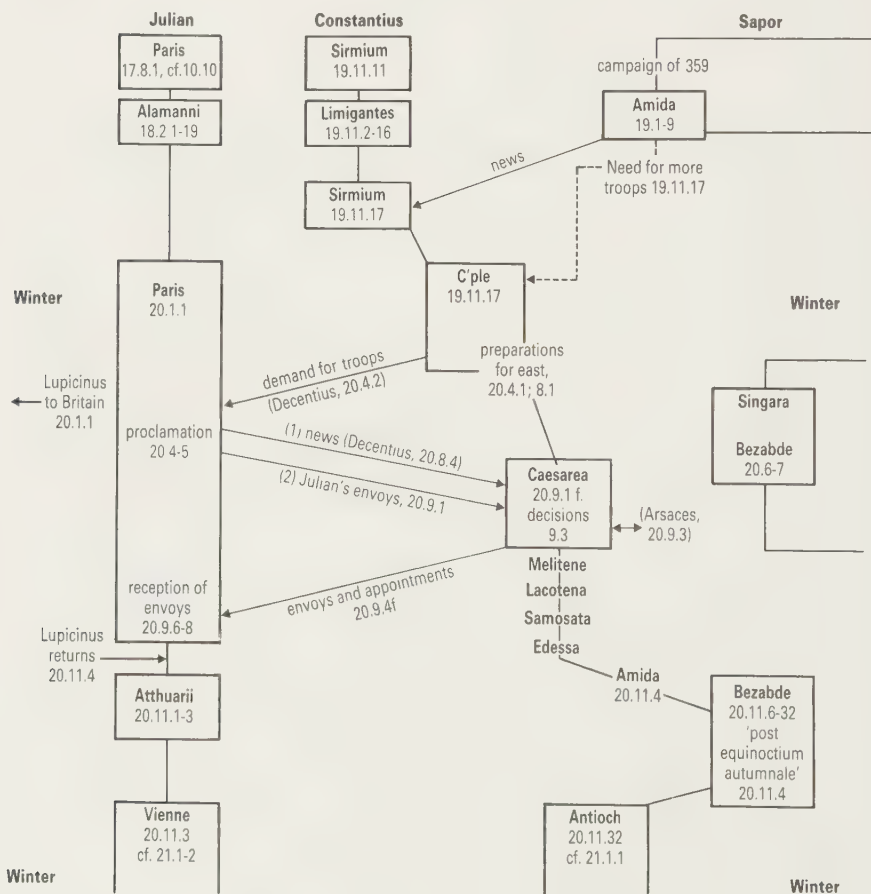
In 361, despite Julian's preparations against him, Constantius again decided, after some hesitation, to devote himself to the eastern frontier, thinking that he could more safely attack Julian without an external enemy at his back and still hoping to catch his rival before his undertaking had gained momentum; this at least is what he told his associates, to reassure them (21.7.1). In the meantime he secured Africa by sending there the *notarius* Gaudentius, a manoeuvre which, as Ammianus makes clear, worked very well. As long as Constantius lived, none of his adversaries landed there (21.7.2-5). Constantius again enlisted the kings and satraps of the Transjordanian regions, together with the kings of Armenia and Hiberia, crossed the Euphrates at Capersana and waited at Edessa for Sapor to decide whether or not the omens would permit him to invade that year (21.6.7f.; 7.6; 13.2). The emperor was dismayed to learn that Julian had already occupied the pass of Succa (21.13.6), though he presumably also knew that his *comes Thraciarum*, Martianus, was preparing to amass troops to the east of Succa and prevent Julian from advancing further (21.12.22). It was nevertheless an immense relief when Constantius heard that Sapor had yielded to the omens and taken his army away from the frontier without attempting a crossing (21.13.8). The emperor at once returned to Hierapolis and devoted his attention to the suppression of Julian. Ammianus – who, we must remember, was in the east at the time – remarked that no one doubted for a moment that Constantius would win the war (21.7.3). He later has occasion to mention one Theodotus of Hierapolis, who had escorted Constantius from his city among the 'honorati' and flattered the emperor with gross effusiveness ('deformiter') as the certain victor – an act which many people later reported to Julian, who forgave him (22.14.4). Theodotus' conduct is a sure measure of what people expected the outcome would be.

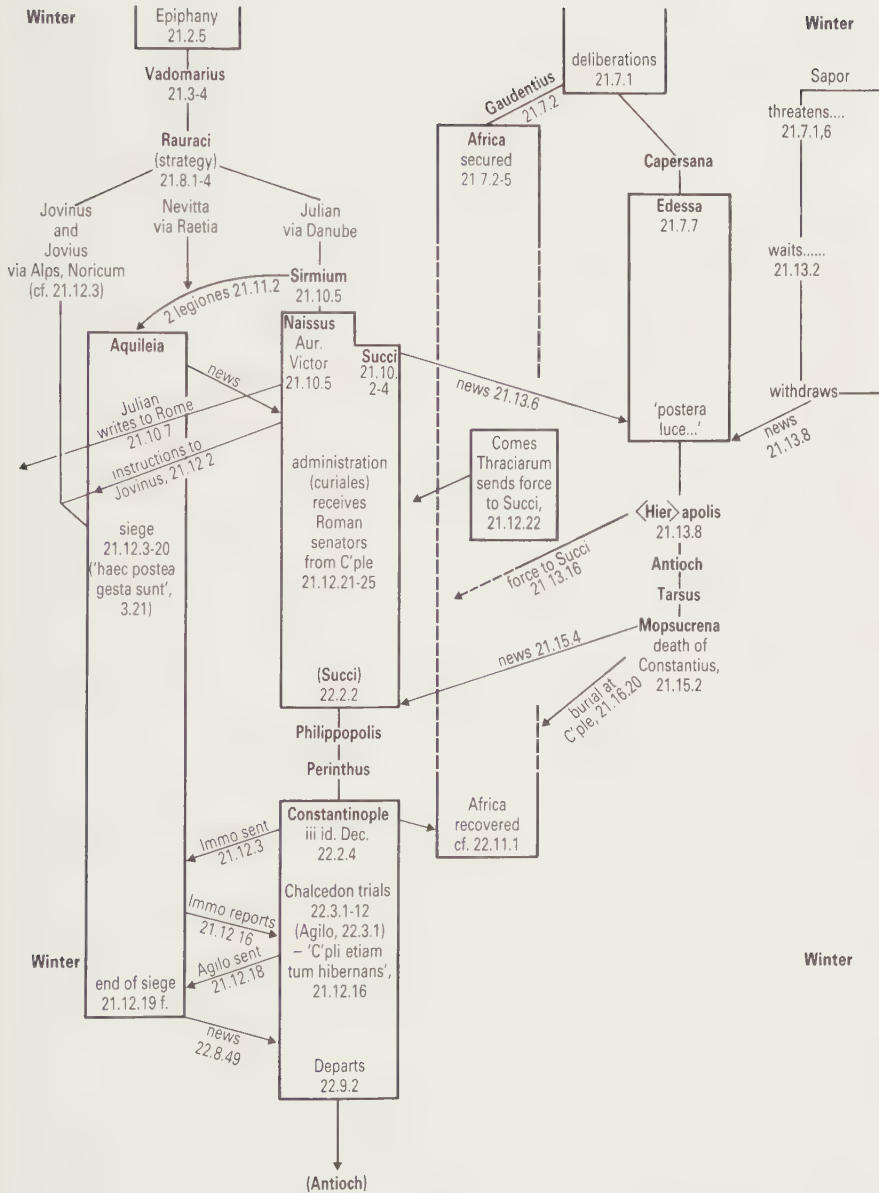
Not for the first or last time in Julian's career, Fortune took a hand. Constantius led his army from Hierapolis to Antioch and from there on to Tarsus and into Cilicia; and there, at Mopsucena in the shadow of the Taurus mountains, on 5 October 361 he succumbed to a fever that he had contracted at Tarsus but hoped with typically stolid determination to shake off by travelling. Whether truthfully or by a useful fiction, he was said while his mind was still lucid to have named Julian as his successor. He then lapsed into silence and passed away after a long death-struggle; 'diuque cum anima colluctatus iam discessura abiit e vita' says Ammianus, bringing Constantius' life to an end with words of a ceremonious, almost liturgical dignity (21.15.2).

The operations of the partisans in the civil war of 360 and 361 are summarised in the chart overleaf, which is designed not to supplant

The Rise of Julian, 359–62

The chart shows the movements of Julian and Constantius from late 359 to early 362: every detail shown is either stated or directly implied by Ammianus. Its purpose is to present an integrated view of events in different theatres of action; to illustrate the difficulty of the task of narrative reconstruction and co-ordination faced by Ammianus; and to show how successfully he achieved it, working from such individual items of information as those shown on the chart.





the narrative of these events but to show graphically the complexity and coherence of Ammianus' account of them; every detail there included is either stated in or can be directly inferred from his text. Taking for granted the accuracy of the narrative, we are free to analyse the conflict in terms of the respective strengths of the two sides.

In his *Letter to the Athenians*, Julian mentions Constantius' supply depots, three million 'medimnoi' of grain stored at Brigantia (Bregenz) to the east of Lake Konstanz, and the same quantity near the Cottian Alps. Constantius, who on this evidence planned to mount an attack upon Julian from both Italy and Illyricum, had also written to his supporters in Italy to impose a blockade against any troops from Gaul and had sent instructions to the praetorian prefect of Italy (*Ep. ad Ath.* 286A-C). Julian seized the corn supplies and intercepted the letters to Taurus. He also alleged Constantius' readiness to use barbarian allies against him, an allegation borne out by Ammianus' description of the arrest of king Vadomarius of the Alamanni while at dinner with the Roman commander at Kaiseraugst (21.3-4). A Roman *notarius* had been intercepted by Julian's guards bearing letters from Vadomarius to Constantius reporting on his Caesar's 'lack of discipline', while he simultaneously addressed Julian as 'dominus' and 'Augustus'. Ammianus also stated that Vadomarius had been instructed to cause sufficient unrest in the regions adjoining his own principality to prevent Julian from leaving the Gallic frontier (21.3.4f.).³⁰ The westerly penetration of Constantius' power, and the fragility of Julian's support there, are further shown by the hostile reception by the Roman senate of Julian's letter addressed to that body from Illyricum (21.10.7); while he also received at Naissus (and promoted) two leading senators who had been sent as envoys to Constantius and were now returning – disconcerted, no doubt, to find Naissus already in the hands of the usurper (21.12.24).³¹ The attachment of the senate to Constantius must be seen in the light of its relations with an emperor who had visited Rome with such success only four years previously; these things were remembered. Two 'legiones Constantiacae' that Julian found at Sirmium, sent with a cohort of archers to serve in Gaul because he did not trust them, entered Aquileia on their way there and declared the city and its region loyal to Constantius; this was a serious problem, and one only resolved – and even then not immediately, for the defenders of Aquileia were reluctant to believe it – by the arrival of the news of Constantius' death (21.11.2ff.).

Julian's most effective manoeuvre in face of the massive territorial and military advantage of Constantius was speed – such speed as would frustrate the emperor's hope that he could both patch up his differences with Sapor and meet Julian before his campaign had gathered momentum (21.7.1). All sources – Julian himself, Zosimus (from Eunapius) and the panegyrist Mamertinus as well as Ammianus – emphasise the extraordinary speed of Julian's advance down the Danube to Sirmium, using a fleet of river-boats that he either found by chance (according to Ammianus) or had ordered to be constructed (in the version

of Eunapius).³² He also split his army into three divisions in order, as Ammianus says, to allow rumour to exaggerate the size of his forces as they advanced along different routes. In doing so, he was imitating Alexander the Great and other expert generals who had done the same when need arose (21.8.3) – a rather ‘literary’ interpretation of a manoeuvre permitting Julian to strike quickly for Illyricum while the supporting divisions advanced by way of north Italy and Raetia respectively (21.8.3). In the event the manoeuvre was partly undermined by the adherence of Aquileia to Constantius, to which Julian was obliged to divert the division marching under Jovinus by way of north Italy (21.12.2). The speed of Julian’s advance is shown also by the flight to the court of Constantius of the praetorian prefects of Italy and Illyricum, Taurus and Florentius, and by Julian’s dramatic night-time capture of Constantius’ general Lucillianus at Bononia near Sirmium. Lucillianus was in bed expecting nothing of the sort, when he was woken up by a commotion and found himself surrounded by total strangers who escorted him to the young pretender (21.9.4-8)!

In one sense, Julian had overstretched his resources. He had no difficulty advancing past Naissus and seizing the strategic pass of Succus leading down into Thrace, but did not have the forces to advance beyond it.³³ The Thracian armies had been mobilised against him by the *comes Thraciarum* (21.12.22), while Constantius was preparing an attack as soon as he could free himself from his problems in the east (21.6.6). Further, Constantius controlled Africa (21.7.2-5), Aquileia was loyal to him, and an eastern field army was being prepared for an advance into Thrace ahead of Constantius’ own arrival (21.13.16). Ammianus is justified in portraying Julian at this time as apprehensive and anxious (21.12.21); a state of mind in which we should imagine his conduct of the sacrifices and divination performed at Naissus, among them rites that indicated the coming death of Constantius. Despite this (he did not know of Constantius’ own premonitions of his approaching end), Julian dared not attempt to break out of the Dacian provinces into Constantius’ dominions (22.1.1f.).

The tension was resolved, and the omens confirmed, by the sudden arrival of the news of Constantius’ death, brought by two envoys who also told Julian that his rival had named him as his successor (22.2.1). The reign of Julian as sole Augustus effectively begins at this point, but Ammianus preserves a continuing sense of its character as a journey with digressions, beginning with his descent of Succus and rapid advance to Constantinople, then in a series of stages through Asia Minor to Antioch, and from there to the Persian campaign on which, still marching, he was killed.

Julian’s periods of residence in the cities of the empire through which he passed on his journey are characterised by Ammianus through activities of government and administration picking out guiding themes of his reign. At Naissus he received embassies and made appointments, heard litigation and, at the instance of town councils, imposed civic

burdens on many individuals, an act criticised by Ammianus (21.12.23-5). It was from Naissus that Julian wrote to the Roman senate and probably also his letter to the council and people of the Athenians, as we have seen a crucial source for the events of his usurpation.³⁴ It was one of a series of missives sent to the cities of Greece, a region that with the occupation of the prefecture of Illyricum now fell under his control. The letters to Sparta and Corinth are also mentioned in our sources, though with the exception of a brief citation from the letter to the Corinthians describing his father's residence in the city, they do not survive (Zosimus 3.10.4; Libanius, *Or.* 14.29f.).

Julian's sojourn at Constantinople is portrayed in a series of episodic chapters describing aspects of his regime: the trials at Chalcedon at which, in the intimidating presence of the military, several unjust as well as just sentences were imposed (22.3.1-12);³⁵ the reform of the palace administration by an onslaught upon elimination of ostentation and waste, in which Ammianus, while permitting himself an eloquent digression on luxury that occupies most of the chapter, thought that Julian went further than befitted a true philosopher (22.4.1-10); the treatment of Christians and, in an ironically juxtaposed chapter, of some litigious Egyptians (22.5-6). The Egyptians were sent to Chalcedon on the pretence that the emperor himself would come to hear them, and orders then issued that no man must transport an Egyptian from Chalcedon to Constantinople. The litigants eventually became disheartened and returned home (22.6.1-4). The Christians were granted a freedom of belief that, in Julian's opinion, would ensure their rapid decline into squabbling sectarianism (22.5.3f.). It is in this context that Ammianus makes his explicit avowal of Julian's early adherence, 'a rudimentis pueritiae primis', to the gods, and describes his open declaration of support for the old religions, with instructions that the temples should be reopened and sacrifice restored (22.5.1f.).

These chapters are followed by a description of Julian's conduct in the senate of Constantinople, introduced by his behaviour on the Kalends of January 362, when the new consuls, Mamertinus and Nevitta, were admitted to office (22.7.1-6). Ammianus' comment that Julian, in a gesture praised by some but criticised by others as cheap and affected, processed with the consuls on foot, is confirmed by the panegyric of Mamertinus delivered on the occasion.³⁶ There is then a rapid transition to Julian's conduct of military affairs, including his famed rejection of the advice to make war against the Goths (22.7.8), and his reception of various embassies. In rising degrees of implausibility they came from the Transtigritane regions and Armenia, from India and Ceylon and from Mauretania in 'the south', and, in the solitary northern regions of the Black Sea, from the Bosporani and 'hitherto unknown' peoples, petitioning that they be allowed to live in their ancestral lands (22.7.8). Perhaps such embassies (or some of them) did arrive, but the whole passage is an essentially 'literary' collection of peoples, whose main function is to dramatise the extent of Julian's power and to furnish a

transition to the long digression on the Pontic regions with which the rest of Julian's sojourn at Constantinople is occupied (22.8.1-48). The digression ends, incongruously, with the arrival of yet more good news (in addition, that is, to the arrival of the envoys), the surrender of Aquileia and the burning alive of those who had inspired its rebellion (22.8.49).

That is the end of Julian's sojourn at Constantinople. Only upon his departure does Ammianus indicate such an important matter as the emperor's benefactions to the place, 'incrementis maximis fultam'; other sources mention a harbour with a portico in the form of the Greek letter sigma – a semi-circle – leading to it, and a library (built in fact by Constantius), to which Julian donated all the books he possessed (Zosimus 3.11.3).³⁷ Only now, too, does Ammianus specifically mention Julian's affection for the city as his birthplace – though this might of course have been explained in one of the lost books (22.9.2). His departure from Constantinople took him by Chalcedon and Libyssa – the burial place of Hannibal, adds Ammianus in a characteristically erudite note (22.9.3) – and on to Nicomedia, whose recent devastation by earthquake provided another opportunity for the exercise of civic munificence by Julian, 'pari modo ad reparanda ... abunde praestitis plurimis' (22.9.5). Again, we saw earlier how it is only at this point that Ammianus mentions Julian's boyhood residence at Nicomedia under the tutorship of bishop Eusebius (22.9.4; p. 85).

The journey continues, in Ammianus' presentation a typical combination of itinerary and encyclopaedia. On the boundaries of Galatia (for literary purposes styled 'Gallograecia' by Ammianus), a diversion from the main route takes Julian to the shrine of Magna Mater at Pessinus. It also provides the historian with the opportunity for a learned remark on the Second Punic War and the Cumaeen Sibyl, a back-reference to his description of the reign of Commodus, in which he had narrated the arrival of the image of the goddess in Italy, and a little piece of etymology in which Ammianus unusually specifies Latin rather than Greek as his 'own' language. The place was called Pessinus, 'apo tou pesein, quod cadere nos dicimus', for it was there that the image of the goddess had fallen to earth: though other writers gave different explanations (22.9.5f.).³⁸ Julian sacrifices to the divinity and returning to the main route proceeds to Ancyra, where he is besieged by crowds of litigants demanding the return of confiscated property or complaining that they were unjustly added to the lists of city councillors. Some even went so far as to accuse their opponents of *maiestas* (22.9.8) – a charge for which recent events gave considerable scope, if what was meant by 'maiestas' was publicly declared support for Constantius; many men in the east were so committed (above, p. 101). Amid all the rancour Julian held fast to the cause of justice, but is again criticised by Ammianus because petitions by city councillors for additions to their number were hardly ever refused, whatever the force – through privilege, military service or origin – of claims for exemption (22.9.12). The passage through 'Pylae', that is the Cilician Gates separating the provinces of Cappadocia

and Cilicia, allowed Julian to renew an acquaintance with a fellow-student at Athens, now governor of Cilicia, whom he conveyed with him in his imperial carriage to Tarsus; the man obviously knew of the emperor's approach and was waiting at the provincial boundary to greet him (22.9.13). Then, pursuing in reverse the fatal journey of Constantius the previous year (one would love to have had described the reception given him at Mopsucrena), Julian came to Antioch, the 'Crown of the Orient; *'orientis apicem pulchrum'* (22.9.14). He was received 'like a god' by welcoming crowds acclaiming him in almost Messianic terms as a 'star of salvation' come to shine upon the east, in an example of the traditional 'adventus' ceremony described elsewhere in this book (pp. 231ff.); the same thing, in the same fashion, had happened at Sirmium (21.10.1f.) and at Constantinople (22.2.4), and doubtless, on a lesser scale, everywhere along the emperor's route. Since his arrival at Antioch coincided however with the celebration of the festival of Adonis (on 18 July), it was also marked by ill-omened cries of mourning for the stricken youth (22.9.15); it will be recalled that Ammianus had used the same image of lamentation in describing the funeral of the Chionite prince at Amida (p. 61). It is the first hint of the religious foreboding that will from now attend Ammianus' description of the reign of Julian until the moment of his death in Persia, and can in that sense be seen as a turning point in the narrative.³⁹

It is not surprising that Julian's stay at Antioch should be pervaded by the atmosphere of the approaching campaign; it is, after all, why he was in the city in the first place – as is earlier hinted by Ammianus' description of the rejection of war against the Goths in favour of a more worthy enemy (22.7.8) and, in a context immediately preceding the move from Constantinople to Antioch, by his evocation of the undying success bestowed by Fortune upon her favourite; quite apart from his past victories, Julian was throughout his sole reign free of the threat of civil war and foreign invasion (22.9.1). Now, Julian's stay at Antioch was extremely eventful, particularly in religious controversy and in the emperor's dispute with the city over problems of the corn supply. Ammianus' description of it is however barely more substantial than that of the few (perhaps six) months spent at Constantinople; and it contrasts markedly, in detail and in emphasis, with Julian's own account in his pamphlet the *Misopogon* or 'Beard-Hater' in which the emperor, by a brilliant inversion of literary postures reflecting the ritual impersonations and masquerades characteristic of the New Year festivities at which it was composed, denounces the people of Antioch through a sustained double parody of their judgment upon him.⁴⁰

Compared with this vividly subjective impression, Ammianus' presentation of Julian's regime at Antioch is a model of studied caution. History is not satire, and Ammianus' verdict on the *Misopogon* is that it 'added many things to the truth' (22.14.2). There is a point of contact, in Ammianus' introductory comment on the emperor's resistance to the 'seductive pleasures in which all Syria abounds' (22.10.1) before he passes

on to his determined commitment to the conduct of law. The connection of thought is that Julian avoided frivolity in order to devote himself to serious concerns. Even here, Ammianus offers criticism. Julian tended to be impulsive, and sometimes asked litigants what was their religion – not that this could ever be shown to have led to an untruthful or unjust outcome (it is however a curious view of legal impartiality) (22.10.2). Under Julian it was almost as if, in the emperor's own words, the goddess Justice herself had descended from heaven to earth – were it not that he did sometimes permit legal decisions to be swayed by his own will rather than the strict rule of law, and so clouded many fine achievements (22.10.6). Julian made many improvements in the laws, removing ambiguities so that they declared clearly what was allowed and what was not – but against this was his intolerable prohibition of adherents of the Christian faith from acting as professors of rhetoric and grammar; 'illud autem erat inclemens, obruendum perenni silentio, quod arcebat docere magistros rhetoricos et grammaticos ritus christiani cultores' (22.10.7).⁴¹ Setting aside this specific complaint, Ammianus' reservations in this passage are in striking contrast to the unqualified admiration for Julian's financial and judicial administration expressed in similar digressions on his rule in Gaul. In this they are consistent with his view that it was the earliest phase of Julian's rule that was the most remarkable (16.1.5; cf. above, p. 89f.).

The next substantial episode in the narrative of Julian's regime at Antioch, the murder of bishop George of Alexandria by a seditious crowd there (22.11.2-11), is loosely connected with Julian's legal activities by the arrest, trial and execution of the former *dux Aegypti* Artemius, which encouraged the Alexandrians to turn against Artemius' ecclesiastical ally (22.11.2). This is however an invalid connection, since the riot at Alexandria and the murder of George can be clearly dated to the end of 361, before Julian had come to Antioch and before the Alexandrians had had the opportunity even to petition for the removal of their hated commander, let alone secure his trial and execution.⁴² Ammianus follows this misplaced episode with an account of Julian's preparations for the Persian campaign, and of his excessive sacrifices at Antioch, which led to disgraceful scenes as his soldiers were carried to their lodgings incapable from their indulgence in the left-overs from the sacrifices, and caused a proliferation of fortune-tellers of all sorts who sprang forth, eager to exploit the emperor's passion for divination (22.11.6f.). Julian further encouraged the atmosphere of religious 'curiositas' by ordering the purification and reopening of the oracular shrine of Castalian Apollo at Daphne, an event followed by the destruction by fire, on 22 October 362, of the beautiful shrine of the god and his magnificent image (22.12.8-13.1).⁴³ Ammianus' brief account of the restoration of the oracle and the burning of the temple is however remarkable for his failure to make the causal (as opposed to merely chronological) connection between these events that is certified by our other sources (below, pp. 439ff.).

Equally unrelated to its historical context is his description, which

follows the burning of the temple, of the failure of the autumn rains which led to the running dry of normally perennial streams (22.14.1). This is seen by Ammianus as an omen and is linked to the further devastation of Nicomedia and damage to Nicaea in an earthquake, all of which added to the emperor's anxieties. He makes no specific connection between the failure of the rains and the already existing corn shortage which it aggravated, setting Julian's policy of fixing food prices merely in the context of his desire to win popularity and seeing this as a distraction from the serious business of preparing the Persian campaign (22.14.1f.). It is in the setting of Julian's dispute with the city council of Antioch over this issue that Ammianus mentions the *Misopogon*, in which the emperor denounced the Antiochenes (22.11.2), in return being made to suffer insults for his odd physical appearance and mannerisms, and his excessive religiosity. All of this is quite well conveyed by Ammianus and the chronology (the New Year festivities of 363) is accurate, but it remains curiously remote from its actual historical context. The *Misopogon* provides a partisan but coherent account of the origins and the development of the corn crisis in the winter of 362/3. If Ammianus (as we may assume) had read it, he remains remarkably indifferent to the evidence it provides (below, p. 409).

There is little more to say about Julian's stay at Antioch. After a brief description of his ascent of Mount Casius to see the sunrise and sacrifice to Jupiter – an occasion that provided an opportunity to forgive the supporter of Constantius from Hierapolis mentioned earlier – Ammianus reports the discovery in Egypt of the sacred bull Apis and turns this into a long digression on that country which carries him through to the end of Book 22 (14.6-16.24). Despite the claim that the context 'demands' ('videtur ... flagitare') the digression, it does not fit naturally into its context. It should be seen as a parallel to the digression on the Pontic regions that concludes the narrative of Julian's sojourn at Constantinople (22.8.1-48; above, p. 106). In both cases, the transition is of a literary rather than a substantive character, the motive being to add scale to a narrative that might otherwise lack it.

Book 23, the first on the Persian campaign, begins with the abortive restoration by Julian of the Temple at Jerusalem – an act which again, despite its obvious connection with the emperor's religious policies, Ammianus describes as expressing merely Julian's ambition to leave behind some worthy monument of his reign; 'imperii sui memoriam magnitudine operum gestiens propagare' (23.1.2). It is another somewhat detached perspective in which Ammianus seems deliberately to ignore the most obvious and most widely held, that is to say the religious, interpretation. The failed attempt to restore the Temple, which may be misplaced in Ammianus' narrative, is followed by a group of appointments to high office, and by the deaths of Julian's uncle and of a *comes sacrarum largitionum* which usher in a series of adverse omens.⁴⁴

Only two aspects of the actual preparations for the Persian campaign are relevant at the moment. The first is Julian's writing to Arsaces of

Armenia, which foreshadows the role of that king in the strategy of the campaign (below, p. 138); and the second, Ammianus' remark that orders were issued for troops to assemble from their winter quarters in all parts of the east, and to await the emperor's arrival at their various postings; 'dispersi per stationes varias adventum principis exspectabant' (23.2.3). Ammianus, we shall see, makes his first personal appearance on the campaign near Zaitha on the Euphrates, a day's march below the junction with the Khabur and so already in Assyria (23.5.7; p. 132). It remains a matter of speculation what the historian had been doing between Ursicinus' departure from office in 360 and the Persian campaign of 363. Whether he rejoined the service after a spell in private life, or was attached to the campaign from some more distant assignment, Ammianus can have joined the army at any of a wide variety of possible locations. It is by no means certain that he was actually with the army of Julian as it left Antioch on 5 March 363.

*

Between the two detailed military narratives of the usurpation of Julian and his Persian campaign, Ammianus' account of the actual reign of his hero is surprisingly inconclusive. As suggested earlier, it might almost be described as a journey (with digressions) from Naissus to Antioch, Julian's brief sojourns both at Constantinople and at Antioch being 'filled out' by digressions on the Pontic regions and on Egypt, introduced with more literary than historical purpose, in the middle and at the end of Book 22. (In Book 23, an immense digression on Persia, with more obvious justification but far exceeding what is needed for Ammianus' purpose, has a similar effect in expanding the scale of his treatment). Further, the episodic nature of Ammianus' description of the domestic reign of Julian contrasts with the fluency and complexity of his narrative of the military events that flank it on either side.⁴⁵

Important aspects, especially of the religious personality of the emperor, are presented by Ammianus in a curiously oblique manner. It is not that the historian is inexplicit or evasive. We saw that he mentioned Julian's studies in Asia Minor and Athens, his early 'conversion' to the cause of the old gods and his interest in divination, then the initial dissimulation and the gradually emerging openness of his religious policies, especially in the restoration of sacrifice and of the temples of the gods. This is coherent and convincing, but none of it is stated in any detail, and certain aspects only in retrospect. As to the restoration of the oracle and subsequent destruction of the temple of Apollo at Daphne and the attempted rebuilding of the Temple at Jerusalem, Ammianus seems to reject the opportunity to adopt a dimension of religious controversy that is clearly recognised in other sources. The restoration of the oracle is presented in its broadest sense as part of a perspective looking back to the Athenians' purification of Delos in the fifth century BC, and not as part of the intensely controversial setting at Antioch that we know did exist

(Chapter XVII.2, pp. 439ff.). Although it is chronologically connected, the destruction of the temple is causally separated from the restoration of the oracle, the 'envy of the Christians' that was suspected as the cause of the fire being acknowledged but given the least possible emphasis. According to Ammianus, they simply objected to the building of a peristyle there – not false, but a mere fragment of the true situation (23.13.2; p. 439). The restoration of the Temple at Jerusalem, placed emphatically and perhaps with dramatic licence at the beginning of Book 23, is given a context in Julian's munificence rather than forming any part of a religious policy such as the emperor's own writings help to define; the Jewish God fits perfectly, indeed pre-eminently, into the theory of 'national divinities' expounded in his tract *Contra Galilaeos*.⁴⁶ The 'balls of fire' that broke out and put an end to the work on the Temple are given no explanation, human or divine, but are attributed simply to the 'determined opposition of the element' (that is, fire). In a fascinating piece of understatement, their repeated blows made the place 'inaccessible to the workmen'; 'fecere locum exustis aliquotiens operantibus inaccessum' (23.1.3)!

Ammianus' only direct comment on the religious personality of Julian, apart from his interest in divination, relates to his superstition. Ammianus notes this both in his own person, and as a reaction assigned to the people of Antioch (22.12.6f.; 14.3). Perhaps thinking them no part of the public policy of a Roman emperor, he says nothing of matters as important to Julian as his institution of a revived provincial priesthood organised on a hierarchical basis (rather like the Christian clergy), nor of his promotion of charitable activities connected with the temples to rival those associated with the Christian church.⁴⁷ In all this, although Ammianus' account by no means lacks a religious dimension, it remains detached from the emperor's own perceptions and even, on occasion, hostile to them. How is this to be explained?

A puzzling feature of Ammianus' obituary of Julian is the lack of connection there made between the emperor's virtues, which are discussed in terms of the four 'cardinal' and other subordinate virtues defined by the philosophers, and his shortcomings, presented briefly in the form of a series of separate observations (25.4.16-21). The discrepancy can be viewed in various ways, for example in terms of literary technique and the structure of Ammianus' account (p. 468f.); what is important for the present is the extent to which the historian seems careless of the force of the shortcomings he adduces. Julian is criticised for his impulsiveness and his love of popularity, for his excessive interest in divination and for a religiosity that seemed to broach the borders of superstition; for the law forbidding Christians to teach rhetoric and grammar unless they adopted the cause of the old gods, and for his over-insistent imposition of the burdens of town-councillors upon men who possessed valid exemptions. It amounts to a criticism of every major aspect of Julian's policies, religious, cultural and civic, and in his archaically restrained treatment of the imperial office.

An additional feature of Ammianus' presentation is that he repeats his

criticisms almost verbatim from narrative text to obituary – almost as if he were deliberately denying to the latter the more generalised quality that might enable the shortcomings of Julian to be weighed against his virtues.⁴⁸ This is true of his description of Julian's edict on professors of rhetoric, where the general clarity of his legislation is also mentioned in both contexts (22.10.7, cf. 25.4.20), and of the enforcement of membership of curial orders (22.9.12, cf. 25.4.21), as well as of his general administration of justice, where both passages allude to Julian's claim that the goddess Iustitia had returned to earth, in each case with an allusion to the poet Aratus, who had described her flight to heaven to avoid the wickedness of men (22.10.6, cf. 25.4.19).

That the shortcomings of Julian remain peripheral to Ammianus' judgment of the emperor would in a way be more serious if it were confined to the obituary notice in Book 25. In fact, as we have seen, it pervades the articulation of Ammianus' view of his hero. It is not that certain aspects are not made clear; they are simply not made central to Julian's character, in a way that the emperor himself and our other sources would lead us to expect. The origins of Julian's apostasy in his youth and the steady development of his religious predilections are mentioned, but in retrospect; his sojourns in Asia Minor and at Athens contain no indication of their intellectual implications; the personal religiosity of Julian during his stay at Antioch is connected with his interest in divination and sacrifice, but the restoration of the oracle at Daphne and the burning of the temple, and the attempted restoration of the Temple at Jerusalem are described in such a way as to minimise the air of religious controversy that surrounded them; all this has been mentioned and need not be repeated.

It is therefore not simply that the faults assigned to Julian remain unintegrated in Ammianus' obituary of the emperor; they are not a 'load-bearing' feature of his narrative text either, where they occur as incidental remarks that are clearly not intended by Ammianus to cast fundamental doubt on his portrayal of the positive qualities of Julian's reign. The problem can be solved most simply and radically by asking what, in Ammianus' judgment, were the positive virtues of the reign. The answers are clear – indeed, they can be read from the first and dominant section of the obituary of Julian. Apart from his personal asceticism and self-control, Julian is praised for his administration of law and justice, for his financial management which enabled him to reduce and even to abolish taxes, and for his skill, courage and authority in all aspects of war; that is to say, for Ammianus, Julian was not primarily a religious figure. In fact, intensity of religious feeling forms no part of Ammianus' view of what makes a good emperor. Both Julian and Constantius are criticised in their obituary notices for their 'superstition' (21.16.8; 25.4.17), while the Christian Valentinian is praised for his religious neutrality (30.9.5).

Ammianus' emphasis on the administration of justice, finance and war conforms closely to his own experience of Julian, focussed as it was on the

beginnings of his regime as Caesar and upon the Persian campaign. It also conforms to the restrained proportions of a narrative of Julian's 'peacetime' government which, crammed in between the proclamation and its sequel in Books 20 and 21 and the Persian campaign beginning in Book 23, is itself inflated by long digressions on the Pontic regions (22.8) and Egypt (22.15-16); these digressions, as we saw, are appended to accounts of Julian's sojourns at Constantinople and Antioch that are themselves no more than episodic and, without the digressions, might look insubstantial. Whether his emphasis conforms also to Ammianus' own personality is a subjective question, and unanswerable because it can only be posed in relation to a text that is itself the sole evidence for his personality; yet merely to pose the question may help to remind us that the late Roman empire was not merely a hot-house of religious piety but that it did contain its pragmatists, men more interested in the necessities of finance and administration and in the course of justice than in the self-indulgencies of religious introspection.⁴⁹ In setting religious piety at the margin of his account of Julian, Ammianus may have presented the emperor as he wished to remember him rather than as he actually was; unless it really was possible for men of Ammianus' persuasion to view the emperor in the light of his public policies rather than his private beliefs, and to see the latter as a relatively unimportant flaw – when taken to excess – in a reign of overwhelming integrity and virtue. Something has in any case been omitted that was extremely important to Julian himself and to many hostile and friendly observers, and that in the last resort left a profound impact on the outcome of his reign. Readers of this book who, like Ammianus, are eager to pass directly to an account of the Persian campaign of Julian, may do so (Chapter VIII); those who wish to attempt an impression of religious influences set on one side by Ammianus – and, in the process, come to a fuller and more complex assessment than he offers of the reign and personality of Julian – may begin by considering in a new perspective some of the events described or referred to in the first part of this chapter.

CHAPTER VII

Julian and the Philosophers

In his *Lives of the Sophists*, Eunapius refers to an incident which took place in Gaul before Julian's declaration of civil war against Constantius in 360.¹ In this incident, Julian met with three men including his doctor Oribasius and the hierophant of the goddesses at Eleusis, whom Julian had summoned from Greece, and 'by performing certain rites known to them alone' gained the courage to abolish Constantius' tyranny (*V. Soph.* p. 476). Eunapius explains that he had narrated the affair in more detail in the books about Julian in his *History*: the passage does not occur in any surviving version or fragment of that lost work. So, too, Eunapius had told in the *History* how, according to another passage in the *Lives of the Sophists* (p. 498), Oribasius had 'through his outstanding excellence' made Julian emperor. It is more than possible that this is a veiled allusion to the same episode.²

Eunapius' account is tantalising in what it does not tell the reader. The question as to the nature of this transaction between Julian, Oribasius and the hierophant, is however partly answered by a letter which Julian wrote from Gaul to another Greek friend, the philosopher Priscus. Julian asks his friend to send him a book, of which he knows that Priscus can get a corrected copy from his sister's father-in-law (a person otherwise unknown, no doubt also a philosopher). He describes the book as 'the commentaries of Iamblichus on the works of my namesake' (*Ep.* 12; p. 19 Bidez).

Identification of this 'namesake' presents no problem. He was the so-called 'Julianus the theurgist', said to have lived in the time of Marcus Aurelius and to have been the author of works listed in the Byzantine lexicon, the *Suda* (I, 642), as '*Theourgika, Telestika, Oracles (Logia)* in verse, and other occult works relating to such arts'. Julianus is said in other sources to have composed also commentaries on the 'Oracles' and a work on the heavenly 'Zones'; a reference is given by one of these sources to Book 7 of this work. He is claimed in the *Suda*, how credibly we do not know, to have been the son of another Julianus, known as the 'Chaldaean', who lived under Trajan and wrote a work in four books 'On Demons' (*Peri daimonôn*).

It has been suggested that the word '*theourgos*', or 'theurgist', was actually coined by (the younger) Julianus. Formed by analogy with such Greek words as those for 'metal-' or 'stone-worker' (*chalkourgos*,

lithourgos), it would imply that Julianus was not merely a speculative writer on the gods and the occult, but that he could put his knowledge to practical use; like a blacksmith or stone-mason, he could 'work' his material, in this case the gods, by performing miracles. Julianus the theurgist, an Egyptian magician, and Christian prayers are rival claimants for the 'Rain Miracle', a famous episode, commemorated on the Column of Marcus Aurelius, when Marcus' army was saved from disaster in his Marcomannic wars by a sudden rainstorm.³ Another story has Julianus obstruct the attempt of another magician, Apuleius, to make the 'seven-rayed' Sun come down and meet him – an ungenerous performance which, as we shall see, is much more closely allied in its technique to 'theurgy' as later philosophical tradition understands it.⁴

Power over the weather and other natural phenomena was part of the standard repertoire of a late Roman miracle-worker. The hierophant Nestorius on one occasion, following instructions given to him in a dream, consecrated a little image of Achilles in a miniature temple, which he placed beneath the statue of Athena in the Parthenon and by joint sacrifices to image and statue saved Attica from an earthquake: this was in the year 375. Zosimus, who tells this story (4.18), had as his source a hymn to Achilles written by the fifth-century Neoplatonist philosopher Syrianus. Nestorius, a 'very old' man when he saved Athens from the earthquake, was none other than the hierophant of the goddesses summoned to Gaul by Julian, the participant with Oribasius in the secret rites mentioned by Eunapius. He was probably also the same as a 'priest' Nestorius who had once cured of depression a Roman senatorial lady who was convinced that her soul had in previous incarnations occupied in turn the bodies of a slave-girl to a family of inn-keepers in Attica, a dog, a serpent, and a female bear. As the slave-girl, she had been cured of forgetfulness (an inconvenient failing in a barmaid!) by an encounter with a spirit; the dog and the serpent, she – that is, her soul inhabiting their bodies – had in shame forced to suicide by making them throw themselves respectively from the roof of a house and under the wheels of a cart. The poor lady could remember all this very clearly.⁵

Apart from his power over the elements and gift for psychoanalysis, Nestorius was known as a prophet and astrologer. He had in another dream received an astrological formula linking the seven vowels of the alphabet with the seven planets, and the consonants with the signs of the zodiac. The first of these at least was a technique known to magicians and theurgists; Ammianus tells of the fate of a young man in the time of Valens, executed for magic because he was seen to perform certain gestures in the public baths while reciting to himself the seven vowels of the Greek alphabet (29.2.28; below, p. 222). As for his skill at divination, the hierophant was once questioned by the Athenian sophist Prohaeresius whether Julian's tax reforms would be permanent, and was told that they would not. Prohaeresius, a Christian, made his enquiry in a spirit of irony, combined with a personal interest in whether Julian would last for long; he had lost his chair in consequence of Julian's edict

forbidding Christians to practise as teachers of rhetoric (V. *Soph.*, p. 493).

The accumulation of Neoplatonic and (in the question of the transmigration of souls) Pythagorean doctrines, and of the priestly duties of a hierophant with skill as a diviner and miracle-worker, is not exceptional, but a typical illustration of religious tendencies of the late Roman period. Through his grandson Plutarch and his great-granddaughter Asclepigeneia, Nestorius was further instrumental in the transmission of theurgical doctrine to the Athenian Neoplatonic school of Syrianus and his pupil Proclus in the fifth century. Even before his initiation by Asclepigeneia into what his biographer Marinus calls the 'perfect theurgical art', Proclus had by the use of *iunges* – magical spinning discs – relieved Attica from drought and, like Nestorius earlier, given protection against earthquakes. It is not surprising in view of these successes that Proclus too had a dream, in which he was informed that he belonged to the 'chain of Hermes' and that he possessed the soul of Nicomachus, a famous Pythagorean philosopher.⁶ The 'chain of Hermes', originally the golden chain by which in Homer's *Iliad* (8.19) Zeus threatened to show his strength to the other gods by hauling them up to heaven in a sort of cosmic tug-of-war, had come to symbolise for Neoplatonists the authentic lineage of philosophers who had received from heaven their knowledge of divine truth.

For the Neoplatonists, theurgy was however not simply a technique for 'working the gods' in the sense of achieving miracles by magic: at a more profound level, it was one of the means by which the soul, wrapped in the envelope of the physical body, could achieve purification and re-unification with the divine principle from which it had descended into the world of the senses. Theurgy could operate at various levels, from the white magic used in the 'affairs of human life', as in the rainmaking and prevention of earthquakes just mentioned, through the preparation of the mind for divine knowledge by ritual and divination, to an all-encompassing 'theurgy' employed in the achievement of mystical union with the divine principle, or the One.⁷ According to Proclus, theurgy in this higher sense was 'greater than all human wisdom and knowledge, comprising the benefits of divination and the purifying powers of initiation (*telesiourgikê*); in a word, all the operative functions (*energêmata*) of divine inspiration'. God was not to be sought as if he were the object of definite knowledge, but by 'abandoning oneself to the divine light', by 'shutting the eyes' like a religious devotee. Being unknowable, God was not to be conceived by 'those who know about divine matters', nor expounded in normal discourse. He was to be understood only by 'analogy' – or, to put this in more practical terms, by magical 'symbols' and procedures. By these 'symbols', Proclus meant the physical objects and substances, the words (as we might say, the spells) of regular magic as used for the enlightenment and elevation of the soul, and also, at the highest level, the metaphysical 'analogies' by which the divine essence could be grasped and union with it achieved.⁸ The soul has an affinity with God and the divine world, just as physical objects – stones, herbs,

animals, and so on, as well as words – have their own affinity with and potentiality to ‘return’ to the Ideas, or Forms, from which they are derived. It is these lines of ‘sympathy’ – symbols, or *sunthêmata* – running through the Platonic universe, which the theurgist can exploit by magic ritual. ‘Relying on these divine symbols’, wrote Julian’s revered Iamblichus, ‘theurgy ascends to the superior beings to which it is united’ (*De Mysteriis* 4.2).

Such, in outline, is the theoretical basis of the ‘telestic’ art, the art of spiritual purification as practised by the theurgists.⁹ A particular aspect of their skill relevant here concerned the acquisition of knowledge concerning the nature of the gods and the religious and moral conduct required of their observer, or knowledge of the future. This could be done by the animation of statues. ‘The practisers of the telestic science’, wrote the Byzantine Michael Psellus, after Proclus, ‘fill the cavities of statues with substances belonging to the powers (*dunameis*) presiding over them: animals, plants, herbs, seals, engravings, sometimes also sympathetic spices, and set up together with them mixing bowls, vessels for offerings, censers: they animate the images and move them with a secret power’ (*Ep.* 187 Sathas). Whatever theatrical special effects – as some contemporaries believed – clever use of lighting and mirrors or sheer fraud were involved in such feats, the animation of statues was another of the regular techniques of ancient magic, mentioned also by the magical papyri.¹⁰ ‘Theurgy,’ according to Proclus, ‘through certain symbols applied to the “illumination” of artificial statues calls forth the unbounded goodness of the gods.’

Through oracles, given by animated statues and in other ways, the divine powers revealed their nature and declared the future. Such revelations might occur spontaneously to divinely-inspired individuals. One of the philosophers described in Eunapius’ *Lives* had a dream in which the god gave him an oracle in hexameter verse. Waking up, he found that he could remember the general sense of what he had been told but not the ‘divine meaning’, until a slave attendant showed him that writing had appeared on his left hand. It was, of course, the oracle (*V. Soph.*, p. 464). Eunapius tells also the fascinating story of a young man, the son of Julian’s friend the philosopher Chrysanthius, who had only to put on a crown and face the sun in order to produce oracles which were always truthful and ‘composed according to the most beautiful form of divine inspiration’, although (an unlikely claim) he had never been trained in grammar or metre.¹¹ The gods clearly loved this young man. Without having had a single day’s illness in his life, he died at twenty (*V. Soph.*, p. 504).

Ammianus cited ‘oracles and famous writers’ as authorities for the way in which a very few men had through their virtues been granted acquaintance with their ‘genius’, the personal guardian spirit that is born with every man and attends him through life: such, among philosophers, were Pythagoras, Socrates, Hermes Trismegistos (Latinised by Ammianus as ‘Termaximus’), Apollonius of Tyana and Plotinus. Ammianus went

on to explain how Plotinus had written profoundly on the origins of these *genii* who, 'linked with human souls, protect them as if they held them to their bosom, and teach higher truths, if they see them to be pure and preserved from the taint of sin by undefiled association with the body' (21.14.5; below, p. 434). According to his biographer Porphyry, Plotinus on one occasion attended a seance in the temple of Isis at Rome, at which an 'Egyptian priest' promised to secure for him a vision of his *daimôn* (the Greek equivalent of 'genius').¹² The priest brought with him birds 'for protection' (as an apotropaic symbol) and the *daimôn* appeared, turning out however to be not a mere *daimôn* but an actual god – thus showing how elevated was the soul of Plotinus. The potentially interesting discussion between Plotinus and his god was prevented when for some reason – 'either through envy', says Porphyry, 'or because he was afraid of something' – the friend of Plotinus who was holding the birds throttled them so that they died (V. *Plot.* 10). Had the god's replies been forthcoming they might well have been expressed, or at least recorded, in oracles in hexameter verse.

With this transition we return to the figure of Julianus the theurgist, the author or editor of the 'oracles in verse' on which the commentary written by Iamblichus was requested from his friend Priscus by Julian the Apostate. There is not much doubt that these oracles were in fact the so-called 'Chaldaean Oracles' of which fragments survive, as preserved by the later Platonists, especially by Proclus, and by Michael Psellus, who knew well the works of Proclus and his contemporaries.¹³

*

The *Chaldaean Oracles* were a collection of propositions in hexameter verse about the nature of God and the universe, and prescriptions as to how the deity was to be approached and comprehended. Their interpretation presents many difficulties. They would not deserve the name of oracle if they had been invariably lucid, direct and free from ambiguity; and further, since we owe our knowledge of the oracles to selections and quotations made from them by other writers, we rely on these writers to have produced a reasonably accurate representation of their contents, and one that is not distorted by being forced to serve their own, often polemical ends. Yet it would be evasive not to attempt some summary of their theological content, and we may begin with the First Principle or 'Father' whose nature is evoked by the oracles. This Supreme Deity is said to exist beyond all knowledge in a 'transcendental abyss' (Fr. 18), in a 'god-sustaining silence' (Fr. 16). He is associated with, yet at the same time remote from, the other members of a triad, or Trinity, of gods or 'Fathers'; these other two are called 'Intellect' (*nous*) and 'Power' (*dunamis*). Hidden in himself, unknown and unknowable, the Supreme God is so profoundly secluded as to be separated even from his own creative aspects:

he does not enclose even his own Fire in the Power of his Intellect. (Fr. 3)

The second member of the divine triad, 'Intellect', has a double nature, since it contemplates at once the First Principle and the universe of which it is apparently itself the creator:

... By the Father resides a Dyad;
it has these two functions, to conceive by intellect the Intelligibles,
and to introduce sensation to the worlds. (Fr. 8)

The third member of the triad, 'Power', is the animating force by which 'Intellect' (the creator, or Demiurge) expresses its creative purpose. 'Power' seems in some Oracles to be identified with Hecate, from whose right side

leaps the swelling stream of the primordial Soul,
animating light, fire, ether, stars. (Fr. 51)

There is no need to stress the magical role of Hecate, mistress of the Underworld, in Greek and Roman religious belief – as in her invocations in Book Six of the *Aeneid* and especially the *Second Idyll* of Theocritus, a prime source for ancient magical practices, and in the mystic cults adopted by the members of pagan nobility of Rome in the later fourth century.

In addition to this triad of 'Father', 'Intellect', and 'Power', the *Chaldaean Oracles* describe divine beings of lower status, especially the 'spinners' (*iunges*), which are themselves the thoughts, or perhaps the bearers of the thoughts, of the Father:

They, themselves thought of by the Father, also think,
moved to do so by his unutterable counsels. (Fr. 77)

'*Iunges*' are in another context – as in Theocritus' *Second Idyll* – the spinning discs or 'rhombi' of ancient magical ritual. In Chaldaean theology they form a lower triad with entities described as the 'connectives' (*sunoches*) and the 'masters of initiation' (*teletarchoi*); these latter are described in one Fragment as the 'masters of souls' (Fr. 86).¹⁴ In these beings is inherent the theoretical justification of the notion of initiation and purification by magic, by means of the symbols or 'sympathies' which 'connect' the physical world with the realm of Ideas and, correspondingly, the human soul with the divine:

The Intellect of the Father has planted symbols through the universe,
He who contemplates the Intelligibles: they are called the unutterable
beauties. (Fr. 108)

The theurgist used the magical 'symbols' of physical objects and substances, and devices such as spinning discs, which operated by analogy on the *iunges* or 'spinners' of the theology of the Oracles; these are normal techniques of ancient magic, here applied to the religious purposes of the Neoplatonists.

It is essential to recognise that the use of these methods was justified in relation to the central issue in later Platonic thought, that of the descent of the soul and its longing to conceive, and ultimately to return to, the world of the Intelligible Ideas from which it came. This could not be done, according to the *Oracles* as also to Iamblichus and Proclus, by rational thought:

There is a certain Intelligible, which you must conceive with the flower of the intellect;

For if you intensify your mind and contemplate that Intelligible as a particular object, you will not conceive it...

...

You must not conceive that Intelligible with vehemence, but with the refined fire of a refined intelligence, which may measure everything

except that Intelligible. You must think of it not with concentration, but with the holy gaze of an averted eye.

Extend to the Intelligible the emptied intellect of your soul in order to learn the Intelligible, for he exists outside the grasp of intellect.

(Fr. 1)

Another Oracle calls for the exercise to the same end of ritual act and incantation:

Seek the channel of the soul, from where it comes in a certain order to do hired labour for the body, and how you will again lead it up to its ordered place, uniting act with sacred word. (Fr. 110)

'Uniting act with sacred word': it would be difficult here to mistake the reference to magic arts.

This conception of the 'Intelligible' as beyond the grasp of a purely intellectual contemplation was fundamental to the use of magical techniques by the theurgists. In the view of Iamblichus, the soul's descent to the world of the senses was so complete that it had lost all affinity with the Intelligible, in a thorough-going dualism that reflected the human experience of sin and suffering. The chasm between the two could *only* be crossed by magic. This opinion was however not that held by the founder of Neoplatonism, Plotinus. For Plotinus, the higher part of the soul still retained an affinity with God, who could on this basis be approached by sustained intellectual effort in the Platonic manner. But it was a real objection to Plotinus' method that even he, throughout his life of rational

contemplation at the highest possible level, had only four times experienced 'ecstasy' – moments in which, in a glimpse of heaven his soul had 'stood outside' his body and been united with God – and Porphyry only once (*V. Plot.* 23). It was evidently an exclusive ideal. How many ordinary men were granted the opportunities – material as well as spiritual, for the life of the philosopher presupposes his economic independence – to reach such a goal?

Ancient commentators undoubtedly over-simplified the situation in seeing it in this way, but for them the division in the Platonic school between the 'intellectual' tradition of Plotinus and the 'theurgical' tradition of Iamblichus was fundamental to its history. According to a sixth-century Neoplatonist, 'some put philosophy first, such as Porphyry, Plotinus, and so on; others the priestly art (*hieratikê*), like Iamblichus, Syrianus, Proclus and all the priestly school' – meaning the theurgists; and Michael Psellus, reflecting the views of a sixth-century opponent of the Platonists, noted that after reading the *Chaldaean Oracles* Iamblichus and Proclus had abandoned 'Greek' – that is philosophical – for 'Chaldaean' – or magical – doctrine.¹⁵ Iamblichus is said by Eunapius occasionally to have prayed privately to God, 'performing certain rites' – but to have discouraged his pupils' belief that he levitated to a height of ten cubits and turned a lovely golden colour while he did so. He did on one occasion consent as a demonstration of his powers to evoke two divine beings from the hot springs in the baths at Gadara. With a clever touch of historical scruple Eunapius admitted that he had no eye-witness account of this scene (*V. Soph.*, p. 458f.).

*

The division between the supporters of Plotinus and of Iamblichus, between the 'philosophers' and the 'priestly school', is essential for understanding the position of Julian the Apostate. As a young man, 'travelling around wherever he wanted', as Eunapius drily noted, 'accompanied by the emperor's suspicions and a bodyguard', Julian came to Pergamum in Asia Minor to see the great philosopher Aedesius, a former pupil of Iamblichus; it was Aedesius who had found miraculously written on his hand the words of the oracle which he had dreamed (above, p. 118). Aedesius, an old man, recommended Julian to consult certain of his pupils, now themselves teachers of philosophy. (To read between the lines of Eunapius' account, Aedesius had found the persistent Julian a rather wearing experience; in going to these pupils, Julian would, he reckoned, 'cease to harass my old age'). He named four such pupils, of whom one, Maximus, had gone to Ephesus, while Priscus, to whom Julian later wrote from Gaul for Iamblichus' commentaries on Julianus the theurgist, had gone to Athens. Two others, Eusebius and Chrysanthius,

were still at Pergamum (*V. Soph.*, p. 474).

Eusebius and Chrysanthius presented a contrast, which we can understand at once in terms of the two Neoplatonic traditions just described. Chrysanthius, like the absent Maximus, was 'passionately involved in working marvels, and studied the science of divination'. Eusebius, on the other hand, used to add an epilogue to his lectures, to the effect that the only true realities lay in dialectical argument. The impostures of witchcraft and magic that deceive the senses, he would say, were the works of conjurers, 'insane men led astray into the exercise of material powers'. The words here used for 'material powers', *hulikas ... dunameis*, are technical expressions for the use of physical materials as magical 'symbols'.

Julian, puzzled by Eusebius' epilogue, at Chrysanthius' suggestion asked him what it meant. Eusebius then told Julian of an experience of his own, in order to show how Maximus' genius had led him to despise logical proof in favour of the 'acts of a madman'. Maximus had taken Eusebius and some others to a temple of Hecate at Pergamum – not a random choice of goddess. He had there consecrated and burned some incense, recited to himself 'some hymn or other' (magical papyri sometimes stress the need to mutter the incantation so that it cannot be overheard), and succeeded in making the image of Hecate smile and even laugh aloud. Maximus then announced that the torches in the goddess's hands would break into flame. Before the words were out of his mouth, they did so (*V. Soph.*, p. 475).

For Eusebius, the whole occasion was a piece of 'theatrical wonder-working'.¹⁶ This does not mean that he disbelieved the authenticity of what Maximus had done, any more than Plotinus, despite his indifference to it, actually disbelieved the effectiveness of magic; simply that he was unmoved from his conviction that the highest aim of philosophy was the elevation of the soul by reason. In this whole narrative, in fact, Eusebius was declaring his commitment to the tradition of Plotinus and Porphyry against that of Iamblichus and the theurgists. Julian, anxious as ever for quick results, had other ideas. 'Farewell', he said to Eusebius, 'devote yourself to your books: you have shown me the man I wanted', and off he went, dragging his bodyguard (not to mention the emperor's suspicions) to Ephesus to find Maximus.

Julian's commitment to the theurgists, after the choice presented to him so explicitly by Eusebius, is no flirtation with some vague exotic mystery, but a declaration, with serious consequences, in favour of a specific tradition in late Platonism. This also emerges from the letter to Priscus (*Ep.* 12 Bidez), in which Julian requested the commentary of Iamblichus on Julianus the theurgist. He referred in the letter to the libels against Iamblichus of the 'supporters of Theodorus' (*Theodoreioi*). Theodorus of Asine believed, like Plotinus, that part of the human soul had remained unfallen from its divine state, and so implicitly rejected theurgy in favour of the intellectual approach of Plotinus and Porphyry.¹⁷

It would be difficult to over-emphasise the importance of the theurgical tradition of Neoplatonism in Julian's mentality. At the end of his allegorical *Hymn to the Mother of the Gods* (180 B), Julian offers a prayer in which he asks to be given true knowledge about the gods and made perfect in theurgy. Earlier in the same tract, having written in a piece of pure theurgical doctrine of the growth of plants as caused, like the rising up of the soul, by the attractive power of solar rays, he goes on; 'if I should mention the unutterable mystery of the seven-rayed God of whom the Chaldaean spoke ecstatically, as through his agency he caused the souls to ascend, I should speak of unknown things, unknown especially to the vulgar crowd, but known to the blessed theurgists' (172 D). The word here used for the 'seven-rayed' Sun, *heptaktis*, occurs in the *Chaldaean Oracles* (cf. Fr. 194), and also in the source that described how Julianus the theurgist had prevented the Sun from coming down from heaven to meet Apuleius.¹⁸

This discussion of certain aspects of Neoplatonic religious practice has had little to say of Ammianus Marcellinus; but it is important to recognise that Julian was devoted to theurgy, not as a dilettante to something he happens to find colourful and exotic, but as a serious philosopher to a technique central to his philosophy. We can look more closely now at some possible effects on his reign, and at Ammianus' view of them.

During his studies at Ephesus with Maximus and Chrysanthius (who joined them there), Julian was told of a man of still greater wisdom in Greece, the hierophant of the goddesses at Eleusis, and went to visit him. Eunapius, who records this, was unable to reveal the name of the hierophant, since he himself had been initiated by him into the mysteries of Eleusis. The hierophant, in fact Nestorius, had prophesied in Eunapius' presence the destruction of the temples and of Greece, and other misfortunes, all of which in later years came to pass (*V. Soph.*, p. 476).

When he was appointed Caesar in Gaul, after some victories over the barbarians Julian sent for the hierophant, who came to Gaul; and it was with him and others, in the incident with which this chapter began, that Julian mustered the courage to attack Constantius, after 'performing certain rites known to them alone'. The reference to theurgical acts is by now surely unmistakable. In so far as any chronology can be inferred from Eunapius' account, the incident took place at a time when Julian had as yet no explicit intention of claiming the imperial throne for himself (above, p. 99).

At a later stage, according now to Ammianus, while Julian was spending the winter at Vienne after his proclamation and debating his policy towards Constantius, he inferred Constantius' imminent death, both by the use of divinatory techniques, 'in which he was expert', and from dreams (21.1.6). Ammianus digresses at this point to defend Julian, 'a learned *princeps*, and a student of all forms of knowledge', against

those malicious critics who asserted that he employed corrupt arts in order to learn the future; 'praenoscenti futura pravas artes assignant'. In reply to these critics, Ammianus will explain briefly how a 'wise man' ('sapienti') may possess skill in learning the future, a 'not inconsiderable branch of learning'; 'doctrinae genus haud leve' (21.1.7).

The passage in which Ammianus does this (21.1.7-14) is extremely interesting for the light which it casts on Ammianus' own theological learning, and is analysed in this sense in a later chapter of this book.¹⁹ As far as Julian's conduct is concerned, Ammianus confines himself in the digression to a description of traditionally accepted modes of divination – augury and *haruspicina*, the inspection of entrails, oracles uttered by divinely-inspired media, the interpretation of apparently random sounds and sights, thunder, lightning, shooting stars and dreams. These techniques, none of which could be described as 'corrupt', Ammianus regards as fully accredited, subject only to the imperfection of men's skills in interpreting them (21.1.13f.; pp. 428ff.). Julian himself, while still at Vienne before the march against Constantius, had a dream in which a splendid figure appeared to him, many times repeating in heroic verse, of which Ammianus gives the Greek text, a prediction of the exact date of Constantius' death. In consequence, Julian was convinced that no more harm could be done to him (21.2.2).

For the time being, Julian kept his activities quiet and maintained his pretence of Christianity. In private, however, with 'a few accomplices in secret rites' ('arcanorum participibus paucis'), he devoted himself to *haruspicina* and augury, and to 'the other things which believers in the gods have always done'; 'et ceteris quae deorum semper fecere cultores' (21.2.4). It is unlikely that Ammianus is here referring to theurgy or to any other activity that might pass under the rubric of 'pravae artes': it is simply that anything to do with the worship of the old gods had to be treated by Julian as a secret and performed in private with accomplices.

Later, coming to the east after Constantius' death, Julian wrote to his teachers, Maximus and Chrysanthius, and invited them to join him at court. The two men conferred and took the omens, which were hostile. Chrysanthius decided to conform to the will of the gods, but Maximus was recalcitrant. It was the duty of Greeks, especially of educated Greeks, he argued to Chrysanthius, 'not to submit feebly to the first obstacles they meet, but to wrestle with the heavenly powers until you make them yield to their servant'. Chrysanthius still refused, but Maximus 'tried every means, until he secured what he wanted and desired'; and so he went to Constantinople surrounded, as Eunapius describes, by an escort of admirers and fêted wherever he passed (*V. Soph.*, p. 477). Maximus and Julian induced Priscus to join them from Athens, but Chrysanthius remained unmoved in his obedience to the gods, stayed in Lydia and was in the end entrusted with the high-priesthood of the province. Here too Chrysanthius read the future more accurately than most, and did not use his office in aggressive support of Julian's religious policies. He built no

temples and was not harsh, as others were, to Christians. Indeed so mild was he that 'throughout Lydia the restoration of the temples almost passed unnoticed' (*V. Soph.*, p. 501). But it was Chrysanthius' reading of the future that proved accurate, and because of his mildness, when Christian emperors again took over there were no reprisals in his province.

The philosophers retained their influence upon the emperor, even during the Persian campaign of 363. Writing to Libanius, Julian recalled his journey as far as Hierapolis by the Euphrates, noting in particular the signs of traditional religious practice in cities on the route (*Ep.* 98 Bidez; below, p. 144). At Hierapolis, he had a happy meeting with a co-religionist of whom he had heard but never met. This man, presumably a philosopher, had married a daughter of Sopatros, and he in turn had been a pupil of the 'most divine Iamblichus' (p. 182 Bidez). About Iamblichus enough has been said; Sopatros also is well-known. Like Iamblichus a Syrian, he had come to Constantinople in or soon after 330 in the hope of restraining the 'impulsiveness' of the Emperor Constantine – that is, of moderating the Christian policies which were increasingly dominating his reign.²⁰ But how did Sopatros intend to achieve this – by writing polite notes to the emperor and seeking audiences in which he might persuade him? or by theurgical magic? Sopatros in any case met an appropriate end. He was denounced by a Christian supporter of Constantine and beheaded; the charge was that he had by magic 'fettered the winds' which brought the corn-ships from Alexandria to Constantinople (*V. Soph.*, p. 463). It was a splendid finale, a piece of weather-making well worthy of the tradition of Julianus the theurgist, Nestorius the hierophant and Proclus the Neoplatonist philosopher.

The course of the Persian campaign brings out, in two episodes in particular, the impact of the theurgical tradition on Julian's conduct as emperor, and lends an extra dimension to Ammianus' assessment of his religious policies.

The unique quality in Ammianus' account of the Persian campaign that distinguishes it from others is precisely its emphasis on the role of the divine in its conduct and outcome.²¹ Ammianus underlines the omens which made it clear that the campaign was doomed to fail; he has them dominate his narrative and makes clear from the beginning the truth of what they portended. On the second day of the march was brought to Julian the body of a huge lion which had attacked the army but been shot down. Then a soldier of the 'lofty name' Jovianus was killed by lightning, together with the two horses he had been watering in the Euphrates. The official seers, *haruspices*, who were travelling with the army, set to work on the interpretation of the omens. Getting out their books, which Ammianus specifies as the 'libri exercitiales' and 'libri fulgurales', the seers pronounced that the omens were adverse; the gods were advising against the campaign. Their opinions were however 'trodden underfoot' by the 'philosophers', whose authority was 'at that time revered'. These philosophers, 'persisting long in matters that are little understood'

declared that the omens were either indifferent or were actually in favour of the campaign (23.5.10ff.). Later, in the early hours of the day of Julian's death, a spectacular shooting star was seen. The *haruspices*, again consulting their books, 'Tarquitiani libri, in titulo de rebus divinis', declared that nothing must be done that day or that at the very least there must be a delay (25.2.7f.). Again, their advice was overruled by the philosophers, with the consequence that within a few hours the latter found themselves acting in another professional capacity – sharing Julian's death-bed reflections on the immortality of the soul.²²

These 'philosophers' were of course none other than Julian's old friends Maximus and Priscus, and it would be completely against their previous record if on these occasions too they were not producing their opinions after theurgical rites designed, as Maximus had put it to Chrysanthius, to 'force the heavenly powers to yield to their servant'. At this point a fragment of the Chaldaean Oracles comes very firmly into the reckoning, for it explicitly denies the value of traditional *haruspicina*:

Let go the humming circuit of the moon; it always runs by force of necessity;
the course of the stars was not brought forth to favour you.
The broad heavenly flight of birds is never truthful,
nor the incisions of offerings and entrails; these are all but games,
sustaining a corrupt deception. Avoid these things,
if you would open up the holy paradise of piety,
where virtue, wisdom and good order meet together. (Fr. 107)

If so, then to be strictly consistent with his own philosophical views and those of his advisers, Julian would be committed to a trust in theurgical *as opposed to* traditional modes of divination: a position difficult to reconcile with the religious duties of a *pontifex maximus* and Roman emperor. There is no need to interpret Julian's position quite as strictly as this. Ammianus, after all, has explained that Julian was an expert in all forms of knowledge, which should and does mean that none was excluded. Further, it is not as if the *Chaldaean Oracles* were such a coherent body of texts that one pronouncement, however emphatic it may seem to be, can be made to yield a single general conclusion without risk of contradiction by others. Nevertheless, the difficulties that might arise in the case of a direct conflict of opinion, such as occurred during the Persian campaign, should be evident. We have seen that Ammianus gave the actual titles of the priestly books which the *haruspices* brought out in order to give their interpretations of the omens. He contrasted these with what he showed as the spontaneous inventions of the philosophers, supported by some pseudo-scientific rationalisation (24.5.14). Now, Ammianus must have known enough about the philosophers to have been aware that behind their pretensions as prophets lay an extensive literature of religious and philosophical exposition. What then should we make of his assertion that the philosophers 'persisted long in matters that are little understood': 'in parum cognitis perseverantium diu'

(23.5.11)? Did he mean that they held out for hours against the *haruspices* until they got their way – or that they had wasted their whole lives in pointless speculation?

*

Ammianus' summary of Julian's religious attitudes, classified among the shortcomings briefly set out in the obituary of the emperor, was that he was 'superstitious, rather than a legitimate observer of divine matters'; 'superstitiosus magis quam sacrorum legitimus observator' (25.4.17).²³ 'Superstition' is a notoriously difficult word to define; Ammianus also writes of Constantius' 'old woman's superstition' in his obsessive treatment of the disputes of the Christian religion (21.16.18), and the emperors themselves used it in their legislation of anything to do with the practice of pagan cults or magic arts. It might be possible to get further with the word 'legitimus', as applied to Julian's religious conduct.

It was partly a matter of degree. Julian drenched the altars with the sacrifices of hundreds of victims – Ammianus cited as parallel a mock letter of the 'white cattle' to Marcus Aurelius, protesting that if he went on winning victories they, the white cattle, would be exterminated! Julian's sacrifices at Antioch were so lavish, and the meat provided by them so plentiful, that his soldiers had sometimes to be carried home to their billets incapable from food and drink (22.12.6). The more precise nuances of 'legitimus' might be inferred by analogy from certain of Ammianus' attitudes to the political system of his day. Ammianus does not formulate any general 'theory of kingship', but he took a definite stand as to the proper behaviour of emperors in certain situations. They should operate within the framework of institutions and rules by which individual rights, as well as the emperors' interests, were protected, and it was in contempt for these procedures that unconstitutional power found its expression (below, pp. 250ff.). The word 'legitimus' should mean something analogous when applied to an emperor's religious conduct. Ammianus criticised Julian for accepting the views of the 'philosophers' in his entourage and for rejecting those of the *haruspices*. For a Roman army on campaign, led by a Roman emperor, the *haruspices* were the proper interpreters of the information provided by the gods. In a case of conflict, it was on their understanding of the signs, rather than on that of the 'philosophers', that the 'conjectures of men', in a phrase of Cicero's approved by Ammianus, were more securely based (21.1.14).²⁴ Ammianus brings out this point of view by his references to the books on which the authority of the *haruspices* rested, citing their titles (in one case also the chapter in question), and by contrasting this with the unyielding ignorance of the philosophers. In their own context, the books of the *haruspices* were the equivalent of the public institutions such as the courts of law, whereby the emperors preserved legitimate constitutional government and avoided personal despotism.

Julian's rejection of the *haruspices* on the Persian campaign brings out the ambiguities in his position as emperor and as restorer of the ancient gods; ambiguities which were not trivial or superficial, but part of the essential nature of his religious position. They were also inherent in the nature of late Roman paganism. The philosophy to which Julian and the 'philosophers' to whom he committed himself adhered, was concerned less with matters of common interest to late Roman society than with the position of the individual in relation to the divine world from which he had descended. The practice of magic, too, tends to be connected with the personal interests of an individual, and owes its efficacy to the preservation of its occult, or hidden, nature. Neoplatonic theurgy was not an approach well adapted to the service of a restored public paganism, and Julian showed great (and characteristic?) unsureness of judgment in letting the 'philosophers' acquire the influence which they did in the public counsels of a Roman emperor. He was to some extent, no doubt, the victim of circumstances in allowing the contradictions to appear so openly as in the disputes between the philosophers and the *haruspices* on the Persian campaign; but such conflicts must have arisen sooner or later, and if an admirer like Ammianus had such doubts as he expressed or implied on these episodes and in general on Julian's religious policies, the most serious questions must attach to the coherence of these policies and to their prospects, in the best of all possible worlds, of success. The 'best of all possible worlds' included, it goes without saying, a successful outcome to the Persian campaign of 363, and it is to the conduct, and to the failure and consequences of this, that we must now turn.

CHAPTER VIII

The Invasion of Persia

(1) Historical perspectives

At the beginning of April 363, Julian's army crossed the river Khabur near its confluence with the Euphrates at Circesium. The passage took some time, and only when every man had gone over did the emperor cross the Khabur himself and have the bridges dismantled behind him (23.5.4). The army then advanced to Zaitha, 'the Olive Tree', and a further day's march in the direction of Dura, before Julian gathered the troops together and addressed them. This was not the first time, he reassured them, that Romans had entered the realms of Persia. Setting aside those Republican generals who had been successful in those regions, Julian recalled his predecessors among the Roman emperors. Trajan, Verus and Septimius Severus had each of them returned victorious from Persia. So too would the Emperor Gordian have returned, had he not fallen victim to the treachery of Philip and his supporters, struck down in the very place where he now lay buried. Julian reminded his army of the tomb of Gordian, which they had just seen as they passed it on the march (23.5.16f.).

The authenticity of speeches in ancient historians is a notoriously difficult problem. The distinction between the words actually spoken on any occasion, and what could be convincingly attributed to it, is in the nature of things a very fine one. Thucydides was unusually scrupulous in asserting as a principle that he would make some attempt to convey what was actually said in the speeches he included in his history or at least to respect their specific historical circumstances (1.22.1), and he was not generally followed by his successors in his observance of it. A speaker would normally try to say what was fitting for a particular occasion, and a literate historian – one accomplished in rhetoric, the art of persuasion – would be no less competent to make up something suitable. There was little reason for a historian to attempt more, and his audience would not expect it. Zosimus, narrating Julian's campaign from the lost *Histories* of Eunapius, merely says of this speech that the emperor addressed the troops with 'fitting' words (3.13.3). Zosimus' comment must simply mean that he found here in Eunapius nothing out of the ordinary – and this was in a passage of narrative more detailed in some respects than Ammianus' own.¹

A speech in the manner of that ascribed by Ammianus to Julian was evidently given to an army which, on crossing the Khabur, had effectively

entered Persian territory. The army's advance did indeed take it by the tomb of the Emperor Gordian, who had died in Persia and been succeeded by Philip (in AD 244). Ammianus located the tomb at or near the place called Zaitha. Exactly how near is not immediately apparent, for, as Ammianus noted, the tomb could be seen from far off; 'longe conspicuum' (23.5.7). Other writers give its precise position as twenty miles from Circesium, which would seem to concur with what Ammianus says.² There is however a difficulty. Ammianus has described how Julian went to pay his respects to Gordian at the tomb, after which, pressing on towards Dura, he was brought the body of the huge lion which had attacked the army and been shot down (23.5.8). In the evening of the next day, 7 April, the soldier Jovianus was killed by lightning as he returned from watering horses by the Euphrates' edge (23.5.12f.). Only at this point of his narrative, between Zaitha and Dura and at the end of the second full day of the march, does Ammianus place Julian's speech and its reception by the army; yet he introduces the speech with a second reference to the dismantling of the bridge over the Khabur and describes the need to make it as Julian's most urgent priority ('antiquissimum omnium') upon crossing the river (23.5.15).

If we accept the implications of these last remarks, Julian actually delivered his speech immediately after crossing the Khabur. This is of course where such an address would have been expected by the army and where, on the evidence of Zosimus, it was placed by Eunapius. Ammianus' subsequent narrative supports this interpretation, in apparent contradiction of his first sequence.³ After an immense digression on the districts and peoples of the Persian empire (23.6.1-88), Ammianus resumes his story at the beginning of Book 24 by mentioning again the joyful reception by the army of Julian's speech (24.1.1). He then marks formally the entry into Assyria at the dawn of the following day, surveys the dispositions of the army and describes for a second time, but more briefly, the two-day march to Dura (24.1.1-5). From this alternative sequence it would appear that Julian's speech was in fact delivered immediately after the army had assembled beyond the Khabur, when Julian himself had crossed and the bridges had been dismantled.

For reasons which may appear later (p. 178f.), Ammianus has in Book 23 displaced Julian's speech in its narrative context. He has achieved this by bringing forward certain events of the first two days of the march so that in his narrative they appear to precede a speech made in fact at the outset of the campaign. He has then given a corrected sequence at the beginning of the next book of his history, in which the invasion is narrated continuously from its outset. One consequence of this double presentation is of particular interest. If Julian's speech was in fact delivered not after, but before, the army had come to Gordian's tomb twenty miles from Circesium, then its reference to that monument, 'which we have just seen with respect' (23.5.17), cannot have been made in this form. Being consistent with a distorted narrative sequence, it is the work not of Julian himself, but of his historian.⁴

In this case, Julian's – or rather Ammianus' – allusion to the betrayal and death of Gordian can be linked directly with the reference the historian has made to Gordian in his narrative, shortly before coming to Julian's speech. At Zaitha, he wrote, suggesting for the first time his own presence on the campaign, 'we saw (*vidimus*) the tomb of Gordian the emperor, conspicuous from a far distance: of whose deeds from earliest boyhood, successful leadership of armies and death by treachery I have told in the proper place' – that is, of course, in one of the lost books of the history (23.5.7).

The notion that Gordian died as a result of Roman treachery, though shared by other Classical historical sources and, in part, by the thirteenth so-called *Sibylline Oracle* (vv. 13ff.), is not totally unchallenged. The 'official' Persian view, assuming this to be what is given in the trilingual inscription at Naqsh-e Rostam near Persepolis known as the *Res Gestae Divi Saporis*, was that Gordian had been killed in battle with the Persians, and his successor Philip forced to treat for terms. This is the version also illustrated in the great rock sculptures at Bishapur, which show Philip as a suppliant before Sapor, whose horse treads down the prostrate corpse of Gordian.⁵ The battle at which Gordian met his death, according to the *Res Gestae*, was fought at a place called Misichê, now renamed (in its Greek transliteration on the inscription) 'Pêrôs-Sabour'. It is the Persian city of Peroz-Shapur on the Euphrates, Pirsabora in Ammianus, which was besieged and taken by Julian in the campaign of 363. Its name meant 'Sapor Victorious' (it has been thought of as a sort of Persian 'Nicomolis'), and it was described by Libanius as the city named after the Persian king (*Or.* 18.227). For Zosimus, Pirsabora was after Ctesiphon the greatest city in Assyria (3.18.6). It stood over two hundred miles from Gordian's tomb, in true Babylonia, below the division of the Euphrates and the great canal leading direct to Ctesiphon.⁶

It is therefore by no means certain that Gordian was in fact killed, as Ammianus had Julian claim, at the place where he was buried, and frustrating that, with the loss of the book of Ammianus' history in which it was described, we cannot be sure whether he deliberately intended his allusions to Gordian's death to be read as a prefiguration of that of Julian himself. But Ammianus' entire account of Julian's expedition is pervaded by doom and foreboding, punctuated by omens, prophecies and portents whose significance he makes no attempt to disguise, but emphasises.⁷ If the historian can remind us that he had written in one of his lost books of Gordian's 'deeds in first boyhood and glorious leadership of armies' and then of his 'death by treachery' while on a Persian campaign, it is beyond belief that he should not have seen, nor intended, the parallel with Julian. As often with such allusions, it is not clear how far he meant the parallel to be pursued. Ammianus gave no hint in his account of Julian's death that the emperor had fallen by treachery to a Roman hand; but even if he did not himself accept this, he must have known that there were many others who did believe it.

However we understand Ammianus' intentions here, the precedent

ascribed to Julian's speech, of the Persian campaign of Gordian, was at best ambiguous. So was another, which is not in Julian's speech but appears by implication in Ammianus' later narrative. After reducing a Persian fortress not far from Ctesiphon, Julian went forward with a small party to survey the ruins of the once great city of Seleucia, destroyed (so Ammianus believed) by the Emperor Carus. The bleak scene which met Julian's eyes as he viewed the ruins was made still more desolate by the corpses of relatives of the garrison commander who had given up Pirisabora to Julian. They had been searched out and crucified in the ruined city (24.5.3).

The Persian campaign of Carus was not mentioned in the speech ascribed by Ammianus to Julian, though it had in fact been used by Julian in a genuine oration, his first panegyric to Constantius (*Or.* 1.18A). The expedition had become an object-lesson in the proper limits of Roman ambition in the east. Carus had taken Seleucia and Ctesiphon, but had then been struck dead, either by plague or, in an alternative but less plausible version, by lightning. One writer, contemporary with Ammianus, canvassed the idea that Carus had ignored oracles warning him not to go beyond Ctesiphon; another thought that his death showed the envy of the divine power for too great prosperity among mortals.⁸ These notions are elaborated by the late fourth-century author of the *Historia Augusta* into an allegedly current belief that fate had forbidden Roman emperors from advancing beyond Ctesiphon. The belief is challenged by the writer and ascribed to timidity, and he calls on the Emperor Galerius, to whom he purported to dedicate the *Life of Carus*, to provide the remedy. It could be done, said the author darkly, if the promised favour of heaven were not betrayed by Roman neglect.⁹

Whether the author of the *Historia Augusta* intended his words to evoke Julian rather than Galerius and, if so, what he intended by them, are not easy questions to answer. It is not as if Julian, for all the 'promised favour of heaven', had in true conscience overcome the inhibitions of fate: he had rather confirmed them. Evidence that Galerius campaigned in this part of Assyria, and a curious link between Galerius and Julian are however provided by the discovery by Julian's army in the town of Anatha on the Euphrates of an old soldier of Galerius who had fallen sick and been left behind by the Roman army. Ammianus told his story as witnesses had heard it: the soldier had settled down in Persia, married several wives in native fashion and raised a large brood of children. Now aged, he had for long known and had predicted that he would be buried in Roman soil (24.1.10).¹⁰

With the exception of Galerius, the more recent precedents in Roman history were therefore not unambiguously favourable; an emperor might as plausibly expect sudden death as spectacular conquest – or, worst of all, captivity in Persia. The Emperor Valerian had met Sapor I in battle and been taken prisoner, his captured legionaries being deployed by the Persians as builders and technicians in such exemplary projects as the construction, about thirty miles east of Susa, of the new city of

Gundeshapur and of the 'King's Dyke', a dam to control the waters of the river Karun. This victory, like that over Gordian, was magnificently celebrated in the rock sculptures at Bishapur and Naqsh-e Rostam.¹¹ For later emperors of the Roman east, it was an image of humiliation which they were not allowed to forget, and of which Ammianus must necessarily have written something in his lost books.

Strictly speaking, the fate of Valerian was not a precedent for an emperor planning an invasion of Persia, since he had been defeated not in Persian territory but in the Roman empire, near Edessa in Osrhoene. But it was not less ominous for that, given the aggressive pretensions currently shown by Sapor II. Edessa was the city from which the general Sabinianus had been instructed to co-ordinate the defence of northern Mesopotamia against the great attack which in 359 saw Amida, and in the next year Singara and Bezabde, besieged and captured. Indeed, it was in part to relieve the pressure on this northern region, constantly threatened by Sapor's declared intention to win back his 'ancestral dominions' in Mesopotamia, that Julian undertook his ambitious strike into Assyria and Babylonia. If successful, his expedition would transform the balance of power in the region and shift the diplomatic initiative as decisively in Rome's favour as had Galerius' victory over Narses (p. 53). In the case of Julian, we may add another, more personal though no less potent, motive – to discredit the inglorious eastern policy of the dynasty of Constantine in favour of the more assertive one of the emperors of the first two centuries, upon whom he modelled himself.

*

Few Roman military enterprises were so surrounded by discussion and criticism as Julian's Persian campaign. It could hardly have been otherwise – the emperor's ambition was so transparent, the possibility of success so seductive and the risks of failure so obvious, while the directness of Julian's personality and his informality as emperor invited the free, and sometimes provocative, expression of opinion. Ammianus thought Julian's critics defeatist and malign, as they expressed indignation at the disruption of the entire Roman world which had taken place merely because of a change of emperor – views which, in their eagerness to get the campaign put off, they deliberately expressed in the hearing of those whom they knew would take them to Julian (22.12.3). Some criticism was more directly expressed. While waiting at Circesium for his army to cross the Khabur, Julian received a letter from the praetorian prefect of Gaul, imploring him not to persist with the campaign. Ammianus mentioned the letter among omens and portents through which the gods also were expressing their opinion, concluding for his part that Julian was held immovably by the decrees of fate (23.5.4). It was of course too late now to turn back, even had the emperor wished to; but Ammianus might have recalled Julian's own protest, when Constantius insisted on recalling troops from Gaul for the eastern

campaign of 360, that the defences of Gaul were being weakened (20.4.7). The prefect's anxiety can well be understood, as he saw a huge army, including many troops from the west, committed to a reckless gamble on the Euphrates. He was proved right by the outcome. When Valentinian became emperor in 364 he found renewed chaos on the Rhine frontier – so soon after Julian's successes there. Indeed Valentinian's own financial severity could be defended by the extent of his needs after the 'Parthian disaster' of Julian; 'post procinctus Parthici clades magnitudine indigens impensarum' (30.8.8). Ammianus was frank enough to report this, but could only raise against it the argument that there were no circumstances whatever which could have justified the degree and methods of Valentinian's avarice. That the campaign of Julian had been a disaster was not in doubt.

Ammianus offers his most explicit defence of Julian's Persian policy at the end of his obituary of the emperor. Those critics, he here wrote, who believed that Julian had provoked 'new tumults of war to the detriment of the state' should know the plain truth. It was not Julian but Constantine who had kindled war with Persia, when, as Ammianus had explained fully in an earlier book, his greed had led him to believe the 'lies of Metrodorus'; 'non Iulianum sed Constantinum ardores Parthicos succendisse, cum Metrodori mendaciis avidius acquiescit, ut dudum rettulimus plene' (25.4.23). It was for this that armies had been defeated, generals and troops captured, cities and forts destroyed, provinces exhausted by taxation.

The story of Metrodorus happens to be known, for a version of it is preserved by an eleventh-century Byzantine writer, Cedrenus (pp. 516-17 Bonn). Metrodorus was a philosopher, supposedly of Persian descent, who in the time of Constantine had visited the Brahmin wise men of India. He had there been held in honour and had been permitted to enter sacred shrines of the Brahmins, from which he had taken precious stones and pearls. He had received more from the king of the Indians, to present to Constantine; but Metrodorus offered the treasures to the emperor as a personal gift, alleging that there had been more, which had been confiscated as he passed through the country of the king of Persia. Constantine was provoked to write to Sapor demanding the return of the jewels, and this was the cause of the breaking of the peace between Rome and Persia.¹²

This is essentially the same episode as that mentioned by Ammianus. He shares with Cedrenus the allegation that Metrodorus' story was the cause of the ending of the peace, while the theme of Constantine's greed, stated by Ammianus and implied by Cedrenus, was a regular feature of pagan criticism of the Christian emperor. It was Constantine, wrote Ammianus in another context, who first opened wide the jaws of his associates, while Constantius stuffed them with the vital substance of the provinces. These, in Ammianus' eyes, were well-attested facts; 'ut documenta liquida prodiderunt' (16.8.12).

Ammianus' attribution of the collapse of the peace to the 'lies of

Metrodorus' must be explained by the convergence of two strong sentiments, his dislike of Constantine and a wish to defend Julian at any cost against his critics; for on any reasonable assessment of the circumstances, the attribution seems trivial and irrelevant. The journey of Metrodorus took place in the late 320s, when Constantine's relations with Sapor were peaceful and Sapor himself, who had assumed the throne in childhood in 310, was still a young king; to this fact can perhaps be ascribed the extremely patronising tone in which (if the letter is genuine) Constantine wrote to proclaim his piety to Sapor and to commend to his protection the Christians in the land of Persia (Eusebius, *Life of Constantine*, 4.9-13). It was in the mid-330s, as Sapor's authority and ambition grew, that his relations with Rome became more warlike. There arrived in the Roman empire, appealing to a treaty with Constantine, a faction of Armenian noblemen whose king had been seized, blinded, and taken to the Persian court, and whose country had then been invaded by Sapor's army.¹³ Constantine's response to this appeal was vigorous. It involved the bestowal of the title 'King of Kings' upon his nephew Hannibalianus and his dispatch to Caesarea in Cappadocia; the fortification by Constantius Caesar of the city of Amida, which is mentioned by Ammianus (18.9.1; p. 54); and, in 337, a military campaign against Persia, which Constantine was preparing when he died.¹⁴ From the moment of his accession, as Julian himself said in his first panegyric to Constantius (*Or.* 1.20B-21D) Constantine's successor was preoccupied by the Persian threat to Mesopotamia. Every year they came, beginning in 337 or 338 with an unsuccessful two-month siege of Nisibis, the first of the three sieges which it suffered between Constantine's death and 350.¹⁵

It is obvious that far more was at issue in Constantine's relations with Persia than a fit of avarice induced by the lies of a philosopher. Nor could Ammianus fairly maintain that Constantine's policy, however provocative he believed that to have been, made Julian's Persian enterprise any less disruptive of the Roman empire than its critics claimed. Julian inherited the Persian problem from Constantius, as Constantius had from Constantine. Something had to be done; but nothing emerges more clearly from Ammianus' account than the force of Julian's personal obsession with the invasion of Persia, and his belief in his own unique ability to pursue it successfully.

These facets of Julian's personality had been shaped by his recent experience. His successes in Germany, achieved against all expectation, and his bloodless victory over Constantius in the civil war, had encouraged his confidence that he was the special favourite of fortune and the gods. The news of Constantius' death had filled him with elation, not only because it had resolved a military situation which he feared was not in his favour (21.12.21f., cf. 22.1.3), but because it fulfilled the public reading of the omens which he had conducted for the first time in Illyricum. Julian was already convinced by dreams, by private divination and by various experiences of the time of his proclamation, that he was in

the hands of a divine power, and this belief was now confirmed by the first public declarations of his apostasy (22.5.1f.). Elated by success, wrote Ammianus in a later passage, Julian breathed more exalted air than ordinary men. Fortune had never failed him in her generosity, bestowing glory without end; and Ammianus endorsed the emperor's conviction, adding as further proof of the gifts of Fortune that in the time of his sole reign Julian was troubled neither by foreign invasion nor by any civil disturbance (22.9.1). Ammianus has not at this point of his narrative mentioned the Persian campaign, but it is implied immediately by the move from Constantinople to Antioch (9.2). In moving east, Julian had ignored advice to turn his attention to the Goths. They had often proved unreliable, Julian was told; but he replied that he was in search of a 'better enemy' ('hostes ... meliores'), and would leave the Goths to Galatian slave-traders, by whom they were sold everywhere, well-born and humble alike (22.7.8). Julian did in a way manage to find a 'better enemy', but given the progress of events after his death, few of his judgments on the contemporary situation were so spectacularly misconceived.

Ammianus' fullest description of Julian's mentality in this period is reserved for the account of his stay at Antioch (22.12.11ff.). Then, wrote Ammianus, Julian strenuously prepared the campaign, which his noble mind had 'long before' conceived, passionately determined to avenge sixty years of destruction which the Persians had inflicted on the Roman empire – Ammianus is evidently not at this moment thinking to blame Constantine for 'kindling war with Persia'. Julian burned with desire for war; impatient of inactivity, he dreamed battles and the blare of trumpets, while the pleas of supposedly intractable German kings, still fresh in his mind, fed his ambition to add 'Parthicus' to the glorious titles which he already held (12.12).

Ammianus clearly accepted Julian's belief in his mission and in his unique capabilities to fulfil it; so that it is welcome confirmation that the emperor spoke for himself in his work, the *Caesars* or *Kronia*, composed at Antioch towards the end of 362. In this mock-contest of emperors, held before the assembled gods at the festival of the Saturnalia, the winner is of course Julian's model, Marcus Aurelius; the loser, stigmatised with terrific ferocity for his self-indulgence, prodigality and moral wickedness, is Constantine.¹⁶ There is an intruder among the contestants, Alexander the Great, who is made to excel even Julius Caesar in martial achievement, especially by virtue of his eastern conquests. It is Alexander whom the warlike Trajan joins at the end of the contest, seeing in him a kindred spirit. Trajan had argued on his own behalf that he had tried for the same achievements as Alexander, but more prudently (*Caesars*, 333A).

The reason for the intrusion of Alexander, and for this emphasis on military prowess, is obvious. The *Caesars* was written while Julian was in the heat of preparations for the Persian campaign, and Trajan and Alexander reflect his preoccupations – Alexander being imported also to

give expression to Julian's Hellenism, to associate Roman with Greek triumphs over the Persian empire. Yet the spirit of Alexander rose before any emperor who turned his ambitions to the east. Cassius Dio had told how Trajan went to Babylon during his Parthian campaign, to offer sacrifice in the room where Alexander was believed to have died, and how he stood on the shore of the Persian Gulf, watching a boat sail away to India. The ageing emperor was moved to a nostalgic reflection: so would he too have crossed the sea to India, if he had but been a young man (Dio 68.29f.).¹⁷

*

Julian's recollections of the submission of those German kings, who had been supposed readier to accept defeat than to face surrender, might suggest that the object of the Persian campaign also was to extract from Sapor a negotiated peace. This would no doubt be too strict an interpretation of a train of thought attributed to Julian at this time by Ammianus (22.12.2), but it raises the question already touched on, of the precise aims of the campaign and Ammianus' understanding of them.

The strategic design of the campaign is intelligible from Ammianus' narrative, though he nowhere sets it out explicitly. Certain crucial details have to be recovered from other sources, and at one point his text seems to have suffered damage. The idea of a double strike by both Tigris and Euphrates routes into Assyria had already been exploited by Trajan, who in Dio's fragmentary narrative first appears supervising the crossing of the upper Tigris in boats taken in pieces to the river and assembled there, then later at Hit on the Euphrates, from where he went on to attack Babylonia (Dio 68.26).¹⁸ Likewise Julian marched first to Carrhae to give the impression that he was going to attack Sapor in the familiar battlegrounds in northern Mesopotamia, but then struck south by the Euphrates route into Assyria. Meanwhile a substantial army under Procopius and Sebastianus was deployed in the north, to secure the Tigris frontier against attack and later, if possible, to link up with Arsaces of Armenia and ravage parts of Media before joining the main army in Assyria (23.3.5). Exactly what was implied by this last provision is unclear. Ammianus seems at one moment to represent the dispatch of the army of Procopius simply as a response to an unexpected attack by the Persians on the Tigris frontier (23.3.4f.), but he notes at the same time that the army had formed part of Julian's earlier plans, and twice mentions the supply depots prepared for its use in those regions (23.3.6; 25.8.7).¹⁹ This army was obviously a major element in Julian's strategy, being intended at least to distract Sapor and occupy him in the north, in order that the main advance to Ctesiphon should be unimpeded by serious opposition, and do what further damage it could. The importance of this design is reflected in Julian's haste to reach Ctesiphon quickly, as he pressed sieges and sometimes passed by fortresses without trying their strength, and in his mounting anxiety as he approached Ctesiphon

that the Persian army would arrive prematurely. The failure of the army of Procopius to achieve the more limited of its objectives was crucial to Julian's failure at Ctesiphon: it is not however Ammianus (as his text survives) but a fragmentary Greek source which tells how Sapor realised that he had been deceived into committing his main army to the north, and describes – or invents – some of the measures which he took to retrieve the situation.²⁰

While this omission may possibly be attributed to a fault in the textual transmission of Ammianus' history (p. 159), it is a more serious deficiency in his account that he fails anywhere to state explicitly what political aims Julian's military strategy was designed to achieve. Libanius, who might conceivably have known, asserted in a letter that Julian intended to install Hormisdas on the Persian throne in place of Sapor (*Ep.* 1402). Hormisdas was a Persian prince who had fled to the court of Constantine in an earlier dynastic conflict in Persia, and was highly favoured by that emperor, as by Constantius.²¹ The strength of his claim to the Persian throne should not be discounted, but it seems unlikely that this renegade could have hoped to supplant the great Sapor, now at the height of his immense authority. Hormisdas plays a prominent role in Ammianus' narrative, as a general, and as the recipient of insults from beleaguered Persian garrisons and captured Persians, but with no suggestion that he figured in any wider plans of Julian. It is not impossible that he played such a role, if only as one of several contingencies. Ammianus may simply not have known if this were the case; equally, Libanius may have been indulging in speculation, in an attempt to deduce such plans where none were immediately apparent to the outside observer.

It is after all possible that Julian's campaign had no such precise object. A military campaign with diplomatic aims will always be less easy to characterise than one whose aim is conquest, though the physical methods used might not differ much from one case to the other. There could be no doubt of Sapor's ambition to recover and hold by military action what he regarded as his ancestral dominions in Armenia and Mesopotamia; but no one could seriously have envisaged the permanent annexation by Rome of the regions overrun by Julian's army in 363. Julian's desire to capture Ctesiphon is as clear as that of Sapor to take Nisibis, but there can have been no question in Julian's case of holding such a prize permanently. The capture of Ctesiphon would be the splendid climax of the campaign, Julian's guarantee of a safe withdrawal (the Persians would not allow their capital to be destroyed) and his chief weapon in the negotiation of a favourable, lasting peace. It would show too that Julian could match the emperors of earlier times – those emperors mentioned in the speech ascribed to him by Ammianus at the outset of the campaign. Trajan, Verus and Septimius Severus had taken Ctesiphon and departed safely (it does not matter for these purposes that Trajan's successes were fragile and short-lived). They had adopted the title 'Parthicus' coveted by Julian, increased their own prestige in Roman eyes and demonstrated the enemy's weakness to surrounding peoples –

Saracens, Armenians and others whose attitudes were much affected by the success of the postures adopted by their imperial neighbours. Julian could hardly hope to achieve more than these predecessors. The real danger was that, in his own eyes at least, he had more to prove. To an eastern public, Julian's victories in Germany, the work of a gifted amateur rather than a true professional, must still have seemed distant and parochial in their importance, and they had not been fairly represented in Constantius' propaganda. Success against Persia, the historic enemy, would surely transform the prospects for Julian's domestic policies, in the religious sphere and others. It was easy for Ammianus' 'malign critics' to point to the dangers; but what if the gods were to declare themselves for Julian and he returned victorious? 'It could be done, if the promised favour of heaven were not betrayed by Roman neglect'. Julian had satisfied the condition: what might he not expect in return?

(2) Historical geography

Roman historians' descriptions of military campaigns are often our best evidence for the character and way of life of those less civilised peoples against whom they were directed:²² this is true of the *Gallic War* of Caesar, of the account given by Tacitus of the suppression of the African rebel Tacfarinas in the time of Tiberius, and of Ammianus' own richly detailed narrative of the defeat by Theodosius of the Moor Firmus in the early 370s.²³ Julian's Persian campaign, by contrast, was a journey to the origins of civilisation itself, to a land of ancient culture fully equal in material resources and complexity of social organisation to the Classical Near East of Ammianus' birth and upbringing. For Ammianus, Mesopotamia was in a sense the natural extension of the Classical world. The town of Circesium, where Julian's army crossed the Khabur into Assyria, and where Ammianus may have joined the campaign, was already half-way from Antioch to Ctesiphon. The Persian capital itself stood towards the far end of the 'Fertile Crescent', a politically divided but culturally and linguistically homogeneous band of territory of which Ammianus's native city was the pivot.

As Ammianus well knew, the conquests of Alexander the Great and the work of his successors had long ago planted the landscape of Mesopotamia with Greek cities, which were within the intellectual horizons of men of the Classical world, even when they were outside its political boundaries.²⁴ Among the finest and most successful of these cities was Seleucia on the Tigris, which in the days of Strabo and the elder Pliny, who describe it, was one of the greatest cities of the east, inside or outside the Roman empire. Founded by Seleucus Nicator in the late fourth century BC to outrival Babylon, Seleucia had by Strabo's time (16.1.16) replaced it as the metropolis of Assyria. Pliny ascribed to the city a population of 600,000, a later estimate suggesting 400,000 for the mid-second century.²⁵ Such calculations in ancient authors must always

be viewed sceptically, but figures like these would make Seleucia at its height a really great city, of the order in size of Syrian Antioch – a comparison actually made by Strabo (16.2.5). It had from the beginning possessed a mixed character, since it contained not only the Macedonian Greeks involved in its foundation by Nicator, but the Semitic and Iranian populations of Opis and Babylon, who were moved there, and many Syrians. The result was a city of notorious volatility and periodic violence, especially between Jewish and Syrian inhabitants, and one, from a Parthian point of view, of dubious loyalty. Towards the middle of the first century AD. Seleucia held out for seven years in revolt against its enfeebled Parthian masters.

Close by Seleucia across the Tigris lay Ctesiphon, built up by the Parthian kings as their winter residence, as Strabo explains, in order to spare the people of Seleucia the nuisance (and no doubt, given their political temper, the provocation) of quartering the 'Scythian people and soldiery' employed by them (16.1.16). It was with a nice sense of Graeco-Roman civic proprieties that Strabo described Ctesiphon as a 'large village'. He meant by this that it had no formal civic constitution in the Greek manner; yet, as Strabo made clear, it was in all respects of size and importance a city, since apart from its function as a royal residence, it was a trading centre for goods that 'suited the Parthians' and so was an assertion of Iranian cultural identity in contrast with the Hellenistic character of Seleucia. When Julian confronted the place in 363 it had been further developed by the Sasanians and seemed impregnable (24.7.1; below, p. 158).

As for Seleucia, it was by then an abandoned site, referred to by Syriac sources as 'Sliq Kharawta', 'empty' or 'deserted Seleucia': so too by Ammianus (24.5.3; p. 157) who, like the Syriac writers, shows it as a place of execution outside a new city, Coche (or Kôkhê). This is the city also known as Veh Ardeshir, so named after Artaxerxes I (c. 226-c. 241), the Sasanian monarch who had built it. Coche-Veh Ardeshir, not Ctesiphon as was earlier assumed, is the 'round city' that appears in archaeological plans beside the rectangular Hellenistic plan of Seleucia, across an old bed of the Tigris that seems, in this respect misleadingly, to separate them.²⁶ It is here necessary to understand the true sequence of events. The Tigris had indeed once flowed by the walls of Seleucia, but had already receded when Coche-Veh Ardeshir was founded in the third century; it then flowed, with the assistance of walls and dykes, round the eastern side of the new city, separating it from Ctesiphon. Then, in a further shift of the river-course that must at the time have caused a major urban disaster, Coche-Veh Ardeshir had itself been cut in two, the segment of the city left on the eastern bank of the new river course being absorbed into Ctesiphon. It was possible, according to a passage in the Babylonian Talmud, to go to the water's edge at Veh Ardeshir and see there ruined walls running down into the water where part of the city had once stood;²⁷ a reminder of the day when flood had divided it in two. For the purpose of defining Sabbath limits, Veh Ardeshir and Ctesiphon were



Map 4. Seleucia and Ctesiphon. Drawn from the plan in Clark Hopkins (ed.), *Topography and Architecture of Seleucia on the Tigris*, 164, with amendments from G. Gullini, *Mesopotamia* 1 (1966), 7-28, J.M. Fiey, *Sumer* 23 (1967), 3-38, and A. Oppenheimer, *Babylonia Judaica in the Talmudic Period*, 179ff. (plan at 233).

regarded in the Talmud as one city, being divided only by the Tigris, and this, as in effect a single city with the river running through it, is how they were described by some Classical accounts of the Persian campaign of Julian.²⁸

The decline of Seleucia, initiated perhaps by the first-century Parthian foundation of yet another city, Vologesias or Vologesocerta, to serve as the port of Ctesiphon and undermine its dissident rival, was ensured by the shift eastwards of the course of the Tigris.²⁹ The role of repeated Roman attack was, relative to these events, of lesser significance, although the sack of Seleucia by the army of Avidius Cassius in AD 165 was particularly destructive – gratuitously so, since the population had received the Romans inside under promises of friendship. Even after that, the city was rebuilt. Its archaeological history is one of progressive

decay rather than sudden destruction. By the mid-third century Seleucia had declined, Coche-Veh Ardeshir had been founded, and Classical sources begin to refer to the place indifferently by its old and new names – as indeed does Ammianus: ‘Coche, quam Seleuciam nominant’ (24.5.3). It must have been an eerie sight, quite apart from the corpses gibbeted in the abandoned city; the walls of Coche-Veh Ardeshir, round which the Devil himself had once been seen running,³⁰ overlooking huge sand-swept ruins, the old harbour of Seleucia (clearly visible in aerial photographs) enveloped by the still swampy river bed abandoned by the Tigris, the once busy water-courses neglected and choked with silt (below, p. 151). The decline in modern times of nineteenth-century industries has familiarised us, in very different circumstances, with the image of archaeological sites emerging from fading communities, disused canals and railway tracks reverting to a ‘natural’ state that does not disguise their artificial origins. It is not an inappropriate image to have in mind as we contemplate the end of the once great city of Seleucia: always remembering that in terms of the region as a whole we are looking not at decline but at shifts of population and economic activity from one urban centre to another under the influence of a locally unstable physical environment.

*

For those with eyes to see, an advance down the Euphrates to Ctesiphon was a journey to one of the richest, most ancient and most complex areas of civilisation of the Near Eastern world. This fact should encourage us to view Julian’s campaign in its cultural and geographical setting, even if it had not been attended by such an observant and alert participant as Ammianus. Not that Ammianus was the only one of his kind to accompany the campaign. Julian’s doctor, Oribasius, kept a memoir which he made available to his friend, the historian Eunapius (cf. fr. 8). Libanius referred to the many men who came back from the campaign with notes on it, and himself composed a well-informed and detailed account in his *Funeral Oration* for Julian (*Or.* 18.204ff.).³¹ There were too those ‘philosophers’ travelling with the camp, whose opinions on omens were so eagerly sought by Julian; whatever the quality of the advice which they proffered the emperor, one would expect them to have been observant men, interested in what they saw around them.

The presence of such men on Julian’s campaign would lend it, like its predecessors and especially the eastern campaigns of Alexander the Great, something of the quality of a ‘study tour’. The philosopher Plotinus had, according to his biographer Porphyry, actually joined the Persian campaign of Gordian in order to find out more about Persian and Indian philosophy (*V. Plot.* 3), a transformation of military campaign into intellectual venture which may seem eccentric but is far from unique. Julian himself conveys a fitting tone of curiosity in his last letter to Libanius, in which he describes the opening stage of the journey, from

Antioch to Hierapolis near the Euphrates (*Ep.* 98 Bidez).³² He passed on the way a ruined site, which he took to be the remains of an 'Antiochene winter camp' (whatever he understood that to mean) perhaps to be located at Imma; then travelled along a rough road to a marshy place where stones appeared to have been assembled and laid deliberately, but not by any usual building procedure. It has been convincingly suggested that his description answers to a bed of volcanic lava, broken by natural process into regular shapes to give the appearance of a made-up road. The emperor went by a place called Litarba (El-Terib), where he received in audience the Antiochene senate, which had accompanied him so far, and came to Beroea. Here he visited the acropolis, sacrificed a white bull to Zeus and lectured an apparently indifferent – no doubt because Christian – local council on the virtues of piety. Next on the road was Batnae, where traces of sacrifice and proper religious practice were to be seen. Batnae reminded Julian of Daphne near Antioch, with its fertile landscape dotted with young cypresses; a simple lodging had been prepared for the emperor, made of wood with no painted decoration, and there was a pleasant garden, with fruit and vegetables growing in little plots, cypresses and other trees neatly planted in rows.

Here too Julian sacrificed, before going on to Hierapolis, to be delightedly received there by an adept of Neoplatonist philosophy whom he had never before met – though the philosopher's father-in-law was none less than Sopatros, pupil of the 'divine Iamblichus' (see p. 126). The philosopher had often met Constantius and Gallus Caesar, without yielding to their inducements to abandon his piety to the gods.

It is difficult, in reading this little *journal de voyage* addressed to an intellectual friend, to visualise the actual circumstances of Julian's journey – the dust, the clatter of wagon wheels, the hordes of troops and officials who accompanied him. In Hierapolis itself, a portico by the main gate collapsed on Julian's army as it passed underneath, causing heavy casualties, fifty dead and many injured (23.2.6). Julian understandably omits to mention this episode in his letter to Libanius; yet in general the details included by Julian are not unlike those often picked out by Ammianus and other sources on the journey down the Euphrates to Ctesiphon – matters of an antiquarian rather than a military interest, but adding variety to the account and showing the curiosity of an eye-witness. Ammianus describes an elegant royal palace near Seleucia, spared by the army because it was constructed in the 'Roman style', and the hunting park adjacent to it (24.5.1f.; below, p. 157). Both were mentioned also by Eunapius and, in confused but colourful detail, by Libanius (*Oratio* 18.243). Ammianus remarks on the buildings of a suburban estate near Ctesiphon, with the interesting comment that the Persians never showed anything in their paintings and sculpture except 'various forms of slaughter and battle scenes' (24.6.3).³³ He recalls too the ruins of ancient walls seen near the place where the Euphrates divides into the first of its great navigable canals. They had been built long ago to protect Assyria from foreign invasion (2.6).

In one brief reference to a weakly fortified town sacked by the Roman army, having been abandoned by its Jewish inhabitants (24.4.1), Ammianus touches a fact of great importance about the population of central Mesopotamia. The position of the town may be consistent with that of the famous Rabbinic academy of Neardea,³⁴ but there is no need to press the identification in order to seize the interest in Ammianus' remark. Pronouncements in the Babylonian Talmud assume that in many communities in the area a substantial part, sometimes a majority, of the population was Jewish. So: a barrel of wine is found floating in the Euphrates, and the question arises, has it been prepared by Jews and so can be consumed by them, or is it libation wine of the gentiles? The verdict: if the barrel was found near a town with a Jewish majority, it may be consumed; otherwise, it must not be used. In the light of this decision, a later rider that the barrel might after all have floated down-river from Hit and is therefore untouchable, seems pedantic and grudging – though it has the merit of making it clear that the town of Hit, lying above the edge of the alluvial plain of the Euphrates, was beyond the strict limits of Babylonian Jewry or 'area of pure lineage'.³⁵

It is a little surprising that the Talmud, with all its emphasis on particular situations, real or hypothetical, has no specific reference to the Persian invasion of Julian. Problems arising for the Jewish community from military mobilisation in Persia are occasionally discussed, with reference to Sapor's internal wars against Arabs and others, but it seems that the invasion of Julian, which caused very great damage to persons and property, both by the direct action of the Roman army and because of the efforts of the inhabitants to resist it, did not raise the problems of legal and religious propriety with which Talmudic sources concerned themselves.³⁶ To the Jewish populations of Babylonia Sapor was a tolerant king, who ruled firmly but did not restrict their religious freedom nor subject them to oppressive taxation – he could hardly, given their numbers, have done otherwise. It is unlikely that Julian would have been able to undermine the Persians by making of the Jews a dissident faction among them, and we can view with reserve the possibility that any of Julian's domestic policies, in particular his attempted restoration of the Temple, were intended to attract the sympathies of Jews living in Mesopotamia.

*

The progress of Julian's march, from the Khabur crossing to Hit and beyond, was, for the army at large, relatively uneventful. Not that it was entirely free of incident, as in the fate of the soldier Jovianus, struck by lightning while leading horses from the Euphrates' edge (23.5.12). Another soldier swam over the river while drunk, to be seized on the other side by Persians and killed in full view of the Roman army (24.1.16). A more general mishap was caused by a sudden gale which blew up and caused destruction and chaos in the Roman camp. It was impossible to

keep a steady footing, says Ammianus, so strong were the gusts (1.11). Yet more ominously, on the same day the Euphrates overflowed when some sluices broke and some grain-ships were sunk in the deluge. In view of what was to happen later in the march, it is surprising that Ammianus ever imagined that the breaking of the sluices could be due to an accident; though he was observant enough to remark that the sluices themselves, built to control the water for irrigation, were made of stone in the customary manner.

The first major town to be encountered was Anatha, which stood like many Euphrates settlements on an island in the river (24.1.6). Anatha was surrounded overnight by a fleet sent on ahead with a picked detachment of 1,000 men, and quickly surrendered.³⁷ Other towns, such as Thilutha and Achaiacala, were passed by since they declined to yield instantly, but preferred to wait and see what happened, while Julian had no time to spend on them. Ammianus describes in stately language how their inhabitants gazed respectfully over their walls at Julian's fleet as it slipped by; 'verecunda quiete spectabant immobiles' (2.1f.). Other deserted settlements were sacked and burned, their people having fled rather than trust their defences (2.2f.).

The nature of the landscape and habitation of the country are well suggested by the account written by Captain (later General) F.R. Chesney of the journey by raft down the Euphrates, which he undertook in 1831 as an exploratory mission for the British Government to see whether an overland route could be found to India and the Far East.³⁸ Captain Chesney recorded how, beginning his descent of the river at Anah (Anatha), he passed on his raft between 'well-wooded banks, and along islands of various dimensions', past the 'still perfect walls of ancient Tilbus' (Ammianus' Thilutha) and Hadisa, 'built on high ground, surrounded by a defensible wall washed by the river'. Hadisa was perhaps the same as Achaiacala, since Ammianus too mentions its difficulty of access, with a suggestion of its height; 'arduumque transcensu' (24.2.2). Other island settlements were El-Oos, a town of some importance, 'with two mosques, some flourmills, and about 250 houses', where Chesney's raft grazed the walls as they came down into the water; and Jibba, 'with some 500 houses ensconced in a date-grove, which extends for more than a mile along the centre of the river, which is here shut in by high ranges of hills ...'.

Throughout the whole distance from Anna to Hit (131 miles) [wrote Chesney in summary], we passed though a constant succession of watermills and aqueducts, villages and hamlets, which succeed each other at almost every fresh sweep of the river; now showing themselves between the low hills which skirt the river's banks, now enlivening the wooded islands which frequently divide the stream – which, in this part of its course, has an average width of 350 yards, a depth of 11 feet, and a current of three knots per hour in the season of floods. I counted fourteen islands during this part of our descent, many of which have small towns upon them, often built upon some ancient site. (*Euphrates Expedition*, 75f.)

Contemplating this and other accounts of travel in Assyrian Mesopotamia, one wonders whether on surveying the site of Anatha in preparation for its siege, Julian shared the reaction of a French traveller of the seventeenth century, Jean Baptiste Tavernier, who was reminded of Paris, 'for it is built upon both sides of the River Euphrates; and in the midst of the River is an island, where stands a fair Mosque'.³⁹ Tavernier was writing for a Parisian audience; it is unlikely that despite his affection for Paris, Julian was struck by any such resemblance, even allowing for the replacement of the temple which no doubt stood in Roman times on the Ile de la Cité, by the cathedral of Notre Dame. Writing of another town, Diacira (Hit), Ammianus does however happen to mention that there could be seen over the river a high temple, placed on the summit of the hill round which the town was clustered; 'Diacira civitas ..., in qua templum alti culminis arci vidimus superpositum' (24.2.3).

The town of Hit marked the end of the first stage of Capt. Chesney's journey down the Euphrates, as it did of Julian's. It was overhung by a pall of smoke from the boiling bitumen springs for which it was famous; Chesney was greeted by the governor, Sheik Mohammed, 'whose attire accorded well with the murky atmosphere of the place' (*Euphrates Expedition*, p. 76)! At Hit, Chesney had a boat made in the age-old manner: a wooden frame was staked out on the ground, the flat bottom and sides of the boat were constructed of lattice-work, the sides held firm with ties and the whole vessel coated inside and out with layers of pitch – just as Noah was instructed to 'make an ark of gopher wood ... and pitch it within and without with pitch' (*Genesis* 6.14); the result was a boat light in construction, with a large capacity and shallow draught, ideal for its purpose. The Assyrian name for Hit, Id, comes from the word for pitch, *iddu*, just as its Aramaic name, Ihi Dekira (Ammianus' Diacira, Dakira in Eunapius) means 'place of asphalt'.

Ammianus too mentions the 'bubbling well of bitumen' ('fonte scatenti bitumine', 24.2.3) seen by Julian's army opposite the town of Hit. It was an imposing sight. 'Near unto the river Euphrates,' wrote a sixteenth-century traveller through Mesopotamia to the East Indies, Cesar Fredericke –

there is a city called Heit, nere unto which city there is a great plaine full of pitch, very marvellous to beholde, and a thing almost incredible that out of a hole in the earth, which continually throweth out pitch into the aire with continuall smoake, this pitch is thrown with such a force that being hot it falleth like as it were sprinkled all over the plaine in such abundance that the plaine is always full of pitch, the Mores and the Arabians of that place say that that hole is the mouth of hell and in truth it is a thing very notable to be marked: and by this pitch the whole of the people have their benefit to pitch their barks.⁴⁰

Shorter but no less evocative is the description given in the account of the Assyrian King Tukultu Enurtu II, who in 884 BC made his encampment

'opposite Id, close to the sources of bitumen ... where the great gods speak'.⁴¹ The springs were the same as those inspected by Trajan during his campaign of AD 116. It was from them, the emperor was correctly informed, that the bitumen had been taken for building the walls of Babylon (Herodotus 1.179.4); they were made of brick cemented with bitumen, just as Ammianus and Eunapius described the formidable double walls of Pirisabora, built by a Persian monarch a millennium later. It was, wrote Ammianus, the most durable manner of building known; 'quo aedificii genere nihil esse tutius constat' (24.2.12).

A detachment of Julian's army was sent over the river to take Diacira.⁴² They killed the women found there and took large quantities of the salt which in modern times too is an important product of the region. After Diacira was Ozogardana, where a tribunal was shown, built for Trajan to address his troops in the campaign of 116 (24.2.3). This town, like Diacira left undefended, was taken and burned, and it was soon after this (two days being allowed for rest) that the Persian army was first seen in the open. An ambush laid for the general Hormisdas was almost successful. Ammianus, alert as ever to the dramatic possibilities, used the occasion to introduce briefly the Persian commanders, and to convey the impact on the Romans of their previously elusive enemy. There they stood, arrayed for battle in the first light of day, with their glinting helmets and bristling armour; 'visi tunc primitus corusci galeis et horrentes indutibus rigidis' (2.5). Their commanders were a splendidly assorted pair – Surena, a Persian nobleman whose ancestors had led the king's armies for centuries (it was a Suren who defeated Crassus at Carrhae in 53 BC), and Malechus, a lawless desert chieftain whose customary delight it was to terrorise Roman frontier regions; 'famosi nominis latro, omni saevitia per nostros limites diu grassatus' (24.2.4). We shall in a later chapter see something of the wider significance of this most interesting figure.⁴³

After a skirmish, in which the Romans closed quarters and prevented the enemy from using its strength in archery, the army came to Macepracta, where ruins of the great walls were seen, built in ancient times to defend Assyria against invasion (24.2.6); and below this, to the point where the Euphrates divided into the first of its main derivative channels. It was an important moment in the campaign.⁴⁴ The river had now, a few miles below Hit, entered its alluvial plain. The physical geography of the region, in terms of the relationship between the river and its surrounding lands, had crucially changed; the natural resources available for Persian resistance were multiplied, and Julian's enterprise became ensnared in difficulties for which the journey so far had given little preparation.

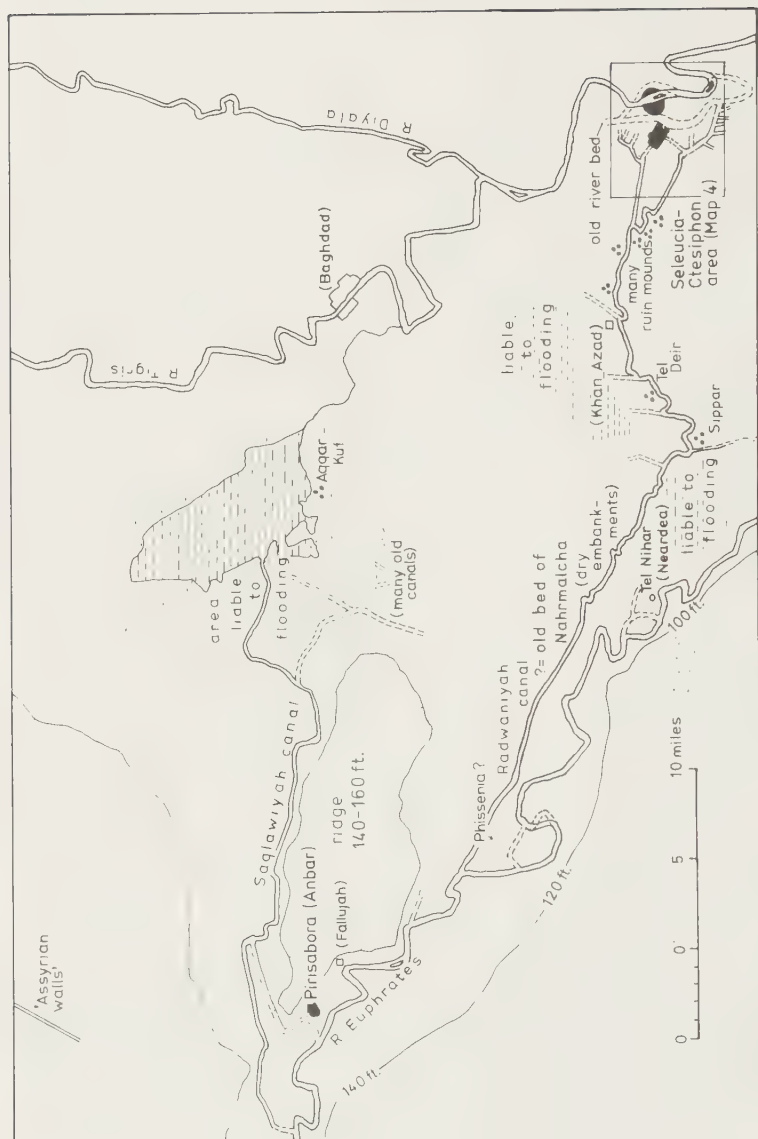
*

In the book of the Babylonian Talmud called *Berakoth*, 'Blessings', the following pronouncement is recorded:

He who sees the Euphrates up to the Babylonian bridge says 'Blessed be thou who has made the Creation'; but nowadays, since the Persians have altered it, that Benediction is only to be pronounced above Be Shapur. Rab Joseph said: 'Only above Ihi Dekira'.⁴⁵

This means that there was a point on the Euphrates below which it was not right to bless the Creator, since his handiwork had been effaced by changes made by man to the nature of the river. Differing opinions were offered as to where this point was located, the strictest view picking out Ihi Dekira, or Hit. The less rigorous alternative, Be Shapur ('place of Sapor') is to be identified with Peroz-Shapur, Ammianus' Pirisabora, the next major town to be attacked by Julian. Piri-sabora, the Arab city of al Anbar, 'the Arsenal', contained or was very close to the famous Rabbinic academy of Pumbadita, an Aramaic word suggesting the separation of the waters of the Euphrates. As we have seen, it was just above Pirisabora that the Roman army came to the first of the great canals of the Euphrates.⁴⁶ Here, wrote Ammianus, the river divided, one part going to inner Babylonia to irrigate the land and provide water for its cities, while the other branch flowed past Ctesiphon. This channel, according to Ammianus, was called the Naarmalcha, or 'King's river', and at the point where the waters divided stood a tall tower like a lighthouse (24.2.7).

The channel so described by Ammianus, and now crossed by Julian's army, was at least in its earlier sections the ancient predecessor of the Saqlawiyah canal, through which Captain Chesney in 1838 sent a steamer to the Tigris a little below Baghdad. The Saqlawiyah canal, as Chesney noted, was undoubtedly 'one of the most ancient commercial communications in the world', though this observation applies, as relevant to Ammianus' account, only to the first part of its course.⁴⁷ The channel as seen by Ammianus, and as described by the elder Pliny in the first century (*Hist. Nat.* 5.90), like the Saqlawiyah had its inlet above Pirisabora and followed the course of the Saqlawiyah to the north of the ridge that extends eastwards for about twenty miles behind that city. The channel must then have turned south round the end of the ridge, leaving the course of the Saqlawiyah canal to join by one of many possible routes the waterway which Classical and Talmudic sources more usually know as the Naarmalcha or King's river ('*basileios potamos*' in Greek), running from the Euphrates past the site of ancient Sippar and on to the Tigris at Seleucia. Ammianus' account raises a problem as to the correct location of the Euphrates inlet of the Naarmalcha. The problem is best solved by the supposition that there were more than one. Beginning with the most southerly, an inlet was located by Ptolemy (5.17.5) on the same latitude as Sippar and Seleucia. Near the inlet, according both to Ptolemy and to Talmudic texts, stood the Jewish city of Neardea; this is no doubt represented by the ruin mound shown on modern surveys as Tel Nihar or Tel Quhr Nahar, on the left bank of the Euphrates due west of Seleucia just where Ptolemy placed it.⁴⁸ It is however implied by Eunapius' account of the campaign that the Naarmalcha also possessed an inlet



Map 5. Julian in Mesopotamia (Pirisabora-Ctesiphon). Drawn from maps prepared by the British Mesopotamian Expeditionary Force, $\frac{1}{4}$ -inch scale (1917-19), sheet TC 87 Baghdad-Saklawiyah, with details added from 1-inch map (1918-20), sheets 85-6, 100, 102-3.

further to the north, possibly on the alignment of the later Radwaniyah canal (below, p. 153); while as we have seen, Ammianus assigned the name Naarmalcha to a third, still more northerly channel leaving the Euphrates above Pirisabora. In this he has the support of Pliny's statement that the channel drawn from the Euphrates near Massice (Parthian Mšyk or Misichê, later renamed Pirisabora) was called the Naarmalcha by 'all the Assyrians'.⁴⁹ The source of the ambiguity in locating the Euphrates inlets of the Naarmalcha may well be that the original 'King's river' (*nâr šarri* of Babylonian texts) had run from Sippar to the Tigris at the time when Sippar lay on the Euphrates, and that all three later inlets which connected the Euphrates with the ancient canal as the bed of the river shifted westwards came to share its name. The cuneiform name for the Euphrates is, precisely, 'river of Sippar', though very early texts suggest that the river was already receding from the city. The site of Sippar (Abu Hubbah) is now waterless, as is the ruin mound of Tel Ibrahim, linked with Sippar to the south by the dry but once heavily settled riverbanks known in Arabic as *Habl-Ibrahim* ('Abraham's Rope'), which mark the old course of the Euphrates.⁵⁰

It is evident that description of settlement in this region has to accommodate frequent, and sometimes quite marked, shifts in the river-courses, the distribution of urban sites being inexplicable without the assumption that the great rivers and their derivative channels once took water to places now isolated in the desert. One such change, on a smaller physical scale than the abandonment of Sippar by the Euphrates but quite as dramatic in its consequences, has already been discussed as relevant to the local context of Ammianus' narrative (p. 141). The bed of the Tigris had shifted eastwards as it passed Seleucia and Ctesiphon, leaving Seleucia isolated from the river that had sustained it. It had then, in a subsequent change of course, cut in two the new city of Coche-Veh Ardeshir which had succeeded Seleucia, to form the configuration visible in Ammianus' day.

This is a landscape subject in both larger and smaller dimensions to constant change, caused both by natural process and by human intervention, as watercourses become silted and have to be cleared or replaced, and in which what is a 'natural' and what an 'artificial' river-bed are not clearly distinguished one from the other. Strabo wrote of the continuous labour and the difficulties involved in clearing and maintaining the canals, especially at their inlets, 'for the soil is so deep, soft and yielding that it is easily swept away by the currents; and so the plains are eroded, the canals filled and their inlets choked by silt' (16.1.9). The consequence of damage or inadequate maintenance is that the land is liable to flooding and, lacking natural drainage, can degenerate into insect-ridden swamps and marshes.

A lively glimpse of some of the arrangements necessary for the maintenance of the canals is given in the Talmud. We read there, for instance, of the arrival of a Sasanian canal official – even if the vision of his methods of enforcement seems over-dramatised:

R. Zera's father was tax collector for thirteen years. When the head of the canal came, he would advise, 'Come, my people, enter into thy chambers' [*Isaiah* 26.20, which continues: 'and shut thy doors about thee: hide thyself for a little moment, until the indignation be overpast'], and to others he would say, 'The head of the canal is coming to town, and he will slaughter the father in the presence of the son, and the son in the presence of the father'. So they all hid. When the officer came, he would say, 'Of whom shall I make the demand ...?' (*b. Sanhedrin* 25b)

The demand is no doubt for some sort of *corvée* or tax devoted to canal maintenance. Herodotus had noted (1.193.2) that Babylonia was like Egypt in being divided by canals, and papyri from Oxyrhynchus illustrate the obligations laid on farmers to take their part in the maintenance of the dykes (*P. Oxy.* 1409, 2847), record accusations of bribery of the canal superintendent by individuals who wish to avoid their obligations (3264), and mention other abuses (1469, 2853). References in the Talmud show the elaborate arrangements surrounding the rights of usage by landowners of water from irrigation channels, and such details as their obligation to maintain and keep clear a towpath of specified width beside canals used for barge transport.⁵¹

To the use of canals for irrigation and transport, a third function should be added, that of defence: and with this, we return to the campaign of Julian. The city of Pirsabora is described by Ammianus as 'protected by water like an island' ('ambitu insulari circumvallatum', 24.2.9), though in this case it is the more systematic description of Eunapius, as preserved by Zosimus, which shows that the city was defended to the north by a wide channel drawn from the river, which also provided its water (3.17.4; p. 174).⁵² Another place several miles further on, called Phissenia by Eunapius but unnoticed by Ammianus, had a deep ditch by its walls, into which the Persians had admitted water drawn from the nearby 'King's river', evidently below the second of the three inlets identified earlier. In consequence, the Roman army passed it by without offering siege. Later, at an unnamed place near Ctesiphon, Ammianus noted two towns formed into island sites by the stream – here the ancient Naarmalcha between Sippar and the Tigris. The inhabitants of these settlements, less sure of their defences than the people of Phissenia, had made off for Ctesiphon, some through the 'dense woods', some by circuitous routes through the nearby marshes, carried on boats made of hollowed-out trees (24.4.8). The marshes in question were no doubt connected with the 'immense lake' debouching into the Tigris near Seleucia, alluded to by Ammianus (5.3) and other writers. It was formed, not strictly as Ammianus thought by the waters of a 'constant source' but by the Naarmalcha and its branches as they tried to enter but were held back by the swift-flowing Tigris, and so were heavily silted at their outlets.⁵³

The last episode at Phissenia illustrates another use of water as a defensive resource, fully exploited by the Persians in their resistance to Julian. Beyond the settlement the entire countryside had been

transformed into a swampy morass (24.3.10f.; Zosimus 3.19.3). The Persians had achieved this by the simple but drastic method of deliberately flooding the plain, both from the main channel of the Euphrates and also (Eunapius was precise on this, even if Zosimus' summary of him is confused) from the Naarmalcha: the army was marching between the two.⁵⁴ Eunapius used the difficulties now faced by the army to show the resources and determination of Julian in getting his men over the morass, having experts build bridges over water channels and crossing the shallower parts of the inundation on woven mats. Libanius also wrote at some length of the emperor's courage and ingenuity, and of the determined patience of the army during this part of the march (*Or.* 18.223ff.). Ammianus was content with a brief description of the difficulties experienced in getting the army over, which was done by using pontoons, boats and inflated bladders, and rafts of woven palm-branches (24.3.10f.). Both Zosimus and Ammianus make clear that the army had to camp overnight in this uncongenial and obviously unhealthy country, though for some the conditions were eased by the discovery at a place called Bithra of a palace and buildings in which they could stay (Zosimus 3.19.4). It was after this that the army reached huge palm-groves, extending as far as Mesene (Maišan) and the Persian Gulf. Here, stated Ammianus, the main stream of the Euphrates divided into many small branches; 'pars maior Euphratis in rivos dividitur multifidos' (24.3.14).

Julian's predicament is to be understood in the context of two basic features of Mesopotamian geography. The first relates to the habits of alluvial rivers, as in their seasonal flooding they deposit at their edges quantities of debris, which is left there as the waters of the river spread over the flood-plain and in due course recede. The banks of such rivers are gradually built up by such deposits until the river-course is guarded, like Mark Twain's Mississippi, by embankments (known as *levées*) which generally contain the river when it is full but are broken from time to time. When the Mississippi overflowed its embankments, the landscape became like that of a 'vague dim sea that is shoreless, that fades out and loses itself in the murky distances', the embankments themselves being visible like thin ribs in the water. It was just such an embankment of river or canal of which Libanius wrote, when he described how some of Julian's men made their way precariously along a steep and narrow bank, with the floodwaters lapping up to each side (*Or.* 18.224).⁵⁵

In such a terrain, the banks of canals are built up by human agency more quickly than those of natural river-courses, as their beds are dredged to keep them clear and the sludge is dumped on the edge of the canals. Eventually the banks become so steep and high that the operation is impracticable, and when this happens a channel will be abandoned to silt up, and a new one started. By repetition of this process the whole of this part of Mesopotamia is littered with the remains of old canals that have been replaced by new courses. The ancient Naarmalcha itself is dry between still huge embankments, while the modern Mahmudiyah canal

runs on a parallel course to the south of its ancient predecessor.

At the same time as the banks of such water-courses are built up in this way, deposits of silt raise their beds as well, so that in due course the maximum water level may be higher than the surrounding plain. The prospect of flooding in such circumstances can be imagined, as the river or canal spills over its banks and down onto the land around. More pertinent to Julian's experience, when a deliberate breach is made in the walls of a watercourse, the flooding will be progressive, as the water runs down from its higher level over the plains; and since drainage back into the water course is impossible until its natural level falls, and is at best extremely slow, large tracts of land are reduced to a swampy condition which, without effective remedial action, may rapidly destroy good soil.

The second factor of Mesopotamian geography therefore concerns the regime of the river Euphrates. Rising in the Armenian mountains, the river increases its flow as the snows melt in spring, adding their volume of water to the seasonal rainfall. In the two months from the middle of March, the Euphrates doubles its rate of flow, producing at Hit by mid-May in a typical year over 50,000 cubic metres of water (nearly 400,000 gallons) per second.⁵⁶ The rise in its level in the same period, measured at Ramadi just below Hit, is almost two metres, though the difference can in some years be much more than this. The contrast in the conditions experienced by Julian's army and by Xenophon's Ten Thousand in 401 BC is instructive. When Cyrus reached the Euphrates at Thapsacus in Syria and found the boats there burned to prevent his crossing, his men were actually able to wade over the river (*Anabasis* 1.4.17f.). Local people remarked that the level of the river was unnaturally low; in fact no one could remember its ever being crossed in this way before. The conditions, certainly very rare, were unimaginable except during late summer, when the Euphrates flows at its lowest. Julian's campaign, on the other hand, took place when the river was rising to its highest level. Ammianus remarked, as the army left Callinicum at the end of March, on the swelling of the Euphrates from the waters of its tributaries; 'aquis adolescentibus undique convenis' (23.3.8). And so it continued; by early May, when the army encountered the flooding in the region beyond Pirsabora, the Euphrates had still to rise over half a metre before it reached its maximum. The inundation was progressive, and would not abate in time for the army to leave Mesopotamia by the same route as that by which it had entered.

The use of water to provide large-scale strategic as well as local defence of Babylonian cities was a very ancient device. The best-known instance is Nebuchadnezzar's Babylon, which according to Herodotus was protected by a large lake drawn off from the Euphrates at some distance north of the city (Herodotus 1.185). In consequence, the approach to Babylon was made more indirect and tortuous for an enemy planning an attack from the north:

To strengthen the fortification of Babylon I continued, and from Opis upstream to the middle of Sippar, from Tigris bank to Euphrates bank I

heaped up a mighty earth-wall and surrounded the city for 20 *beru* [80 miles] like the fullness of the sea. That the pressure of the water should not harm the dike, I plastered its slopes with asphalt and bricks.⁵⁷

On the reconstruction accepted here of the route of Julian's army, the emperor had crossed the inlet of what Ammianus calls the Naarmalcha (the Saqlawiyah canal) and continued his advance along the left bank of the main channel of the Euphrates. Crossing other canals drawn from the Euphrates, the army proceeded to and then followed what Ptolemy and other sources knew as the 'Royal river'; this, as we have seen, left the Euphrates at the same latitude as Seleucia. In this case the army, advancing along the Royal river by the ruins of ancient Sippar, will have passed to the west and then to the south of the area covered by Nebuchadnezzar's lake; yet it remains an intriguing reflection that the Persians defended their capital against Julian by recreating in more improvised fashion the water defences designed by Nebuchadnezzar for the protection of Babylon.

*

One major obstacle, a waterside fortress called 'Maiozamalcha' by Ammianus, still stood between Julian and Ctesiphon. The same place, not named but described as a fortification ('phrourion') near a city called Besouchis, was located by Eunapius ninety stades, or just under twelve miles, from the Persian capital (Zosimus 3.20.4f.).⁵⁸ It is clear too that the fortress lay by the Naarmalcha, but despite these indications neither its location nor that of Besouchis has been positively identified. This is in itself not so surprising. Habitation along the great waterways of Mesopotamia was often very intense, neighbouring sites being occupied successively over a long period of time. As with modern urban growth that absorbs nearby villages as a city expands along its lines of communication, it might not always be easy to tell by observation just when one had left one community for another, the whole district being a rather indeterminate mixture of urban and rural settlement.

The name 'Maiozamalcha' given to the fortress by Ammianus, however, raises a more particular problem. 'Mahoza' – 'market' or 'town' – was the Aramaic name for the seat of one of the four Rabbinic academies of Babylonia; two of the others, Pumbedita-Pirisabora and Neardea (the fourth is Sura), have already been mentioned in this narrative of Julian's campaign. Now Mahoza stood, as Talmudic references make absolutely clear, by the Tigris. It was because they drank the waters of the swift-running Tigris, said one pronouncement, that the people of Mahoza were so shrewd (*Berakoth* 59b, adding, in less complimentary terms, that they had blotchy faces because they indulged in sexual intercourse in the daytime, and weak eyes because they lived in dim, dark houses, while the women liked jewellery and 'ate without working'!). Mahoza is Coche-Ctesiphon, the twin city formed when Coche, or Veh

Ardeshir, was built in the third century to replace Hellenistic Seleucia (p. 141). The place-name 'Maiozamalcha' – the second element meaning 'royal', as in 'Naarmalcha' and the personal name 'Malchus' – ought to represent a fuller Aramaic designation of Coche-Ctesiphon: for it would be strange if unadorned 'Mahoza' meant Coche-Ctesiphon while 'royal Mahoza' were some other place than the Persian capital. It looks as if Ammianus has misnamed the fortress besieged by Julian, either by simple error or possibly by confusing the name of the district in which the fortress stood with that of the fortress itself. A Greek source called the district round Ctesiphon the 'land of the people called the Mauzanitai' – that is, of Mahoza – and some such description as this may be the source of Ammianus' confusion.⁵⁹

Eunapius' Besouchis, near which the fortress stood, also looks like an Aramaic place-name, in some such form as Bê Saukhê, 'place of branches' – just as Ammianus' Bezabde represented the Syriac Beth Zabde (above, p. 53). That it has not been located might again reflect the density of the urban development of this region, in which cities and townships present themselves so frequently, and under so many names, as to baffle systematic description. Besouchis must in any case be distinct from the strong 'castellum' near Ctesiphon assaulted and taken, with losses on the Roman side, after the capture of 'Maiozamalcha' (24.5.6ff.). Unnamed by Ammianus, the 'castellum' was identified by Eunapius as Meinas Sabatha and located thirty stades, less than four miles (Besouchis was twelve miles), from Seleucia (Zosimus 3.23.3). Meinas Sabatha is clearly the city known to the Arab geographers as Sabat or Sabat al-Mada'in;⁶⁰ far from being a mere fortified outpost, it is none other than Volagesias or Volagesocerta, Parthian Valashapat, founded in the first century by Volageses I to outface Seleucia as a trading centre and obviously a major city. We should also take account, in forming our impression of the socio-economic character of this region, of the two unnamed settlements on the Naarmalcha whose inhabitants, not trusting their defences, had escaped through woods and marshes (24.4.8).

Al-Mada'in was the name given by Arab writers to this land of 'the great cities', the 'cities of the country of the Arameans', and we can begin to see just what was so remarkable about it. The whole region must, if we knew more about it, have been one of the most amazing exercises in urban development ever known in the ancient world, a staggering expression of a mastery of the arts of production, transportation and communications, achieved by social organisation allied to the experience of centuries.⁶¹

Ammianus' 'Maiozamalcha' was protected, like so many other strongholds encountered by Julian, by water as well as its walls. The army had to be conveyed across the Naarmalcha in order to begin the siege (Amm. 24.4.6), and Libanius adds a particularly vivid and picturesque detail: the place stood on an island and was surrounded by a thick bed of reeds, which concealed the path from the walls to the river's edge (*Or.* 18.235). After intense fighting, the place was taken in the small

hours of the third day of the siege by a famous exploit, a tunnel being dug to within its inner fortification. This achievement, and the daring of the three soldiers who first leapt out of the tunnel inside the city and were later decorated by Julian before the assembled army (24.4.23f.), was universally reckoned to be one of the outstanding moments of the campaign.⁶²

While the fall of the fortress was awaited, an advance party went on to test Persian resistance to the crossing of the Tigris (24.4.31), and in the two days' rest given to the army after its capture, Julian visited the deserted site of Seleucia; nearby were palaces built in the 'Roman' style – that is, presumably in a Hellenistic style derived from the architecture of Seleucia – and the great hunting park of the Persian king, into which Julian let his cavalry to enjoy themselves (24.5.1ff.). Resuming its march, the main army crossed more canals, evidently irrigation canals derived from the Naarmalcha, and, under increasingly effective threat from the garrisons of Coche and other strongholds (24.4.31; 5.5ff.), reached an old, now dried-up and blocked channel of the Naarmalcha to the Tigris. Ammianus thought that this channel had been excavated by Trajan and re-used by Septimius Severus in their respective campaigns against Ctesiphon, and that it was itself called the Naarmalcha, but this view was mistaken. The channel with its control sluices ('cataractis', 24.6.2) was undoubtedly more ancient, excavated originally to take the Naarmalcha to the Tigris above Seleucia. What is more, Trajan had not actually had the channel opened, being advised that its level was higher than the Tigris and fearing that, once opened, it would cause the Naarmalcha to run dry and become unnavigable (Dio 68.28.1ff.). The cut had long been disused; indeed Libanius reports that its blocked inlet was cultivated – which is presumably why it was so hard to find – but Julian, who knew of its existence 'from books', had it cleared (*Or.* 18.245ff.). The waters of the Naarmalcha then carried the Roman fleet quickly through the channel to the Tigris, a distance of thirty stades, or less than four miles (24.6.2). It is Libanius, again, who notes that the inhabitants of the 'two cities', Coche and Ctesiphon, were apprehensive for the safety of their walls when they saw bearing down on them the waters of the Tigris swollen by those released from the Naarmalcha – fears for which, as we have seen, they had the best possible justification, for it was through just such a disaster that their cities had been formed as they were (*Or.* 18.247; above, p. 141).

Meanwhile the Roman army relaxed in an elegant and shady park near Coche, fresh with the beauty of fruit trees, vines and green cypresses; 'in agro arbustis et vitibus et cupressorum viriditate laetissimo' (24.6.3). The whole landscape, with its parks, gardens, retreats and frequent townships, has in Ammianus taken on a distinctly suburban character, reminiscent even of the ideal of a 'garden city'. It was here, in referring to the 'diversorium', or pavilion, in the middle of the park near Coche that Ammianus remarked on the violent subject-matter of the paintings and sculptures with which the Persians enlivened their buildings,⁶³ and this

may be an apt moment to note that the word 'paradise' comes to us, through Greek sources, from the Persian word for a garden – potent symbol, both for desert- and for city-dweller, of peace and rest, reflecting however no innocent state of nature but the expression of a social ideology through highly sophisticated techniques of environmental control.

Ctesiphon itself now lay opposite and Julian, convinced as ever that all difficulties would yield to his touch, decided against his generals' advice to force a night crossing. A strike force got across the Tigris, a fierce battle secured the other bank, and the Persian resistance was driven back into Ctesiphon (24.6.4ff.). But the euphoria was short-lived. Julian's generals prevented their men from entering Ctesiphon in pursuit of the Persians, for they would only get caught inside (24.6.13). A note of sudden uncertainty is struck by Julian's sacrifice of ten fine bulls to Mars, which was rejected by the god (24.6.17), and for the first time the military aims of the campaign fall under a shadow of doubt and perplexity.

Perhaps the most striking aspect of Ammianus' description of the council of war now held to decide whether or not to besiege Ctesiphon, is the readiness with which Julian's generals were prepared to abandon as a 'rash and untimely enterprise' ('*facinus audax et importunum*', 24.7.1) what had obviously been the prime object of the campaign.⁶⁴ If the city really did seem, as Ammianus now says, to be impregnable in its situation ('*situ ipso inexpugnabilis*'), then Julian had clearly underestimated its capacity for resistance. He had perhaps been misled by the experience of previous emperors, who had found the place a relatively easy prize – though intelligence on the current state of its defences was surely not hard to come by. More ominously, it was believed that the Persian king, escaping from whatever entanglements had been devised for him in the north, was about to arrive with a great army (24.7.1).

It was at this point, in order to press further inland and away from the river, that Julian made his sensational decision to burn his boats and pursue the campaign without them, keeping only what would be needed for the construction of bridges. Protest broke out in the army, suspicion falling upon the Persian deserters who were now guiding it. The deserters, indeed, confessed under torture to misleading the army, and Julian's order was countermanded (24.7.5). The impact on the morale of the army, when it proved impossible to quell the flames and save the ships, was catastrophic; yet Julian knew that something like twenty thousand men had been occupied in managing and protecting the boats (24.7.4), and Ammianus seems somewhat uneasily to agree that, without the encumbrance, the army was more coherent and stronger for its advance into the interior (24.7.6). It would in any case have been impossible to haul ships upstream against the strong current of the Tigris, and it may be, too, that with the opening of the old channel to the Tigris the Naarmalcha itself had, exactly as Trajan had once feared, run empty and become unnavigable.

It is unfortunate that Ammianus' text may have suffered damage precisely where it would have enabled Julian's decision to be better

understood (24.7.2). Other sources mention at this point such important matters, absent from Ammianus, as the reception by Julian of envoys from Sapor;⁶⁵ and it was perhaps here also that Ammianus set out the reasons, which he later said he had given but which appear nowhere in his text as it now stands, for the failure to appear of the army sent to the north under king Arsaces and the Roman generals, Procopius and Sebastianus (24.7.8, 'ob causas ... praedictas'). It is therefore uncertain whether the burning of the boats, however symbolic it may appear of Julian's predicament, followed from a decision to advance further into Persia (whatever this could have achieved), or to retreat. Ammianus clearly believed the former, in showing Julian's eagerness to press on (24.7.6), and his impatience with his generals' inertia in urging him to release his grip on a country which was practically won (24.7.3). The decision to retreat by Corduene is reported in a different and later context (24.8.5).

By then, circumstances had changed still further. Procopius and his colleagues had failed to show up, while, as might have been expected, the Persians had burned their standing crops, the fires forcing the Romans to stay in a fixed camp and depriving them of food, and began to harass the army (24.7.7). Retreat by way of Assyria was impossible, as Julian and others made clear in argument to the discontented soldiers. The terrain was stripped, the ground sodden and flooded, the rivers still rising beyond their banks. Moreover, the whole land was filled with gnats and mosquitoes, rising in such clouds that, in Ammianus' words, 'they obscure the light of day and the glitter of stars at night' (24.8.3). There were also those cities which in his haste Julian had passed by without reducing, and which would now be only too happy to turn out to oppose his retreat.

It has been suggested that the later development by the Sasanians of the region of the Diyala river east of the Tigris, made possible by a massive and complex system of canal irrigation, was a consequence of the devastation and economic decline of the districts overrun by Julian's army in 363.⁶⁶ This view is probably an exaggeration. Unlike the feeble Abbasid rulers of the thirteenth century, unable after long decline to make good the destruction wrought by the Mongols to dykes and canals, the fourth-century Sasanians possessed the political organisation and will to undertake the rehabilitation of the land. The prosperity of the Diyala region should be associated with the further development of Ctesiphon as the Persian capital in the fifth and sixth centuries, a period which witnessed the highest degree of urbanisation and the most sophisticated economic organisation ever known in the regions east of the Tigris. Yet the damage caused by the invasion of 363 must have been extremely severe, no less from the flooding and the destruction of dykes and canals than from the ravages directly caused by the Roman army. No account of any previous Roman campaign against Persia mentions the tactic of deliberate flooding being used against it, and it is possible that Julian's most serious miscalculation in his Persian campaign was his failure to anticipate the readiness of the Persians to damage their own

land in order to resist him. This was itself a consequence of Julian's successful diversion of Sapor to the theatre of war in the north, a strategy of which his own delay, because of the flooding, in reaching Ctesiphon had lost him the advantage.

*

Julian's army broke camp on 15 June, to try to secure retreat by the Tigris route to Corduene. For Ammianus, it was a moment of especial significance, which he registered with emphatically formal solemnity: 'sextum decimum Kalendas Julias, promotis iam signis, progresso imperatore cum lucis exordio ...' (24.8.5). The army had scarcely moved when a halt was sounded, because of the appearance in the distance of a cloud of dust or smoke. As to what it might be, opinions differed. Perhaps it was a herd of wild asses, travelling close together to deter attack by lions. Some thought that Arsaces and the Roman generals were arriving, attracted by rumours of a great siege of Ctesiphon: others, that it was a Persian force, lying in wait for the Roman march.

In the uncertainty the army encamped for the night in a valley near a watercourse, adopting a heavily defensive formation. The cause of the cloud of dust, which could only be dimly seen as the evening mists rose, could still not be determined (24.8.7).

At this point, Ammianus ends Book 24 of his history. He begins the next in unbroken continuation of the narrative ('et hanc quidem noctem ...'), proceeding at once to the suspense of the waiting army. The night was black and starless, and the men spent it (or as Ammianus actually says, '*exegimus*'; '*we* spent it') as one would expect in a tense and uncertain situation: no one dared sit down, or close his eyes in sleep, for fear. In the first light of dawn the metallic glint of armour, and breastplates gleaming in the distance, showed the truth. The king's army had arrived (25.1.1).

It is a moment as arresting as any in Roman historical writing, contrived with great craft, and it conveys what is most obviously characteristic of Ammianus' presentation of the campaign (of which it was, of course, a crucial turning point): the immediacy and sense of involvement deriving from his own experience of it, and his awareness of the dramatic significance of particular moments. The word 'dramatic' is here used strictly. From the very beginning of his account of the campaign, Ammianus wrote with explicit recognition that it was destined to fail, and that the emperor would die. From this recognition, his work draws a sense of tragedy which, carefully worked out in the technique of his composition, is what most clearly distinguishes his narrative of the campaign from others that survive.

It is with this quality of Ammianus' in mind that we may now go on to assess the relations between this part of his history and other descriptions of the campaign which may have been available to him. The question is not merely to what extent Ammianus may or may not have

used written sources to supplement his own observation, or for clarification on matters of fact. This would of course be worth knowing: far more important, however, is the way in which he used such sources within the framework of his own distinctive presentation of Julian and his fated enterprise.

(3) *Ammianus and other sources*

The manner in which a historian handles the written material available to him is always relevant to an understanding of his principles of writing and to any judgment of his reliability.⁶⁷ It is often the only control of these matters that we have, and since the procedures of textual comparison that are involved are relatively straightforward and objective, it is not surprising to find that much, especially of the earlier modern, writing on Greek and Roman historians is devoted to enquiry into their written sources. The method is most apt when a historian is clearly inferior to his sources in knowledge and judgment, when he draws his information from materials that are limited in number and variety, and especially when he is describing a remote period of which he has no personal experience. In such cases source criticism is less a method of research into the secondary authority than the recovery of original material that will, once recovered, become the object of study; so with the raising of the Greek historians Ephorus or Hieronymus of Cardia from the voluminous pages of Diodorus and – relevant to the subject of this book – of the history of Eunapius from Zosimus.⁶⁸ In neither case is the dependence on or the inferiority of the surviving writer to his source in any doubt. Both Diodorus and Zosimus were compilers or summarisers without valid claims to originality as historians, and both were without direct personal experience of the subject-matter of their books.

The dangers of source criticism when these conditions do not apply – as when a historian uses many different sources and types of source, or combines personal research and testimony with his written material – are obvious. As applied to Ammianus' account of the Persian campaign of Julian, the technique fails to encompass the complexity of a historian's problems in assembling and ordering information on a subject as large in scale, as well documented, and as controversial as this was. Further, it ignores the plain evidence of Ammianus' involvement in such earlier episodes as the suppression of the usurper Silvanus, the fighting on the Tigris front during the invasion of 359, the siege of Amida, as well as the Persian campaign itself. In his preface to Book 15 Ammianus promised to set down what he was old enough to have witnessed himself or could by interrogation learn from others, and nothing is more obvious than the depth of his interest in the personality and fate of Julian. It would be paradoxical if such a historian should, after such experiences and having made such declarations, produce an account of the tragic climax of the reign of Julian that essentially derived from other written accounts.⁶⁹

This is not to deny that Ammianus made any use at all of other sources

of information, and the Persian campaign provides an opportunity to consider some of the material which was available to him. The campaign was a sensational enterprise which attracted interest from many different points of view. Its failure and the death of Julian provoked reactions of extreme and lasting intensity, from the jubilation of the emperor's Christian opponents to the bitter grief of his supporter, Libanius. Libanius remarked that many men had come back from the Persian campaign with notes and memoirs on it. In a letter he complains that men who had promised to give him written material and verbal accounts had failed to do so, interest in the emperor's deeds having died with the emperor himself. Some soldiers, unknown to him before, had provided information about times and distances on the journey, and the names of places, but nothing worthy of a proper history of the emperor's achievements (*Ep.* 1220). Despite his complaint in this letter, Libanius did not find information hard to come by. His *Funeral Oration* in Julian's honour (*Or.* 18) shares common ground with other accounts in its narrative of the campaign but also, as we have seen, provides circumstantial details which are not in other sources and add touches of colour of their own.⁷⁰

One of the returning witnesses of the campaign whom Libanius (*Ep.* 1434) shows to have kept notes on it, was surely known to Ammianus. This was Philagrius, who had served in Germany under Julian and was then the central figure in an episode for which he must have been Ammianus' source, since it features a confidential letter given by Julian to Philagrius, to be opened only under the particular circumstances which in fact occurred (21.4.2f.).⁷¹

Another such figure was Eutropius the historian, who accompanied the campaign, little though he has to say of it in the *Breviarium* of Roman history which he dedicated in about 370 to the Emperor Valens (cf. *Brev.* 10.16.1). Eutropius' book will have held scant interest for Ammianus, at least as far as contemporary events were concerned. Its author was however mentioned in Ammianus' account of the treason trials conducted at Antioch and other eastern cities in 371, in which he narrowly escaped the fate of other former friends of Julian (29.1.36). Ammianus could clearly, if he wished, have consulted Eutropius on the Persian campaign and discussed it with him – much as he surely learned from another historian, Aurelius Victor, who happened to be there, the circumstances of Julian's advance upon Sirmium in 361 (21.10.6).

That it should be possible to suggest the names of certain individuals with whom Ammianus may, if he chose, have talked of Julian's Persian campaign, is not particularly significant, for it is obvious that in the years after 363 the eastern provinces were full of such men, making their way home with reminiscences of what they had seen. The 'philosophers' such as Priscus and Maximus, who in Ammianus' opinion had so much to answer for in the advice which they gave to Julian, were doubtless articulate in narrating their experiences and justifying their actions, and there were many others. The Roman empire must in these years have

resounded with recrimination and with justifications of Julian's policy; both attitudes are reflected in Ammianus' defence of the Persian campaign, which he appended to his obituary of the emperor, and in phrases from handbills and graffiti denouncing Jovian which are cited in a passage of the Suda perhaps to be assigned to Eunapius.⁷² The campaign must for a time have been the dominating subject of conversation in the streets, bars and dining-rooms of Antioch and every other eastern city. It would be unrealistic to limit Ammianus' contacts with witnesses of the campaign to those whom it may be possible to name and identify: the problem would rather have been to hold to one's own opinion among the welter of those expressed.

The issue is not quite the same in the matter of what written sources existed for Ammianus' possible use. Here again, far more was available to Ammianus than his modern reader can ever know of. In the second century, Lucian had satirically described the flocks of histories inspired by the Parthian campaigns of L. Verus, by authors aspiring to be a second Thucydides, Herodotus, or Xenophon; how true it was, he wrote, that 'war was the father of all things', if it had at one stroke generated so many histories (*On the Writing of History* [Libell. 59], 2)! The situation was no different after the Persian campaign of Julian. Yet Lucian's point would be missed unless most of what was written were rubbish; and in discussion of Ammianus, we may look most profitably at two particular writers of the many who existed: Magnus of Carrhae, of whom a summary of about 700 words survives in the sixth-century chronicler, John Malalas; and Eunapius of Sardis.

*

The fragment of Magnus which is preserved by Malalas is not sufficient to define his qualities as a historian. Yet Magnus was a real person, who stood in an intelligible relationship with Julian's campaign, even if he was not, as has been argued, one of the three soldiers who leapt out of the tunnel at 'Maiozamalcha'.⁷³ His native city, Carrhae, was crucial to Julian's strategy, for it was from there that the roads to the east divided, one going to Nisibis and northern Mesopotamia, the other to Circesium and the confluence of the river Khabur with the Euphrates.

As we have seen, Julian's initial strategy was to convince the Persians that he was about to launch a major attack by the northerly route and to draw the enemy to that battle-zone while he took his main army south in a rapid strike at Ctesiphon. Magnus' narrative made clear the purpose of the army of Sebastianus and Procopius to act as a diversion. He described Sapor's manoeuvres when he realised he had been deceived and, descending from history to romance, told the story of two Persians who allowed their noses to be cut off (in the manner of a famous tale in Herodotus) and were sent mutilated to Julian's camp to lead him astray into the desert and gain time for the army of Sapor to make its way south. Ammianus either did not know or did not believe this story, though he

described how the burning of the boats was inspired by misleading information given by Persian deserters, and mentioned the guides to whom Julian proposed to entrust himself in a further march into the interior beyond Ctesiphon (p. 158). In general Julian's strategy, though ambitious, was not obscure, and one would not have thought that Ammianus, who offers an intelligible account, would have needed to consult Magnus in order to produce it. He mentioned the projected rendezvous of Procopius and Sebastianus with Julian from the point of view of the main army in its predicament at Ctesiphon, and the absence in Ammianus of any account of its failure must be due to a deficiency in his text as it survives, for he explicitly claims to have done so (p. 159). The only similarity between Ammianus and Magnus on which any sort of argument can be based is the description of the parting of the roads at Carrhae, and even this is not conclusive (below, p. 169f.).

A more productive comparison with Ammianus is the history of Eunapius of Sardis. Eunapius was a young student at Athens at the time of the death of Julian and never knew him personally;⁷⁴ but through his interest in medicine he later came to know Julian's doctor and intimate friend, the famous Oribasius, who made available to him a detailed personal record or 'memoir' (*hupomnēma*) of the reign – including, of course, an account of the Persian campaign.⁷⁵ Traces of the information provided by Oribasius have been found in the works of fifth-century writers whose own use of Eunapius, and above all that made of him by Zosimus, enables us to assess the nature of his work. Zosimus' epitomator, the ninth-century patriarch Photius, commented that he differed from Eunapius only in his brevity and greater clarity, and in his freedom from the extravagant figures of speech of which Eunapius was fond (*FHG* IV, p. 9f.). Photius knew and could compare both texts: his testimony is explicit and should be accepted.

The suggestion that Magnus of Carrhae rather than Eunapius was the source for Zosimus' *New History* can be discounted, not least because it contradicts the direct evidence of Photius. It is of course possible that Eunapius himself, writing some years after the Persian campaign, used such a narrative history as that of Magnus, especially if the memoir of Oribasius was of a relatively informal nature and Eunapius preferred also to work with a source that already provided an explicitly historical framework. But the state of preservation of the texts does not permit this possibility to be tested, and although we should bear it in mind we can seriously discuss the question of Ammianus' use of his sources on the Persian campaign only in terms of his relationship with Eunapius, as he is preserved by Zosimus.

*

We find here a detailed and precise narrative of the Persian campaign, which even in Zosimus' summary (3.12-29) is at many points a supplement to that of Ammianus. Zosimus produces the names of places

not mentioned by Ammianus or presented by him in different forms, describes incidents and episodes which Ammianus does not record, and offers many differences of detail and in presentation.⁷⁶

To begin with discrepancies in the names of places, Zosimus records two settlements, Sitha and Megia, in the neighbourhood of 'Dakira' (Ammianus' Diacira, or Hit), which are not registered by Ammianus, and, further south, the towns of Bithra, identical with or near to the unnamed Jewish settlement mentioned by Ammianus (24.4.1); Besouchis, near which Ammianus' 'Maiozamalcha' was situated; and Meinas Sabatha. 'Maiozamalcha' is referred to by Zosimus as a 'fortress' (*phrourion*). Whether Eunapius also did this is not known, but it is possible that Ammianus' form of the name was itself based on a misunderstanding (above, p. 155f.). We saw earlier how Magnus of Carrhae, referring to the same place, mentioned the 'district of the Mauzanitai'; that is, the region of the town of Mahoza, or Ctesiphon.⁷⁷

The names of places mentioned by both writers can appear in Zosimus in forms clearly independent of those given by Ammianus. The island fortress of Anatha is described by Zosimus as located 'near Phathousa', the explanation in this case perhaps being that Eunapius was referring to the settlement on the bank of the Euphrates opposite Anatha rather than to the site on the island. Ammianus' Ozogardana, where the Emperor Trajan's tribunal was shown (p. 148), appears in Zosimus as Zaragardia, and the city of Coche is given by Zosimus as Zochasa.⁷⁸ It is of course possible that the name has been affected in its transmission from Eunapius to Zosimus. As we saw earlier, the settlement patterns and nomenclature of this region of Mesopotamia are immensely complicated, and discrepancies between different authors are the least to be expected. Where they do occur, however, they are proof of the independence of these authors, one from the other.

A more substantial omission in Ammianus is the town of Phissenia south of Pirisabora, surrounded according to Zosimus by a ditch flooded from the nearby channel of the 'King's River' or Naarmalcha. This part of Julian's advance is covered by Ammianus merely by a reference to a journey stage of fourteen miles beyond Pirisabora, upon which the floods were encountered (24.3.10). Ammianus makes no mention, as Eunapius did, of Julian's determination and ingenuity in getting the army across the morass, nor of the 'palace' near Bithra which, for some, made their overnight stay in the swamps less unpleasant. He leaves unstated the source of the flooding, and located what he called the Naarmalcha well to the north, above Pirisabora. On the assumption that the Naarmalcha had more than one inlet to the Euphrates, Ammianus' account is compatible with that of Eunapius, but clearly independent of it.⁷⁹

The forcing of the canal at Pirisabora, summarily presented by Ammianus (24.2.8), was described in detail by Eunapius as a major engagement. The Romans met severe resistance, which they overcame by a tactical manoeuvre inspired by Julian, and by the soldiers' tenacity and bravery in action. Eunapius described the difficulties caused by the

muddy ground, which especially hampered the cavalry, and by the depth of the channel, as well as by harassment from Persian missiles. Julian himself has the motion of sending Lucillianus' task force of 1,500 picked men to cross the channel lower down, while Victor is to make a night crossing out of sight of the Persians, and effect a rendezvous with Lucillianus. The manoeuvre is carried out and the Persian defenders are taken in the rear and overcome by the combination of Roman forces.

The greater detail in this account, compared with Ammianus' summary notice, is evident. Ammianus mentions the Persian missiles and the crossing of the Naarmalcha on pontoon bridges, but he gives no indication of the difficulties described by Eunapius, nor of the manoeuvre by which they were countered. This is interesting, for Julian's military expertise and ingenuity are repeatedly emphasised in Ammianus' history, and 'scientia rei militaris' is one of the set of virtues around which his obituary of Julian is constructed (25.4.11). If Ammianus knew Eunapius' history and was accustomed as a matter of course to use it, why should he have neglected an episode so illustrative of the emperor's military genius?

So much for specific divergences – more could easily be found – in individual details and episodes of the campaign. The differences between Ammianus' and Eunapius' accounts can be explored in more continuous fashion in their descriptions of the earlier stages of the invasion. Eunapius began with a different selection of details from that furnished by Ammianus in describing Julian's march from Antioch to the Euphrates; this was, of course, a part of the campaign which Ammianus may not have known at first hand, if he joined it at a later point. Where Ammianus merely records that Julian marched to Hierapolis 'by the usual route' and from there moved on hurriedly ('propere', 23.2.6f.) across the Euphrates to Batnae, Eunapius noted that the journey to Hierapolis took five days and that this city was the assembly point for the military and transport ships coming down the Euphrates from Samosata and other places (Zosimus 3.12.1f.). The name of the commander of the fleet is given as Hierius, who is nowhere mentioned by Ammianus, and since the river Euphrates runs in an arc a good twenty miles to the east of Hierapolis, that city cannot be where the fleet was actually assembled. The apparent anomaly may in fact confirm Eunapius' accuracy, if, as Zosimus implies, he described how Hierius was 'sent on ahead' from Hierapolis while the emperor delayed there, in order to supervise the assembly of the fleet on the Euphrates, detaching him from his command in the land army for this purpose (Zosimus 3.12.1).⁸⁰ Ammianus explains how the assembled fleet later rejoined Julian below Callinicum (23.3.9). After three days at Hierapolis, Eunapius continued, the army moved on to Batnae in Osrhoene, where Julian received a deputation from Edessa, offering him a crown and inviting him to visit the city. The embassy is not mentioned by Ammianus, and Eunapius was mistaken if he believed that Julian accepted the invitation; in fact he refused to visit the city on account of the excessive Christian piety of its inhabitants, with which he had become acquainted as emperor.⁸¹ This error may however have been

introduced by Zosimus. From Batnae, the army proceeded to Carrhae, where the roads to the east divided in the manner already mentioned.

Eunapius now gave a story which, if it was known to Ammianus, was rightly rejected by him. Having dispatched the army of 18,000 men (which Ammianus gave as 30,000 and Magnus of Carrhae as 16,000) to defend the Tigris frontier under Sebastianus and Procopius, Julian is alleged to have conceived a desire to inspect the army from a secret vantage point, for the sheer pleasure of seeing it (Zosimus 3.13.1). The story is surely no more than a rhetorical fabrication to enable Eunapius to describe the army, whose total numbers, infantry and cavalry, are given in this context as 65,000 men. The army then left Carrhae, as Ammianus also describes (23.3.6f.), advanced by way of various intermediate stations to Callinicum, and from there to Circesium on the Euphrates. Julian then crossed the Khabur and embarked on his journey down the Euphrates, followed by the boats carrying supplies and the soldiers guarding them.

Eunapius next introduced the fleet, with more discrepancies between himself and Ammianus (13.1-3). It consisted of 600 wooden and 500 skin-covered boats, with 50 troop-ships as well as 'other' (Eunapius may have meant 'another fifty') flat-bottomed vessels for crossing rivers, and many others to carry siege machinery and timber for building engines. The fleet was commanded by 'Lucianus' and 'Constantius'. For Ammianus, who described the fleet not here but earlier (23.3.9), its strength was 1,000 ships for transport, supplies and siege machinery – a figure differently classified and lower than that given by Eunapius, whose total of 1,100 excluded the ships carrying siege machinery. In addition, there were 50 warships and 50 vessels for the construction of bridges; in these figures Ammianus agrees with Eunapius. Their commanders, given by Ammianus in reverse order from that in Eunapius – and in reverse order of seniority – were Constantianus (a mere tribune) and Lucillianus. These, and not those given by Zosimus, were the correct forms of their names; although it is easy for such variations to occur in the process of transmission of a text.⁸²

If Ammianus here knew Eunapius' account, or any other from which it derived, he was clearly not dependent upon it either in points of detail or in his disposition of the material. In locating his description of the fleet near Callinicum rather than after the crossing of the Khabur, for instance, Ammianus supplied a more subtly integrated narrative context than that of Eunapius. Instead of a formal enumeration of the fleet, on which Eunapius was actually more specific, Ammianus has the reader visualise the impact of its arrival among the rest of Julian's preoccupations; 'while he was addressing the Saracen envoys ... the fleet arrived, commanded by the tribune Constantianus together with the *comes* Lucillianus, packing solid the great width of the river Euphrates. It contained a thousand transport ships constructed in various fashions, carrying great quantities of supplies, weaponry and siege machines, fifty other warships and another fifty boats necessary for the assembling of

bridges' (23.3.9). Eunapius continues by referring to Julian's address to the assembled army, which he locates at its natural (and correct) place immediately after the crossing of the Khabur, and mentions the donative of 130 silver pieces for each man which was made by the emperor (Zosimus 3.13.3). Ammianus has no donative, and the complexity of his presentation of the speech of Julian has already been noticed (p. 131). Whatever the explanation of his treatment, it has nothing to do with any use of literary sources. Ammianus is writing in his own terms, making his own stylistic and rhetorical calculations, and independently of any such account as that of Eunapius.

As to the marching order of Julian's army, Ammianus and Eunapius are in broad agreement, the main differences being of arrangement and presentation. Eunapius began with the names of Victor and Hormisdas, the commanders of the cavalry, and Arintheus, commander of the infantry, and then went on to explain the marching order, with the cavalry on the left (protecting the army on the side exposed to the desert, from where mounted raids might be expected) and part of the infantry on the right, while the rest of the army followed on, the pack animals being grouped in the middle. In his subtler, more flexible manner, Ammianus incorporated the names of the commanders in his description of the order of march, adding that the right flank of the army, marching by the river, was led by Nevitta, that Dagalaifus, Victor and last of all the *dux Osrhoenae* Secundinus brought up the rear (evidently in command of cavalry forces), and that the fleet kept pace, proceeding along the winding reaches of the river (24.1.2ff.). Ammianus' additional names and details of the disposition of the army are clearly important for the understanding of Julian's marching tactics. Such apparent omissions by Eunapius cannot be pressed, since they may be due to Zosimus' attempts to summarise him, but the greater freedom with which Ammianus presents his material is a significant point of contrast.

Both Eunapius and Ammianus noted the extension of the army as it moved into Assyria. It spread over seventy stades, according to Eunapius (Zosimus 3.14.1); 'almost as far as the tenth milestone' ('decimo paene lapide', 24.1.3) in the words of Ammianus, who thereby provides his description with a touch of traditional Roman vocabulary, such as we find frequently in his account of the campaign (cf. 23.2.6). Ammianus compares Julian's strategy to that of king Pyrrhus, who spread out his forces to give the impression that they were greater than they really were. In a similar allusion, he compared a tactic used by Julian in the march against Constantius in 361 with one employed by Alexander the Great 'and other skilled generals' when need arose; he had sent his army over the Alps in three divisions, to create rumours and give an impression of great numbers (21.8.3; p. 105). Whether this was Julian's intention on the Persian campaign is questionable. From the standpoint of an interested observer of the campaign, a different aspect may be stressed – the difficulty of securing a coherent view of the experiences of an army spread out over ten miles of country, with a fleet that because of the

winding course of the Euphrates must often have been completely out of sight and was sometimes deployed independently of the land forces.

*

If Ammianus knew of Eunapius' account, or any other from which it derived, he was clearly not dependent upon it. He omits places and some quite significant geographical details which were mentioned by Eunapius, and leaves aside opportunities to include anecdotes which would have confirmed his heroic conception of Julian; and where he shares information with Eunapius, he deploys it with a freedom of presentation, and sometimes with a rhetorical purpose, which differ from those of the Greek writer.

There remain a few passages where the subject-matter and similarity of language between Ammianus and Eunapius, even as preserved by Zosimus, are close enough to suggest a specific connection between them. The argument needs to be conducted with care. When two ancient authors share a known error, this may be inexplicable unless one derives from the other: the possibilities of error being boundless, an error shared is significant. Similarities of language where the subject-matter is the same and there is no reason to suppose error are much more difficult to interpret, and conclusions based on the similarities must often be a matter of judgement rather than of proof. In the case of Ammianus' relationship between Eunapius and other sources, a basis for judgment can be offered by setting out the passages in question, in translations which reflect the language and word order of the originals.

(1) The division of the roads to the east beyond Carrhae is presented in similar terms by Ammianus, Zosimus, and Magnus of Carrhae, as summarised by John Malalas:⁸³

... and from there he found two roads, one leading off to the city of Nisibis [then held by the Romans], and the other towards the Roman camp (*kastron*) called Circesium, which lies between the two rivers, the Euphrates and the Aboras (Khabur). This camp was founded by Diocletian, emperor of the Romans. (Magnus, in *FHG* IV, p. 4; the words in square brackets were presumably added by Malalas)

Now from that point two roads lay before him, one leading in the direction of the river Tigris and the city of Nisibis and the satrapy of Adiabene, the other in the direction of the Euphrates and Circesium (this is a fortress (*phrourion*) encircled by the river Aboras and the Euphrates itself, and adjoins the borders of Assyria). (Zosimus 3.12.3)

... from where two royal roads ('*viae regiae*') lead in separate directions to Persia, to the left in the direction of Adiabene and the Tigris, to the right in the direction of Assyria and the the Euphrates. (Ammianus 23.3.1)

In such brief accounts of a well-known geographical situation, it is not

clear that any of these writers need necessarily have known any of the others. Although it is clearly possible that the versions of Eunapius and Magnus are related and that Ammianus knew one or the other, the similarities between them are not sufficiently precise to demonstrate this. Ammianus included in a later passage a description of the site of Circesium, as mentioned also by Magnus and Eunapius:

... its walls are encircled by the rivers Aboras and Euphrates, which form it into an area like an island. This fortress, formerly weak and suspect, was provided by Diocletian with walls and lofty towers, when he was arranging the inner frontiers on the actual borders of the barbarian territory ('cum in ipsis barbarorum confiniis interiores limites ordinaret') (Ammianus 23.5.1f.)

Ammianus' description has in common with both other sources the encirclement of the site by the Khabur and the Euphrates, but it is unlikely that he would have needed to consult either Magnus or Eunapius for the geographical nature of a place which he had seen himself, and whose essential defensive qualities lay in its protection by the two rivers. Further, Ammianus deploys his description of Circesium more freely than Eunapius and, as in the case of the arrival of the fleet near Callinicum, gives it a more closely integrated narrative context. It forms part of a small digression in Ammianus' account of the arrival of the army at Circesium at the beginning of April, and is followed by an explanation of Julian's delay there while he allowed the entire army to cross the Khabur before having the bridges dismantled, and by his receipt of the letter from the prefect of Gaul attempting to dissuade him from the expedition (23.5.4f.).

Ammianus' note, which he shares with Magnus, on the fortification of Circesium by Diocletian, is also freely deployed, being followed by an anecdotal digression on a Persian attack made on Antioch a century before Ammianus' time. In the time of Gallienus, before Circesium was strengthened and when the Persians could make raids into Syria at will, the people of Antioch were on one occasion sitting in the theatre, intently watching a scene from married life being acted in a mime. The wife in the mime suddenly broke the audience's concentration on the performance by a startling exclamation: 'Unless I'm dreaming, the Persians are here!' (it was evidently a bedroom scene). Turning their heads as one to look up, the spectators saw the Persian arrows pouring down on them, and scattered in all directions. In the sack of the city which followed very many were killed, and nearby places as well as Antioch itself were set on fire and pillaged by the Persians, who met no opposition and left without suffering any harm. Mareades, an Antiochene deserter who had led the Persians to his own city, was burned at the stake (23.5.3). The story of the deserter Mareades (or Cyriades) is variously told in other sources, but two particularly colourful details not recorded elsewhere – the surprising of the people at the theatre and the execution of the traitor – occur in

other Antiochene writers, namely in speeches of Libanius (*Or.* 24.38; 40.2) and an entry in John Malalas (p. 295f.) respectively. The latter adds that Mareades, councillor of Antioch, fled to the Persian through debt – he had embezzled funds entrusted to him for the preparation of racehorses at Antioch – and that his execution was by order of King Sapor I for betraying his own city.⁸⁴

If Ammianus knew of Eunapius' or of Magnus' histories, it can hardly be shown that he depended on either of them for his description of the most obvious feature of the town of Circesium, its situation between the Euphrates and the Khabur. This, and his account of its fortification by Diocletian, which Ammianus shares with Magnus, occur in a context that reflects independent knowledge on Ammianus' part, and in the second case the personal interest of an Antiochene, which leads him to tell a story of essentially local interest, in a form and with a chronology which it does not possess in non-Antiochene sources.

(2) The second passage concerns the capture of the Euphrates fortress of Anatha.⁸⁵ The similarity of expression is here between Ammianus and Eunapius, as he is summarised by Zosimus:

Sending Lucillianus against this fortress with the thousand assault troops under him, (Julian) laid siege to it. As long as it was night, the besiegers were undetected, but when day came they were seen by one of the men in the fortress when he came out to fetch water, and threw into panic those inside (Zosimus 3.14.3)

At the onset of evening, the *comes* Lucillianus was sent by the emperor with a thousand assault troops embarked on ships, to storm the fortification of Anatha, which like many others is surrounded by the waters of the Euphrates. In accordance with instructions, the island was besieged by the vessels, disposed around it in appropriate places, the night mists keeping the assault secret and hidden from view. But when daybreak came, someone coming out to fetch water suddenly saw the enemy and with cries and shouts warned the defenders, roused by the excited din of voices. (Ammianus 24.1.6)

Later, after Julian had received the surrender of Anatha:

he sent the men, with the children and women, under armed guard to territory under Roman control, and gave to their commander Pusaeus the rank of tribune and held him among his friends, having made trial of his loyalty. (Zosimus 3.14.4)

Pusaeus their commander, later *dux* of Egypt, was granted the rank of tribune. The rest meanwhile were treated generously and sent off with their families and household possessions to the city of Chalcis in Syria. (Ammianus 24.1.9)

The additional information provided by Ammianus is not necessarily significant, in that Eunapius may have been abbreviated by Zosimus – though some of Ammianus' details, like the reference to the later rank of *dux Aegypti* held by Pusaeus, the settlement of the inhabitants of Anatha at Chalcis, and the comparison of Anatha with other Euphrates strongholds, are characteristic of him. The discrepancy between the names given to the place by Ammianus and Eunapius has already been explained (p. 165); Eunapius was referring to the settlement on the bank opposite Anatha, Ammianus to the fortress on the island. It is however in the light of this and other discrepancies, suggesting the independence of Ammianus and Eunapius, that the similarities between their narratives of the capture of Anatha must be explained.

The possibility that the Greek Eunapius would have made use of the Latin history of Ammianus, even if their respective dates of publication permitted it, can be disregarded.⁸⁶ What needs to be accounted for, if the similarity of the parallel passages is agreed to require explanation, is Ammianus' use of Eunapius. The explanation is in the nature of the attack on Anatha. The fleet was dispatched ahead of the main army, leaving in the evening from a point four days' easy marching, say 55 miles, below Dura (24.1.6). Sailing with the current of the Euphrates, the ships covered overnight the distance of about 35 miles by the winding route of the river, arriving at Anatha before dawn, while the Roman army (as well as the Persian garrison of Anatha) slept peacefully.⁸⁷ The fortress was surrendered on the same day, and it would be late on the next that the main army would begin to arrive, having since the departure of the fleet marched a distance by land of about 25 miles. Anatha was therefore taken by the fleet and its thousand assault troops a full day before the army reached the place. Unless Ammianus had happened to be a member of the task force under Lucillianus, he could not himself have been in a position to observe its capture. He therefore referred, for this particular purpose, to the account of a writer who was in a position to tell him exactly what had happened. But Ammianus does not leave it at this. Having narrated from this source the capture of Anatha, he reasserted his independence by introducing the aged veteran of the campaign of Galerius, found among the surrendered population of the place. The old man himself told his story ('ut aiebat'), affirming to witnesses ('testibus adfirmans') that he had long predicted his return to Roman soil (24.1.10). It is easy to imagine the interest the old soldier would have attracted in the Roman camp – and to see Ammianus himself among those gathering around to hear what he had to say.

(3) A similar explanation resolves a third similarity between Ammianus and Eunapius, relating in this case to the capture of Diacira:⁸⁸

After some days' marches, he came to Dakira, a city lying on the right to one sailing (down) the Euphrates. Finding it deserted of inhabitants the soldiers seized the large amount of corn stored there and a considerable quantity of salt; and killing the women left behind in the city, they destroyed it so

thoroughly that no one looking at it would believe a city had ever been there. On the opposite bank to that on which the army was travelling was a source emitting asphalt. (Zosimus 3.15.2f.)

From there (Baraxmalcha) the river was crossed and the city of Diacira, lying at a distance of seven miles on, was attacked. The place was empty of inhabitants, but full of corn and pure salt, and in it we saw a shrine of great height, built on the citadel. When this city had been put to the flames and the few women found there killed, passing a bubbling source of bitumen we took possession of Ozogardana (Ammianus 24.2.3)

Diacira stood on the right bank of the Euphrates, opposite the main army as it marched down beside the river. Obviously, not the entire army but only a detachment of it was sent over to reduce an almost unoccupied town. As in the case of Anatha, unless Ammianus were himself in the party sent to reduce the place, he could not know from personal observation what was found at Diacira or happened there. Again, Eunapius offered a practical way of finding out, well-placed through Oribasius' memoir to give an authoritative version of what took place. And again, as in the case of the old soldier found at Anatha, Ammianus seems deliberately to reassert his own standing as a first-hand observer. The attack on Diacira, in which Ammianus did not take part, is described in the third person (*'invaditur'*); the capture of Ozogardana, which lay further down on the left bank of the Euphrates, in the first person (*'occupavimus'*). The lofty shrine at Diacira could be seen from over the river by Ammianus and the main army, as is also noted in the first person (*'in qua templum alti culminis arcu vidimus superpositum'* 24.2.3). In all this, Ammianus distinguishes what he had himself observed and taken part in, from what he owed to others.

(4) The forced crossing of the canal above Pirisabora, which Ammianus knew as the Naarmalcha, was narrated, as we have seen, in quite different terms by the two authors – Ammianus being content with a brief notice, Eunapius giving a lengthy account of the difficulties of the terrain, the Persian opposition, and the Roman manoeuvre used to overcome it. The assault on the fortress of Pirisabora and its capture produce certain similarities which may be thought to show derivation of Ammianus from Eunapius. One in particular is persuasive, the experience of Hormisdas, who advances to the walls at the inhabitants' request to parley but is then rejected with insults:

Sometimes they requested Hormisdas to be sent forward to discuss terms, but then heaped insults on him as a deserter, an exile and a traitor to his country. (Zosimus 3.18.1)

Sometimes, urgently requesting discussions with Hormisdas as a native of the country and of royal family, when he approached they assailed him with insults and reproaches as disloyal and as a deserter. (Ammianus 24.2.11)

In their descriptions of the site of Pirisabora the two sources naturally have much in common. The place was there for all to see and enough time was spent there for an observer to note its obvious and most important features – the double walls and great towers of brick and bitumen, surrounding a high citadel, the watercourse on the northern side offering protection. But there are differences. Eunapius' remark that from half-way up the towers were made of brick and gypsum (rather than bitumen) gives a detail not noted by Ammianus. The watercourse protecting the north side is described by Eunapius as an artificial channel used also for watering the city (Zosimus 3.17.4); Ammianus regards it as part of the Euphrates (24.2.12). The difference was perhaps not clear to one simply looking at the site. The fighting lasted two days according to Eunapius, for Ammianus the best part of three, though the first was largely taken up with the negotiations involving Hormisdas (24.2.12ff.). Eunapius gave a much fuller account of the food supplies and arms taken after the surrender of the place, before the remainder, 'suitable only for the use of Persians' (Zosimus 3.18.6), were burned or thrown into the river. Ammianus is content with a formal note that the Romans burned what was of no use to themselves when they set fire to the town; 'unde necessariis sumptis, reliqua cum loco ipso exussere' (24.2.22). Ammianus differed widely from Eunapius in the number of prisoners taken; 2,500 against Eunapius' 5,000. Both writers remark that the rest of the inhabitants had escaped in boats, but Ammianus, unlike Eunapius, suggests that this had happened in anticipation of the siege and not after its conclusion; 'nam cetera multitudo obsidium ante suspectans ...', (24.2.22). The name of the commander of the garrison, Mamersides in Ammianus, appeared in Eunapius as Momoseiros; this was the man whose relatives were found crucified at Seleucia (24.5.3; cf. above, p. 133).

In his description of the site of Pirisabora, Ammianus, as in other cases, handles his material with greater freedom.⁸⁹ Eunapius began with a formal description of the site in which, as we have just seen, he presented certain details not included by Ammianus. Ammianus' information is deployed more selectively, and as it becomes relevant to his narrative. The only physical detail which he presents at the outset is the protection of the fortress by watercourses, which surrounded it like an island; this is relevant, and sufficient to give the setting for Julian's initial survey of the city (24.2.9). The description of the citadel, and of the construction of its walls in brick and bitumen ('the strongest means of building known') is deferred, to the moment when the defenders abandon the double walls of the outer city for the citadel, which on the northern side fell sharply to the waters of the Euphrates. With the exception of this side, which broke off an arc of the circular rim, the citadel presented the appearance of an Argive shield; 'cuius medietas in sublime consurgens tereti ambitu Argolici scuti speciem ostendebat' (24.2.12). The comparison, appealing to the visual imagination of the reader, is surely also intended to convey Ammianus' personal impression of the site of Pirisabora.

A closer study of the text of Ammianus in relation to that of Eunapius,

even as he is preserved by Zosimus, would no doubt produce more expressions and details in which derivation of Ammianus from Eunapius might be suspected. The purpose of this selective discussion has not been to establish for its own sake the likelihood of Ammianus' use of Eunapius but to suggest more precisely the extent of this use and its implications. These can be quite closely defined. Ammianus used Eunapius' history to gain knowledge of specific circumstances, such as the surrender of Anatha and the capture and sack of Diacira, which he considered essential for his narrative but was unable, for particular reasons, to have witnessed for himself. In other cases, such as the forcing of the canal at Pirisabora and the crossing of the swamps below Phissenia, he took no notice of Eunapius' presentation, even when one would have thought this congenial to him in the evidence which it provided of Julian's character and military abilities. On many occasions when he could have added from Eunapius more precise details of geography and narrative than he himself possessed, he did not do so. Sometimes he seems deliberately to declare his credentials as an independent observer after passages in which Eunapius has been used, and he deploys descriptive and explanatory material more freely and in a manner more integrally linked with his narrative.

We can now with more confidence see some of Ammianus' other details for what they are – the observations of an eye-witness, writing of the campaign of Julian in his own terms and from his own point of view. The stone irrigation sluices, built in the local manner, which caused the Romans' first experience of flooding near Anatha (24.1.11), the old survivor of the campaigns of Galerius discovered in the city (24.1.10), the walls of Macepracta, built in ancient times to protect Assyria from invasion (24.2.6), the engineer killed by a misfiring artillery machine, whose body was so violently shattered that it was unrecognisable, and whose name Ammianus was unable to recover ('cuius nomen non suppetit', 24.4.28) – these and many other passages show Ammianus observing and recording details for himself and using them to add circumstantial colour to his account of the campaign.

A class of details particularly prominent in Ammianus' history has been held back, as expressing that aspect of his writing which most clearly distinguishes him from Eunapius and his other Greek counterparts. It is in his moral and dramatic intention that the true measure of Ammianus' independence of the contemporary Greek tradition appears most clearly. In relation to this, the limited and severely practical use to which Ammianus put Eunapius or any other written source that might be identified or postulated, is an issue of secondary importance in the understanding of his historical purpose.

*

Photius, introducing his summary of Eunapius' history, remarked that the part of it relating to the reign of Julian was more like panegyric than true history.⁹⁰ We can see something of what he had in mind by comparing

Eunapius' account, as it is preserved by Zosimus, with that of a genuine panegyrist, Libanius, in his *Funeral Oration* for Julian (*Or.* 18). The advance of Julian is presented in these versions as a triumphal progress, punctuated only by the reduction of fortresses and cities and the defeat of Persian armies in battle (*Or.* 18.214ff.). Problems such as those experienced in passing over the inundated area south of Phissenia, crucial as they were in the failure of the campaign by delaying Julian's progress and allowing the main army of Sapor to make ground in its approach from the north, could be presented as difficulties, there to be overcome by the emperor's persistence, bravery and ingenuity.

It was above all the failure to force the siege of Ctesiphon, as Ammianus was uneasily aware (p. 158), that left something for the supporters of Julian to explain; and this they signally fail to do. Neither Libanius nor Zosimus offers any convincing explanation of the decision to turn away from the Persian capital, nor acknowledges the change in the prospects of the campaign which it implied. Indeed, Zosimus contrives to record the crossing of the Tigris and subsequent advance northwards without mentioning Ctesiphon at all (3.26.1f.), an omission which it is presumably impossible to attribute already to Eunapius, especially since the latter cited an oracle mentioning Seleucia (*Fr.* 26) and named a place called Abouzatha, presumably north of Ctesiphon, which is not in any other source (Zosimus 3.26.1). The withdrawal from Ctesiphon, presented not as a retreat but as a further advance of indeterminate purpose, is narrated in an atmosphere of continuing but progressively more unreal glory, and Julian's death in battle comes with total unexpectedness and is the sole cause of the failure of the expedition when it was at the brink of success. The aftermath, the agonising march back to northern Mesopotamia and the humiliating surrender of territories under duress by Jovian, is ascribed to the impact of this one accident. At the death of Julian, wrote Libanius, the Persians behaved as if their enemies had been swallowed up by the earth (*Or.* 18.271)!

This interpretation ignores the extreme predicament into which Julian had led his armies, and makes no attempt to allow for the skill and resource with which the Persians had after initial embarrassment recovered their position in opposing Julian's advance and hampering his retreat. Above all, it lacks that sense of the transformation of the mood of the campaign from optimism through ominous uncertainty to sure disaster which is so central to the account of Ammianus.

Ammianus from the beginning regarded the Persian enterprise, in all its ambitious splendour, as doomed to failure, the fates having willed that it should be so (23.5.4). In a presentation full of rhetorical contrivance he develops this conception, marking with heavy and often dramatic emphasis the moments at which the inevitability of failure became ever more apparent.

Ammianus' account of the reign of Julian is laden with signs and portents, which emerge with an ironic persistence from the emperor's own religious piety. His entry to Antioch had coincided with the festival of

mourning for Adonis, the air being full of cries and wailing (22.9.15). Ammianus' first mention of the Persian campaign is accompanied by a reference to Julian's excessive sacrifices (22.12.6) and by his decision to purify and restore the oracle of Apollo at Daphne (22.12.8). The omens become more sinister; the temple of Apollo at Daphne burns down (22.13.1-3), there is a shortage of water, normally plentiful springs running dry, and an earthquake destroys what was left of Nicomedia and part of Nicaea (22.13.4f.).

The catalogue resumes, after a description of Julian's worsening relations with the people of Antioch and a digression on Egypt, provoked by the discovery there of the bull-god Apis (22.14-16). The failed attempt to restore the Temple at Jerusalem is presented as an example of Julian's manifold diligence and energy in the midst of the preparations for the campaign, rather than as possessing in itself a particularly ominous character (23.1.2f.); but the death of the emperor's uncle Julian, following that of the *comes sacrarum largitionum* Felix, gave a sinister meaning to the imperial titulature displayed to the people on placards and inscriptions, 'Felix Iulianus Augustus', suggesting that the emperor would be the next to die. As Ammianus remarked, the outcome was not long delayed (23.1.5). When Julian entered his consulship on New Year's Day 363, an aged priest collapsed and died while ascending the steps of the temple of Genius with Julian and the members of his college. The death of a consul seemed to be portended – but of which: the older, or the senior in power? As it turned out ('ut apparuit'), the latter (23.1.6). There was an earthquake at Constantinople, which inspired expert advice to call off the campaign. The Sibylline Books at Rome were consulted, and warned that the Roman emperor should not leave his domains that year (23.1.7).

Ammianus not only registers the omens; he makes absolutely clear what they portended. As Julian left Antioch for the campaign, his parting threat to the Antiochenes was that when he returned from Persia he would not see them again but would set up his residence at Tarsus in Cilicia; he had written to the governor instructing him to make all appropriate arrangements ('cuncta usui congrua'). And that is what happened, for after Julian's death his body was taken to Tarsus and buried there in accordance with his instructions (23.2.5). After the disaster which occurred at Hierapolis when a portico by the city gate collapsed, killing fifty soldiers passing underneath and injuring others (23.2.6), at Batnae a huge pile of chaff stored there slipped, suffocating fifty of the crowd of attendants who had gone there for fodder. This was a 'woeful portent', wrote Ammianus ('illaetabile portentum', 23.2.7), and after it the emperor left 'sadly' for Carrhae; '*maestus* inde digressus ...' (23.3.1).

At Carrhae, Julian made sacrifice to the Moon, 'who is devoutly worshipped in those parts' (23.3.2), but was disturbed by dreams suggesting some unhappy outcome. As was discovered later, it was on the same night that the temple of Palatine Apollo at Rome caught fire, the

Sibylline Books themselves only being saved by the great numbers of those who came to help (23.3.2f.). At the point of his departure from Carrhae, Julian's horse Babylonius was seized by an attack of gripe as it was led to him and fell, scattering its regalia. The occasion was saved by Julian's presence of mind. 'Babylon has fallen', he pronounced, 'and is stripped of her ornaments' – but he delayed a little before leaving, to confirm by sacrifice that the omen was favourable (23.3.6f.). At Circesium, the letter was received from the praetorian prefect of Gaul, attempting to dissuade Julian from making the campaign. It was in this context that Ammianus offers his most decisive comment on its outcome, that the fates, once decided, cannot be swayed by any human force or virtue (23.5.4),⁹¹ and the army's departure from Circesium was attended by yet another 'woeful portent' ('omen illaetabile'). It passed the corpse of an official executed by order of the praetorian prefect Salutius because the supplies which he had promised had not appeared. The ships carrying them arrived on the following day, when the poor man was already dead; 'miserando homine trucidato advenit, ut ille promiserat, alia classis ...' (23.5.6).

Immediately, Ammianus describes the arrival of the army at Zaitha, near which the tomb of the Emperor Gordian could be seen, and its march from there towards Dura (23.5.7f.). During this stage of the march Julian is brought the body of the huge lion, which seems to portend the death of a king, and the soldier Jovianus is struck by lightning. Both omens provoked dispute between the *haruspices* travelling with the army and the 'philosophers' of Julian's entourage. Ammianus' sympathies are with the *haruspices*, who brought out their ritual books on the different classes of omen and demonstrated that the signs were against the campaign; but their views were 'trodden underfoot' by the philosophers with their objections (23.5.10f., 13f.; p. 126f.).

It may now become clear why Ammianus only at this point introduces the speech of Julian to the army, which was in fact delivered immediately after the crossing of the Khabur.⁹² By holding it back, he has been able to pursue his sequence of omens continuously into the first days of the march into Assyria. In the disputes between the seers and the philosophers, Ammianus has shown not only that the campaign was doomed and that the emperor would die, but that this outcome itself was somehow a consequence of Julian's lack of judgment in listening to the wrong advice – or rather, we might say that his character as shown in this lack of judgment was the vehicle through which the 'fatal order', which had declared itself against the campaign, was expressed. Following these two omens in Ammianus' narrative (but in fact preceding them), Julian's speech to the army, with its air of hesitant optimism, acquires an edge of dramatic irony. In a speech that can be proved to be essentially his own invention, Ammianus has Julian hint at his own death (23.5.19), and the reference in the speech to Gordian's tomb and to his death during a Persian war connects with Ammianus' own reference to the lost books of his history, in which he had told of Gordian's youthful exploits, successful

leadership of armies, and treacherous murder (above, p. 132). For Ammianus, the price of some temporary narrative distortion, made good at the beginning of Book 24 of the history, was a price well worth paying for the dramatic effect which he gained by displacing Julian's speech from its correct position.

The omens, with Ammianus' explicit interpretations, pursue Julian through the failure at Ctesiphon to his death in the skirmish beyond the Tigris. The change in the atmosphere of the campaign, as the attempt on Ctesiphon is abandoned, is marked by the failure of Julian's sacrifice to Mars. The emperor's exclamation that he would never again offer sacrifice to Mars was fulfilled, for his death followed swiftly (24.6.17). His glimpse, of which he told his closest associates, of the figure of his tutelary deity, or Genius, whom he had first seen at the time of his proclamation in Gaul, now creeping sadly away through the imperial quarters, was followed by the appearance to the sleepless emperor of a shooting star. The seers, summoned before dawn in their last appearance in the history and on the morning of Julian's death, warned that nothing must be attempted that day (25.2.7). But this interpretation, and the plea of the *haruspices* for at least a few hours' delay, were alike rejected.

That Eunapius as well as Ammianus said something about the attitude of the gods towards Julian's campaign is implied by Zosimus' remark that as he left Antioch the sacred signs were unfavourable, 'but as to how this was so, though I know I will pass over' (3.12.1).⁹³ Among the Byzantine excerpts attributed to Eunapius is a fine hexameter oracle predicting the emperor's re-union with the gods after subjecting Persia by sword as far as Seleucia.⁹⁴ Yet Ammianus was surely always unique in the sheer weight of emphasis which he devoted to this aspect throughout his narrative of the Persian campaign and in the manner in which he allowed it to dominate his interpretation and to carry its rhetorical articulation. He constantly moves between one level and the other, the divine and the human. The abortive sacrifice to Mars is followed, in Ammianus' narrative, by the conference held to decide whether or not to press the siege of Ctesiphon, a conference overshadowed by the first open mention of the imminent appearance of the army of Sapor; then follow in rapid sequence the burning of the boats, 'as if Bellona herself had applied the torch' (24.7.4), the impact on the Romans of the Persian scorched-earth policy which was to deprive them of food, the book ending with the sighting of the mysterious dust-cloud and the next beginning with the dramatic appearance of the Persian army of Sapor (p. 160). For the reader of Ammianus, his entire narrative has as its counterpoint the premonition of failure, most clearly conveyed in the repeated signs of divine opposition to the campaign, which haunt the departure from Antioch, attend the successful early phases and the critical turning point at Ctesiphon, and escort Julian, the servant of the gods, to his ordained death.

CHAPTER IX

Legitimacy and Usurpation: Jovian to Procopius

Ammianus' account of the retreat from Ctesiphon is compelling in its expression of hardship, intensely conveyed, for it was shared by the author. The reader will also gain an impression of defeat and demoralisation. The army could no longer live off the land, since the Persians destroyed the crops (24.7.7, cf. 25.1.10; 2.1), and it suffered miserably from hunger. It was constantly harried by the Persians, who could attack as they chose, slowing down the Roman retreat and making it extremely difficult to establish secure encampments. The Tigris was in spate and the Romans were unable to make a crossing. There were desertions, and cowardice in the line of battle, which Julian dared not punish with the usual rigour (25.1.7ff.). Ammianus remarks more than once on the Persian unwillingness to take on the Romans in set battles, but they can hardly be blamed for fighting in the manner that best suited them – rapid attacks on exposed parts of the Roman army, and swift withdrawals before effective counter-attacks could be mounted. The Persians held every tactical and strategic advantage, and time was on their side as the physical state of the Roman army declined.

The catastrophe of Julian's death came early in the retreat. The army had broken camp on 16 June, but halted immediately when (as it turned out) the king's army was sighted in the distance, and it was on the morning of 17 June that the Romans got under way, with a foray in which a Roman officer, Machameus, was killed (25.1.2). The army moved slowly, spending two days at a well-stocked place called Hucumbra, and three days in truce after a fierce battle in which Persian losses were heavy (25.1.4-2.1). It was on the night of 25-26 June that Julian, unable to sleep, imagined that he glimpsed the veiled figure of the Genius Publicus 'creeping sadly away' through the tents and, leaving his bed, saw the ominous shooting star interpreted by the seers (25.2.3f.). The departing spirit makes a good story, either told to or invented by Julian's intimates (25.2.3), complementing its appearance before the proclamation at Paris (cf. 20.5.10). Yet a military camp at night will be full of silent, creeping figures who might lend themselves to this construction; Julian was perhaps simply looking at a deserter or, still more humbly, a soldier slipping off to relieve himself away from his tent. As for a shooting star, that is a common and rather beautiful spectacle on a clear night – not

pleasant, however, for an anxious man who believes in the gods and divination, and knows that he is in trouble.

On the next day the army was marching in defensive formation, though not very compactly (it emerges later that it covered four miles of ground). Julian was surveying the way ahead, unarmed, when he was told of an attack on the rear of the army. Grabbing a shield and hastening there (but not thinking to put on a breastplate), he then learned of an attack on the vanguard, where he had just been, and trying typically to be everywhere at once, rushed off there. The Persian onslaught was clearly a calculated effort, for a heavy attack of cataphract troops and elephants was now launched at the middle section of the army. It was repelled by a counter-attack and the Persians turned in retreat. Julian threw himself into the pursuit, shouting and waving his arms to excite his men, but also making himself conspicuous. His bodyguard, now scattered – Ammianus attributes this to fear, but confusion, and the emperor's own indiscipline, are likelier explanations – shouted at him from all sides not to expose himself to such a 'tottering mass' of fugitives, but he ignored them and was struck by a spear loosed from horseback; it grazed his arm, passed through his ribs and lodged in the lower liver. Julian tried to pull it out, but cut through the tendons of his fingers on the sharp edges. Falling from his horse, he was hustled away for medical treatment while the battle continued. Encouraged by an easing of the pain, he demanded weapons and a new horse, but the extent of his wound became apparent to him as his strength failed. He realised his last day had come when he asked what the place was called; its name was 'Phrygia', where, in one of those ambiguous forecasts so beloved of ancient historians, it had been predicted that he would die.¹ The place-name is not much use to the modern historian (it was perhaps not genuine anyway, or at best an approximation of some Aramaic or Persian name). The next location to the north reached by the high command of the army was Sumere, or Samarra (6.4); Julian died about fifty miles north of the site of Baghdad.

The death-bed speech now provided by Ammianus for Julian is in the circumstances one of staggering complacency, or so one would conclude if the reported words were in fact those of the emperor; if Ammianus' own, then they are a vivid illustration of the force of literary convention in a situation of whose gravity the historian was certainly conscious.² Now that the emperor was ready to repay his debt to nature (so Ammianus has him begin) how could he not prefer the better condition to the worse, given the universal belief of philosophers that the spirit is more blessed than the body? Death, he observed, was sometimes given by the gods as a supreme reward to the pious. He repented of nothing he had done, either in his years of obscurity or after he had become emperor. In civil affairs he had sought moderation, in military aggression or defence the most rational course of action (this is certainly not a full account of his motives in the Persian campaign, as Ammianus himself presents them); granted, the success and utility of his projects had not always run hand in hand, the ultimate outcome of human ventures lying always with the gods (as if

it were not also an emperor's duty to match utility with the prospects of success). He would not hide it from his listeners that he had long ago learned by prophecy that he would die by the sword (so he should have been more careful about the breastplate). He thanked God that he had not succumbed to conspiracy, long disease or the death of a condemned man, but was departing in the midst of his glory, a noble exit; and he had not done the cowardly thing of wishing for death when times were hard, or shrinking from it when the right moment came (it is hard to think of a less opportune moment except, from Julian's point of view though of little consolation to the army, that his glory was palpably coming to an end in the chaos that now surrounded him). More he would not say, as his strength was failing; as for a successor, he would recommend no one, for fear of passing over a worthy man or, in nominating one, exposing him to mortal danger if another were preferred. So justifying his neglect of an obvious contingency, he made certain dispositions of a personal nature, asked for Anatolius the *magister officiorum* and wept when told that he was dead. He then fell to discussing with the philosophers Maximus and Priscus certain matters pertaining to the sublimity of souls, but was seized by an aggravation of his wound. Feverish and gasping for breath, he asked for a drink of water and died at about midnight. It is an eloquent but astonishingly unreal scene, and an effort to recall the actual circumstances – a tent in the desert, an army not only grieving (when it heard the news) but thirsty, hungry, desperate for escape from the dreadful situation into which its emperor had led it.

Ammianus' is by far the fullest account of the death of Julian that we possess.³ He wrote from a personal acquaintance with the circumstances, and had clearly made himself well informed on many of the more intimate details. He told how Julian was carried from the field for medical attention, how the spear, wielded from horseback, drove down through the ribs into his liver, and he gave an adequate account of the development of Julian's condition. It is however in the medical aspects of the situation that we might expect Eunapius to have been particularly well informed, because of his access to the personal material collected by Oribasius. The influence of Oribasius has been detected in one most striking detail, preserved in a fifth-century writer who can be shown to have used Eunapius, the ecclesiastical historian Philostorgius (p. 101 Bidez). When the spear that killed Julian was pulled out, explains Philostorgius in a nice point of medical observation, the flow of blood drawn from the wound was accompanied by 'kopros', or faeces. A specific point of vocabulary in Philostorgius surely also derives from Oribasius, when he reports that the spear drove down into the emperor's 'peritonaion'. This, in its Latin form 'peritoneum', is the modern term for the membrane which lines the abdominal cavity.

Eunapius also preserved more precise information than Ammianus in the matter of the identity of the man who killed Julian. Ammianus specifically says in narrating the episode that the source of the fatal spear was not known – 'incertum <unde>, subita equestris hasta ...' (25.3.6)⁴ –

but he later has Persians taunting the Romans with having killed their own emperor, having heard from deserters that Julian had fallen to a Roman weapon (25.6.5). This version appealed also to ideological supporters of Julian such as Libanius, who wished to impute their hero's death to treachery by a Christian Roman (*Or.* 18.274). According to Philostorgius, however, Julian's assailant was a Saracen spearman on the Persian side, who having struck Julian was himself pursued and killed. Indeed, Libanius himself in a later speech identifies Julian's killer as a 'Taienos', that is a Tayy Arab – what Ammianus would call a Saracen – instructed by the Persians to kill the emperor (*Or.* 24.6). Ammianus remarks on Saracens fighting with the Persians during this phase of the campaign; they preferred this service to the Roman because, in another triumph of tact and commonsense, they had been told that Julian, a warlike emperor, possessed no gold, but only iron (25.6.10). A Bedouin horseman fighting with the Persians, immediately slain in the battle: so much for Libanius' earlier argument that Julian's killer must have been a Roman, because no Persian had ever come forward to claim the reward offered by Sapor in a proclamation (*Or.* 18.274)!

*

The succession crisis following Julian's death shows the late Roman decision-making process at its most accident-prone – though to be fair, nothing like it had happened for a very long time; the dynasty of Constantine had been founded long before most of those present were born, and one had to go well before that to find a real parallel. The generals met (on 28 June) with the commanders of infantry and cavalry units and were divided, some looking for a good candidate from the survivors of the regime of Constantius, others for someone from the Gallic army establishment (25.5.2). In the deadlock they turned unanimously to Julian's praetorian prefect Salustius Secundus, but he demurred, pleading old age and ill-health. It was not a good moment at which to become philosopher-emperor and Salustius' reluctance, which has been variously interpreted, is not hard to understand.⁵ At this point an unnamed soldier of some distinction ('*honoratior aliquis miles*') asked the generals, and Salustius in particular, what they would have done if, as sometimes happened, the emperor had committed the war to them in absence? Would they not put all other considerations aside in order to get the army out of its predicament? Then, if they ever saw Roman territory again, an emperor could be chosen by the united suffrage of armies of east and west; '*utriusque exercitus consociata suffragia legitimum principem declarabunt*' (25.5.3).

It is a schematic, but not necessarily an unrealistic, presentation of the course of the meeting. As to the identity of the '*honoratior aliquis miles*', Gibbon suspected that this was Ammianus himself, discreetly indicating his own presence (and good judgment) in the situation.⁶ But this seems unlikely. At no other point in his narrative does Ammianus stand in such

close relation to the central command of the campaign. He writes as an alert observer rather than an active contributor at this level, recording no personal exploit of his own from beginning to end of the campaign. It seems more probable that the 'honoratior miles' is to be envisaged as a respected soldier of long service putting forward the soldiers' point of view to the council: get out of Assyria, then think about an emperor, and do not waste time now in partisan argument and professions of reluctance. In fact, despite its appearance of practical sense it is not a particularly realistic point of view. Historical experience would show that it was very hard to prevent emperors being made in these circumstances, in fact difficult to control the situation at all; and wise heads surely knew that an agreement with Sapor would have to be made, and that nothing less than an emperor would be able to make it. The Persian king would wish to be sure that any peace agreement made with the Romans would be honoured.

It was all futile. The discussions had not taken long, says Ammianus, considering the importance of the matter, when somewhere else in the army a candidate was put up, clothed in the imperial purple and shown to the army. It was Iovianus, first in rank of the *domestici*, and son of Varronianus, a well-known general who had recently retired. Jovian was, says Ammianus, 'paternis meritis mediocriter commendabilis' (25.5.4), an expression one can ponder for hours without knowing whether the 'mediocrity' is to be understood primarily of the son or the father. The point is that Jovian was a familiar figure; his father well-known to the army, Jovian's accelerated promotion in the *domestici* had kept him in the public eye and near the emperor. More particularly, he had escorted the remains of the dead Constantius for burial at Constantinople, the sort of honorific duty that would tend to draw attention to a man, and for which one would need to look the part. Jovian was young, affable and vigorous, and nothing was known against him except that he liked food, drink and sex – all of which emerges shortly in his obituary notice in Ammianus, together with the remark that he might have corrected these shortcomings, had he lived, out of respect for the imperial office (26.10.15). Ammianus writes of the proclamation of Jovian as 'disorderly' ('tumultuantibus paucis', 25.5.4), and has a deserter who feared Jovian's enmity tell Sapor that it was accomplished by a mutiny of camp attendants ('turbine calorum concitato', 25.5.8); but it is hard to see how he can have known of allegations made to the Persian king. It is more reasonable to suppose that the proclamation was plotted by relatively junior officers excluded from the generals' deliberations. The army was about to move, something had to be done, and Jovian was produced; 'subitoque productus e tabernaculo per agmina iam discurrebat proficisci parantia' (25.5.5).

The reign got off to an unfortunate start when the name 'Iovianus', acclaimed back in the army, was misheard by those in front as 'Iulianus' – the difference, as Ammianus remarked, only amounted to a single letter, 'o' being for these purposes equated with 'u' – but they were quickly

disabused when they saw approaching an immensely tall, stooping figure in no way to be confused with Julian. The death of Julian made no difference to the sacrifices now made and omens sought; and when these urged an immediate start and not the delay envisaged by Jovian, the new emperor, though a Christian, concurred.

The army was soon under way, harried as usual by the Persians. On the approach to Samarra was discovered the body of the *magister officiorum* Anatolius, killed in the same battle as that in which Julian had been fatally wounded, and from which the prefect Salutius had narrowly escaped with his life (25.3.14). The passage gives a rare indication of Ammianus' own deployment in the army, for in the same place, he writes, 'we received' ('recepimus') sixty soldiers and some officials who had taken refuge from the battle in a fortification called 'Vaccatum' (25.6.4; 3.14). Ammianus was thus with the part of the army that now approached Samarra, at which a battle had already been fought by the vanguard; it is painfully slow progress in which an army cannot cover the extent of its own deployment in a day's march. On the next day they came to Charcha, then (on 1 July) a place named Dura, where the Romans were unable to move for three days through constant harassment from Persians and their Saracen allies (25.6.10). The soldiers were desperate and, misled by a rumour that the Roman frontiers were now not far away, clamoured to be allowed to cross the Tigris. Some Germans and Gauls, familiar from childhood with strong north European rivers, were chosen to swim across at night, and managed to get to the opposite bank. The army in general, frantic to make the crossing, was restrained by the promises of engineers to construct floating bridges supported on bladders, a forlorn project to which they now devoted their efforts while the army waited (25.6.11-7.1). The river was too fast, there was a lack of materials for the operation, and two more days were spent in miseries of hunger (25.7.4).

Having so vividly portrayed Roman misfortunes, Ammianus now tries, unconvincingly, to show Sapor as equally troubled, reflecting on his losses in men and beasts, the determination of the Romans and their desire for revenge rather than safety (this directly contradicts what has just been said about their desperation to cross the river); considering also the ease with which a new army could be summoned from the Roman provinces by a simple command for mobilisation, and the fact (which Sapor is presented as 'discovering') that another army was left in Mesopotamia, hardly smaller than the one that faced him now; while five hundred men had safely crossed the Tigris, killing its defenders and inspiring their colleagues to like exploits.

Only by such misrepresentation of Sapor's position can Ammianus justify his view that what happened next showed the favour of heaven for the Roman side; 'erat tamen pro nobis aeternum dei caelestis numen' (25.7.5). Against all expectation the Persians were the first to sue for peace, but Ammianus' assertion that they too were despondent in view of the growing Roman supremacy in battle is belied by the terms they offered, 'difficiles et perplexas' as he describes them. In the name of

humanity, said the envoys, their most clement king was prepared to let the Romans return to their own territory, if Caesar and his associates would comply with his demands. The praetorian prefect Salutius and the *magister militum* Arinthaëus were sent to consider the terms, and in the four days then spent in negotiations, the Roman army suffered further torments of hunger (25.7.7).

In Ammianus' opinion, the emperor could have taken advantage of the time wasted before the Roman envoys were sent (this must mean while the attempts were being made to construct the bridges), to extricate the army gradually from Persia to the safety of Corduene, which Ammianus alleged to be only a hundred miles from where they now were. It is true that every day that passed was to the Persians' advantage, but the argument does not show Ammianus at his most persuasive.⁷ The true distance to Corduene was nearer two than one hundred miles, and Ammianus had made it clear how the Persians could at will prevent the Roman retreat by the lightning tactics at which they were adept, in one case for four whole days. On that occasion the rumour that the Roman frontiers were not far away is described as a fiction welcome to men in desperate fear, and the army had hardly moved at all since then (25.6.11). Further, a dash for Corduene was hardly consistent with the physical condition of soldiers whose sufferings from hunger Ammianus repeats like an incantation; 'attenuata rerum omnium copia, herbis frumentisque crematis...' (25.1.10); 'commeatibus nos destitutos inedia cruciabat iam non ferenda' (25.2.1); 'furebat inedia iraque percitus miles, ferro properans quam fame, ignavissimo genere mortis, absumi' (25.6.4); 'dies quattuor sunt evoluti inedia cruciabiles et omni supplicio tristiores' (25.6.7); and, even after the signing of the peace treaty with Sapor, '... multorum, qui fame ad usque spiritum lacerati postremum' (25.8.1) – and so on, for the army's sufferings did not stop when, by agreement with the Persians, it had crossed the Tigris and marched unharassed. The seventy-mile march from the derelict desert city of Hatra towards the Roman frontiers was devoid of fresh water, and no edible vegetation was found; the army survived on the water taken from Hatra and was reduced to eating slaughtered camels and pack-animals (25.8.6). At a Persian site called Ur the *dux* of Mesopotamia and a tribune met the army with what was left of the food stockpiled for the force led by Procopius and Sebastianus (25.8.7), but this did not last for long. Soon a single *modius* of barley, if it happened to be found, might be sold for ten gold pieces at least – a rhetorical exaggeration no doubt, but effective, for it happens to be a hundred times the famine price of wheat (not barley) recorded elsewhere by Ammianus (25.8.15; cf. 28.1.18).⁸ The situation was not relieved until the army reached the city of Nisibis, a longed-for sight; 'Nisibi cupide visa' (25.8.17).

There is no need to revert now to the terms and conditions laid down for the Romans' safe departure from Assyria; the surrender of the five Transtigritane satrapies, with fifteen Roman *castella* and Nisibis, Singara and castra Maurorum (25.7.9). Ammianus presents Jovian as

inspired by his fear of a proclamation by Procopius to agree without delay to Sapor's demands; yet Procopius turned up loyally to meet the emperor south of Nisibis (25.8.16), and Ammianus inconsistently remarks that Jovian's envoys achieved it as a 'difficult' concession that Nisibis and Singara be evacuated before they were handed over, and that the garrisons of the surrendered forts be permitted to return to Roman territory rather than become Persian prisoners (25.5.7, 11). The negotiations took four days to complete, during which the Roman army suffered extremes of hunger; it was hardly then a case of 'hasty' capitulation on Jovian's part.

Ammianus' final judgment on the peace treaty of Jovian is to question whether in the entire recorded history of Rome territory had ever been surrendered to an enemy by an 'imperator' or consul. Further, on occasions agreements made in humiliating circumstances had been disowned, even after oaths were exchanged, and war renewed (25.9.9f.). On the first point, it is no doubt pedantic to note Aurelian's abandonment of Dacia in the 270s, and various other occasions on which less significant territories, such as the 'Agri Decumates' beyond the Rhine⁹ (p. 308), had been given up and never recovered by Rome. Tacit abandonment is not the same as deliberate surrender. On the second point as on the first, Ammianus' examples are taken from ancient Republican days, when agreements reached by commanders in the field might be disavowed by a senate that was the ultimate arbiter of the making and breaking of war and treaties. Present circumstances were very different. What did Ammianus really suppose should happen when the emperor himself was the commander in the field, and had left it with a thirty-year treaty of peace which only he, and no longer the senate, was competent to make? His implied suggestion is not only in principle (as is obvious) but also in practical terms most questionable.

*

Little more need be said of the short reign of Jovian, except to note the procedures undertaken to secure his position in the Roman empire at large. He had already, from Ur in Mesopotamia, sent agents to Gaul and Illyricum to inform those regions of the death of Julian and his own accession. They were to travel night and day, wherever they went spreading the rumour that the Persian campaign had ended successfully. They were also to deliver into the hands of military commanders and civil governors letters from the new emperor, and to convey back swiftly both their replies and what could be divined of their true sentiments (25.8.12). At Sirmium they were to find Jovian's father-in-law Lucillianus, a military officer also (like Jovian's father) now in retirement, give him letters of promotion as *magister equitum et peditum* and ask him to go to Milan and settle matters there.¹⁰ Lucillianus did so, taking with him two tribunes, Seniauchus and Valentinianus; the second of these was also at leisure in Illyricum, having earlier been relieved of his duties in Gaul by

Julian (16.11.7). From there they made haste to Rheims to secure the Gallic army; Malarichus, offered the insignia of *magister militum* in Gaul, had declined that office, which remained in the hands of Jovinus, a distinguished general whom Jovian (if Ammianus is to be believed) would have preferred out of the way (25.8.11).

At Rheims a junior financial official for reasons of his own went to the army alleging that Julian was still alive and that this was rebellion against him, and Lucillianus and Seniauchus were killed in a military demonstration in Julian's favour. Valentinian was protected by an old friend, named Primitivus (25.10.7). The truth soon emerged, however, and Jovinus sent elite soldiers to Jovian to declare the allegiance of the Gallic army to his regime. Jovian received the delegation at Aspuna in Galatia, rewarded its members and sent them back to their service in Gaul. His general Arintheus went there also, with instructions to confirm Jovinus in his office, arrest the authors of the sedition at Rheims and send them to the imperial court. Valentinian was made commander of the second Schola Scutariorum, went on with Jovian to Ancyra and remained there while the emperor continued his journey towards Constantinople, with instructions to follow later (26.1.5). He was no doubt glad of this unexpected opportunity to resume his interrupted career.

Jovian entered the consulship at Ancyra with due ceremony, marred ominously by the screaming refusal of his colleague, his little son Varronianus, to be conveyed on the curule chair (25.10.11). The emperor proceeded to Dadastana on the borders of Galatia and Phrygia, had a good dinner, went to bed, and was found dead during the night. As to the cause of death, no enquiry was made. Over-indulgence, for which Jovian was well known, was thought possible, alternatively poisonous fumes filling the room in which he slept, which had been newly plastered (25.10.13). The likeliest explanation is carbon monoxide poisoning caused by fumes from a charcoal brazier; Julian had once nearly met a similar fate at Paris (*Misopogon*, pp. 340D-342A).¹¹ One must feel sympathy for the citizens of Dadastana, whose efforts to dine their emperor and to prepare elegant lodgings at such short notice (the freshly plastered room) had issued in such disaster. Rarely can the excitement of an imperial 'adventus' have collapsed with quite such awful finality.

Ceremony of another sort followed: of mourning while the body was prepared, to be escorted this time to Constantinople for burial, 'inter Augustorum reliquias' (26.1.3). And again the high civil and military officials met to choose a suitable candidate; 'moderatores quaeritabant diu exploratum et gravem'. Some had hopes for themselves – which, given the recent history of the imperial office, must be seen as a tribute to human optimism as well as ambition. The process did not take long. The name of Aequitius, tribune of the first Schola Scutariorum, was hesitantly mentioned but turned down by the more influential of those present because of his abrasive and uncultivated character, an interesting point of discrimination; 'displicuisset ut asper et subagrestis' (26.1.4). Some support went to a relative of Jovian, Januarius, but he was

rejected as too far away (he was military commander in Illyricum). Preference then fell, with no dissentient voice, upon Valentinian.¹² One can understand why. He was the right age and his recent activities had made him known and given some indication of his resource and capacity for survival (he might easily have been lurking in unseen retirement in Illyricum, or at the other extreme of fortune have been killed in Gaul). Valentinian was at Ancyra commanding the second *Schola Scutariorum*, and while he was fetched Aequitius and a Pannonian colleague named Leo took measures to ensure that the army would not bid for a candidate of its own from among those present; this was a precaution conspicuously neglected at the time of the proclamation of Jovian. For ten days the Roman world was without an emperor, as was divined at the time by the *haruspex* Marcus, consulting the entrails at Rome (26.1.5).

Valentinian arrived at Nicaea on the eve of the 'bissextile day' of February, an intercalated day believed to bring bad luck, and he refused to appear in public until it had passed. Ammianus cleverly reproduces the delay in his text by inserting a careful account of the origin and vicissitudes of the bissextile day, ending after centuries of arbitration by priests with its regularisation by Augustus, following the calculations of Greeks; so, Ammianus concludes rather incongruously in the circumstances (except that in doing so he reminds us again of Rome and of the gods), 'with the help of the divinity, eternal Rome, which will live with the centuries', established the principles of calculation' (26.1.14). The next day Valentinian was presented to the army. Ascending the tribunal in full imperial regalia with a prepared speech, he was greeted with murmurs of discontent, the soldiers agitating for the appointment of a second emperor. The unrest grew, inspired, some thought, by the bribery of overlooked candidates but more likely the result of genuine anxiety in the army, fostered by recent events. Valentinian seized the occasion and after an address of unexpected authority was escorted to his quarters already secure in his position; 'ambitiose stipatum iamque terribilem' (26.2.11). He did however concede the need for a colleague to be appointed.

As to who the colleague should be, Valentinian again called together the senior statesmen and asked them their opinion. No one spoke – an ominous silence, since everyone knew that Valentinian had a younger brother in the army. The general Dagalaifus broke it, no doubt speaking for all when he told Valentinian that 'if he loved his own, he had a brother; if the *res publica*, he should look around for someone to clothe in the purple' (26.4.1). Valentinian was annoyed but kept his counsel, and after the army had entered Nicomedia, on 1 March he appointed Valens to the rank of *tribunus stabuli*; was this to ease the transition to empire, or did Valentinian still wish to delay, while keeping his options open? He continued to ponder, or to give the appearance of it until, on 28 March, after his arrival at Constantinople, he pronounced Valens Augustus at the military suburb of Hebdomon and, in a time-honoured gesture (Constantius had done it for Julian), took him up into his carriage as his colleague.

The emperors must have made a curious pair, if one had seen them at close quarters; Valentinian tall and well-built, healthy, clear-eyed and forbidding in expression, Valens dark, sluggish in movement, slightly pot-bellied and with bow-legs. This however is how Ammianus described Valens' appearance fourteen years later at the time of his death (31.14.7); advancing middle age does not lend majesty to everyone, and Valens perhaps looked better at thirty-six than at fifty. Though not personally distinguished, he would not necessarily make a bad emperor. The trouble with choosing the 'best man', as Valentinian realised, was that it left too many disappointed candidates; the advantage with brothers is that no one can question that this is what they are. No one challenged the elevation of Valens, nor doubted his submissiveness to the superior authority of Valentinian.

The emperors spent the summer quietly, except for a feverish illness affecting them both and for a time bringing the supporters of Julian under suspicion; and towards the end of the year they went together to the imperial residence of Mediana just outside Naissus (26.5.1). There they split the empire, distributing generals, army and palace staff between them – Ammianus referring in very exact terms to the categories of the division; 'partiti sunt comites ... et militares partiti sunt numeri ... diviso palatio' (26.5.1-4). This was all done according to the wishes of Valentinian, who chose the west and went to Milan to hold the consulship of 365 while Valens went to Constantinople as his colleague (26.5.2ff.). Of the generals claimed by Valentinian the most important for future events was Aequitius as *comes* of Illyricum.

The division of the empire is rather succinctly described by Ammianus, and it is easy not to appreciate what a significant undertaking it was. Traces of the division of the 'comitatensian' or 'field' army can still be detected in the *Notitia Dignitatum*, which lists the units of this army as they were after a further generation's often turbulent use. Existing units were divided in two, the new formations, which were no doubt intended to be brought up to regular strength by intensive recruitment, bearing the titles 'seniores' and 'iuniores' associated respectively with Valentinian in the west and with Valens in the east. A mark of the division appears almost immediately in Ammianus. Among the units acquired by Procopius at the outset of his rebellion of 365 were the 'Divitenses Tungrecanique Iuniores' (26.6.12; the term 'Iuniores' is to be understood of both units). Sent by Valens to meet an anticipated Gothic invasion in Thrace, they were intercepted and used by Procopius in his proclamation. Their counterparts, the Divitenses and Tungrecani Seniores, take part in Valentinian's early Alamannic campaigns, contemporaneous with the rebellion of Procopius (27.1.2), and in the early fifth century are listed, still together and now serving in Italy under the command of the *magister peditum*, in the western *Notitia*.¹³ The Divitenses and Tungrecani Iuniores are nowhere to be found, in eastern or in western *Notitia*. They had either been disbanded for treason by Valens, or else were among those units annihilated at the battle of Hadrianople. The year 395 is often

taken as that in which the Roman empire was divided into eastern and western 'partes', leading to the separate and divergent developments of each in the post-Roman period. In the closer perspective of the late empire itself, the division of 364 was quite as significant.

*

From the death of Julian until the accession of Valentinian and Valens less than a year later, Ammianus has twice described, with much circumstantial detail, the transfer and establishment of imperial power in the late Roman world. He says much about the legitimacy of power, the diffusion of information and rumour, the control and deception of public opinion that attended the transfer of power, about political ambition and the workings of chance. The modern historian of Ammianus' time has nothing remotely comparable at his disposal. And it is not yet over, for even before Valentinian had settled down to the wars against the Alamanni to which he had elected to give his attention, and before Valens had left Asia Minor for the eastern frontier, rebellion had broken out at Constantinople. The usurpation of Procopius repays attention, not only as a most elegantly constructed narrative but as a commentary on imperial power no less telling than the legitimate accessions described so far.¹⁴

To begin as Ammianus does with the individual, Procopius was an introverted, taciturn man, gloomy in manner and strict, not to say repressed, in his personal behaviour. Though not marked by any particular disability, he would probably not have advanced far in the imperial government, if he had not been connected with the imperial family. But as he was so connected, he rose high in the ranks of *tribuni et notarii*. He took part in Constantius' second embassy of 358 to Persia (Ammianus has him responsible for the famous coded message in the sword scabbard sent to Ursicinus), and under Julian was at the rank of *comes* put in joint command of the troops sent to the northern sector of the Mesopotamian frontier during the Persian campaign (above, p. 138). The rendezvous which they were supposed to effect with the main army of Julian failed, however, and Procopius and his colleague managed only to meet the Roman army, now the army of Jovian, on its return across the desert (p. 186f.). Procopius was given the duty of escorting the body of Julian for burial at Tarsus, after which he may have reported back to Jovian and then retired to his family estates in the territory of Cappadocian Caesarea. This at least is the version of Zosimus, derived from Eunapius, but Ammianus makes Procopius go immediately into hiding without returning to Jovian, for fear that he was being hunted down by the new emperor; 'nec inveniri usquam potuit studio quaesitus ingenti' (25.9.13). There is every reason to believe Ammianus' account rather than that of Eunapius.¹⁵ A dangerous rumour was abroad that Julian had named Procopius for the succession (despite Ammianus' explicit assertion that Julian had made no such nomination), a rumour

that will scarcely have been quieted by his selection for the ceremonious duty of escorting the remains of the dead emperor for burial. Jovian had himself as *primicerius domesticorum* performed the same duty for the remains of Constantius, and he was now emperor; these duties tended to put one in the public eye. Procopius had also heard (who had not?) of the fate of another Jovianus, a hero of the storming of 'Maiozamalcha'; behaving with foolish indiscretion after the death of Julian, he had been escorted from dinner in the camp at Nisibis, hurled down a well and buried with stones (25.8.18). There was clearly much to be said for not being in the public eye.

Ammianus' description of the usurpation of Procopius is a minor masterpiece of construction, falling into several stages which are well represented by the modern chapter divisions of his text. The first phase, discussed in more detail below, introduces Procopius and narrates the earliest stages of his rise and proclamation (26.6). The second explains the manoeuvres by which Procopius established a civil and military regime and the initial response of Valens – both sides acting with a hesitancy and confusion quite understandable in the circumstances (26.7). Next (26.8) is a phase of success for Procopius as he secured Bithynia, Pontus and the Hellespont and began to extend his control into Asia. In an act of rash over-confidence, Procopius offended the retired general Arbetio, who was provoked to lend his authority to the cause of Valens; and by the spring of 366 Valens, having organised his response with effective support from the commanders of the east and of Illyricum, overcame Procopius, whose supporters handed him over for execution to Valens near Nacolia in Phrygia (26.9). Then are narrated the subsidiary proclamation of Marcellus and its prompt suppression by Aequitius, commander in Illyricum, followed by a description of, and reflections on, the judicial enquiries that were the natural sequel to the civil war. The book actually ends (27.10.15f.) with a description of the earthquake and tidal wave of 365 and the destruction wrought by them. The effect, surely deliberate, is to suggest a counterpart in the natural elements to the political turmoil among humans, and Ammianus is able to make Book 26, after its frantic activity and transfers of power, close quietly with his own role in later years as observer of the ship cast two miles inland by the tidal wave at Mothone in Laconia. 'Ut nos transeundo conspeximus' (26.10.19); it is like the signature on a painting.¹⁶

Ammianus has created a dramatic structure of classic type from the historical circumstances of the rebellion of Procopius. What is remarkable is the manner in which he has been able to convey this effect by artful deployment of the factual material available to him. This is particularly evident in the first of the phases mentioned above, describing the earlier career of Procopius, his disappearance after the accession of Jovian, and his proclamation at Constantinople. Ammianus begins with Procopius' background and earlier career, explaining how after Julian's death he came to be suspected and sought by the new emperor. He therefore goes into hiding, suffering hunger, squalor, and a life without

human contact (and so, if this is taken literally, beyond the reach of authentic evidence as to his activities), until he decides to seek refuge with an old friend living at Chalcedon. From there he begins to make visits to Constantinople. Ammianus' claim that Procopius' unshaven face and emaciated look made him physically unrecognisable (like a spy) involves an element of romance, for his friend was a former soldier, now a senator of Constantinople, who could no doubt afford to look after his friend; but the fact of the visits to the capital was beyond doubt, for it was established, as Ammianus specifically notes, in the enquiries that followed his fall (26.6.5). The statement that Procopius used the visits to gather rumours of discontent about Valens, though of its nature beyond specific documentation, provides a link between Procopius' movements bringing him to Constantinople incognito, and a digression on the state of opinion there, particularly hostile to Valens' father-in-law Petronius, a military officer suddenly raised to patrician rank. Petronius' eagerness to raise money led him to search out debts as far back as the reign of Aurelian, and to torture, and to fine quadruple, men who owed tax or were claimed to owe it (26.6.7). Ammianus is careful to cover all sectors of opinion in his description of the complaints; rich and poor houses alike were closed, both provincials and military men were afraid of worse to come, and there was a widespread wish, at present whispered only darkly, for change, 'with the help of the Supreme Power' (26.6.9). Ammianus admits some literary embellishment to his picture, in the form of comparisons of Petronius with the prefects Cleander and Plautianus under their emperors Commodus and Septimius Severus, but he guides the digression firmly back to Procopius with the reminder that he observed all these things from his hiding-place; 'quae Procopius latenter accipiens ...' (26.6.10). Narrative and explanatory digression, drawn together into a connected whole; it is a beautifully ingenious piece of writing that stays strictly within the bounds of authentic history.

For the time being Procopius lay low, 'like a beast of prey waiting to leap on its victim' (26.6.10), but the opportunity for action soon arose. It is an opportunity also for Ammianus to broaden his narrative, which he does by recalling Valens' departure from Constantinople for the east at the end of the previous winter (26.6.11). On the journey Valens was informed of a Gothic threat to the Danube frontier, and dispatched part of his army to meet it. It was these troops, the Divitenses and Tungrecani Iuniores, that were solicited by Procopius as they passed through Constantinople, spending two days there in the usual fashion; they were billeted in the Anastasian Baths, named after a sister of Constantine (26.6.12, 14). We have already seen how up to date is Ammianus' designation of these units (p. 190). Their arrival at Constantinople not only provides Procopius with the opportunity to initiate his usurpation, but from the point of view of Ammianus' narrative links the pretender with the wider military situation.

Procopius' elevation by these troops is described in terms designed to emphasise the ill-fated nature of the enterprise; it is characterised as a

ridiculous piece of burlesque, as Procopius is dragged to the tribunal pale-faced and trembling, clothed in a parody of the imperial vestments and looking more like a slave apprentice than an emperor (p. 236f.). In portentous language derived from a well-known passage of Sallust, Ammianus drives home the absurdity of the occasion, and piles on dramatic colouring to emphasise its doomed outcome.¹⁷ Procopius is presented as a 'disturber of public tranquillity' ('quietis publicae turbatorem'), although this can scarcely have been evident, as Ammianus claims it to have been, at the time of his promotion to the rank of *comes* by Julian; his withdrawn temperament, as there described, does not make Procopius look like a potential usurper (26.6.1). His proclamation is a hollow image of the real thing, Procopius trembling with fear on a platform to which he had been taken by his soldiers as if he were their captive; 'in modum obsessi' (26.6.14). As they escorted Procopius through the narrow streets, the soldiers protected him by holding their shields over his head to ward off stones and tiles that they feared might be hurled down at them from roof-tops. As they did so, their shields clashed together 'mournfully'; 'horrenti fragore scutorum lugubre concrepantium' (26.6.16). Ammianus surely means us to recall his descriptions of how soldiers expressed their sentiments in parade-ground demonstrations. They declared their support for the elevation of Julian as Caesar by clashing their shields against their armour, 'horrendo fragore' (15.8.15). They greeted Julian's speech on the occasion of his proclamation as Augustus by fiercely clashing spears against their shields, 'hastis feriendo clipeos sonitu adsurgens ingenti' (20.5.8), and another speech of Julian, as he set out against Constantius, was received by the soldiers 'immani scutorum fragore' (21.5.9). In their efforts to protect their leader from physical harm, Procopius' soldiers unwittingly produced, as it were, an ominous variant of these noisy demonstrations: '*lugubre concrepantium*'.

The people's reaction to Procopius' appearance was indifferent, in so far as they were not motivated by a normal desire among common folk for novelty and change – together with dislike of Petronius, of whom Ammianus adds an effective reminder at this point (26.6.17). The usurper's words are heard in an 'unhappy silence' ('silentium triste'), though one might wonder whether the silence was not simply attentive, and the acclamations in his favour begin hesitantly, led by men bribed for the purpose (26.6.18). Acclamations were normally initiated by cheer-leaders, and Ammianus is unlikely to have had specific information that they had been paid by Procopius, however safe it was to assume it. Procopius then enters the senate, which is described as being ill-attended, and only by men of inferior distinction, no '*clarissimi*' being present. The proclamation, arranged at overnight meetings among the military officers concerned, was early in the day and not expected by anyone; Procopius could not expect both the element of surprise and a crowded senate waiting to greet him. He then hurriedly entered the imperial palace 'with ill-omened footsteps'; '*palatium pessimo pede*

festinatis passibus introiit' (26.6.18). The date, we happen to know from another source, was 28 September 365.¹⁸ Ammianus concludes the section with historical parallels, for the benefit of those who could not believe that events so ridiculous and embarked upon so incautiously could produce such woeful disasters to the state; '*irrisione digna principia incaute coepta et temere, ad ingemiscendas erupisse rei publicae clades*' (26.6.19).

For all its rhetorical colour, so cleverly worked into the texture of his narrative, Ammianus' account of the rebellion is as it progresses a model of exact historical analysis. He exposes the 'anatomy' of power, seen in its civil and military, its strategic, financial and geographical dimensions, and with a considerable and most interesting attention to the modes and limitations of communications between individuals and bodies of men, and between different regions of the empire. This last emphasis is not surprising, if we recall some of Ammianus' own experiences as a serving officer under Constantius. At times, orders given in the best of faith by a distant authority could seem incomprehensible to recipients closer to the field of operations (p. 41).

After his proclamation, Procopius set about the selection of a civil and military administration, choosing first a prefect of Constantinople, a *magister officiorum* and a pair of generals, then a praetorian prefect, and securing the arrest of supporters of Valens (26.7.4ff.); this was all done quickly, not to omit any means of causing fear and apprehension among his opponents (26.7.4). Ammianus remarks on the motivation of the men who now came forward to offer service. They were from the lowest social ranks, driven by desperation and blind ambition, together with men of good birth who were about to fall low, some to exile or death (26.7.7). At the outset of the rebellion, small-time profiteers, men who served or had served in the palace, and some retired soldiers, joined Procopius, either willingly or under some sort of compulsion: others, who did not like the look of things, took themselves off to the camp of Valens. Among these was the *notarius* Sophronius, the first to reach Valens at Caesarea and inform him of the uprising: perhaps he was also an informant of Ammianus, who mentions that he was later – in about 382 – prefect of Constantinople (26.7.1-2).¹⁹ There were also the grievances against Petronius, twice already and now for a third time mentioned by Ammianus. These united rich and poor, civil and military, against the regime of Valens (26.6.9, 17; 8.14).

Ammianus explicitly distinguishes between the formation of an administrative establishment, which he calls '*factio*' or '*party*', and the assembling of military support (26.7.8). In this matter Valens played helplessly into Procopius' hands, for in addition to the Divitenses and Tungrecani Iuniores responsible for his proclamation, more (unnamed) units of horse and foot also passed through Constantinople on their way to Thrace, and were won over (26.7.9). The motives of the soldiers are presented with a different emphasis from those of Procopius' civilian supporters. Swayed naturally by money and the promise of rewards

(26.6.13; 7.9), they were susceptible also to Procopius' prestige and connections. He gained the Divitenses and Tungrecani by approaching men among their number whom he already knew, and accepting their promises to bring over the rest (26.6.12f.). No doubt his acquaintance with them went back to the Persian campaign of Julian. Still more interesting is the effect of Procopius' claim to be linked with the house of Constantine.²⁰ He took around with him the posthumous baby daughter of Constantius, and was sometimes also accompanied by her mother, Constantius' second wife Faustina. Their presence helped Procopius win over the second of the groups of troop units referred to by Ammianus (26.7.10), and they were with him too in the military campaign of early 366 (26.9.3). In a remarkable early *coup* near Nicaea, Procopius was able to win over more of Valens' troops, the Iovii and Victores (again, though Ammianus does not say so, the 'Iuniores' of those names), by running before their lines, greeting a soldier called Vitalianus and appealing to him to abandon the 'unknown emperors' whom he now served in favour of a representative of the old regime (26.7.16). He also received help, too late in the event, from three thousand Goths, they too attracted by the reputation and name of Constantius (26.10.3).²¹

Ammianus shows the importance of finance, both by incidental allusion and by deliberate statement. An agent of Valens, sent to Nicomedia for money to pay the troops of the eastern garrisons, found the city (and its mint) already in the hands of Procopius and made haste for Cyzicus, where Valens' *comes domesticorum* Serenianus had been sent to guard the treasuries (26.8.7). The city was powerfully fortified, but its harbour was penetrated by the valorous exploit of the tribune Aliso, Serenianus being captured and imprisoned at Nicaea (26.8.9f.). Having secured these cities, with Helenopolis, Nicaea and Chalcedon, Procopius was master of Bithynia. He now cast his eyes upon Asia, and to win over its wealthy cities sent there, in an ominous expression, men 'skilled in extracting gold'; 'eruendi peritos auri' (26.8.14). Ammianus regarded this phase of the campaign as blunting Procopius' effort, begun with such energy but now allowed to fade. It is true that Valens was able to regroup his forces in the meantime, but he would have done that in any case, being secure in his control of the east and not dislodged from the possession of Anatolia. Winter had come, and no one would advance then to meet him. There was little choice for Procopius but to embark upon a period of consolidation, and an expansion of influence to the rich cities of Asia by what one might broadly call 'diplomatic' means.

The provinces of Thrace fell to Procopius by the simple device of arresting their military commander, enticed to Constantinople by letters extorted by force ('violenter') from Valens' imprisoned praetorian prefect (26.7.5). The acquisition of Thrace gave Procopius a further claim on the troops sent by Valens to face the anticipated Gothic invasion, and the city of Philippopolis remained loyal to him until the end (26.10.6). He tried to secure Illyricum, further west, by the interesting ploy of sending there men with gold coin minted in his name and image, but Valentinian's

commander in Illyricum, Aequitius, caught and killed them (26.7.11). Ammianus regarded the failure to secure Illyricum as a serious impediment to Procopius' chances of success (26.7.12), and lays repeated stress on the passes that led from Illyricum into Thrace, particularly the pass of Succus bringing the military high road down past Philippopolis (26.7.12; 10.4). The same point was crucial in Julian's march against Constantius; he delayed at Naissus while Constantius grouped his forces in Thrace, and was very lucky not to have to face battle there (p. 105).

Seen from Valens' point of view, the rebellion of Procopius shows the sheer diversity of an emperor's preoccupations.²² After the division of the empire late in 364, Valens had entered his consulship for 365 at Constantinople (26.5.4ff.). Recent events however made his presence on the eastern frontier seem imperative, and he set off there at the end of the winter. His progress through Anatolia was measured, for he did not prepare to leave Caesarea until the summer heat had waned, making the journey through Cilicia a more tolerable prospect (26.6.11; 7.2). He had already received reports from his provincial commanders of a prospective Gothic invasion, to which he had to send troops, who passed by Constantinople with the results already noted. The rebellion of Procopius in late September was a third field of action, compelling Valens to defer his march to the east and return to Bithynia. After his initial failures there he established a holding position in Galatia (26.7.2, 13), making his base at Ancyra (26.8.4). Ammianus presents Valens as totally disconcerted by the turn of events, and ready to surrender the imperial regalia if his associates had not encouraged him to carry on (26.7.13). This is no doubt exaggerated, but one can readily see the situation from Valens' point of view; here was an emperor seriously involved on both eastern and lower Danube frontiers, but distracted from both of them through civil war in Asia Minor.

Valens was encouraged to hope for better things by the prospect of reinforcements from the east, and these in due course arrived, permitting an advance to Pessinus in old Phrygia (26.8.4; 9.1). He had in the meantime been able to mount attacks on Procopius' forces in Phrygia, forcing the departure from his province of the archaically styled 'proconsul' Hormisdas (26.8.12).²³ The emperor's resources were clearly superior, and so, when it came to a crisis, was his authority. The general Arintheus had at an early stage won over detachments from Procopius by simply ordering them to arrest and hand over their useless commander (26.8.4). A similar intervention by Arbitio in Lydia achieved the defection of Procopius' general Gomoarius (26.9.6), and at the confrontation near Nacolia the majority of Procopius' forces turned down their spears and joined the emperor (26.9.7). Procopius was tied up by two of his own officers and delivered to Valens for execution (26.9.9).

*

Throughout Ammianus' account, questions arise of time, distance and communications, and their effect on the conduct of the civil war. Procopius

produced so-called 'messengers' from the west, claiming that they had come from Gaul and reporting the death of Valentinian there (26.7.3); this was a clever move on Procopius' part, for nothing was better calculated to undermine the standing of Valens than the loss of his senior colleague and author of his dignity. Meanwhile Valentinian did not know what had happened to his brother. Rumours of a usurpation reached him, but left it unclear whether or not Valens was dead. A firm report was sent in by Aequitius in Illyricum, who had got his information from a military tribune in Dacia Mediterranea (26.5.10). Again there was little detail beyond confirmation of the fact of rebellion. Valens' fate remained unclear – naturally enough, since Constantinople was between Valentinian and Cappadocia, and Procopius sat astride the direct routes of communication with the west.

Valentinian responded by raising Aequitius to the rank of *magister militum*, with instructions to secure Illyricum against a rapid attack from Thrace; he did not want the equivalent of a march of Julian against him (26.5.9ff.). In the meantime he sent agents with a select force to secure Africa in case Procopius should attempt to win that province – a practical and economical action, precluding the usurper at an early stage from control of the corn supply of Rome (26.5.14). If Valens were eliminated, Procopius might use such control to blackmail Valentinian into recognising him. Aequitius easily overcame Procopius' attempt to subvert Illyricum (26.7.11), no further action being required of him for the moment. As the rebellion neared its close he hesitated, uncertain what was going on in Asia Minor, where he knew, without any detail, that the war was now being fought. He moved into Thrace and attacked Philippopolis, thinking that he might have to outflank Procopius and advance through Haemimontus (on the European coast of the Black Sea) to bring help to Valens and not daring, if he did so, to leave Philippopolis loyal to Procopius. In performing these manoeuvres, remarks Ammianus, he had 'not yet heard what had happened at Nacolia' – that is, the death of the usurper (26.10.4). As for the defenders of Philippopolis, they refused to yield their city until they had actually seen the head of Procopius being carried to the Gallic provinces (26.10.6). Just so, the citizens of Aquileia had refused to yield to Julian until they had proof of the death of Constantius (above, p. 104). In both cases, the leaders of the resistance were punished with a severity that drew comment from Ammianus (21.12.20; 26.10.6).

Ammianus' narrative is studded with allusions to modes of communication and expressions of opinion indicating the sentiments at work in the usurpation of Procopius. The ceremonial installation of the usurper was attended by acclamations in his favour, beginning hesitantly, but gradually encompassing the populace of Constantinople. It was preceded by the hustled progress through the streets of the city, and followed by a speech to a sparsely attended senate. The soldiers too make acclamations, swearing mighty oaths by Jupiter (26.6.13; 7.17); they lower their spears and standards as a sign of defection, in one case

from Valens, in another from Procopius (26.7.17; 9.7). In the first case their gesture of submission comes instead of the fearsome battle roar, known as 'barritus', which was expected (26.7.17). Procopius could win over a detachment by greeting and personally addressing (in Latin) a soldier whom he claimed to know (26.7.15f.), and with equal aplomb Arintheus could scorn battle and bring troops over to his side by addressing them with the full weight of his authority, ordering them to throw in chains their despicable commander, an ex-palace attendant (26.8.5). Both are interesting indications of the 'face to face' contact expected between commanding officers and their troops, and indeed in social relations generally in Ammianus' time.²⁴

Particularly notable is the immense influence on the formation of opinion of the reputation of the house of Constantine.²⁵ This is especially true of the army. His possession of the baby daughter of Constantius, and the presence on one occasion of her mother Faustina when Procopius received some element of the imperial insignia, had a real effect, specifically linked by Ammianus with Procopius' bids for military support (26.7.10). At a later stage, Faustina and her daughter attended Procopius in the field before he committed himself to battle. The idea was to get the troops to fight with the enthusiasm due to a member of the house of Constantine (26.9.3), but Procopius was outdone by the emergence from retirement of Arbitio, angry at the stripping of his house of its priceless furniture (26.8.13). The appearance before one of Procopius' armies of this distinguished general swayed opinion towards Valens, especially when he reminded them of their shared labours of old; let them follow him, a general known for his famous victories, rather than a worthless profligate bound to be deserted and fail (26.9.5)! Respect for a general of the time of Constantine was expected to calm the soldiers' eagerness for war, and so it turned out; 'ut Constantiniani ducis verecundia truces animi lenirentur, neque secus evenit' (26.9.4).

Procopius' propaganda made much of the lack of distinction of the obscure Pannonians now raised to the imperial throne. Addressing Vitalianus before the front line of the Iovii and Victores, he denounced the 'Pannonius degener' who dared to crush beneath his heels an empire to which he had never in his prayers dared to aspire – Procopius himself claiming to be of the highest in the state, that is to say a member of the house of Constantine; 'culminis summi prosapiam' (26.7.16). Still more stinging sneers were reserved for Valens personally, when he tried unsuccessfully to prise Chalcedon from Procopius' hands by siege. Among the taunts hurled down at him from the city-walls was the slang-name 'Sabaiaarius'. 'Sabaia', as Ammianus explained, was a cheap drink made in Illyricum from barley or wheat (26.8.2). A century-and-a-half earlier, the Bithynian Greek Cassius Dio, who had governed Pannonia as consular legate and claimed to write from personal knowledge, had described Pannonians as a violent people who possessed nothing to induce them to an honourable life. They had only a little wine of poor quality, and instead drank beer made from barley and millet (49.36.2ff.).

It is remarkable to see the very same Mediterranean prejudice against the north repeated after such a lapse of time by Dio's Bithynian compatriots at Chalcedon. To the modern historian, nothing seems more natural than that imperial dynasties should be replaced, when they come to an end, from the military classes of Pannonia. It is the story of the third century, culminating in the rise of Constantine the Great, born in the military city of Naissus and proclaimed in Britain. It clearly looked different in the later fourth-century east; the dynasty of Constantine had shaken off its origins and, after two generations of rule from Constantinople, was the very image of civilised imperial power. The insults flung from the walls of Chalcedon take us close to an interpretation of Procopius' rebellion as an expression of class and cultural prejudice of eastern urban dwellers against rural upstarts from the west – at the same time as they provide a commentary on the essential narrowness of Procopius' power base. If he could not control Illyricum he could not control the empire, as Ammianus well understood; 'magna perdidit instrumenta bellorum' (26.7.12). The observation is as relevant on the ideological level as on the strategic: so much for contempt for beer-drinking Pannonians!

Two other aspects of the 'public imagery' of the rebellion will repay a moment's reflection. The first is Procopius' attempt to win over Illyricum by sending there men to distribute gold coin bearing his image and to embark on a policy of subversion by corruption; 'aureos scilicet nummos effigatos in vultum novi principis, aliaque ad illecebras aptantes' (26.7.11). It would have been neglectful to do less; although Procopius may have over-estimated the appeal his name would have in Illyricum (the swift response of Aequitius ensuring that it would not be put to the test), there was much to be said for trying such measures, if they were not too expensive, in areas beyond his current military capacities. Procopius' appreciation, and Ammianus' recognition, of the propaganda value of coinage in such circumstances, are telling items of evidence in the modern historian's understanding of this important general issue. The coinage itself, struck at the group of mints in the Hellespontine region – Constantinople, Nicomedia, Cyzicus, and (in bronze coin only) Heraclea in Thrace – displays in gold and bronze denominations a variant of a legend much used in the second half of the reign of Constantius, but never employed by Valentinian and Valens: 'REPARATIO FEL(icius) TEMP(orum)'.²⁶ The issues of silver, struck in the first instance for donatives to the army, look forward hopefully to the fifth anniversary of the reign, 'VOT(a) V'. The image of Procopius, who is shown as an ascetic, lean-faced and bearded figure, is an obvious reminiscence of the portraiture of Julian. So too, on a closer inspection than the soldiers of Illyricum are ever likely to have given the coins, are certain of the mint-marks employed on them, but it is more likely that these, if not also the choice of legends, have more to do with routine minting procedures than with active propaganda. There is however no doubt about the portrait, and this is the detail noted by Ammianus.

The second aspect is in a grotesque way connected; no longer the coin image, but the actual head of Procopius being transported from Asia Minor to Gaul, on its way by dumb appeal persuading the citizens of Philippopolis to end their resistance to Aequitius (26.10.6). So on later occasions, the heads of the usurpers Maximus and Eugenius, successively defeated by Theodosius, wound their way across the Roman empire mounted on the end of a pike, to be displayed on the walls of Carthage.²⁷ The scene is easy to visualise: a detachment of mounted troops brandishing banners and devices, the head of the usurper held aloft with a painted placard, like an increasingly macabre parody, as its condition deteriorates, of the imperial standard; trumpeters and a herald to make a proclamation before the walls of cities, whose populations send out envoys with loyal addresses, make acclamations to the legitimate emperor, and donations in celebration of his victory. The end of the usurpation of Procopius matched the beginning, politics as dramatic scena or tableau; 'ut in theatralli scaena simulacrum quoddam insigne per aulaeum vel mimicam cavillationem subito putares emersum' (26.6.15).

*

Ammianus' attitude to the rebellion of Procopius is interesting for his categorical endorsement of legitimate power. It is clear that he sympathised with the widespread dislike of the regime of Valens, and especially of Petronius, whose oppressive financial administration and nasty character are repeatedly brought to our notice (26.6.7f., 17; 8.14). Of the general Serenianus, imprisoned at Nicaea and murdered there by Marcellus after the fall of Procopius, Ammianus remarks that his death was the saving of many lives, for he would have killed many innocent men had he lived to be on the winning side. Serenianus came like Valens from Pannonia, was uncultivated and cruel, and resembled his master as much as he was congenial to him; 'Valentique ob similitudinem morum et genitalis patriae vicinitatemque acceptus' (26.10.2). Procopius on the other hand is in personal terms favourably treated. Quiet and respectable, strict in his personal conduct and inclined to depression (Procopius lived, says Ammianus in a marvellous phrase, 'amid the shadows of a sad nature'), he was well educated and, what was especially remarkable, throughout his life untainted by the shedding of blood (26.6.1; 9.11).²⁸ The short obituary notice of Procopius, in which this last point is added to what Ammianus had said earlier, immediately precedes the character-sketch of Serenianus in Ammianus' text, in a clearly deliberate rhetorical contrast: 'sed, quod est mirandum, quoad vixit incruentus' of Procopius (26.9.11), is followed by the description of Serenianus; 'occultas voluntates principis introspiciens ad crudelitatem propensioris, multas innocentium ediderat strages' (26.10.2).

Yet, distasteful as it might be, it was Valens who was the legitimate emperor and Procopius the usurper, venturing an illegal assault on the imperial throne and justly defeated and executed. Despite his lack of

capacity for the office, low origin and unpleasant character, it was the cause of Valens that was 'piissima' (26.10.13) and Procopius, far superior in birth, character and temperament, who was a 'disturber of public calm' (26.6.1), a 'usurper of improper power'; 'usurpator indebitae potestatis' (26.7.12). He was a 'praesumptor' (26.8.24), his cause a 'criminal outrage'; 'proterviae totius auctore' (26.8.4). Procopius' captors, his own officers Florentius and Barchalba, were themselves executed, but this was for Ammianus an ill-considered act. If they had betrayed a 'princeps legitimus', Justice herself would have applauded their execution. As it was, they had surrendered a 'rebel and assailant of civil tranquillity' ('rebellem et oppugnatorem internae quietis') and should have been generously rewarded for a noble deed; 'amplas eis memorabilis facti oportuerat deferri mercedes' (26.9.10). It was no doubt what they had hoped for themselves.

Ammianus evoked the social confusion spawned by civil war, the prospects of gain attracting ambitious palace officials and men who had retired from imperial service, some former soldiers (26.7.1). Procopius failed to appreciate that a happy man may by a turn of Fortune's wheel be most wretched before the evening (26.8.13), and people committed themselves to his cause not knowing what the future would bring, and not always of their own volition (26.7.1). Some (Ammianus is thinking here of the people of Constantinople) liked change for its own sake, which is not to say that there were no complaints with the present state of affairs (26.6.17). The judicial enquiries which followed the suppression of the rebellion were among the instruments by which this social upheaval was achieved, and Ammianus dwells on them, with more rhetorical intensity than precision of detail, emphasising the emperor's cruelty, the tortures and penalties, proscriptions and exiles that ensued – their purpose being, in Ammianus' eyes, to transfer the wealth of the defeated into the pockets of the victorious party (26.10.14). The victors' cause was just, but tainted by the manner of its celebration; 'causae quidem piissimae, sed victoriae foedioris' (26.10.13).

It is disconcerting to find Ammianus' endorsement of legitimate power so undisturbed by the moral quality of those who now exercised it, but he gives no indication that he regarded such judgments as relevant to the circumstances. The overriding consideration seems to be the formal legitimacy of the government in office. That being so, it is not easy to feel totally satisfied with Ammianus' criticism of Valens' conduct of the judicial enquiries which followed the suppression of Procopius. Procopius knew, and Ammianus knew, what was the nature of power in the fourth-century Roman empire, and what happened to those who, whether by magic arts, subtle conspiracy or armed rebellion, challenged it unsuccessfully. It was precisely through the judicial pursuit of such challenges that good men were brought down, suffering death or exile in a manner that seemed to Ammianus quite normal in times of civil war; 'ut in certaminibus intestinis usu venire contingit' (26.7.7).²⁹ Legal processes were no mere incidental adjuncts to situations that had been resolved

elsewhere. The emperors took their duties seriously and had to be equipped against the possibility of attack, and the courts of law were as integral to the maintenance of their position as was the capacity to take military action against a rebel. All emperors, including Julian, used them, and Ammianus recognised their necessity (p. 252). Nor is it as if the emperors were disinterested observers of threats to their own position. Not for the first time, Ammianus has failed to take the imaginative step of putting himself in the emperor's position. But then, what realistic man of conscience could have chosen without unease between principles of judicial conduct apt for an ideal world in which people did not rebel, and support of legitimate government in a real world in which they did? If Ammianus seems at times to want the best of both worlds, the maintenance of legitimate government without the judicial processes necessary to defend it, that is not in human terms surprising, nor is it morally absurd to argue that legitimate power should be defended by the minimum of necessary force. The difficulty lies in establishing what degree of force constitutes the minimum, and on this point emperors, their historians and their victims might easily take different views.

CHAPTER X

Valentinian and Valens: Sex, Magic and Treason

In a brief preface to Book 26, Ammianus had referred to the dangers of composing the history of an age that now lay within the reach of living memory, and to his hesitation in embarking upon a period that was so well known, in a narrative so open to the attentions of untimely critics; ‘convenerat iam referre a notioribus pedem, ut et pericula declinentur veritati saepe contigua et examinatores contexendi operis deinde non perferamus intempestivos’ (26.1.1). A historian may give offence by the omission of unimportant trivialities – the reasons for the punishment of common soldiers, what the emperor said at dinner, the names of minor fortifications and of those who paid court to the urban praetor, and so on. On such matters Ammianus turns his back, in favour of the true claims of history, which is accustomed to run among ‘high places’ and not scuffle about after irrelevant details; ‘praeceptis historiae ... discurrere per negotiorum celsitudines assuetae, non humilium minutias indagari causarum’. What other ‘dangers’ might be involved apart from the giving of offence by untimely omission, has been the subject of much speculation relating to such issues as an author’s freedom of speech under an autocracy and the expression of religious dissent in an age of prejudice;¹ but it is possible that Ammianus’ declaration amounts merely to a promise that he will be as open and frank as he has been before, not in defiance of any physical threat to his own person but of the risks to a literary reputation that might be incurred by the writing of contemporary history. Current affairs were, after all, the proper field of the panegyrist, whose claims to truth can only in special cases, such as that of Julian, be compared to those of the historian (16.1.3; p. 468). A renewed invocation of truth, integrity and a lofty purpose was appropriate as one approached living memory, and it was a neat touch to conciliate the audience by acknowledging the risks of adverse criticism that were involved.

It is often argued that the preface to Book 26 indicates an extension of an original design that had not been intended to go beyond the death of Julian and its immediate sequel.² It is however difficult to believe that the usurpation of Procopius was not from the beginning an integral part of Ammianus’ plan. Not only is the information of a sustained quality, the writing as artful and controlled, the portrayals of character as penetrating and varied as ever; the whole book is arranged with a

symmetry perhaps equalled only in Book 14 of the history. It consists of ten divisions of subject-matter, the first five, after the preface and other preliminaries, narrating the election of Valentinian and his choice of Valens as colleague, as described above (p. 190). The division of the empire completed at Mediana near Naissus and at Sirmium is then immediately expressed in practice by the invasion of Alamanni which took Valentinian to the west, and the revolt of Procopius. These two events, introduced together at the centre of the book, are followed by a statement of Ammianus' method in the new circumstances, east and west with their separate histories (26.6.7-15). The Alamanni are deferred to Book 27, the second half of Book 26 being devoted to the usurpation of Procopius and the punishment of his supporters – a work of art in itself, as we have just seen.

Ammianus knew from the outset that, once it had happened so soon after Julian's death, he would have to describe the rebellion of Procopius. Granted this, to terminate with the rebellion would offer some advantages. It would allow the aftermath of the Persian campaign of Julian to be satisfactorily resolved, it would mark the true end of the dynasty of Constantine, and bring the new emperors to power without committing the historian to a detailed account of their rule. In a sense Ammianus' remarks about the hazards of writing contemporary history would read more convincingly at the beginning of Book 27, for that is where the contemporary age really began. Did Ammianus in effect transpose his preface from Book 27, in order to punctuate his work for formal reasons at the beginning of Book 26, the second half of his third decad? If this were so, by parity of reasoning he should have put his earlier preface not at the beginning of Book 15 but of 16; as for Book 27, we have just seen that it is in substance as well as structure linked with its predecessor, invasions of Alamanni, which are integral to Ammianus' presentation of the attitude taken by Valentinian to Procopius and so to the history of the rebellion, being deferred to it. Ammianus' transition at the beginning of the book is explicit in connecting the two issues; 'dum per eorum haec, quae narravimus, diversi rerum expediunt casus, Alamanni ... supra Gallicanos limites ... iam persultabant' (27.1.1).

We should conclude that the preface to Book 26 declares no more than the author's realisation that he is now approaching the generally more controversial field of contemporary history, without implying that what follows should be read as an amendment to any 'original' plan. We must however allow for contingency, and for the tendency of events to take unexpected directions. When Ammianus first embarked on his research for the history of the period after Julian's death he cannot have known how far he would have to go, nor that Valentinian and Valens would die within three years of each other, making possible a relatively well-defined termination to the history; nor did he then know that the death of Valens would be in circumstances so portentous, permitting a final book of such power. The climax of Ammianus' history, the Gothic wars culminating in the battle of Hadrianople in August 378 and the

death of Valens, was a catastrophe for the Roman empire but historiographically a gift of Fortune, who also provided the author, in the outlandish Huns and the Alani, with a marvellous opportunity for picturesque description with which to begin his final book (below, Chapter XIV.2).

Despite these observations, Books 27-31 of Ammianus' history differ from their predecessors, not only in the less expansive scale of their narrative – two-and-a-half years per book rather than one year per book in 14-26. The division of army, court and provinces between the two emperors meant that a historical narrative must for practical purposes be similarly arranged, in order to preserve the coherence of events that were contemporaneous but had for clarity to be described, as east and west were governed, separately.³ Ammianus explains this with care, having mentioned Valentinian's refusal to help Valens against Procopius and just before embarking on his narrative of the usurpation: events in east and west took place simultaneously and only confusion would be caused by jumping all the time from one to the other; 'ne dum ex loco subinde saltuatim redire festinamus in locum, omnia confundentes squaliditate maxima rerum ordines implicemus' (26.5.15). What was true in particular of the revolt of Procopius was true also of the general character of the reigns of Valentinian and his brother.

The division of the empire under these emperors was essentially a reversion to previous practice, the reign of Julian being a brief and inconclusive exercise in unity. In the time of Constantius, Ammianus had had to co-ordinate events between east and west, while preserving the coherence of each. Yet there was a difference between this and the contemporary age. In the earlier books, Constantius' relations with his Caesars, Gallus and Julian, provided a link between the two halves of the empire, effective even in its demonstration of Constantius' failure to maintain the loyalty of his subordinates. The rise of Julian and his march against Constantius bound together east and west in a pattern converging dramatically upon a civil war averted only by Constantius' death.⁴ The reigns of Valentinian and Valens on the other hand brought about a divergence of the two parts, with only occasional links between them, such as the appointment of a protégé of a western praetorian prefect as governor of Syria and proconsul of Asia (29.2.22), or the presence of an Antiochene as prefect of Rome (28.4.3). The march of Gratian to help Valens at Hadrianople might have been an expression of unity, but in the event proved not so, for the emperor was detained by an invasion of Alamanni, and failed to arrive in time (31.10; 12.4-7).

There is also the contribution of Ammianus' own career to the unity of his history. From 354 until the return of Julian's army to Antioch in 363, with the exception of the 'lost' years after the dismissal of Ursicinus, Ammianus had himself been involved in many of the events he described. His movements around the empire and beyond its frontiers had even in their more unpredictable phases given coherence to the histories of the widely separated regions of which they formed a part. After the accession

of Valentinian and Valens, this narrative and dramatic focus deriving from Ammianus' own participation is lost. Instead we find scattered allusions, such as his presence at Antioch during Valens' treason trials there (29.1.24; 2.4), and the victimisation in the trials of some men whom he knew: moments of intense involvement but passive in nature and not forming part of a wider pattern.

Without these elements of unity between the two parts of the empire, the reigns of Valentinian and Valens assume in Ammianus a less cumulative, more episodic, air than those of their predecessors. Certain themes provide continuity with what has gone before. Ammianus still gives accounts of the tenures of office of urban prefects – though he omits some (below, p. 212). He has an excursus on the senate and people of Rome (28.4) which complements his digression in Book 14 and links these widely separated parts of his text.⁵ So too there is a second digression on Thrace and the Pontus (27.4) to set beside one in an earlier book (22.8). His account of the Huns and Alani is not only pertinent to its context, but in style and manner reminiscent of other descriptions of foreign peoples, such as the Saracens, in earlier books. The promotion of the young Gratian to the rank of Augustus, after his father had recovered from a serious illness in which there was much talk of the succession, balances and adds a certain ceremonial variety to other accounts of the elevations of imperial candidates (and usurpers) – Julian, Jovian, Procopius, and Valentinian and Valens themselves (27.6.1-16).

The most important issue of the reign of Valentinian of which Ammianus gives any sort of continuous narrative is his campaigns against the Alamanni. Although his chronology is not always exact year by year, he has chapters on this subject under the campaigning seasons 365 and 366, 368, 369, 370, 371-2, and 374.⁶ After this, the emperor was forced to attend to invasions of the Quadi on the Danube frontier, in the course of which he died; he had nevertheless determined to return to the Rhine as soon as he was able to, believing this to be the more important frontier (30.5.17). Military operations elsewhere, as in Britain (27.8; 28.3) and against the Saxons (28.5.1-7), are dealt with in separate chapters, not always with an exactly stated connection with other areas of activity. Close study of Ammianus' text is needed to elicit the chronology of the campaigns of Count Theodosius in Britain (367-8),⁷ and the transition from this subject to events in Tripolitania carries a statement of the precedence of thematic over chronological arrangement, with a back-reference to the beginning of Valentinian's reign to make it clear that the origins of the African episode are given out of sequence; 'haec in Britannis agebantur. Africam vero iam inde ab exordio Valentiniani imperio exurebat barbarica rabies ...' (27.9.1). After this brief indication that something is amiss in Africa, Ammianus moves to a short digression on Valentinian's excessive favour to the military, and defers a full narrative of the Austurian uprising to a separate treatment; this occurs, after many other matters have intervened, in the last chapter of the following book (28.6.1-30). The origins of the uprising are here traced still

further back in time by the statement that the first signs of unrest actually took place under Jovian (28.6.4). Events are then followed through from the ceremonial acceptance by the provincial council of Valentinian's rule ('ob imperii primitias', 28.6.7) and are only resolved when a report was submitted to his successor Gratian by the then proconsul and *vicarius* of Africa (28.6.28): that is to say, the events described in this chapter cover a full twelve or thirteen years, and extend both before the accession and after the death of Valentinian. The final outcome, the suicide of the court official Remigius, is in the very last sentence of Book 28 further deferred to a still later passage (30.2.9-12), where it occurs as part of a brief western diversion in a predominantly eastern narrative.

Another substantial episode, the rebellion of Firmus in Mauretania in Book 29, does not cover the same wide chronological range as events in Tripolitania, but here again the narrative of the episode, whose origins lay in a dispute over the inheritance of a Moorish king, incorporates the events of a full three campaign seasons (29.5.1-56).⁸ Although his text has suffered damage at this point, Ammianus begins his description of the affair with an explanation of its thematic nature, as remote in subject-matter and location from other events described in the same part of his history, and to avoid confusion best kept separate from them, 'ne, dum negotiis longe discretis et locis alia subseruntur, cognitio multiplex necessario confundatur' (29.5.1).

Ammianus' decision in such cases to present his narrative in consolidated 'blocks' of material covering several years of narrative, was in the best interests of coherent exposition. The Tripolitanian episode dragged on through embassy and petition, complaint, evasion and sordid conspiracy: no need to present under their exact year, even had this been possible, the separate elements of the episode, when their internal connections were clear and nothing elsewhere hung on the outcome or chronology. In the case of the Mauretanian rebellion, one needed only to know that by the beginning of 373 Theodosius, after successful campaigns in Britain and on the Rhine frontier, was available to take the command (29.4.5; 5.4). At no other point, save only the involvement of the *comes Africae* Romanus in this as in the Tripolitanian episode, was there need of co-ordination with any other sequence of events. Ammianus would gain nothing by separating the affair mechanically into an annalistic framework, and there were great possibilities of confusion in trying to do so. Ammianus similarly put Valens' campaigns against the Goths in 367-9 into a single narrative covering all three years of operations (27.5.1-10). That he prefaced this narrative with a digression on Thrace, of clear relevance to its subject-matter (27.4.1-14), adds further to one's sense of reading a little monograph, excursus followed by narrative in a miniature anticipation of Book 31, within the main structure of the book; though the narrative is 'tied in' to what has preceded by a reminder of the still recent suppression of Procopius. It was the military support offered to Procopius by the Goths that gave Valens

his opportunity to make war on them when after enquiry he professed himself dissatisfied by their excuses (27.5.1).

*

In the case of one particularly important episode, of domestic rather than foreign policy, Ammianus' account compacts the events of many years into a single narrative, but without providing the points of integration with other parts of his text necessary to have made it fully intelligible. Since this episode, the trials for magic and adultery conducted in senatorial circles by Valentinian's agents, is central to the impression conveyed by Ammianus of the reign of this emperor, and since the issue of magic in its social context is important to our general understanding of Roman society, it will be worthwhile to indicate Ammianus' treatment of the subject and some of the problems that attend it.⁹ The discussion may also, as it does in Ammianus, balance the equally severe investigations into conspiracy and magic conducted at Antioch under Valens in the same years.

Ammianus introduces his subject with ostentatious hesitancy as one of extreme delicacy, in words reminiscent of the 'pericula ... veritati contigua' mentioned in the preface to Book 26. He recoils from the events that lie before him, and relies upon the 'moderation of the present age' to make possible a selective account (in 57 sections) of the most memorable aspects of the affair; 'tamen praesentis temporis modestia fretus, carptim, ut quaeque memoria digna sunt, explanabo' (28.1.2). Ammianus adds a parallel from ancient times to help explain his position. The Athenian playwright Phrynichus had been punished by his countrymen for telling them the truth in a play about the sack of Miletus (during the Ionian Revolt of 499-4 BC). He had upset his audience by his imputation that their city was to blame for the sack by its failure to help its fellow-Ionian allies against the Persian siege (28.1.3f.). Ammianus presumably intended his remark as a general illustration of the courage of a writer who dared to tell the truth, without implying a more precise analogy between himself and Phrynichus. The tale does little to show how the Romans could have helped their fellow-citizens who were victims of the prosecutions conducted by Valentinian's agents, nor into what danger Ammianus could fall by writing of them in later years.

Ammianus dates the troubles to 'the sixteenth year and more' after the destruction of Nepotianus; 'anno sexto decimo et eo diutius post Nepotiani exitium' (28.1.1) – he means that they began in 365 or 366 and continued thereafter. A surviving source on the rebellion at Rome of Nepotianus has corpses piled in the streets after its suppression by Magnentius (Aur. Victor, *Caes.* 42.7), an account which no doubt resembles that furnished by Ammianus in one of his lost books (12 or 13). Yet, if the reader of Book 28 was intended to apply such a description to the more recent troubles, it is curious that the chronology implied by the fall of Nepotianus for the prosecutions of Valentinian is not supported in

Ammianus' narrative. They began when a senator named Chilo and his wife alleged to the urban prefect Olybrius that their lives had been threatened by sorcery, naming a musician, a wrestler, and a fortune-teller (28.1.8). Q. Clodius Hermogenianus Olybrius held the prefecture of Rome from the autumn of 368 until 370, being last recorded in August of that year.¹⁰ Since he suffered from a protracted illness, the enquiries were transferred at the plaintiffs' request to the *praefectus annonae* Maximinus. These circumstances do not fit Ammianus' chronology, for it was certainly not before late 369, in view of the delay caused by Olybrius' illness, that the affair was transferred to Maximinus.

Another indication might be provided by an early victim of the trials, the proconsul of Africa Julius Festus Hymetius.¹¹ Hymetius was accused of consulting a diviner in order to make the emperor lenient to him. His offence was that to meet a famine at Carthage he had released from imperial granaries there corn destined for Rome, selling it at a high price and replacing it at a third the cost when corn was plentiful (28.1.17ff.). For this service he was thanked by a statue and inscription set up in his honour after Valentinian's death (*ILS* 1256), but the emperor was less well pleased and complained that Hymetius had made insufficient restitution for what he had taken. Yet Hymetius remained in office as proconsul until 367 or 368, and his consultation of the soothsayer must come after this; given the attitude of Valentinian to such matters, he would not have been allowed to remain as proconsul with any suspicion of fraud hanging over him. Neither the complaints of Chilo and his wife nor the case of Hymetius can provide the basis for Ammianus' dating of the outbreak of the prosecutions. If this is to be found, it must be sought elsewhere than in Ammianus, by far the most precise of the other evidence being provided by the legislation of Valentinian.

A law of 8 October 367 addressed to the urban prefect Praetextatus refers to punishments of 'exceeding severity' ('*austerior ... ultio*') inflicted on senators for proportionately serious offences, requiring that the emperor be consulted in such cases (*CTh* 9.40.10). This law, and whatever circumstances give rise to it, accord better with Ammianus' dating of the beginnings of the trials at Rome, although they bear no relation to his account of the manner in which they actually arose. The desire to protect the reputation of Praetextatus if he were in some way connected with the origin of the troubles might conceivably explain Ammianus' embarrassment in narrating them; but if so, he would have achieved his result by a misleading presentation of the facts that seems both uncharacteristic and unnecessary. There was no need to be so precise in the first place; if Ammianus' motive were to protect Praetextatus, he need never have invited trouble by writing that the prosecutions began in the sixteenth year after the suppression of Nepotianus, when his own narrative suggested a different chronology.

Ammianus connects the trials primarily with the tenures of office of successive *vicarii* of Rome. Maximinus, the evil genius of the prosecutions, with whose background and character Ammianus sets the

tone of his narrative (28.1.5-7), was promoted to the vicariate from the post of *praefectus annonae* when his report on the situation at Rome was accepted by the emperor.¹² He received as assistant a fellow-Pannonian Leo, subsequently *magister officiorum* at the court of Valentinian, where Maximinus himself became praetorian prefect of Gaul after his vicariate (28.1.12); it is in Gaul that he is later found, inciting the emperor to further acts of cruelty, of which Ammianus gives a selection (29.3.1ff.). Maximinus' successor at Rome, Ursicinus, was replaced for undue mildness in referring a difficult case to the imperial court (28.1.44); to fill his office came another supporter of Maximinus, Simplicius of Emona, formerly a schoolmaster, devious and sinister (28.1.45). Finally was sent a Gaul, Doryphorianus, chosen for his wild audacity, claims Ammianus, to execute a senator of high standing (28.1.53f.). In the end, as Ammianus concludes his narrative by explaining, they paid with their lives for their presumption. After the death of Valentinian, Maximinus was executed for 'overbearing conduct' under Gratian, Simplicius beheaded in Illyricum and Doryphorianus thrown into the Tullianum at Rome, to be seized from there by the advice of the emperor's mother, taken to his home town in Gaul and put to death there 'amid immense tortures' (28.1.57). Something is known or can be reconstructed of a political reaction under Gratian connected with these violent events, and of the rise to power of a new court faction based on the influence of the poet Ausonius, Valentinian's quaestor and the tutor of his son.¹³ Ammianus says nothing of any of this. He nowhere even mentions Ausonius, and never fulfils his intention, stated in this passage, to tell of the fates that befell Maximinus and his colleagues; 'ut postea tempestive dicetur' (28.1.57). This is one of Ammianus' only two unfulfilled promises, no casual omission, since he introduces Maximinus with the remark that his father, a man skilled in divination, had told him that he would rise high but fall to the executioner's sword (28.1.7). It is possible, and has often been argued, that the omission has to do with events after the death of Valentinian that Ammianus may have thought embarrassing or dangerous, notably the execution at Carthage, in mysterious circumstances, of the *magister militum* Theodosius, the father of the reigning emperor.¹⁴ This may be so; on the other hand, if there were dangers in what he had discovered, Ammianus could easily have avoided them simply by deleting the promise he had made. If he were completing his text towards the year 390, he had ample opportunity to do so (p. 30f.).

By contrast with this sequence of *vicarii*, the prefects of Rome play only a minor role in Ammianus' narrative. He acknowledges Olybrius' involvement in his account of the prosecutions (28.1.8f.), but not in his formal notice, only three chapters later, on the prefecture of Olybrius. This he describes as peaceful and quiet, its holder as an over-conscientious official, anxious to avoid any harsh deed or word, a rigorous opponent of calumny and fraud, insistent on the distinction between justice and injustice, and restrained in his conduct towards those under his authority (28.4.1); not a word, directly or by implication, of the

complaint laid before him by Chilo and his wife.

Olybrius' successor, P. Ampelius, is described in the account of his prefecture as an excellent choice and pleasing to the people, sometimes rigorous except that he failed to maintain his rigour as he should; the reference however is not to capital jurisdiction but to regulations on licensing hours and the sale of food in the streets of Rome (28.4.3f.; p. 414). In Ammianus' narrative of the trials, the former proconsul Hymetius is judged by Ampelius as prefect, sitting in court with Maximinus as *vicarius*. Hymetius seemed on the brink of condemnation and appealed to the emperor, who remitted the case to the senate. Valentinian was infuriated when this body merely exiled him to a Dalmatian island, but allowed the sentence to stand (28.1.22f.). Further, Ampelius was the recipient of a law of Valentinian issued on 6 December 371, of obvious relevance to the circumstances (*CTh* 9.16.10). It specified that those members of the senatorial order ('nonnulli ex ordine senatorio') who were currently accused of magical practices were to be heard by the *praefectus urbi* and remitted to the emperor, with full transcript of the proceedings, when the prefect's court was unable to reach a decision.

It seems clear that the involvement of the prefecture in the judicial hearings at Rome was deeper than is stated or suggested by Ammianus.¹⁵ It may then be significant that none of Ampelius' immediate successors as prefect, Bappo, Principius and Eupraxius, gains any notice in the history; but if so, it is the more puzzling that the last of them receives praise from Ammianus for his integrity and courage on earlier occasions at the court of Valentinian. On one of these occasions, when Valentinian answered the complaint of a senatorial embassy that senators were being tortured against the provisions of the law by claiming that he had given no such instruction, Eupraxius as quaestor corrected his emperor (28.1.25). The quaestor had responsibility in the administration for the drafting of law and imperial rulings on legal questions. Those laws of Valentinian that may conjecturally be attributed to Eupraxius' hand have been described as possessing an 'even and moderate tone', as 'calm, dignified and restrained' – qualities fully consistent with Ammianus' description of Eupraxius' character.¹⁶

The petition of the embassy, which was composed of three high-ranking senators led by Vettius Agorius Praetextatus,¹⁷ arose from the 'relatio' of Maximinus to Valentinian in which, after enquiries into the state of affairs at Rome, he reported that serious crimes were afoot, requiring severe penalties, and received in reply the ruling that they be considered under the heading of *maiestas* (28.1.11). It would in consequence of this ruling be permissible to apply torture even to those normally exempt, like members of the senatorial order, for in the case of *maiestas*, as Valentinian said in a law of 8 July 369 addressed to the urban prefect Olybrius that may embody part of his reply to Maximinus' *relatio*, 'there is only one and the same condition for all'; 'in qua [*sc. maiestatis causa*] sola omnibus aequa condicio est'. In no other circumstance was anyone to be stripped of office or rank in order to allow him to be tortured, at least

without consultation of the emperor (CTh 9.35.1). Ammianus elsewhere alleges a provision of the ancient *Leges Corneliae* that in cases of *maiestas* torture might be applied to men of high social rank (19.12.17). In his discussion of Valentinian's ruling to Maximinus he presents an opposite opinion, in stating that certain categories of people were exempted from torture 'by ancient law and the rulings of emperors' (28.1.11); nor does he know of a partial precedent of Constantius covering cases of magic found at the imperial court (CTh 9.16.6; 5 July 357). It is perfectly possible that Valentinian himself was unaware of the law in insisting to the senatorial legation that he had not ordered the torture of senators. As Eupraxius advised him, he had sanctioned it in allowing Maximinus to proceed under the heading of *maiestas*.¹⁸

The intrusion of *maiestas* into the affair should not mislead us into believing that Ammianus has tried to describe a conspiracy.¹⁹ Individuals, men and women, were executed and exiled (or sometimes acquitted) on accusations of magic arts and, especially in the later years of the prosecutions, for sexual offences. A senator convicted of adultery, one exiled for 'a slight error', another beheaded because he had copied a book on magic 'in the infirmity of youth' (28.1.26) – such miscreants are hardly plausible conspirators. Most of the recorded victims were senators and senatorial women, together with characters like musicians, diviners and charioteers, persons only too familiar in Ammianus' own account as clients and hangers-on of senatorial households (p. 415). As for these men of lower social rank, Ammianus here as elsewhere excuses himself for omitting certain things that happened 'per squalidas personas', not everything that happens being worthy of record (28.1.15). He does however preserve some trace of the penal distinction between the upper and lower classes, senators being beheaded while members of other ranks are beaten to death or burned alive (28.1.16; 28f.).

Ammianus' account of the trials, as he concedes (28.1.15), is imprecise in its chronology – inevitably so, as it is punctuated only by changes in the vicariate of Rome as cases dragged on for years, often involving the pursuit of information laid by men of low estate such as the musician, wrestler and diviner mentioned at the outset. Though named at the beginning of the trials (28.1.9) they were not executed until much later, no doubt when they had said what they had to say and were of no further use to the inquisitors (28.1.29). The execution of the diviner consulted by the proconsul Hymetius is mentioned just before the latter's exile, together with the exile to Britain of an adviser, but in fact fell later (28.1.21). The case of the senator Aginatus, who first quarrelled with Maximinus by disputing the latter's judicial competence as *praefectus annonae* – and so not later than 370, by which time Maximinus was *vicarius* (28.1.30-33) – did not come to fulfilment until several years had passed and Maximinus had after long reflection devised a way to take his revenge. This is in fact the last event in the trials to be recorded (28.1.50-56).

As if to compensate for its chronological imprecision, Ammianus'

narrative is at various points illuminated by external evidence in the form of imperial legislation. In addition to the law addressed to Olybrius already mentioned, two laws of 19 May 371 addressed 'to the senate', may form part of the emperor's reply to the senatorial embassy led by Praetextatus. In one of them (*CTh* 9.16.9) Valentinian distinguished legitimate divination ('haruspicina') from magic, a clear reference to the diviners and fortune-tellers caught up in the prosecutions, as well as testimony to the ease of confusion between the categories of legal and outlawed practices in this area. The other law (*CTh* 9.38.5) pardons one or two accused persons, while observing that such leniency 'brands those persons whom it frees' and concluding ominously that 'he who pardons the senate, condemns the senate'; 'qui indulgentiam senatui dat, damnat senatum'. The act of pardon can in logic be extended only to the guilty, and it has often been noted that Ammianus at no point maintains the innocence of any of those convicted in the trials; his complaint is only that the punishments went far beyond the seriousness of the offences.²⁰ This was also the argument of the senatorial embassy to Valentinian; 'ne delictis supplicia sint grandiora' (28.1.24). A law posted at Rome on 23 March 374 by the *vicarius* Simplicius refers to the harbouring of guilty persons, exactly as happened in the case of the senators Avienus and Anepsia (28.1.49; *CTh* 9.29.1). Another law, addressed after Valentinian's death to Maximinus just before the latter's downfall and execution, prohibits the taking of evidence from slaves and freedmen against their masters except in cases of treason (*CTh* 9.6.1-2; 15 March 376). Anepsia had been informed upon by a slave in a case of sexual misdemeanour associated with her protection of Avienus (28.1.49). Since Maximinus was at the time prefect of Gaul, the law may not apply to Italy or Rome; on the other hand, the next (and last) law addressed to Maximinus was actually posted at Rome on 16 April 376 (*CTh* 9.19.4). It is therefore possible that the earlier law also applied to Rome, and if so, that it arose from the case of Anepsia.²¹

Not the least among many puzzling aspects of Ammianus' account is his failure to draw any structural or thematic connection between the trials and his own digressions on the moral conduct of the senate and people of Rome. The long account of the trials, in 57 sections, concludes with an emphatic formal statement: 'is urbanarum rerum status, ut ita dixerim, fuit' (28.1.57). Then follow two much shorter chapters (fourteen and nine sections respectively) on Valentinian's military activities on the Rhine frontier and the campaigns of Theodosius in Britain, before Ammianus returns to Rome, in a digression of thirty-five sections introduced by the strange remark that he has long neglected the city, being distracted by the great mass of foreign affairs; 'diu multumque a negotiis discussus urbanis, adigente cumulo foris gestorum ...' (28.4.1). It is as if he had totally forgotten his account of the prosecutions. The digression, in which Ammianus denounces the association of senators precisely with charioteers and fortune-tellers, and criticises their addiction to horoscopes and magic arts (below, p. 420), actually begins

with the successive prefectures of Olybrius and Ampelius, whose connections with the prosecutions at Rome have already been noted; yet we saw that Ammianus makes no mention of the subject, no cross-reference of any kind. Further, Ammianus had earlier endorsed the strict action of Apronianus, *praefectus urbi* under Julian, in a case involving a charioteer who had taught magic arts to his son and was executed. On a later occasion, it is alleged, a senator had taught similar secrets to a slave, but escaped punishment by bribery and could long afterwards be seen parading, as if in total innocence, in the streets of Rome (26.3.4f.). In remarking how 'long impunity' made possible this state of affairs, Ammianus again seems to ignore the trials conducted on just this issue by the agents of Valentinian.²² Even if, on the most schematic account of his methods of composition, he had not come round to composing Book 28 when he wrote down his comment on the prefecture of Apronianus in Book 26, he had surely begun to collect his material for the later events and was aware of their significance.

Ammianus' narrative of the trials is therefore a fitting comment, except that he fails to make it, on his own opinion of the conduct of that minority at Rome who sank themselves in immorality, ignorance and vice (14.6.7). It is difficult to understand in its lack of integration with other aspects of his text; not only with the digressions on Rome in Books 14 and 28, but with what he says elsewhere about magic and treason, and with his accounts of the prefects of Rome whom he shows to have been involved; and his initial chronology relating the trials to the fall of Nepotianus finds no trace in his text as it was written. Finally, he even makes no connection between the trials and his presentation of the character of the regime of Valentinian.

In two passages, Ammianus gives examples of Valentinian's cruelty; they are illustrative episodes of a varied character and chiefly affect the court – such as, in a sequence of actions allegedly inspired by Maximinus, the fate of an incautious petition for a change in a provincial assignment, the execution of the superintendent of an arms factory for offering short weight in a piece of armour manufactured under his supervision, the stoning of another official for substituting horses he was inspecting in Sardinia for military use (29.3.4-6). In an earlier passage, before Maximinus has arrived on the scene, Ammianus had mentioned the burning alive of a former head of the state treasuries in Illyricum for 'minor offences', and the execution of four officials who were complained of by a superior officer (27.7.5).²³ In such cases the emperor was perhaps being unduly censorious – and Ammianus rather tolerant – of corruption in the administration, but this austere consideration of justice does not excuse the clubbing to death of a groom for releasing a dog prematurely on a hunting expedition (29.3.3), or the amputation of the hand ordered for a stable boy who failed to control the emperor's horse as he was mounting it. This punishment was held back by the official instructed to implement it, presumably in the belief that Valentinian would relent; in the event there was no need, for the emperor died the following day

(30.5.19). Another court official, Eupraxius, had by a timely exposition of the theory of martyrdom saved the curial orders of three towns from summary execution (27.7.6), and there is always the paradigm of the emperor's pet bears, an anecdote of court life told also of the Emperor Galerius.²⁴ Despite opportunities to do so, nowhere does Ammianus adduce Valentinian's prosecutions at Rome as an example of his cruelty or any other facet of his character or policy, even when the cases present some similarity. A court official was accused of having killed a donkey in the hope of procuring from some part of its remains a magical cure for his baldness, which Ammianus reports without making any connection with the prosecutions at Rome (30.5.11). Nor does he revert to them in his obituary of Valentinian, unless it is in the comment that the emperor hated the well-dressed, the educated, the opulent and the noble; 'bene vestitos oderat et eruditos et opulentos et nobiles' (30.8.10). The first, third and fourth of the hated categories indeed concur with Ammianus' opinion of the senatorial aristocracy at Rome – not however for approval, but for criticism of the ostentation, idleness and fraudulent pretensions of its members.²⁵ The comparison which follows of Valentinian with Hadrian refers to that emperor's envious pretensions to cultural superiority, not to any political or judicial campaign against the upper class; 'ut solus videretur bonis artibus eminere'. It would help to have known what Ammianus wrote in detail of Hadrian. He does not say that Valentinian expressed his hatred by having the objects of his jealousy executed and exiled, and it is possible that in this passage Ammianus is not thinking of senators at all.

Ammianus' account of the trials is thus both chronologically and thematically detached, as if it had little to do with other situations described, and other opinions held, by the historian. He makes no connection between the trials and his description soon afterwards of the conduct of the senators of Rome, nor with the character of Valentinian; he neglects to make clear the role of the prefects of Rome in the prosecutions, and gives an account of their origins that is either deficient or misleading. Not only does he fail to carry out his promise at the end of his narrative to tell of the fall of Maximinus and his colleagues, but in remarking only a few paragraphs later, at the beginning of his digression on Rome, that he had long neglected urban in favour of foreign affairs, Ammianus writes momentarily as if the long first chapter of Book 28 did not exist at all.²⁶ As to the cause of his confusion – political or personal inhibition, sensitivity to his informants or to surviving victims of the trials, fear of their or their descendants' anger – this seems impossible to determine. Perhaps this is because the explanation does not lie in this direction at all. The anomalies in Ammianus' narrative are not all of one order. They involve both major and minor issues, and apply both to its content and to its place in the structure of the history. They might best be explained by some facet of the process of composition, for example by the supposition that the historian failed fully to master, or to revise thoroughly – or both – his complicated source material. Hurried composition or lack of revision

are unlikely, however, to be the complete explanation of the anomalies in Ammianus' account, since the chapter occupies a conspicuous place in his text, and is introduced with an elaborate rhetorical flourish clearly intended to amplify, not to diminish, its dramatic importance (p. 209). It is precisely this emphasis, and the role of the chapter in the broader economy of Ammianus' work, that may give us the clue that we need to seek the explanation of its character not in isolation but in its relationship with other descriptions of similar subjects, notably the account of the prosecutions conducted by Valens at Antioch, described at the beginning of Book 29 of the history.

*

Ammianus' account of the trials conducted by Maximinus and his successors at Rome is in fact the second of three main instances of the prosecution of magic arts and divination which he describes, in diverse but equally interesting circumstances. The first of them, in the time of Constantius (19.12.1-17), arose from the practice of consultation of an oracular shrine of the god Besas at Abydus in the Thebaid. Enquirers there were accustomed to put their questions, personally or through others acting for them, in writing, and many of these documents were left at the shrine after the replies had been given (19.12.4). Some were collected and sent to the emperor, who summoned his famous inquisitor, Paul 'the Chain', and prepared to hold hearings at Scythopolis in Palestine.²⁷ It was chosen as the venue because it was out of the way, and equidistant from Alexandria and Antioch, from which cities came a large proportion of those accused.

Ammianus' account of the trials of Scythopolis is coloured by emotive references to manacled prisoners from all parts of the world and all social classes, to exiles, tortures and executions (19.12.7f.; 13). It actually names only four accused men, two of whom were exiled, the other two acquitted since nothing could be proved against them. One of those acquitted, a philosopher named Demetrius from Alexandria, proclaimed under torture that of course he had sacrificed to the god, whom he had worshipped from childhood, but he had never consulted the oracle on his prospects for the future, nor did he know anyone else who had done so. The other acquitted man, a well-known poet, was guilty of nothing at all and was released (19.12.18). Of those convicted, Simplicius, the son of Constantius' famous praetorian prefect Fl. Philippus, was accused of enquiring about his own chances of power and tortured by imperial order (being otherwise exempt), but survived to go into exile; so little, said Ammianus, did Constantius care for the claims of 'pietas' (12.9)!²⁸ The other named victim, Parnasius of Patrae in Achaia, had often been heard to say that when he had once left his home to seek a public office he had dreamed that he was escorted by 'many figures in tragic dress' (19.12.10). He was sent into exile, in a way fulfilling his dream. He was no doubt unwise to tell it to anyone, but this would be to underestimate the

seriousness with which such signs were regarded by late Roman men.

In terms of the law as it stood, there was nothing unusual about the conduct of these cases. Fourth-century legislation, confirmed at the outset of his reign by Valentinian – and perhaps also by Valens, since the law, which survives only in a later reference to it, has the look of an agreed statement of policy²⁹ – had generally prohibited private divination with the severest penalties, but permitted the public expression of piety to the gods in any recognised fashion (*CTh* 9.16.1-2); while consultation of the gods about the prospects of one's own advancement would at any time, and not only in the later empire, have been severely dealt with. If Simplicius, with his connections and background, really had asked about his own prospects, Constantius would with more reason have been accused of negligence, than praised for loyalty to the son of an old friend, in overlooking it.

Without giving any actual cases, Ammianus describes the extension of the accusations to cover men incriminated because they wore amulets to repel fevers and other illnesses, or executed for sorcery and communion with the dead because they were seen passing a tomb at evening (19.12.14). Raising the ghosts of the dead was naturally visited in the law by capital punishment (*CTh* 9.16.5), Ammianus' complaint being of the flimsiness of the actual evidence adduced. As for innocent magical charms designed to achieve favourable weather, the well-being of crops and the health of the body, these were permitted in a law of Constantine condemning only magic designed for harmful purposes (*CTh* 9.16.3). In responding to such accusations, claims Ammianus, Constantius was indulging his obsessively distrustful temperament. Allegations of disloyalty could be fed into his ears, while serious matters were neglected, by servile flatterers who persuaded him that he was thereby exempt from all evils (19.12.16).

If the trials at Rome reveal magic arts and divination at work in the private lives of senatorial society and its sordid underworld, those at Scythopolis show how, by wilful misrepresentation, innocent loyalties to ancestral belief and harmless old customs could lead to suspicion of dissent. It was at the best of times a matter of interpretation. On an earlier occasion, not described by Ammianus, the Christian sophist Prohaeresius of Athens, deprived of his chair by the edict of Julian, had enquired of the goddesses of Eleusis, whom he had learned would tell the future to anyone who asked, whether the emperor's tax reforms would be long-lasting, and was told that they would not. It was a clever question, but Prohaeresius might have found himself severely exercised in a court of law to prove that he was not asking about the emperor's prospects of survival. In such circumstances, though a clement emperor like Julian might have spared him in order, as he used to put it, to increase the number of his friends (22.14.5), he would be lucky under a suspicious one to escape with torture and exile.³⁰

In contrast with the trials at Scythopolis and Rome, the prosecutions conducted under Valens at Antioch in the early 370s were a clear case of divination in league with conspiracy; though here too this led, through mutual acquaintance and shared intellectual tastes, to the involvement of many who, though not unsympathetic, were in no true sense conspirators, and of others who were totally innocent. The affair began, as often happened, with trivial allegations unconnected with the serious matters that ensued. A certain Procopius denounced two court officials as having used magic arts against the *comes rei privatae* Fortunatianus, who was exacting from them money they had 'intercepted' (that is, embezzled) from the treasury. Questioned by Fortunatianus, the officials named as their accomplices Palladius, a sorcerer of obscure origin, and Heliodorus, a reader of horoscopes. The case was now, magic arts being involved, laid before the praetorian prefect of the east, the same Domitius Modestus who as *comes Orientis* had presided over the trials at Scythopolis (19.12.6). Faced with the prospect of torture in the prefect's court, Palladius announced that what had been discovered was trivial in comparison with what else he knew, and was encouraged – apparently by promise of an amnesty, for he never was punished but on the contrary revelled in his notoriety (29.2.7) – to reveal more. What now emerged was in Ammianus' words an 'endless coil' of crime (29.1.6), an amazing story of dissent and conspiracy: fascinating too for the modern historian interested in the manner and techniques of private divination.³¹

Several men of high rank, including an ex-provincial governor and another who was a court official as well as expert in divination, had made secret enquiries as to who would succeed Valens. By secret methods of enquiry ('motasque secretis artibus sortes') they had learned that they would acquire an 'excellent princeps' but that they, the enquirers, would come to a miserable end (29.1.7). When they asked themselves who was the man in question, the name of Theodorus, second in rank in the corps of *notarii*, came to their mind: and rightly, says Ammianus, for Theodorus, a Gaul, was distinguished in ancestry, educated and erudite, liked by everyone, and in all the virtues superior to the rank and office which he held; 'locoque, quem retinebat, superior videbatur'. This in itself, if it were expressed publicly, comes very close to a treasonable statement. He was also extremely discreet (29.1.8). Other conspirators were named, including a recent *vicarius* of Asia, who also was arrested and placed in custody. The records of the proceedings were in the usual way shown to Valens, who was infuriated – encouraged, Ammianus claims, by the prefect Modestus, who was afraid of losing his post (29.1.11). This may be so, but Modestus would have been guilty of negligence if he had not pressed his view upon the emperor, and such influence and motive are hardly needed to explain the strength of the emperor's reaction.

The preliminary hearings continued ('praeiudicia varia', 29.1.12).³² Theodorus was fetched from Constantinople, where he had gone on family business, suspected accomplices were rounded up from distant

provinces, clapped in irons and put in prison. Theodorus himself, who wore black, having abandoned hope of living ('*praemortuus et atratus*', in Ammianus' bleakly expressive words) was held in a remote place in the countryside of Antioch until the trials were ready to begin.

All of this Ammianus describes with a rhetorical intensity that tends to divert attention from his admission that Valens actually was subject to a conspiracy and had now and earlier been in danger of his life (29.1.15). In particular he had escaped the attack of a *scutarius* called Sallustius as he took his afternoon siesta on the road between Antioch and Seleucia. Other emperors too had escaped such attacks (Commodus and Septimius Severus, adduced at this point, are not the most enticing of parallels) and Valens was entitled to defend himself – but not with cruelty or malice, nor without attempting to distinguish guilt from innocence, driving harmless men into beggary and exile in order to lay hands on their property. We have seen much of this before, as in the suppression of the supporters of Procopius (p. 202). Again, we may sympathise with Ammianus' sentiments without feeling that he has presented the case with much understanding of the emperor's position. It was not as if the guilty and the innocent fell into two neatly separated groups, predestined as in the eye of God for punishment or reward; this was the '*civitas terrena*', the 'earthly city', in which the guilty and the innocent had by the fallible judgment of men to be separated amidst contradiction, recrimination and the playing-off of old scores, and in which much of the behaviour under investigation lay in uncertain territory between the legal and the illegal.³³

Ammianus' description of the trials at Scythopolis began, in keeping with this imagery of Judgment, with the sound of trumpets; '*inflabant litui quaedam colorata laesae crimina maiestatis*' (19.12.1). So too at Antioch, a fanfare of trumpets ('*internarum cladum litui iam sonabant*'), interrupted by a diversion on the emperor's cruelty, then develops into a grotesque fantasia of clanking irons and shouted instructions to apply the tortures, while the various machines, the 'horse', lead weights and lashes, are prepared (29.1.23). As elsewhere, Ammianus renounces the obligation to give a full account of matters so confused and so hard to recall, passing on to a more summary account of what he can remember (29.1.24). He does not however ignore the presence of judicial procedures, reminding us of them in a series of remarks that punctuate the rhetoric and emotional intensity with which events are described. The case of one Pergamius, accused of learning the future by 'criminal imprecations', was dealt with first: he was tortured to the point of expiry and then, almost as if to keep him quiet, executed. Before the judges had yet decided in what order to deal with the cases before them, he had in a flood of terrified eloquence poured out the names of 'thousands' of accomplices the world over; an excessive task for the judges, as Ammianus drily remarks. We then come, '*quasi ad Olympici certaminis pulverem*' (29.1.25), to the case of Theodorus.

Ammianus pauses again to add rhetorical intensity to the scene, but

without losing sight of the procedural development of the trials. The court was formally instituted and the judges declared the law; 'constituto itaque iudicio, et cognitoribus praescripta ostendantibus legum' (29.1.27). What follows is worth waiting for, as the official Hilarius offered to the court a detailed account of the seance in which he had participated. His evidence is presented by Ammianus in the unusual form of an address to the judges in direct speech.³⁴ They had made and consecrated a tripod of laurel wood (it stood before them in the courtroom, having been brought in before Hilarius began to speak) and then, in a house purified by incense, had placed on it a circular plate made of various metals, around the rim of which were engraved at carefully calculated intervals the twenty-four letters of the Greek alphabet. A man performing the role of priest then propitiated by incantations the god of divination and began to swing a metal ring suspended over the centre of the metal plate; the ring too had been consecrated by mystic ritual. The letters on the rim of the plate, marked out by the movements of the magic pendulum, then spelled out a sequence of perfectly formed Greek hexameter verses. They were an oracle revealing the circumstances, as Ammianus indicates a moment later with a citation of three lines, of the emperor's death in war on the 'plains of Mimas' (29.1.31; 33).

When the participants in the seance next enquired who would succeed Valens, the ring indicated the three letters theta, epsilon, omikron. It then added a fourth letter, delta, which seemed enough to indicate the name of Theod(orus); and with that the session ended. Hilarius added, with 'kindly' intent ('benivole'), that Theodorus himself did not know what was being done. When asked by the judges whether the conspirators also had foreknowledge of what was now happening to them, Hilarius quoted the oracle to show that they did, but that the emperor and the judges themselves were also threatened (29.1.33).

After further, conflicting evidence from others, Theodorus was allowed to speak. He began with a prostrate appeal for pardon but in another brusque indication of the actual conduct of the trial was told by the judges to get up and address himself to the point at issue. He then claimed that he had only heard of the affair through someone else and had repeatedly tried to tell the emperor but was dissuaded, on the legally futile but philosophically interesting ground that no actual attempt on the throne was required, since fate would bring about the outcome without anyone's intervention (29.1.34). Theodorus' story was however refuted by the evidence of a letter from him to Hilarius, in which he sought an opportunity to obtain his desire, having conceived hope from soothsayers that he might be successful. The seance was evidently not the only divination that was going on. Theodorus had been making his own enquiries, not being content, as he claimed, to leave the affair passively in the hands of fate; 'spe iam firma concepta ex vatibus, de re non cunctabatur sed tempus patranda cupidinis quaeritabat' (29.1.35).

There is no need to follow Ammianus into the widespread enquiries that now ensued: Eutropius the proconsul of Asia accused but acquitted;

the philosopher Simonides, who admitted knowledge of the fateful oracle but had told no one, laughing at the instability of fortune while burning at the stake; the theurgist Maximus, similarly but perhaps more deeply implicated (he knew the oracle and its interpretation), beheaded at Ephesus, his home city; Alypius, *vicarius* of Britain under Julian, exiled and seeing his son reprieved from execution at the last moment by popular demand while their informer, a lower-class man, was burned alive (29.1.37-44); two brothers who had been joint consuls punished with exile and fines, though later recalled and restored to honour (29.2.9-11).³⁵

It is easy to see how the trials involved matters only indirectly connected with the conspiracy and others far removed from it. If there was any suggestion, as the action of Theodorus implied, that the plan of the fates required human assistance to bring it about, consultation of the fates might well be taken to show that the enquirers were prepared to cast themselves in the role of conspirators, and a favourable response as encouragement to them to do so. A senior *notarius* suffered confiscation of his property for enquiring about the future – on his own account, to find out the sex of a child expected by his wife – being defended from a worse fate by his influential kinsmen. A philosopher was executed by the proconsul of Asia because he had asked his wife in a letter to ‘crown the door of the house’, a proverbial expression signifying that something unusually important is to be done (29.2.25). Also in Asia, a distinguished citizen was put to death because he had cast the horoscope of a man called Valens – his brother, so he said, though the court did not wait for the proof of his claim (29.2.27). Since the brother (assuming that he had existed) was dead, it would appear, ironically, that the horoscope had predicted correctly; had the brother been alive, and the horoscope therefore a failure, he would still have been executed for predicting the death of the emperor.

In all these cases, unjust though the executions may have been, one can see how they came about. The same cannot be said of the punishment of a simple old woman who (again in Asia) was put to death because she cured fevers with a charm, having used the technique, with his knowledge, to cure the daughter of the very proconsul who condemned her (29.2.26); or of a young man beheaded because he was observed in the public baths to touch the wall of the building, and then his breast, while reciting the seven vowels of the Greek alphabet as a remedy for a disorder of the stomach (29.2.28). The seven vowels, mystically connected with the seven planets, figure frequently in Graeco-Roman magical procedures.³⁶ By the terms of the law of Constantine of 318 mentioned earlier (*CTh* 9.16.3), both victims should, if they were telling the truth, have been exempt from execution because they were using magic to benefit the health of the human body, and not to do it harm.

It is not surprising that fears of implication in the prosecutions spread widely, especially among the literate classes of the east. Ammianus writes from his own experience of the atmosphere at Antioch, in which men crept about ‘as if in the shadows of the underworld’, ‘velut in

Cimmeriis tenebris reptabamus' (29.2.4) – recalling the image of darkness with which he earlier described the trials as hidden in the confused shadows of memory; *'ut in tenebrosis rebus confusione cuncta miscente'* (29.1.24). Not only were there indiscriminate executions in the eastern provinces, 'like the slaughtering of cattle' in Ammianus' expression, 'like hens at a banquet' in the colourful phrase of Eunapius referring to the same events (*V. Soph.*, p. 480); whole libraries of books and scrolls were piled up and burned, although most had nothing to do with magic, but were works of literature and legal tomes (29.1.41). Men were so terrified that they even burned their own books for fear of their being examined when their houses were searched, and interpreted maliciously (29.2.4). A familiar story told by John Chrysostom described how when he was young he and a friend one day, when the authorities were searching Antioch for books on sorcery and magic, fished out from the river Orontes a half-written book, to be struck with terror when they saw a soldier nearby; its owner had thrown the book away in fear of being arrested (*PG* 9.273f.).³⁷ It will be recalled that a young senator at Rome was executed for having 'written down' – that is, copied out (*'descripsisse'*) – a book on magic arts (28.1.26).

For the modern observer, one of the most interesting features of the trials of Scythopolis and Antioch is the diverse modes in which knowledge of the future was sought; by written consultation, in person or through agents, of the god at Abydos and, at Antioch, by the use of an ouija board first to produce an oracle in verse and then the name of the favoured successor to Valens. We have already seen one of the purposes of theurgical magic as the eliciting of oracles. Theurgy involved the use of normal magical techniques for religious enlightenment, and the tripod of laurel was constructed by the conspirators at Antioch precisely as set out in a surviving magical papyrus.³⁸ There was naturally some division of opinion as men tried to escape involvement or to pass the blame on to others. One group of defendants maintained that, once the oracle had declared that the 'best man' would become emperor, the enquirers had themselves considered who this might be and had thought of Theodorus: another, that the name of Theodorus was revealed by the ouija board, in the same session that had first produced the oracle. Indeed the description of the seance was only given after conflicting reports had been eliminated by torture and the actual tripod produced in court (29.1.28). The claim that Theodorus was only told afterwards about the consultation was refuted by the letter to Hilarius in which he professed himself ready to secure what he knew 'from soothsayers' was in store for him. We saw that Theodorus' letter also revealed an interesting difference of opinion as to whether it was necessary for men to take active steps to secure what was promised by fate: did human intention itself form part of the fated pattern? The judges posed an equally interesting question to the conspirators, in asking whether they had foreseen the fate that had befallen them. The problem of the failure of men to anticipate, and so to avoid, what would happen to them if divination were a valid

form of knowledge was discussed by Ammianus in his digression on divination, and answered in terms of human error in the interpretation of the divine signs (21.1.13; p. 430). In this instance the conspirators informed the judges that they had indeed known of their fate. Whatever the cost to themselves, the 'conjectures of men' were not in their case at fault.

There was, as in all the best predictions, an element of genuine ambiguity. The oracle that Valens would die in war 'on the plains of Mimas' was taken by the emperor – as, no doubt, by the conspirators – to mean a place near Erythrae in Asia Minor rather than the plains of Thrace near Hadrianople, associated with Mimas by the post eventum 'discovery' of an inscription bearing the name (31.14.9).³⁹ As for the name Theodorus, of which the first letters were produced by the ouija board, perhaps that too was the name already expected and somehow elicited from their seance by the enquirers. It should not have been too difficult to swing the magic pendulum in such a way (in a series of shifting ellipses) that all the letters engraved on the board were indicated in sequence: it would then be for the officiating priest to determine, from his observation of the movements of the pendulum, which were the significant letters of those picked out. This is perhaps how we should reconcile the claim that the conspirators themselves thought of Theodorus with the claim that it was revealed in the seance (29.1.8; 32): both were true, the conspirators already having in mind what they expected to be told. 'THEO...', the letters first produced by the magic ritual, made up one of the commonest elements in Greek proper names, the addition of 'delta' – Ammianus distinguishes this final stage in the revelation (29.1.32) – seeming to be enough to identify Theodorus. It was of course not conclusive. No one thought (how could he?) of the young Spaniard Theodosius, currently an unknown military officer in the west (cf. 29.6.15). Pure coincidence (of course) but it is an important facet of Ammianus' description of the magical procedures, and of his own views on divination, that the conspirators had got the answer right. They should simply have waited for two more letters beyond the 'delta'.

The intensity of Valens' response to the conspiracy of Theodorus is intelligible in another perspective, when we consider it as part of the still active legacy of the reign of Julian. The philosopher Maximus, indefatigable in his pursuit of subversive oracles, is an obvious, and perhaps not deeply regretted, victim of the connection. The proconsul of Asia, Festus of Tridentum (the historian Festus) who came to Ephesus and effected the execution of Maximus and others, is criticised by Ammianus for his cruelty and denounced by Eunapius – falsely, it seems – for his rabid Christianity;⁴⁰ though it was Maximus who in his career had done the greater harm, Ammianus being at best ambiguous on his role under Julian, clearly instrumental with that of the fates in leading the emperor to destruction. The former *vicarius* of Britain Alypius, exiled in the trials, had assisted Julian in his abortive restoration of the temple of Jerusalem (23.1.2f.); like others, he perhaps found his connections with

the emperor hard to shake off. Theodorus himself, an educated and well-born Gaul, can be seen as an early supporter of Julian, who had come to the east with him in 361 and stayed there after the emperor's death. He might then belong to the same political nexus as the historian Eutropius, a cultivated Gaul who had joined Julian in the west and accompanied him on the Persian campaign (*Brev.* 10.16.1); he too fell into danger at the time of the conspiracy of Theodorus (29.1.36). If there was a faction here, it had raised its head earlier. Two supporters of Procopius, Euphrasius and Phronimius, are earlier described as noble and educated Gauls by Ammianus (26.7.4):⁴¹ perhaps they believed, as later did the friends of Theodorus, that the eastern empire could do better than the rough Pannonian who now occupied the throne, and saw in Procopius a more sympathetic successor to Julian, whom they had followed from Gaul to the east in the march against Constantius.

*

The involvement of intellectuals in the enquiries conducted at Antioch was one aspect of the manifold nature of late Roman attitudes to philosophy and magic, science and astrology, religion and the occult. Given also the unifying function of ancient culture and the mobility of the educated classes which this made possible, it is not surprising to find the investigations spreading out from Antioch and Syria to other parts of the east, notably to the cities of Asia. Connections between Syria and Asia Minor were especially strong in the tradition of theurgical Neoplatonism associated with Iamblichus and his followers and adopted by Julian. It was in Asia Minor, not in Syria, that Julian had his 'conversion' to this tradition in Neoplatonism (p. 122f.), and it was back to Syrian Antioch that he took his philosophical supporters from Asia, such as Maximus, when he went east to prepare the Persian campaign.

The role of religion in the affair is much more difficult to define. Despite the involvement of intellectuals and philosophers and its connections with the reign of Julian, in no sense was the conspiracy any sort of 'pagan revival' in the east, nor were the prosecutions an attack on paganism as such. The emperors recognised, and still expressed in their legislation, the difference between the pursuit of magic arts and the worship of the old gods, between astrology and legitimate divination, and (except in the case of Julian, for which he was criticised by Ammianus), between a Classical education and religious belief. But the distinctions cannot in practice be drawn so clearly, there was much scope for distortion, and for genuine as well as wilful misunderstanding. Christians as much as pagans believed in the efficacy of magic, the disagreement between them being one of attitude – whether or not the use of magic was legitimate, whether the deities whom it invoked were true gods (or *daimones*), or evil spirits to be repelled and exorcised. Christians as well as pagans, in the gleeful opinion of the latter and to the embarrassment of Christian bishops, indulged in magical superstitions, wearing amulets and charms,

carrying around sacred texts, 'crossing' themselves – not unlike the young man in the public baths mentioned above – to avert ill-health and misfortune.⁴² The case of the eastern court official who consulted diviners on the sex of the child expected by his wife, has a ready parallel in a long account in Augustine's *Confessions* of discussions in Christian court circles at Milan of the horoscopes of the progeny expected by the wife of a court official and by one of his slaves (*Conf.* 7.6.8f.). Even bishop Athanasius could be accused by his enemies of an illicit interest in the art of foretelling the future, as Ammianus himself records (15.7.8; p. 441).

It is difficult, though not absolutely impossible, to imagine a professed Christian taking an active part in the magical enterprises described to the court at Antioch. Yet many a dutiful bureaucrat no doubt attended church as was expected of him – as did Julian at Vienne before he had declared his apostasy – while reserving his opinion on astrology and divination, and harbouring an interest (forbidden by his bishop) in the occult arts. Fragments of Eunapius preserved by the Suda give in addition to Theodorus the names of three, possibly four, of the conspirators named by Ammianus, adding a further name, Jacobus, which is either the name of a Jew – or of a Christian; he is alleged, how plausibly seems impossible to say, to have drunk poison on the advice of Libanius because he had enquired into the identity of Valens' successor.⁴³ Nothing is positively known of the religious beliefs of Theodorus, but it would be strange to imagine that the conspirators against Valens were connected with Julian the Apostate as shown above, without being connected, at least in public estimation, with his religion.

However one interprets them in this sense, the affairs of Scythopolis and Antioch, ranging in the information they reveal from seances, oracles and their interpretation, to magical charms, harmless superstitions and the raising of ghosts, give a fascinating insight into the variety of pagan belief and its still vigorous residue in east Roman society. As for Rome itself, magic arts in the pursuit of success at the races and in the beds of married women, nothing so creditable can be said; nor, for all his criticism of the conduct of Valentinian's agents there, does Ammianus try to say it.

*

Most of the remainder of Book 29 and the greater part of Book 30 of Ammianus' history are taken up with narrative of western events, although eastern ones are not neglected. Book 31, beginning with a digression on the Huns and Alani, describes the crossing of the Danube by the Goths, culminating in the battle near Hadrianople in Thrace in which the emperor Valens was killed and two-thirds of the eastern field army were destroyed. Ammianus does not waste the opportunity in his obituary of the emperor to remind us of the oracle revealed in the seance at Antioch, quoting again one of the three lines cited in the earlier passage and explaining how the 'plains of Mimas' on which Valens

perished were not, as Homer and Cicero seemed to have indicated, near Erythrae in Asia Minor, but in Thrace (31.14.8, cf. 29.1.33). Circumstantial 'evidence' was naturally provided of the truth of the oracle. An inscription 'was said' to have been found near the place where Valens 'was thought' to have fallen (of course, no one, as Ammianus himself makes perfectly clear, actually knew where this was) bearing the name of one Mimas; the actual text, identifying Mimas as a Macedonian general, being duly produced by later Byzantine sources. Another, longer oracle, of which Ammianus again provides the Greek text, forms part of the sequence of omens with which he actually opened Book 31 of the history. The lines were read on an inscription dug out of the 'ancient walls' of Chalcedon when they were dismantled – in punishment, as other sources tell, for that city's support of the usurper Procopius.⁴⁴

Ammianus further draws together his story in the last episode which he narrates. Julius, *magister militum* in the eastern provinces, in a carefully co-ordinated plan assembled in the parade-grounds of the cities in which they were garrisoned all the Goths already in Roman service, as if to receive arrears of pay. He then had them massacred, an 'efficacious' action by which the eastern provinces were saved from great peril (31.16.8). Eunapius also narrated this episode, alleging that the action was approved by the senate of Constantinople. If this were true, it would be an interesting indication of one of the ways in which the eastern provinces coped with the crisis of authority caused by Valens' death; but the manner and context in which the story is presented inspire little confidence (Zosimus 4.26).⁴⁵ Ammianus for his part describes Julius as *magister militum* 'trans Taurum', thereby locating himself and his reader west of the mountain range that divided Asia Minor from Syria. But we cannot miss the significance of the episode for Ammianus himself. He is describing the liberation from danger of his own native provinces by the initiative of a military commander normally resident in Antioch. It is an unspoken fragment of autobiography, in which Ammianus for the last time enters obliquely into the events he describes. This is immediately confirmed by the epilogue in which Ammianus, the 'soldier and Greek', vainly entrusts the history of the present age to writers of a new generation.

Although in comparison with the earlier books they lack a degree of continuity, the last six books of Ammianus' history are notable for their use of balance and contrast. After the accession of Valentinian and Valens, their division of the empire and the rebellion of Procopius in Book 26, and the campaigns of the two emperors in west and east in Book 27, Books 28 and 29 begin respectively with accusations of magic in upper-class society in west and east; while 30 and 31 close with the deaths and obituary notices of the two emperors. It is indeed possible that some of the difficulties, seen earlier, in Ammianus' narrative of the trials conducted at Rome by Valentinian's agents arise because the historian has tried to present them as a counterpart to the Antiochene trials of Valens, in a way that their substance will not bear; he has tried to

describe as a unified episode with a single meaning events that were in fact disparate, and generally less significant than he makes them.

The more schematic formal character of these books reflects the greater detachment of the historian from the events he describes and the more intractable nature of his source material, not least the division of the empire into western and eastern units of government. It is these considerations rather than any change in the plan of composition that best explain the less integrated, more episodic quality of these in contrast to the earlier books: more like a series of narrative and discursive essays (though Book 31 is a masterpiece of both) than continuous history.

So far, Ammianus the historian has been presented in relation to the events in which he was to different degrees involved as participant or observer, biographical interpretation alternating with excursus within a strict overall structure in a manner that partly reflects his own. It will be obvious that he is a wonderfully eloquent witness of almost every aspect of the life and society of his times. In breadth of interest, wealth of circumstantial detail and power of observation he rivals any other Greek or Roman historian known to us from any period, and outclasses most. As contemporary historians only Thucydides and possibly Polybius have any prior claim to our admiration, and Ammianus' world is so much vaster, its political structures more forbidding, and its cultural complexity far greater than theirs: all seen with the observant eye of an individual fascinated by all forms of human conduct, a still living challenge to the modern historian of his age. In Part Two of this book we therefore turn from Ammianus himself to the description, beginning with the emperors and their office, of the society in which he lived, and for which he provides such a comprehensive wealth of material.

Part Two

Visa vel Lecta

CHAPTER XI

The Office of Emperor

A Roman history running from the principate of Nerva to the death of Valens will naturally assign the central role to the emperors. The personalities and exploits of the emperors of Ammianus' own day dominate his surviving books, just as – to judge by the nature of his back-references – did those of the second, third and early fourth centuries the books that preceded. It may seem impractical to isolate Ammianus' views on the nature of the imperial office, and the documentation of such an all-pervasive issue will inevitably be selective and arbitrary. But that Ammianus did have opinions on the matter will be obvious, and the risk of arbitrary documentation is worthwhile if we may hope to see what they were. The subject is incomplete, however, without a corresponding description of the impact in practice of government on the society of Ammianus' time. 'The Office of Emperor', 'The Character of Government' and 'The Practice of War' are complementary subjects, and should be taken together. If there is some overlap between them, this is justified by the different perspectives that are involved. The first sees the emperors as far as possible in their own right, the second sees them, as it were, from the point of view of their late Roman beneficiary or victim, the third portrays them in their most important single activity. We begin with an occasion notable for the convergence of all three aspects.

*

On 28 April 357 the Emperor Constantius came to Rome on an official visit to his capital city.¹ Ammianus' description of his entry to Rome is classic, both as a demonstration of the historian's technique and visual power, as an evocation of the late Roman imperial office at its most ceremonious, and as a description of one of its best-known actual ceremonies, the imperial arrival or 'adventus'. Constantius approached the city enthroned in a golden carriage, immovable as a statue, amid the glitter of precious stones. He was attended by the emblazoned standards of his army, dragon ensigns fluttering in the breeze;² on either side were mailed infantrymen, their armour fitting as closely as if they too had been bronze statues (16.10.7f.). The emperor was acclaimed by the massed crowds lining the route, while he himself, amid the din, 'never flinched, but showed himself as immobile as he was normally seen in his provinces.



Fig. 1. The Emperor Constantius, seated in consular robes and holding a sceptre, performs the gesture of 'liberalitas'. From his open hand pours coin for the populace, behind his throne are stacked oblong dishes or 'lanxes', intended as largesse for select recipients. The dais, throne and curtains are familiar elements in the imperial iconography of this type. The illustration is from an early seventeenth-century copy of a lost ninth-century MS of the so-called 'Calendar of the Year 354' (H. Stern, *Le Calendrier de 354* [Paris, 1953], pp. 19, 325ff., and pl. XIV). Constantius shared the consulship of 354 with Gallus Caesar, whose corresponding (though standing) image also appears in the Calendar.

He bent his body low when he entered lofty gateways, and kept the gaze of his eyes straight ahead, turning his face neither right nor left, as if his neck were held in a clamp. Like a graven image of a man ('*tamquam figmentum hominis*') he neither allowed his head to shake when the wheel of the carriage jolted, nor was he at any time seen to spit, wipe or rub his face or nose, or to move his hands' (16.10.9f.). The idea was to give an impression of superhuman endurance, granted alone to the emperor, 'as was given to be understood'; '*ut existimari dabatur*' (16.10.11). The whole passage, one of the most famous in Ammianus, is anticipated in remarkably similar terms in Xenophon's book *Cyropaedeia* or 'Education of Cyrus', where the author, writing of Cyrus' methods in establishing his royal power, comes to his recognition of the need to 'bewitch' his subjects by certain facets of deportment:³

Rulers ought not to differ from their subjects simply by being better than they, but ought as it were to cast a spell on them. At any rate [Cyrus] elected to wear Median dress himself and persuaded his associates also to do the same; the purpose of this being to conceal any physical defect and make its wearers look tall and handsome. They have footwear so designed that by adding something beneath the soles they can appear taller than they are without this being realised. He also encouraged the making up of the eyes to enhance their beauty and the use of cosmetics, to make the complexion seem finer than it really is. He taught his associates also *not to be seen spitting or wiping the nose in public, nor to turn their heads round to gaze at anything – as if they were men whom nothing could surprise.* (*Cyrop.* 8.1.40-2)

According to Herotodus (1.99), who claims it to have been an offence for a subject to laugh or to spit in the royal presence, Persian regal ceremonial had been established by Cyrus' ancestor Deioces, with the purpose of exalting the king and setting him apart from potential rivals, equal in birth and virtue. The tendency of the prescribed behaviour is to eliminate spontaneity in favour of a static symbolism of power, and to suggest in the monarch reserves of self-control beyond normal human possibilities – to impose him as if by magical force upon his subjects.

The political and ceremonial setting of Constantius' visit to Rome was actually rather complex. Within its span, on 22 May, fell the twentieth anniversary of the death of Constantine the Great, and so of the accession as full Augustus of Constantius. One source indeed reports of the visit to Rome that he 'celebrated his vicennalia' there (*Cons. Const.* s.a. 357); he had already, at Arles on 10 October 353, given public games to commemorate the thirtieth anniversary of his first promotion to the rank of Caesar by Constantine (14.5.1). The specific opportunity for the visit to Rome was provided by Constantius' continued presence in the west after the defeat of Magnentius, followed by the need for political and military reconstruction there. It is this military and triumphal aspect of the *adventus* that Ammianus emphasised. He saw the visit as a celebration of victories in civil war, by an emperor whose record in foreign campaigns

did not merit it.⁴ Constantius never defeated any foreign people that made war on him, nor did he ever stand in the first line of battle, nor add to the territory of the empire; he merely wished to demonstrate imperial power to a Roman people living in peace and quiet, neither expecting nor desiring to see anything like it (16.10.2). The emperor carried himself 'as if he were off to intimidate Euphrates or Rhine with a show of arms', and his motionless, imperturbable posture was such as it was commonly seen in the provinces (10.6.9). In effect a triumph over Roman blood shed in civil war, the procession was inappropriate for the seat and shrine of empire, the residence of peace, civility and freedom. Once he was inside the city, indeed, Constantius' behaviour was transformed. He addressed the senators in the senate-house, the people from the tribunal in the forum, he held equestrian games and delighted in the friendly shouts of the people, who managed to respect both due modesty and their traditions of liberty. The emperor on his side maintained proper decorum, even allowing the chariot races to reach their own outcome. In other cities, it is implied, he imposed his own discretion on the results of races, presumably by indicating in advance which result he would prefer (10.13f.).

Many of these features of imperial behaviour were obligatory for the occasion, and appear as such in other sources. The acclamations of the people assembled to receive the emperor, mentioned by Ammianus (16.10.9), are described by the poet Claudian, in his panegyric on Honorius' sixth consulship of 404; so too the cheerful exchanges between emperor and people alluded to by Ammianus:⁵

quantamque rependit
maiestas alterna vicem, cum regia circi
conexum gradibus veneratur purpura vulgus
adsensuque cavae sublatus in aethera vallis
plebis adoratae reboat fragor, unaque totis
intonat Augustum septenis arcibus Echo!
(*VI Cons. Hon.* 612-17)

As for the emperor's relations with the nobility of Rome, not only did he address its members formally in the senate-house; according to the panegyrist Pacatus, Theodosius during his visit of 389 attended senators in their own homes. The emperor would dismiss his military escort and enter the senatorial mansion in what Pacatus significantly – because it excludes precisely what Ammianus found *inappropriate*, at least in Constantius' initial posture – calls '*civili progressu*' (*Paneg.* 47.3).⁶ Not only the individual elements in imperial behaviour, but also the transition, on reaching Rome, from 'military' to 'civil' modes of conduct, were aspects of the recognised protocol of such occasions.

No one would suppose that these modes of conduct were more than relics of the past, handed down from the distant days when an emperor's reputation had stood or fallen on the quality of his relations with the

senate and people of Rome. Fourth-century emperors rarely visited Rome, and impinged only occasionally on the life of the city. In his panegyric of 404, Claudian only recognised three such occasions (*VI Cons. Hon.* 392-5); he was referring, no doubt, to one of the visits of Constantine the Great, the visit of Constantius, and that of Theodosius in 389.⁷ Ammianus was for his part too much of a realist to suppose that an emperor should be judged merely, or even primarily, in the context of his relations with the city of Rome and its senatorial class. Yet the senate attached importance to the manner of its treatment by Constantius. We saw earlier how, three years after the visit, in the course of his march against Constantius Julian wrote to the senate a letter of self-justification for his action in proclaiming himself against the emperor, and added sharp comments directed against him. The senate resented this, and demanded in acclamations that Julian should respect the author of his dignity; 'auctori tuo reverentiam rogamus' (21.10.7). This, said Ammianus, was a fine demonstration of the independent spirit of the nobility, and showed its affection for Constantius. The orator Symmachus, addressing the Emperor Valentinian II in 384, recalled another aspect of Constantius' visit; apart from the admiring inspection of old temples also mentioned by Ammianus, Constantius had in his capacity as *pontifex maximus* filled vacancies in the colleges of priests by appointing nobles to them (*Rel.* 3.7). In so doing, he allowed his personal commitment to the Christian religion to yield to the public duties of *pontifex maximus*; another among many instances of the pressures still exerted by ancestral traditions on the developing institutions of the new empire of the fourth century.

Ammianus is unsympathetic to one particular innovation of imperial protocol that was prevalent in his own day. He criticised Constantius for his ambition to model his rule on that of the 'civiles principes' of earlier times, while styling himself in dictated letters as 'Aeternitas Mea' and, in letters written with his own hand, 'Master of the entire world'. This, thought Ammianus, was a departure from 'justice' indulged in by Constantius after the execution of Gallus, when his courtiers persuaded him that his virtue and fortune were without limit, and that he was free from the normal inconveniences of mortality (15.1.3).

Ammianus' objection is a curious one. Apart from its triviality as an instance of the point of principle at stake, he must have known that the style to which he refers was commonplace in imperial pronouncements of the times.⁸ In his obituary notice of Constantius, Ammianus produced a more considered assessment of the public aspects of an emperor's position. He here wrote that Constantius treated the imperial office with the dignity due to it. In an allusion to the raised boot worn by dramatic actors – reminiscent of the raised 'Median shoe' mentioned by Xenophon – he remarked that Constantius always kept on the trappings of imperial authority and despised the pursuit of mere 'popularity'; 'imperatoriae auctoritatis cothurnum ubique custodiens popularitatem elato animo contemnebat et magno' (21.16.1). This, the first of the points offered in

favour of Constantius in the obituary notice, contrasts sharply with Ammianus' judgment of Julian, that he fed on the applause of the multitude, seeking praise without restraint even on the most trivial of matters, affecting in his thirst for popularity to converse with the unworthy; 'vulgi plausibus laetus, laudum etiam ex minimis rebus intemperans appetitor, popularitatis cupiditate cum indignis loqui saepe affectans' (25.4.18).

Ammianus had illustrated this opinion in narrating a number of episodes that occurred at Constantinople in the early part of 362. On the first day of the consular year, Julian appeared in public in humble guise, processing on foot among the 'honorati' rather than riding apart from them. Some liked this, wrote Ammianus, others thought it a cheap affectation, 'affectatum et vile' (22.7.1).⁹ Then, when the consul presided over circus games and slaves were led in according to custom to be manumitted, Julian pronounced the appropriate formula himself, forgetting that on this occasion the jurisdiction belonged to the consul. Julian fined himself ten pounds of gold, as having committed a breach of legal propriety (22.7.2). In the same months, Julian often took his seat in the senate of Constantinople to consider problems of government and to hear cases at law. On one such occasion, the arrival from Asia was announced of the philosopher Maximus. Julian leapt up unceremoniously and, *forgetting who he was* ('qui esset, oblitus') went charging out of the senate to greet his friend, whom he then kissed, received with reverence (that is, as an equal or superior, and not as an emperor receives a subject), and escorted into the senate (of which he was not a member). For Ammianus, the episode seemed to show Julian as an ostentatious seeker for glory, like those philosophers who, according to Cicero, wrote books denouncing fame and ambition, yet put their names to them (22.7.3f.). It is interesting that Maximus' progress from Asia to Constantinople was viewed, from the standpoint of a provincial writer, as a demonstration of pomp and ostentation just as unsuitable for a philosopher as Julian's spontaneous humility was for an emperor (Eunapius, *V. Soph.* p. 442). To each his proper mode of conduct – an ironic reflection on Julian's dream of being like a Platonic philosopher-king. The two modes of life were, in late Roman conditions, simply incompatible.

An emperor ought in his public appearances to set a certain standard of dignified behaviour, to do otherwise being a perverse ostentation. The worst aspects of a lack of dignity are brought out in Ammianus' description of the usurpation of Procopius in 365. Procopius was put up by soldiers in the Anastasian baths at Constantinople, and awaited his public presentation pale and nervous, as if he had been dragged up from the underworld.¹⁰ Since no proper cloak could be found, he was dressed in a gold-throated tunic, so that above his waist he looked like a palace attendant, below it like a slave from the palace training school. He wore purple slippers, carried a spear and held in his hand a piece of purple cloth. Pursuing the dramatic metaphor of the 'cothurnus' used of Constantius, Ammianus remarked that Procopius resembled a stage

apparition, a fancy-dress mockery of the real thing; 'ut in theatrali scaena simulacrum quoddam insigne per aulaeum vel mimicam cavillationem subito putares emersum' (26.6.15). The affair was a ludicrous disgrace, deserving scorn and hilarity had not the outcome been so disastrous; 'ad hoc dehonestamentum honorum omnium ludibriose sublatum ... irrisione digna principia incaute coepta et temere, ad ingemiscendas erupisse rei publicae clades' (26.6.16; 19). Ammianus' expressions carry portentous weight, further increased by their allusion to some famous words of the historian Sallust. In a speech assigned to the consul Lepidus, Sallust referred to one Fufidius, a centurion promoted senator by the dictator Sulla – an unsuitable parallel, no doubt, for a relative of Constantine made emperor, but the basis for a magnificently resonant allusion instantly recognisable to Ammianus' more literate readers; 'quibus praelatus in magistratibus capiundis Fufidius, ancilla turpis, *honorum omnium dehonestamentum*?' (*Hist.* 1.55.21). Ammianus confirms the allusion to Sallust by adding the phrase '*ancillari adulatione*' to describe the self-abasing manner in which Procopius addressed his supporters (26.6.16).¹¹

The proper conduct of Roman emperors, like any question of protocol, was a matter of what was fitting for time, place and company. That it was necessary to accept certain restraints upon personal conduct is no more than one would expect. A *magister militum* made emperor in 421 is said to have regretted his promotion because he was no longer free to come and go as he chose and was unable to play games as he was used to; he had formerly enjoyed himself hugely at banquets, often joining in the antics of mime dancers as they performed before the guests!¹² According to Ammianus, the Emperor Jovian was known for his drinking and eating habits, and for his over-indulgence in sex – faults which he would perhaps have corrected had he lived, out of respect for the imperial office; 'quae vitia imperiali verecundia forsitan correxisset'. He is also said to have been of vivacious expression and is compared with Constantius in that he often worked in the afternoons (the usual time for rest and relaxation) and did not mind being seen joking with his friends; 'iocarique palam cum proximis assuetus' (25.10.14f.). Ammianus' comparison of Jovian with Constantius on this point of *informality* well emphasises what was exceptional in that emperor's public conduct during the ceremonial visit to Rome in 357.

The personalities and tastes of emperors as they appear in Ammianus can indeed be at variance with his descriptions of their conduct in office. The most striking instance is that of the formidable, warlike Valentinian, who is said to have liked 'elegant but not extravagant' dinner-parties. He wrote in an attractive hand, painted and modelled 'charmingly' ('venuste' is Ammianus' unexpected word); perhaps more in keeping with one's expectations, he liked inventing new types of military equipment, but in general was rather fastidious in his taste; 'amator munditiarum' (30.9.4). One might see the emperor as a connoisseur of miniatures, something of an amateur artist and draftsman – an impression hard to reconcile with

that of an emperor who could be described as 'roaring' his objections to the presence of a petitioner, could order the head of another to be struck off importunately, have clubbed to death a young groom who released a hound prematurely and kept man-eating bears outside his bedroom, making sure that they were otherwise not over-fed (29.3.3ff.; p. 260). The poet Ausonius, employed by Valentinian to tutor his son in the literary arts, flattered the emperor as a man of erudition, capable of exchanging Vergilian tags around the dinner-table; 'vir meo iudicio eruditus' (*Cento Nuptialis*, praef.).¹³ In striking contrast is his brother Valens, described by Ammianus as 'uncultivated, untrained in liberal studies', as 'uneducated and rude'; 'subagrestis ingenii, nec bellicis nec liberalibus studiis eruditus ... inconsummatus et rudis' (31.14.5; 8). Yet Valens accepted literary dedications from the historians Eutropius and Festus, and consulted 'learned men' on the interpretation of the prophetic verses that indicated where he would meet his end (31.14.8). Julian was in all respects a special case; as for Constantius, his literary ambitions were frustrated by bluntness of intellect. After failing in rhetoric he turned to writing poetry but did not achieve much in that field either (21.16.4).

The physical appearances of the emperors are described by Ammianus in the authentic manner of Classical biography.¹⁴ Constantius was dark, with soft hair and smoothly shaven cheeks, had rather bulging but sharp-sighted eyes, was long in the body and short in the legs and good at running and jumping (21.16.19); Julian of medium height with strong neck and shoulders, keen eyes, pendulous lower lip and – his personal eccentricity – a long beard, trimmed to a point (25.4.22); Jovian was very tall and dignified in bearing, with a slight stoop, grey eyes and the vivacious expression just mentioned (25.10.14, cf. 5.6). Valentinian was powerful and well-proportioned, with regular features, healthy complexion, grey-eyed with a severe, observant expression and of great physical presence when addressing a crowd (30.9.6, cf. 26.2.5); his brother was of average height with a protruding stomach, dark complexion and a defect in one eye, not apparent from a distance (31.14.7). Ammianus allows us to see his emperors as human beings despite the pressures and constraints of their office. They are required on appropriate occasions to show an almost superhuman endurance but do not conform to any stereotype of character or physical appearance, in which some imperfections, studiously disguised in their more ceremonious performances, were only perceptible at close quarters and in more intimate circumstances.

*

That Ammianus recognised the complexity of the relationship between the personal character of an emperor and the nature of the imperial office is clear at once from those 'faults' which Jovian would have corrected had he lived, from a sense of respect ('verecundia') for his new position. Ammianus cited Valentinian's opinion on the tendency of the strict exercise of power to provoke envy and misinterpretation (30.8.10),¹⁵ and,

introducing his obituary notice of Valentinian, observed in a beautiful phrase how the possession of power is liable to lay bare the intimate reaches of the soul, revealing there good and bad alike; 'vitorum ... vel bonorum, quae potestatis amplitudo monstravit nudare solita semper animorum interna' (30.7.1)

It was especially in these obituary notices that Ammianus gave his most concentrated statements of the qualities shown by emperors and the expectations held of them.¹⁶ The obituaries are valuable for another reason, for it is here that he is likely to assume a consensus of opinion among his readers against which to measure his judgment of their virtues and shortcomings. In general, he offers in these passages candid verdicts on the achievements and shortcomings of emperors – which is not to say that they are free from normal techniques of rhetorical presentation designed to influence the reader's opinion.

The techniques are particularly evident in the obituary notices of Constantius and Julian. In the case of Constantius (21.16.1-18), the register of virtues, stated plainly without much elaboration, runs to seven sections of text (16.1-7); the shortcomings add up to eleven sections (8-18), an ascendancy of vice over virtue achieved largely by the accumulation of rhetorical parallels ranging from Manlius (in a citation of Cicero) to Gallienus, to illustrate the vices. As we saw earlier the obituary of Julian deters objective analysis by its presentation, in the long discussion of Julian's virtues, in terms of the four cardinal virtues defined by the 'philosophers', supported by four corresponding 'external characteristics' of virtue (25.4.1). The obituary has also to be read as the culmination of at least two preceding passages which bear many of the features of panegyric (16.1.1ff.; 5.1ff.). Julian's shortcomings, on the other hand, are presented briefly, and as of little significance compared with the virtues. They have to be considered very carefully by Ammianus' reader if he is to understand how important they are in the context of the emperor's aims and policies, and how insufficiently emphasised by the historian.¹⁷

In these passages, setting virtues against vices in balancing sections, Ammianus writes in the manner of the Classical biographers, sharing their tendency to attribute to the personal characters of rulers actions that are better understood in terms of the situations in which they found themselves. To take an obvious example, the need to raise money may have the best possible justification in terms of the external pressures upon emperors, but will be seen as an expression of their personal greed, 'avaritia'. Ammianus wrote that Valentinian was avaricious, without distinguishing between good and evil; 'aviditas plus habendi sine honesti praeque differentia' (30.8.8). Some excused this by reference to the situation in which Valentinian was placed, that is the immense waste of Julian's Persian campaign, which had left his successor short of troops and the money to recruit and pay them. Ammianus rejected this argument, on the grounds that whatever the circumstances there are limits to what is permitted, even when the power exists; yet his use at

this point of an anecdote showing Themistocles' contempt for personal gain merely repeats a confusion of private avarice with the public stringencies that emperors were from time to time forced to impose.

We cannot expect Ammianus, or any ancient writer, to have seen such issues other than in terms of the personal character of emperors. The Christian apologist Lactantius had similarly attributed Diocletian's financial strictness to his 'avarice' (*Mort. Pers.* 7.2), much as that emperor had himself, in his *Edict on Maximum Prices*, blamed monetary inflation on the 'avarice' of tradesmen aimed, we are asked to believe, at victimising his innocent, defenceless army (praef. 12f.). Ammianus does however imply a distinction between certain irregular ways of raising money frequently resorted to by emperors, such as the confiscation of the wealth of the rich by political prosecutions, and the conduct of regular taxation. Perhaps this is what Ammianus intends to convey in his phrase quoted above, 'sine ... honesti pravique differentia'. Unless he intends some such distinction, Ammianus is guilty of inconsistency, for in their obituaries he records among the virtues of both Valentinian and Valens that they were noted for their restraint in the taxation of provinces. Valens was an 'extremely fair protector of the provinces, whose indemnities he maintained as if they were part of his private household, while urgently attempting to ease the burdens of taxation'; 'tributorum onera studio quodam molliens singulari' (31.14.2). Valentinian is similarly said to have lightened tax burdens; 'tributorum ubique molliens sarcinas' (30.9.1).

This is an interesting judgment even when confined to the domain of taxation, given the exceptions recorded by Ammianus. In the opening years of his reign, Valens is alleged to have raked in tax arrears dating back almost a century, to the days of the Emperor Aurelian, a policy assigned not directly to Valens himself but to his father-in-law Petronius, to escape whose rapacity many men were said to have favoured Procopius (26.6.7ff.). The chief exception to the otherwise moderate policy of Valentinian was his praetorian prefect, Petronius Probus, whose financial ravages in Illyricum Ammianus is not the only author to denounce (30.5.4ff.). It is difficult to see this passage as other than a contradiction of Ammianus' conclusion that Valentinian was sparing of his provincials and tried always to lighten their tax burdens; except that when he heard of it the emperor tried, but failed, to put a stop to Probus' conduct.¹⁸ Of other emperors described by Ammianus, Constantius was ruthless in raising and exacting taxes, the inexhaustible rapacity of his demands bringing him more unpopularity than money; 'plus odiorum ei quam pecuniam conferentium' (21.16.17). Added to this, he never heard an appeal against a tax assessment nor offered any indemnity: he had of course to finance his interminable civil and foreign wars. Julian, by contrast, remitted many overdue taxes ('diuturnitate congesta') and refused the imperial treasury any advantage over private plaintiffs in cases of dispute at law (25.4.15). We may recall his reduction of the tax assessment in Gaul at the beginning of his regime as Caesar there from

twenty-five to seven *solidi*. The justification of the reform, that it was better to set a modest rate of taxation and collect it successfully than to make excessive demands and be forced to grant indulgences, tells as much about the ability of better-placed provincials to defend their interests as about the pressures exerted on them by imperial authorities (16.5.14f.; p. 89).

On a different matter, Valentinian was rather inclined to severity – forgetting no doubt that a man holding great power must avoid all forms of excess ‘like headlong cliffs’; ‘omnia nimia velut praecipites scopuli sunt evitanda’. He never remitted a death sentence, as even the most savage of emperors sometimes did, and was inclined to order the use of torture in judicial enquiries (30.8.2f.). So too Constantius was suspicious and harsh in cases of *maiestas*, again tending to permit torture and even devising new forms of execution (21.16.7ff.). In such cases, wrote Ammianus, Constantius hated ‘with a capital hatred’ the right course of action, though anxious to be known as a just and clement emperor (21.16.11). Here again, Ammianus has allowed interpretations of the personality of emperors to become confused with judgments of public policy, attributing to shortcomings of personal character a procedure, the use of torture, that was long established in the public law of the Roman empire. Ammianus understood this perfectly well, as is clear from his short digression on the treason laws of the Republic (19.12.17). As in the case of finance, a distinction can be made that helps to preserve Ammianus’ consistency. He regarded these emperors as having crossed the borderline between true discipline and vindictiveness, or to have allowed their quest for gain (by confiscating the property of the condemned) to override the restraints of the laws. He makes the distinction explicit in saying on one occasion that Constantius pursued cases of *maiestas* more severely than was correct or proper; ‘acrius exsurgens quam civiliter’ (21.16.9).¹⁹

Among the examples adduced by Ammianus to illustrate the conduct of the emperors of his own day, the holders of that office in the earlier period of Roman history are naturally given a prominent role. Constantius II provides a rich selection, particularly as regards his shortcomings of character and policy. In other ways a moderate emperor, in his pursuit of charges of treason Constantius easily surpassed in cruelty Caligula, Domitian and Commodus, especially at the beginning of his reign, when he murdered all his relations – an interesting hint of what Ammianus had written, in one of the lost books, of the events following the death of Constantine the Great in 337 (21.16.8; p. 84). He exceeded even Gallienus, an emperor who, frequently harassed by actual plots and conspiracies (Ammianus cites those of Aureolus, Postumus, Ingenuus, Valens also named Thessalonicus, and ‘many others’), was nevertheless often lenient in judging them. Constantius on the other hand invented capital accusations from quite trivial circumstances. In this he was unlike Marcus Aurelius, who burned documents incriminating supporters of the rebel Avidius Cassius in order to avoid making unnecessary enemies (16.11). In a slightly different perspective, when Ursicinus fell

under the threat of accusation at the court of Constantius, his prospects are indicated by reference to the fate of Domitius Corbulo, who 'is said' to have been killed 'in the polluted depravity of the age of Nero'; 'in colluvione illa Neroniani saeculi' (15.2.5). The allusion is picked up again by Ammianus in referring to the *magister militum* Theodosius, who achieved distinction under Valentinian. He is here compared with Domitius Corbulo and Lusius Quietus 'of olden times, of whom one flourished under Nero, the other under Trajan' (29.5.4). Ammianus does not need to say that both these generals were killed (or forced to suicide) by Roman emperors; Corbulo by Nero, Lusius Quietus in the turbulence attending the succession of Hadrian in AD 117. The allusions enable Ammianus to acknowledge the fact of the execution of Theodosius in 376 without having to explain the circumstances.²⁰

Of Constantius' successors, Valentinian is similarly equipped with a range of historical *exempla*, including emperors of earlier times, to help define and illuminate aspects of his character.²¹ Among Valentinian's faults was his cruelty, a shortcoming which the emperor could have corrected had he contemplated the example of the Persian king Artaxerxes known as Macrochira, the 'Long-handed'; he devised symbolic punishments so as to avoid penalties characteristic of the government of kings, like beheading, or lopping off the ears of victims (30.8.4). The Republican magistrate Papirius Cursor spared a praetor of Praeneste who had failed to bring reinforcements rapidly in the Samnite Wars, but did not through his clemency sacrifice respect or martial glory. He alone, it was believed, could have resisted Alexander the Great had he invaded Italy – an untestable hypothesis but relevant to Valentinian, who was known both for his military achievements and for his tendency to punish in haste (30.8.5). As to his avidity for financial gain, some justified this by the parallel of Aurelian, who had found the treasury empty after the reign of Gallienus. In his hatred for the upper classes, Valentinian wanted for himself a monopoly of 'bonae artes', a fault which 'we read' was particularly severe in the case of Hadrian; 'quo vitio exarsisse principem legimus Hadrianum' (30.8.10). Valentinian was also overbearing in manner but could be reduced to submission by the emotion of fear. Knowing this, a *magister officiorum* on one occasion mentioned the subject of barbarian incursions in order to curb the emperor's anger: upon which he was as calm and kindly as Antoninus Pius (30.8.12)! In all, there was much in Valentinian's reign worthy of emulation. Had he restrained his shortcomings, indeed, he would have been 'like a second Trajan or Marcus'. This is said with particular reference to his care for the well-being of provincials, his restraint in matters of taxation, and the strictness of his military discipline (30.9.1).

The case of Julian, who is compared in foresight with Titus, in warlike prowess with Trajan, in mildness with Antoninus Pius, and in his pursuit of true reason with his admired model Marcus Aurelius, is discussed elsewhere, as fundamental not only to Ammianus' conception of an ideal emperor but to his entire intellectual and historiographical development

(pp. 468ff.). A brief digression on the character of Gratian – whose death in 383 closely precedes the period in which Ammianus was composing his history – shows him as ‘eloquent, restrained, warlike and tolerant’, indeed emulating the conduct of the best emperors, until he was led astray by obsequious advisers and turned to the ‘vain pursuits of Caesar Commodus’: though Gratian, unlike Commodus, was not known for the letting of human blood. Ammianus comments that the situation of empire (the context is the preliminaries of the battle of Hadrianople, with Gratian bringing reinforcements to Valens) required rather a Marcus Aurelius than an insubstantial dilettante. Not that even Marcus could in Ammianus’ opinion have remedied the situation ‘without colleagues after his own character and sober wisdom in counsel’; ‘sine collegis similibus et magna sobrietate consiliorum’ (31.10.18f.).²²

These parallels were no mere literary exercise. They provided a framework within which Ammianus’ readers were expected to judge the conduct of the emperors of their own day and to compare them with their counterparts in earlier ages. Further, as instances of correct behaviour they were accessible in literature to contemporary emperors, who should permit themselves to be guided by them. If Valentinian failed to imitate the clemency of Papirius Cursor or the restraint of Themistocles, it was because he ‘did not know’ the example or ‘pretended not to know’ that certain things, though possible for one holding supreme power, are not permitted; ‘haec forsitan Valentinianus ignorans’ ... ‘dissimulans scire quod sunt aliqua quae fieri non oportet, etiam si licet ...’ (30.8.6; 9). There is nothing more profoundly Classical in Ammianus than the belief, implied by these words, in the relevance of historical models of behaviour, and in knowledge as the source of true moral action.

If the actions of earlier emperors were guides to the contemporary conduct of the imperial office, we have evidently to assume a compatibility at some level between emperors of the early and later periods of Roman history, and it is worth asking how Ammianus saw the relationship between them. The age of Augustus was indeed far in the past (as far from Ammianus, it is a sobering thought, as Elizabeth I is from us), and Ammianus’ expressions can reflect this. Comparing efforts made in early and recent times to transport obelisks from Egypt to Rome, he designates Augustus (whom he calls ‘Octavianus Augustus’) as an ‘emperor of old’; ‘veterem principem’ (17.4.12). He praises Domitian’s prohibition of the practice of castration as an event, as we might say, of ‘olden times’; ‘iuvat veterem laudare Domitianum ...’ (18.4.5). On the other hand, the episode in which Diocletian made Galerius walk before his carriage after his Persian defeat is described as ‘not such an ancient example’; ‘non adeo vetus exemplum’ (14.11.10). The phrase, interesting for its hint that an *exemplum*, a model of correct behaviour, would normally be expected to be ‘vetus’, is here attributed by Ammianus to the Emperor Constantius, in trying to persuade Gallus Caesar to leave Antioch and return obediently to him. Ammianus can similarly contrast what he saw as the military indiscipline of his own day with the situation

under Galerius, characterising that as a 'recent' period of history; 'contra quam recens memoria tradidit; notum est enim sub Maximiano [sc. Galerio] Caesare ...' (22.4.8). Coming to an end in 305, the Tetrarchy was indeed, for Ammianus as a young man, within reach of the living memory of many who had seen it. One of the minor delights of the Persian campaign of Julian was the discovery in the Persian town of Anatha of an old soldier of Galerius who had been captured by the Persians as a young man, stayed in Persia and raised a family. He was now a bent old man claiming nearly a hundred years; 'centenario iam contiguus' (24.1.10; p. 172).

To see a continuity, in which Greek and early Roman, occasionally even foreign parallels, are no less relevant to his own age than those from the earlier imperial period, Ammianus must clearly be expressing himself in a moral rather than in a political or institutional sense. For he well understood that the institutional character of the imperial office had changed much since the early empire. Ammianus makes clear that he knew this in describing the restoration to favour of Ursicinus at the time of the rebellion of Silvanus in 355. The general is summoned to the consistory and introduced by the 'Master of Admissions'. He is then 'offered the purple': that is, he is invited to kiss the edge of the imperial robe in the ceremony known as 'adoratio' (sc. 'purpurae'). The ritual marks Ursicinus' restoration to favour after a phase in which his reputation has been under a cloud. As we saw earlier, he was encouraged by the gesture to embark on a speech of self-defence, but was cut short by the emperor's observation that this was no moment for recrimination, but for concord and co-operation.

The introduction of the custom of *adoratio* is attributed by Ammianus, in explanation of this passage, to an emperor who had brought it in as a 'foreign rite and royal custom' ('extero ritu et regio more'), emperors of earlier times having, 'as we read', been greeted in the manner of civil governors; 'cum semper antea ad similitudinem iudicum salutatos principes legerimus' (15.5.18).²³ The name of the emperor responsible for the innovation does not now stand in Ammianus' text as we have it, but comparison with other writers, using language closely similar to his, makes it clear that it was Diocletian. Aurelius Victor wrote that Diocletian was the first emperor since Caligula and Domitian to allow himself to be openly addressed as 'dominus', to be 'adored' ('adorari') and to be called a god. He too, expressing in this a despotic and overbearing arrogance, first had gold thread woven into silken robes, adorned himself with purple and his shoes with precious stones (*Caesares* 39.2f.). A similar though much briefer notice in Eutropius' *Breviarium* of about 370 (8.26) permits the inference on technical grounds that the source of information on the matter was a lost Latin imperial history written in the time of Constantine and used by Aurelius Victor and Eutropius.²⁴ Whether Ammianus knew this history at first hand or depended on Eutropius' or some other version of it is not clear, nor need we pursue the question here in order to establish two fundamental points; first, that the

more resplendent ceremonial deportment of the Roman emperors, as introduced by Diocletian, was for contemporaries a point of distinction between the emperors of the earlier and those of the later period; and second, that the ceremonial was itself perceived to be of foreign origin. For all the uncertainties surrounding the late fourth-century collection of imperial biographies known as the *Historia Augusta*, its author expresses a contemporary attitude in alleging that Alexander Severus prohibited 'adoration' of himself, which his predecessor Elagabalus had encouraged, 'in the manner of Persian kings'; 'regum more Persarum' (*Alex.* 18.3). The contrast was symbolic of the distinction between the ideal Roman 'princeps', Alexander Severus, and the grotesque Oriental despot whom he succeeded. According to Herodian (5.6.10) Elagabalus used to go out in public with made-up eyes and cheeks painted with rouge, in a curious and possibly even conscious evocation of the Persian habit mentioned at the beginning of this chapter.

Now it is not true, or at best it is over-simplified, to say with Aurelius Victor that emperors were not regarded as gods before the time of Diocletian.²⁵ So, too, early emperors other than Domitian were addressed as 'dominus', and without provoking objection; it is the standard form of address used by the younger Pliny in his letters to Trajan, that most respectful and 'civil' of emperors. Expressions of the 'sacredness' of the imperial person are also found much earlier than the Tetrarchy, by which time they are commonplace in panegyric. The *Digest* refers more than once to 'sacrae constitutiones' in the sense of 'imperial' constitutions cited by the Classical lawyers (e.g. 41.1.5 praef.). That these references need not be late interpolations is shown by part of the reply to a petition to Commodus referring to a 'sacra subscriptio domini nostri' (*ILS* 6870), and there are other such instances.²⁶ The statements of Aurelius Victor and other writers as to the extent of the innovations introduced by Diocletian and their historical origins are therefore factually questionable, but as to the meaning and function of late Roman ceremonial one thing is clear, and very important: that late Romans themselves believed, both that the ceremonial itself was brought in by Diocletian, and that it was of foreign, specifically of Persian, origin. Their view of the elaborate ceremonial forms surrounding the emperors and dividing them from their subjects reflected their own conviction that they were living under an Oriental, or despotic, system of government, removed both in time and in principle from the tolerant equality, or *civilitas*, in social and political relations maintained by the best of the early emperors.

It is then interesting that Ammianus, in saying merely that he had 'read' of the origins of the ceremony of *adoratio*, and introducing the subject only to explain the act of protocol in which Ursicinus was invited to participate, seems not to imply that he attached any particular importance to it. He gives no indication of having mentioned the matter – as would have been easy for him to do, by adding a short phrase such as he often uses to indicate a back reference – in his lost books on the reign of Diocletian. He reports the origin of *adoratio* dispassionately and

without personal commitment, an absence of feeling that is worth reflection – especially when we consider that not only Ursicinus, but Ammianus himself on his promotion as *protector domesticus*, will have taken part in the ceremony.

The ceremony of *adoratio* is on one level an act of submission to an Oriental despot. For Ursicinus, however, the act marked his restoration to favour after a period of uncertainty. This aspect is made very clear by Ammianus. Ursicinus was ‘honourably’ admitted by the *magister admissionum* – ‘qui mos est honorator’ – and ‘calmly’ offered the purple to kiss; ‘multo quam antea placidius’. When he embarks on his speech of self-defence he is ‘gently’ stopped by the emperor; ‘oratione leni prohibet imperator’ (15.5.18ff.). The atmosphere after the act of *adoratio* is far more relaxed than before it.

In another case mentioned by Ammianus, an official called Thalassius is accused of having plotted against Gallus Caesar and in consequence excluded from Julian’s favour. More precisely, he is prevented from ‘adoring and being present among the *honorati*’; ‘adorare adesseque officio inter honoratos prohibito’. In due course, Julian was reconciled with Thalassius and he returned to the emperor’s favour; ‘rediret in gratiam’ (22.9.16). At this point he is presumably allowed again to adore the purple. On another occasion, during Julian’s march against Constantius in 361 his men caught the general Lucillianus totally unprepared and brought him to Julian in a state of shock. He was at once offered the opportunity to adore the purple and, emboldened by this gesture, began to express doubts to Julian as to his wisdom in attacking Constantius. Julian cut him short; ‘I offered you the symbols of majesty to put an end to your fear, not to enrol you as an adviser’; ‘maiestatis enim insigne non ut consiliario tibi, sed ut desinas pavere porrexī’ (21.9.8)! Leaving aside Julian’s sarcasm, the purple would be offered to a potential intimate or adviser and the opportunity to kiss it was one to seize and welcome: it was a symbol of reconciliation, of inclusion in the charmed circle of the emperor’s friends, those *honorati* privileged to show him respect.²⁷ In the same spirit, a law of 387 concedes to *domestici* and *protectores* the right to greet *vicarii* with a kiss, a gesture implying equality between its participants, as *adoratio* implies subjection; for ‘it would be tantamount to sacrilege, if this honour were not granted to those who are thought worthy to touch Our purple’; ‘qui contingere nostram purpuram *digni sunt aestimati*’ (CTh 6.24.4).

The ritual of *adoratio* is not merely a symbol of the remoteness of an Oriental despot before his subjects, but a demarcation, acted out before one’s eyes, of those imperial supporters entitled to a place in the emperor’s presence, and of an order of precedence within their number. The circle of those so permitted to ‘touch Our purple’ was by no means narrow, if it were to include *protectores domestici* like Ammianus, not to mention a plain *protector* like Fl. Abinnaeus, or the four officers whom the tribune Fl. Gaiolus sent from Egypt to Constantinople to ‘adore the divine purple of the emperors’ (above, p. 77). We should add to the privileged

band, among many others, the officials listed in the *Notitia Dignitatum* who, having served as 'princeps' in their *officium*, adore the purple and receive promotion to *protector*; 'principem de eodem officio, qui completa militia adorat protector' (*Not. Dig., Or.* 39.37, etc.).²⁸

Observers of late Roman public life from Ammianus onwards have seen it in terms of theatrical performance, a sort of ceremonious masque in which power, rank and privilege were proclaimed by courtly gesture, uniform and accoutrement.²⁹ Gibbon wrote in just such language of the insignia of public office preserved in the illustrations to that fine monument to a self-conscious bureaucracy, the *Notitia Dignitatum*:

By a philosophic observer, the system of late Roman government might have been mistaken for a splendid theatre, filled with players of every character and degree, who repeated the language, and imitated the passions, of their original model. (*Decline and Fall*, Ch. XVII; ed. Bury, II, p. 160)

We have seen how Ammianus uses theatrical imagery in describing the public comportment of emperors. He wrote that Constantius always kept on the *cothurnus*, or 'tragic buskin' symbolising the majesty of his position. The usurper Procopius, by contrast, was like a figure brought up from the underworld, a theatrical performer in a comedy, even some striking image of stage decor (26.6.15; above, p. 236f.). So too the 'Median shoe' and facial makeup recommended for a king in Xenophon's *Cyropaedia*, part of an attempt to bewitch the public into regarding its princes as a superior race of men.

Not only the public comportment considered appropriate for the imperial office, but that of late Roman society at large, displayed a taste for the theatrical, for pictorial gesture and pageantry, that is perhaps their most obvious distinguishing feature in relation to the early empire.³⁰ Ammianus describes the airy, light clothing worn by senators, which they would lift up with excited movements so as to show off the fringes and multi-coloured decorations of the tunics beneath (14.6.9). The bishops of Rome went around in a carriage, wearing conspicuous clothes so as to be seen by all; 'procedant vehiculis insidentes, *circumspecte vestiti* ...' (27.3.14). One senator, years after escaping from an accusation of magic arts, could still be seen in Rome, and

as if he alone were innocent of any crime, mounted on a caparisoned horse rides over the pavements followed by columns of attendants. One would think that he was trying to attract to himself some particular interest by a new sort of distinction; 'per novum quoddam *insigne*, curiosius *spectari* affectans'. (26.3.5)

'Insigne', with 'simulacrum', was a word used by Ammianus of the public presentation of the usurper Procopius (p. 236). It is the language of gesture, image and stage-play, such as are met at all turns in the political

life and social relations of the later Roman empire.

When Julian entered Sirmium in 361, he was received with lights and flowers, with expressions of good fortune ('*votisque faustis*') and hailed as 'Augustus' and 'dominus' (21.10.3). Just so had the people of Autun received Constantine in 311, filling the streets with the 'standards of the city guilds, statues of all the gods, the sounds of clear-toned musical instruments' (*Pan. Lat.* 7.8.4).³¹ In the senate at Rome, ritual acclamations had superseded political discussion, at least as regards the relations between senate and emperor. No longer do we find sharp questions on the division of power between the two such as had confronted Tiberius in AD 14 (*Tacitus, Ann.* 1.12.2), or discussions on the issues of senatorial prerogatives and 'liberty', but series of organised acclamations. The best-documented example is the meeting of 438 that promulgated in the west the newly compiled Theodosian Code. The series begins:

Augusti Augustorum, maximi Augustorum (repeated 7 times)

Deus vos nobis dedit, deus vos nobis servet (repeated 27 times)

Romani imperatores et pii felices, multis annis imperetis (repeated 22 times)

Bono generis humani, bono senatus, bono reipublicae, bono omnium (repeated 24 times)

Spes in vobis, salus in vobis (repeated 26 times)

Ut vivere delectet Augustos nostros semper (repeated 22 times)

The grand total of acclamations, which go on to cover such mundane questions as the safekeeping of the new volume and the prevention of interpolation in its text, adds up to seven hundred and eighty-seven, divided between forty-three separate acclamations.³² At a modest estimate of five seconds for each acclamation, we may imagine over an hour of continuous performance. No longer than a panegyric or public lecture, perhaps, but that is not the point. The actual substance of the acclamations, set out as a traditional *senatus consultum* – as could easily be done – would barely take a couple of minutes to read. The rest was pure theatre.

Ceremonial, in sight and sound, is a mode of communication. It was not new in the late empire; it is obvious, and clear from the evidence, that processions, ceremonial receptions, the expression of both popular and senatorial will by acclamations, go back to the early empire and in some cases well before that. Yet the fourth century undoubtedly saw an increase in the frequency and in the elaboration of public ceremonial, and assigned to it a more central role in the relations between emperors and their subjects, whether of the upper or the lower classes in Roman society. It is clear too that contemporaries thought themselves to be in the presence of an innovation, in likening the ceremonial procedures of Diocletian and his successors to those of an Oriental despot. It may be helpful to consider two possible reasons why this had come about.

First, the military commanders of the early empire, like the emperors of that period, had been men of property from landed aristocratic backgrounds in the countries around the Mediterranean, who shared the interests and civilian culture of the senatorial class to which they belonged. They combined military and civil posts in their careers, alternating both types of post with substantial periods in private life, and were not, by any rigorous standard, 'professional' soldiers.³³ The question of their place in and integration with Roman society did not arise in that period, for, by birth, economic background and education, they were already integrated. Subsequently, however, the constant military crises and civil wars of the third century had prompted the evolution of a military ruling elite originating from the frontier provinces – and from distinctly 'non-senatorial' backgrounds – from which first the Roman high command, and in due course the emperors themselves came;³⁴ and these were men sharing little, in background or cultural affinities, with the Mediterranean-based ruling classes of the early empire. The gulf between them is indicated by the historian Cassius Dio, a Bithynian Greek who governed Pannonia in the early third century. In a passage discussed in a previous chapter, Dio could still write of Pannonians as a warlike people who lived in prolonged winter, grew no olives, drank beer, made only a little poor wine and in general possessed nothing that made an honourable life worth while (49.36.3f.; p. 199). His words, expressing a Mediterranean city man's prejudice against those areas and peoples from whom the military ruling classes and emperors of the third century came, represent a failure of communications of formidable proportions. In the new circumstances, and in the stable conditions bequeathed to the fourth century by the Tetrarchs, ceremonial may have provided a mode of 'rehabilitation' between the emperors and civilian society, not on the basis of old ideals of relations among social equals aspired to under the early empire, but on the simplified but workable basis of the relations of an autocrat with his subjects. Modes of popular communication replaced at every level the more literary, philosophical debates about freedom and political rights which, within a much narrower social milieu, had characterised these relations in the early empire.

Secondly, as we shall see more fully in the next chapter, the Tetrarchy was responsible for a great expansion of government, both in intensity and in its sheer scale, that is in the numbers of active – and, in due course, of inactive – participants in its operations. Imperial ceremonial, in such acts of protocol as *adoratio purpurae*, provided a focal point, and a sense of identity, to a new and enlarged governing class, the members of the imperial *militia*. It included them, by visible gesture, in the new order and at the same time differentiated the various ranks among them. Late Roman ceremonial functioned in two ways: to isolate the emperor and show him as different from the ordinary run of mortals, but also to include a large and ever-expanding political and social grouping, those privileged men who, at their various levels and in their various capacities, were the emperor's friends.

*

This chapter began with Constantius' visit to Rome in 357, and it is appropriate to bring it to an conclusion with a reminder that Ammianus' most explicit statement of the origins of the imperial system links it organically with the institutions and traditions of the city of Rome. He introduces the topic to explain why it should be that whenever his narrative turned to Rome there was nothing to tell but of 'riots, drunkenness and other such unworthy matters' (14.6.2). The dignity and grandeur of Rome, symbolised by the glory of its ancient assemblies, were betrayed by the unrestrained frivolity of a minority of the population; '*levitate paucorum incondita*' (14.6.7).³⁵ Ammianus showed the 'splendour of the assemblies' by presenting the growth to power and maturity of Rome as a life-span. From birth to the end of childhood, a period of three hundred years, Rome sustained local wars and in early adulthood and maturity spread influence over the entire world, bringing home laurels and triumphs and establishing the rule of law for all the peoples of her empire. In present times, now approaching old age and 'conquering in name only', Rome has withdrawn to a quieter life, but is everywhere respected as mistress and queen, the white hair of senators and the name of the *populus Romanus* being revered and honoured (14.6.6). Having achieved in maturity the mastery of the world, she has now in old age, like a shrewd parent, yielded her birthright – the exercise of power – in trust to the emperors; '*Caesaribus tamquam liberis suis regenda patrimonii iura permisit*' (14.6.5). This is not an image of decline, far from it; as Rome enters old age, her 'children' in the pugnacious shape of the Roman emperors, carry on the mission.³⁶

That this mission was in essentials a military one is clear not only from Ammianus' formulation of the growth of Roman power, but from the sheer weight of narrative – not to mention the professional interest – that he devotes to warfare in all its aspects: it is an emphasis that merits a separate discussion, in the third of this group of related chapters (Chapter XIII). Yet Ammianus' interest in the subject does not prevent him from recognising that war and armies, like the imperial power itself, are not an end in themselves, but are the precondition of the peace under which all wise men wish to live, protected by law and free from alien domination. Writing of Valentinian, Ammianus gave his understanding of the rightful exercise of imperial power. It was, as the philosophers had defined it, to preserve the interests and security of loyal men; '*finis enim iusti imperii, ut sapientes docent, utilitas oboedientium et salus*' (30.8.14). He expressed this sentiment in very similar terms elsewhere, again ascribing it to 'men of wisdom'. The purpose of empire, he here explained, was to preserve the safety of others: an emperor should restrain his exercise of power to this end, resisting personal enmities and the opportunities for profit; '*nihil aliud esse imperium, ut sapientes definiunt, nisi curam salutis alienae, bonique esse moderatoris*

restringere potestatem, resistere cupiditati omnium rerum et implacabilibus iracundiis ...' (29.2.18).

Ammianus' conception best emerges on those occasions when correct principles of imperial conduct were violated.³⁷ In the prosecutions under Gallus Caesar at Antioch, men were executed, exiled, forced to live on the charity of others, no resources left to them but 'complaints and tears'. Rich houses were closed, as a 'civil and just empire' was turned over to the bloody whim of one man; 'civili iustoque imperio ad voluntatem converso cruentam' (14.1.4). Not even suborned prosecutors were heard in court to preserve that semblance of legal propriety which the most notoriously cruel emperors had sometimes conceded. Whatever Gallus determined was treated as right and lawful and immediately carried out; 'id velut fas iusque perpensum, confestim urgebatur impleri' (14.1.5). No attempt was made to examine the truth of allegations, nor to tell apart the guilty from the innocent. The rule of law was expelled and driven from the courts; 'velut exturbatum e iudiciis fas omne discessit' (14.7.21). At one point, two men were accused before Gallus. One of them, 'a philosopher in name alone, as became apparent', confessed complicity in treason which never existed, when put to the torture and threatened with death. He was in addition, said Ammianus (himself, it will be recalled, an eye-witness of the proceedings), totally ignorant of legal procedure. His colleague, who knew his rights, and proclaimed that the affair was an act of brigandage and not a court of law, demanded a proper accuser and the usual formalities. It did him no good. He was dreadfully tortured for his insolence and dragged out for execution (14.9.5f.).

Other emperors are criticised for the same fault, perversion of the courts of justice for personal ends. Valens professedly wished cases at law to be determined in proper legal fashion, but he committed them to specially chosen judges and allowed nothing to happen against his will. He permitted accusations to be made without distinguishing truth from falsehood – a fault to be shunned in private, everyday affairs, let alone in courts of justice (31.14.6). Constantius was roused by fear of treason to actions more severe than correct ('acrius exsurgens quam civiliter'); he too appointed judges chosen for their harshness (21.16.8f.). Under Julian, an uncompromising judge of right and wrong but inclined to mercy in his application of the law (18.1.2; 16.5.12f.; 22.10.4f.), the goddess Justice herself seemed, as Ammianus twice remarked, to have returned to earth – except that Julian sometimes acted arbitrarily and in haste, following his own inclination rather than the law (22.10.6; 25.4.19). At such times Julian was 'unlike himself', and where his hasty temperament had betrayed him he allowed himself to be corrected by his associates (22.10.3). This is not the whole story, for Ammianus mentions another tendency of Julian, that he sometimes in courts of law asked people their religious opinions. This, Ammianus concedes, was 'untimely' ('intempesitivus'), adding however that on no occasion could this practice be shown to have produced a result inconsistent with equity (22.10.2). As regards capital jurisdiction, despite Julian's well-known mildness the trials of

Chalcedon brought unjust sentences on some of Constantius' supporters, partly because among those whom the emperor put in charge of the trials was a man of known deviousness and arrogance, 'semper ambiguum et praetumidum' (22.3.9). Most of the punishments meted out at these trials Ammianus found entirely justified (p. 93), but it is hard to see how Julian's conduct was in principle better than that of Constantius and Valens, who appointed specially chosen judges when it suited them.

Ammianus was prepared to admit the need for a law of treason. He discussed the matter in narrating inquiries made by Constantius in 359, when an affair came to light involving alleged consultation of oracles, exaggerated by Constantius' suspicion and the pressure of his courtiers into a great affair of state (19.12.1ff.; p. 217f.). Ammianus agreed that strict inquiries in such circumstances were in order; any sensible man, he wrote, would agree to that (19.12.17). A lawful emperor, the protector and champion of men of good will ('propugnator bonorum et defensor') was entitled to the support of those whose safety he was appointed to defend. To this end the Cornelian laws on *maiestas* had permitted the torture of men without respect of social standing. But it was wrong that an emperor should take pleasure in such affairs, so that his subjects appeared to be living under despotism rather than lawful power.³⁸ Cicero had written that excuses should be sought to pardon rather than to punish (19.12.18); as Julian said in the same spirit, an emperor should always seek to 'increase the number of his friends' by clemency (22.14.5).

Ammianus was no abstract theorist on political, any more than he was on philosophical or religious matters. His views of the imperial office and its duties are in this sense not original, but they are straightforward and serviceable. The emperors had inherited the protection of law and settled life from the senatorial government of the Republic. Their function was to defend men of good will, and they were entitled to protection by a law of treason from the machinations of the wicked. But men were not to be hounded down and punished to satisfy the personal whim or avarice of an emperor; there were properly instituted courts of law and regular procedures, and in the observance of these was the essence of what Ammianus, in just this context, called a 'civil and rightful empire'; 'civile iustumque imperium' (14.1.4).

CHAPTER XII

The Character of Government

Imperial government in Ammianus' time was unmatched in Graeco-Roman history in its scale and complexity of organisation, in its physical incidence upon society, the rhetorical extravagance with which it expressed, and the calculated violence with which it attempted to impose its will. Its expansion of scale, though it had begun earlier, derived essentially from the time of Diocletian and his colleagues in the late third and early fourth centuries. The challenges to government and authority posed by the disorders of the third century had been met by a combination of submission to the force of circumstances and greater assertiveness, in quantity and in character, in the governing that was done.¹ Problems of response in an empire under constant threat of military invasion on widely separated frontiers were met by the division of imperial power. This came about, first by repeated usurpations, resisted by 'legitimate' emperors at immense cost to the resources of the empire, and subsequently, and far more sensibly, by the recognition of the need for a collegiate system of imperial power. Under the new arrangements, which in practice were quite flexible, regional emperors in east and west, with Italy, Africa and the Illyrian provinces as a third region between, financed and organised their military operations in relatively compact areas in which the lines of communication were not unduly extended and the possibilities of rapid troop movement were not precluded by sheer distance.² Within these areas, later systematised as the regional praetorian prefectures of the fourth century, the provinces were progressively increased in number and reduced in size – again, more likely for ease of administration than (as has been supposed) through fear of the excessive power that might be acquired by individual governors. By a further definition of powers, carried through by Constantine, military and civilian (including financial) spheres of administration were separated, under the supervision respectively of new *magistri militum* and praetorian prefects. With exceptions in particular cases or circumstances – some of them mentioned by Ammianus, as when a *notarius* was joined with a *dux* in an attempt to build a fort in barbarian territory (28.2.5ff.), or when the military command of Tripolitania was temporarily assigned to the *praeses* of the province (28.6.11) – this separation between the two hierarchies of power was respected in the fourth century.³ Ammianus praised Constantius because he rigorously

kept apart civilian and military personnel and functions; conversely, it was a criticism of Valentinian that, first of all emperors, he raised the military to a point beyond what was good for the public interest, bestowing on them honours and wealth (21.16.1f.; 27.9.4).

By the increase in the 'incidence' of government, by the multiplication of the imperial office, and by their own willingness to travel the frontiers of the empire – 'ultro citroque discurrentes', as Ammianus wrote, in a phrase attributed to Constantius describing the Caesars of the Tetrarchy (14.11.10) – the late emperors offered to their subjects that personal concern and 'presence' (*praesentia*) to which panegyrists of the early fourth century attached particular importance. The panegyrists, and the communities for which they spoke, well knew that, despite the expenditure and risks involved in direct exposure to imperial power, it was through the 'presence' of the emperor that the cities of the empire stood to gain privileges, and exemptions from the very burdens that the government laid upon them. Hence the importance of one particularly well-documented ceremony, that of the emperor's *adventus*, or arrival in a city (pp. 231ff.). An orator from Augustodunum (Autun) in Gaul, addressing the young Constantine at Trier in 310, picked up the theme in urging the emperor to visit his city; this, he said, 'will immediately be restored, once you see it' (*Pan. Lat.* 7.22.7). And so it was. Two years later another orator, also speaking at Trier, recalled Constantine's visit to Autun, commemorating benefactions for rebuilding and the resettlement of land earlier offered the city by the emperor's father Constantius (*Pan. Lat.* 8.4.4) and, from Constantine himself, a five-year tax remission and a reduction of its assessment from 32,000 to 25,000 *capita* (ibid. 11; 13).⁴

The reign of Diocletian was characterised by Lactantius, in a thorough-going onslaught on the administrative innovations of the Tetrarchy, as a time when the numbers of tax-payers in the Roman empire were exceeded by those of tax-collectors (*De Mort. Pers.* 7.3). Like the rest of Lactantius' account it is a caricature, but the genuinely increased scale of late Roman government implied by it can readily be illustrated: by modern estimates ranging from 446 to 834 officials in the palatine office (that is, excluding its provincial departments) of the eastern *comes sacrarum largitionum*;⁵ by the seventy members of curial families currently serving as imperial officials, who are listed on the municipal register of the city of Tingad in Numidia in 362 or 363 – five serving in the office of the *vicarius* of Africa, thirty-seven in that of the *consularis* of Numidia, twenty-three in that of the *praefectus annonae* of Africa, and five in that of the *rationalis* of the *fiscus*, or imperial treasury, of the province; by the fifty or more civil servants and retired military officers who lived and owned property at Hermopolis and Antinoopolis in mid-fourth century Egypt (*P. Flor.* 71);⁶ or by the lists of the *Notitia Dignitatum*, such as (taken at random) that of the *vicarius* of Asiana (*Or.* 24), consisting of a '*princeps*, serving at the rank of *ducenarius* from the corps of *agentes in rebus*, who [on promotion] adores the clemency of the emperor and departs with the insignia [of *protector*]', below him a

cornicularius, a *commentariensis*, an *adiutor*, an *ab actis*, *numerarii*, a *cura epistularum* and, at the base of the structure '*exceptores* and the other *officiales*'. Members of this category, in the case of *consulares*, *praesides* and *correctores* of provinces, are not permitted to transfer to any other service without the specific assent, or 'annotation', of the imperial clemency (*Or.* 43-4; *Occ.* 43-5). Such examples, to which others could easily be added, make clear the enhanced scale of government in the late empire, and also the bureaucratic mentality with which it functioned, in its preoccupation with lists and procedures, grades of appointment, salaries, rules of promotion and the titles of status.

Another innovation assigned by contemporaries to the time of Diocletian was the enhanced ceremonial surrounding the office and person of the emperors; it was taken, as we have seen, to symbolise the transition of the emperor from the 'civil magistrate' of the early empire to Oriental despot. This aspect of the public presentation of the late Roman emperors, expressed in their dress, their comportment and gestures, and the physical setting in which they appeared, applies also to their officials. A late Roman governor or palatine official would receive his letter of appointment in the form of a scroll or bound book, or, in the most senior positions, an ivory diptych – a pair of hinged leaves decorated with figures in carved relief, edged with gold and containing inside the codicils of office. On the cover of the diptychs was a portrait of the emperor or emperors, on the books an acclamation addressed to the recipient of office and wishing him good fortune and success in its tenure. These insignia he would place on a table covered with a blue cloth, which stood in his office. In the case of the more elevated civil appointments a set of candlesticks stood with the insignia on the table, and sometimes on the floor beside can be observed a tall baton-shaped object with carved panels on its sides tapering down towards a tripod base; this is a ceremonial inkstand, symbolising the judicial powers of the prefect or governor in question. The document in which these and other insignia are shown, the *Notitia Dignitatum*, as we have already seen (p. 247), seemed to Gibbon in just this context to evoke a theatrical performance rather than the more prosaic realities of public administration.⁷ At all levels of the governmental system, both within its ranks and in its relations with the public, that *civilitas*, or pretence of equality with which, according to Ammianus and others, earlier Roman emperors had been accustomed to receive their officials, had been replaced by an array of ceremonial relationships, expressed in the stylised 'instant language' of gesture, decor, pose, and acclamation.

The same is true in the field of legislation, for here too the Roman government had left far behind the measured, persuasive style of the early empire. The emperors now proclaim their intentions in strident rhetoric, with moral outrage and threats of violence. So, in a law of Constantine of 331, 'Let the rapacious hands of officials now cease; let them cease, I say: unless they do heed this warning and cease, they shall be cut off with swords If any should imagine that a bribe may be

demanded in cases of civil jurisdiction, armed vengeance shall be present to sever the head from the neck of the wicked offender' (*CTh* 1.16.7). By a law of Theodosius, posted in 390 in public places at Rome, male prostitutes, 'whose criminal practice it is to pervert the male body in the masquerade of a woman's, to submit themselves to the passive sufferance of the other sex and regard themselves as no different from women' shall expiate their crime by being burned alive before the people: 'so that all may understand that no man may without the supreme penalty seek to adopt the opposite sex, having so disgracefully rejected his own'.⁸ Another law of Constantine with horrific aptness orders the execution of nurses who connive at the abduction of girls in their care: their mouths and throats are to be stopped by pouring in molten lead. So shall be repaid the 'fables and wicked persuasions of nurses' (*CTh* 9.24.1, of 320). In a similar outburst of what has been splendidly called the 'didactic symbolism' employed by the late Roman government, false accusation is to be 'stopped in the very throat of the calumniator, the tongue of envy torn out by the roots' (*CTh* 10.10.2, of c. 319).⁹ The language here may indeed be rhetorical, an unhappily chosen metaphor – it is the vice of calumny that is to be removed rather than the actual tongue that utters it. However, two *curiales* mentioned by Ammianus in his narrative of Tripolitanian embassies to Valentinian fled into hiding, the emperor having ordered their tongues to be torn out for making false accusations to one of his officials (28.6.20; 28).

It is not surprising that Ammianus, remarking in praise of Valentinian that he was tolerant in religious matters, can observe that he did not force his subjects 'by menacing prohibitions' to bend their necks to his own belief; '*ne interdictis minacibus subiectorum cervicem ad id, quod ipse coluit, inclinabat*' (30.9.5). The laws of the fourth century make it awfully clear what is meant by 'menacing prohibitions'. They refer constantly to the 'severity' of judges, the 'terror' of punishment, to the strictures of the 'avenging' sword and flames, to the 'carefully devised tortures' with which execution should be embellished, to the horrors of 'prisons dark with filth', where iron manacles rend the flesh to the bone and men may die through the inhuman conditions there. This fate is 'considered pitiable for the innocent but not severe enough for the guilty' (*CTh* 9.2.15, of 320), a hollow reminder of the fact that in Roman penal custom prison was used as a mode of confinement for those awaiting trial and, where it was not carried out immediately, execution, but not in its own right as a form of punishment. Similarly, torture was supposed to be used only to extract truthful information in a court of law and not as a mode or refinement of punishment;¹⁰ yet the most cursory reading of Ammianus Marcellinus, or many another late Roman source, will show how unreal this distinction had now become.

The atmosphere of intimidation and violence conveyed by much fourth-century imperial legislation meets the reader of Ammianus at every turn.¹¹ Imperial inquisitors are sent out to provinces to conduct trials for treason, throwing men of good birth into fetters and herding

them to court like captured beasts, loaded down with chains, to await exile or execution (14.5.3ff., 15.3.10, etc.): a philosopher smiles with contempt for the flames that consume him while his companions are strangled, all in full view of the multitude (29.1.38): courageous individuals suffer on the rack without revealing the names of alleged 'accomplices' (14.9.6; 15.6.1f.): sides are 'furrowed' by iron claws (14.9.4; 28.1.10) and men stand bent double under the instrument known as the 'horse', or *eculeus* (28.1.19). Instruments are prepared – the 'horse' and its lead weights, lashes and rods – while the courtrooms resound with truculent voices, shouting grim instructions to 'seize: fasten: tighten up: take him away', amid the clash of chains (29.1.23). Instances can be multiplied at will: two *curiales* of Aquileia are beheaded for holding their city loyal to Constantius against Julian (21.12.20); an official of Valentinian is after his emperor's death imprisoned in the Tullianum at Rome, then taken to his home city in Gaul and there executed 'after immense tortures' (28.1.57); a charioteer is burned at the stake, a minor official stoned to death, a senator 'hauled aloft' and hanged (28.1.56; 29.3.5); two women are led to execution for adultery, their executioner being later burned alive because he had not allowed one of them to remain decently clothed while she was being led to her death (28.1.28). This last episode is a vivid illustration of the fierce puritanism with which late Roman government conceived its duty.

At times, whole cities lived in dread of judicial vengeance because of their connection with cases of high treason, especially when linked with the conduct of magic arts, or for some other reason. Ammianus recalls of his own city of Antioch how men 'crept around in deathly gloom' while the emperor conducted investigations into magic and treason there (29.2.4; above, p. 222f.). In the same city eighteen years earlier, Gallus Caesar ordered the execution of all the leading members of the curia in a dispute over the price of corn, a threat that would have been carried out, claims Ammianus, had not the *comes Orientis* stood against it (14.7.2). On a later occasion in the west, only the intervention of the *quaestor sacri palatii* Eupraxius prevented Valentinian from ordering the execution of the curial orders of three entire towns (27.7.6). Eupraxius' grounds were that the victims would be regarded as Christian martyrs, as had indeed already happened at a place near Milan known as 'Ad Innocentes' after the executions there of four imperial officials (27.7.5).¹²

On at least three occasions during Ammianus' later lifetime the lives of hundreds, even thousands of men in major cities of the empire hung by the thread of an imperial decision. At Milan in 386 the Catholic congregation occupied a basilica, refusing to hand it over to the Arian community as the emperor instructed. In pulling down the imperial hangings that denoted the building as confiscated property, the Catholics had committed a technical act of treason, but the emperor backed down before Ambrose's power and the urban disorders he could, if he wished, provoke (Ambrose, *Ep.* 20).¹³ In 387 Ammianus' Antioch awaited retribution after riots over taxation in which imperial statues and images

had been overturned.¹⁴ Men fled from the city, while city council, bishop, clergy and local monks spoke on its behalf to the imperial commission of inquiry. There were arrests and confiscations, executions 'by sword, fire, and the jaws of wild beasts' (Libanius, *Or.* 19.37), but in the end the emperor was merciful: the city had feared the worst. At Thessalonica in 390 the worst happened. The people there had killed their garrison commander in riots over the imprisonment of a popular charioteer for homosexuality. A retributive killing was ordered for the death of the commander: the countermand was too late, and thousands of spectators at the races (a later source puts the figure at 7,000) were massacred in the streets of the city.¹⁵

To the modern eye, such acts of judicial violence, individual and collective, appear as reflections of the general temper of the age. Ammianus saw them as something more specific than this – as expressions also of the personal characters of the officials and agents appointed, and sometimes specifically instructed, to enforce the emperors' requirements. The official of Valentinian just mentioned, Doryphorianus, was while in office 'aggressive to the point of insanity', devoted to seeking out ways in which he might ruin a senator, even when no one would help him. In his prosecution of the senator Aginatus, he showed himself to be more a bandit than a judge; 'iudex, quin immo praedo nefandus' (28.1.54f.). His predecessors were Ursicinus, replaced because of his undue mildness in wishing to appear careful and to respect proper procedures by remitting a case to a higher court (28.1.44), and Simplicius, a man of modest demeanour and tactful in expression, but devious and terrifying, 'obliquo aspectu terribilis' (28.1.45).

Ammianus often uses images derived from the behaviour of wild beasts to convey the characters of hostile or aggressive officials.¹⁶ This is more than a merely stylistic affectation. We must also see it in the context of the Classical view of man's rational faculty as that which pre-eminently sets him apart from the world of animals. The comparison of the behaviour of men with that of animals so enables Ammianus to underline, in a manner faithful both to the Classical elements in his own intellectual tradition and to the expressive conventions of his own age, the 'un-human', the excessive or irrational, in the behaviour of men. Instead of allowing the different facets of his character to be moderated by rational reflection, an individual embarks upon a distorted mode of action, a wilful narrowing of the imagination leading, by what we would call irrational obsession, to results more characteristic of animal than human behaviour. In the extreme case, we find ourselves in a sort of nightmare, in which rational, sane and innocent men are made subject to the control of raging beasts. The first of Valentinian's series of *vicarii* of Rome, Maximinus, began mildly, partly through fear, it was alleged, of an associate who might betray him, partly through diffidence at the lowliness of the public offices he then held. He behaved at that time 'like a subterranean serpent, creeping through low places'; 'tamquam subterraneus serpens per humilia reptando' (28.1.7). Upon Maximinus'

promotion from these 'low places' to the vicariate of Rome, he gave vent to the natural savagery implanted in his cruel nature, 'as you often see with wild beasts in the amphitheatre, when the gates are broken aside and they are released'; 'ut saepe faciunt amphitheatrales ferae, diffractis tandem solutae posticis' (28.1.10). What actually happened, as we saw earlier (p. 212), was something rather more prosaic; Maximinus' preliminary enquiries at Rome prompted him to submit a *relatio* to court, in response to which he was instructed to treat cases of magic and adultery under the law of *maiestas* (28.1.10f.).

The metaphor of the snake is applied also to Gallus Caesar (14.7.13), to Constantius' general Arbetio (15.2.4) and, more elaborately, again to Maximinus, when as praetorian prefect of Gaul he directed enquiries against the senator Aginatus like a 'wild man', with the vicious anguish of an injured snake (28.1.33). Meanwhile his successor Leo had come to Rome like a 'funeral gladiator, a Pannonian bandit breathing out cruelty from a wild beast's jaws, as greedy as his colleague for the taste of human blood'; 'efflantem ferino rictu crudelitatem, etiam ipsum nihilo minus humani sanguinis avidum' (28.1.12). In the same terms one of Valentinian's proconsuls of Africa, Julianus Rusticus, conducted himself in his province with the raging thirst of a wild beast for the blood of humans; 'quasi adflatu quodam furoris bestiarum more humani sanguinis avidum' (27.1.6). Gallus Caesar, having ordered the execution of two Antiochene *curiales*, is compared to a man-eating lion; 'ut leo cadaveribus pastus' (14.9.9).

In a similarly colourful metaphor the eunuch Eusebius is like a poisonous viper, sending out its numerous offspring – the junior eunuchs – to inflame Constantius against the general Ursicinus; 'ut coluber copia virus exuberans, natorum multitudinem excitans ad nocendum' (18.4.4). The informer Paul 'the Chain' was a sort of snake, expert at scenting hidden roads of danger for others (14.5.6), and his adjutant Mercurius, nicknamed 'Count of Dreams' (*comes somniorum*) because of the all-pervading reach of his intelligence network, is compared to an untrustworthy dog, wagging its tail as it begs for scraps of food at banquets but inclined to bite without warning (15.3.5). This is a good metaphor, for it was as a guest at banquets that Mercurius picked up much of his incriminating information.

We should not exaggerate the importance of Ammianus' use of these metaphors, nor try to confine it narrowly within the Classical philosophical tradition mentioned earlier. Men have always seen affinities between the behaviour of humans and that of animals, and attributed to animals the moral qualities that their behaviour, so interpreted, seems to merit. Wild beasts provide a repertoire of images of human character and behaviour, opportunities not neglected by the authors of propaganda whether literary or visual, the latter including the formalised symbolism of heraldry. Ammianus' own professional environment, if we can go so far as to call it that, the Roman army, had always exploited such images, not only in the famous legionary eagle and

emblems of the early empire, but more especially in the names and shield devices of the army of Ammianus' own day.¹⁷ Their figures can be seen in the rows of shield devices illustrated in the *Notitia Dignitatum*: a lion's head, birds of prey, dogs or wolves, serpents, wild boars, a bull, a bear and so on, often in hybrid forms such as a serpent with a dog's head or the famous 'horned' design (*cornuti*), of heads emerging from a single trunk and turning to face each other. One of the images is mentioned by Ammianus, in the passage discussed earlier (p. 231), describing the dragon standards on the banners of Constantius' army as it entered Rome in 357. The banners stretched out in the breeze so that the dragons themselves, rather than merely the emblazoned emblem, seemed to hiss angrily, while their coiled tails were borne aloft behind them; 'hiatu vasto perflabiles, et ideo velut ira perciti sibilantes, caudarumque volumina relinquentes in ventum' (16.10.7).¹⁸

Some of Ammianus' images, one may suspect, were, like the furious broken-backed snake of Vergil's *Aeneid* (5.273ff.), more familiar to his urban, literate readership from their knowledge of Classical literature than from encounters in real life: perhaps also in a very different field of cultural experience with which they were no less familiar, the artificial presentation of 'wild life' in the amphitheatres of Rome and other cities of the empire.¹⁹ Some of the most telling images refer explicitly to hunting and gladiatorial games, as with the frustrated Gallic soldiers shut inside the walls of Amida during the siege of 359 like savage wild beasts in their cages, awaiting combat (19.6.4); or Ammianus himself and his colleagues, dreading their fate at Cologne at the hands of Silvanus as if they were prize-fighters about to be exposed to savage wild beasts; 'ut bestiarum obiceremur intractabilibus feris' (15.5.23). The simile of combat in the arena is applied, as we have just seen, to Maximinus' conduct in the prosecutions at Rome of the late 360s; so, too, Valens, in the trials of Antioch 'raged with an extreme frenzy, as if practised specifically in doing harm, like a beast of the arena' (29.1.27). The ultimate, quite literal, application of all this is Valentinian's two pet she-bears, which he kept in cages near his private quarters and had 'looked after with the greatest care, lest their savagery be impaired'; perhaps he was afraid of their being fed titbits by passing visitors. In the end one of the bears, by a nasty turn of humour named 'Innocentia', the emperor ordered to be released into the forest. She had earned her freedom by 'the burials of many men she had torn to pieces'; 'post multos, quas eius laniatu cadaverum viderat, sepulturas'. No doubt the emperor was used to exhibiting her in the amphitheatre at Trier, perhaps at private shows also (29.3.9). Her name is not exactly easy to parallel for a man-eating bear, as Valentinian's were alleged to be ('Simplicius', the name of a performing bear on a north African mosaic, is not too far distant); more typical, no doubt, are names like 'Omicida' and 'Crudelis', which appear on a fourth-century mosaic at Carthage commemorating hunting displays in the arena.²⁰

In this as in other ways, Ammianus' language is notable for the strength of its visual effect and the over-literal, often grotesque

exaggeration of its imagery. Human activity and character are seen no longer in the measured, analytical terms of Classical philosophy but in the instant, universal language of symbolism and didactic posture. The 'ravening wild beasts' jaws' of Ammianus' murderous officials are seen as if part of the artificial combat of the arena rather than in a state of nature – a comparison that reaches to the heart of Ammianus' conception, and in many ways to the reality, of late Roman social and political life.

The violence and brutality with which late Roman government and law enforcement were conducted are no doubt exaggerated by concentration on individual instances, as Ammianus and other sources provide them. Yet it is clear that the impression given by these sources is not totally false. Such things could happen, often in ways unpredictable and inexplicable to the victims of judicial investigation. Of the four members of two successive Tripolitanian embassies to Valentinian – pursuing perfectly normal activities for leading members of Roman provincial communities – two died of natural causes while abroad, a third was executed with three alleged accomplices for lying to the emperor, and the fourth ambassador was imprisoned but escaped (28.6.21f.; 24). In the same affair, two imperial officials committed suicide rather than face the emperor's anger (28.6.27; 30) and another was executed (28.6.22). Two *curiales* of Lepcis went into hiding for fear of having their tongues cut out for lying; 'cum sibi iussos abscidi linguas didicissent ut prodigas' (28.6.28). Against those whose social position or profession exposed them to it, an imputation of treason, or an accusation of magic arts or adultery, might be levelled on the slenderest of evidence; a chance event or passing comment might in an instant expose to judicial processes of an extraordinarily refined violence men whose life had been spent in discreet obscurity and untroubled ease.

Ammianus was moved by the injustices that descended upon those whose discreet obscurity proved insufficient to avoid the inquisitiveness of the laws. He was not, it must be emphasised, against the laws themselves, from which cases of unjust victimisation could spring. He denounced the conduct of magic arts (26.3.3f.), thought adultery a typical expression of the unworthy social conduct of senators (28.4.2), regarded a good flogging followed by exile as a sound punishment for a riot leader (15.7.5) and, in a carefully measured passage, defended the need of the emperors for the protection of a law of treason, with all the consequences that this implied for the nature of the judicial processes involved (19.12.17).²¹

With certain recondite exceptions, some of them mentioned above, the penalties inherent in the laws were not in themselves new, but the harshest of them had by the fourth century come to be imposed at higher points on the social scale than was customary in the early empire. According to the system of punishments graded by social status, as developed in the Classical age of Roman law, execution by burning at the stake, clubbing, or exposure to wild beasts (crucifixion was abolished by Constantine) were accepted as fitting for members of the lower and

servile classes in Roman society, those broadly categorised as 'humiliores'; for the more privileged, those of the 'more honourable' classes ('honestiores'), less brutal modes of execution, usually beheading, were thought appropriate.²² Although he preserves traces of the distinction (pp. 213; 222), we should find it difficult to read in Ammianus' accounts of judicial procedures any such rigorously self-denying application of the law as this. His narrative is full of examples of propertied, cultivated men of the Roman provinces – paradigm cases of what is meant by 'honestiores' – being subjected to tortures and methods of execution to which, two centuries earlier, they would never legally have been exposed.

Apart from the wider extension of more brutal penalties, what is new about fourth-century legislation is the intensity of the rhetoric with which the laws were expressed, as the emperors strove with ever-increasing urgency to win over Roman society at large to their own view of the need for lawful behaviour, and the exemplary punishment of those who deviated from it. Though understandable, it is facile and misleading to read the legislation merely as if from the point of view of those who through guilt or misfortune found themselves the victims of its attentions. In fact, the terror and moral didacticism of its tone were intended to stir a sympathetic response in a public united with its emperor in opposition to criminal, subversive and immoral behaviour. Nor did the emperors exempt themselves from the standards they set for others. According to the Christian preacher John Chrysostom, anyone who brought a prostitute into the imperial palace, or was found drunk there, or did any other such disgraceful thing, was liable to the penalty of death. If such things are not allowed in the palace (Chrysostom went on) how much more shall we incur the ultimate punishment from the king of all, who is present everywhere and sees all (*Hom. in Joh.* 5.4; *PG* 69.60)! It is sometimes popularly believed that the Roman empire declined because of its immorality, but as far as the facts are concerned the opposite is the case; it suffered, if from anything, from an excess of self-righteousness.

*

The working institutions of the late Roman state appear frequently in Ammianus' narrative, in episodes which, while not adding up to a systematic description, can give a lively impression of the impact of the government and its agencies upon the population of the empire. He has occasion to remark, for instance, that among those executed during Valentinian's prosecutions for adultery and magic was the procurator of the imperial mint at Rome (28.1.29). Ammianus' description of treason trials at Antioch incorporates references to the imperial purple-dye and weaving shops at Tyre, together with two arms factories ('fabricae') at unspecified locations; the tribunes in charge of these were named as accomplices in a plot, though in the event innocent namesakes were

arrested by mistake (p. 34). An equally incidental reference brings in the arms factory at Hadrianople in Thrace. A civic magistrate there, angered because the Goths encamped around the city had ravaged one of his estates, raised a force against them from the lower-class population and the workers in the arms factories, 'of whom there are very many living in the city'; 'cum fabricensibus, quorum illic ampla est multitudo' (31.6.2). As this and other evidence shows, the imperial arms factories were considerable establishments, and their workers, organised in trade guilds, a powerful force in the lives of the cities in which they were situated. The 'fabricenses' of Hadrianople had on an earlier occasion demonstrated against a church council held there (Athanasius, *Hist. Arian.* 18), and at Caesarea in Cappadocia they and the textile workers once joined together in popular riots in favour of their bishop (Gregory of Nazianzus, *Or.* 43.57). In a later chapter some metalworkers of Antioch will be found in a similar role, being prominent in leading popular demonstrations during a corn shortage at Antioch.²³

The distribution of *fabricae* through the provinces of the empire is recorded, for the late fourth century, by the *Notitia Dignitatum* – fifteen in the eastern empire, twenty in the west.²⁴ One of the latter, the shield factory at Cremona in north Italy (*Occ.* 9.27), happens to be mentioned by Ammianus. The instigator of the plot against the *magister militum* Silvanus pursued his design by sending letters in the name of Silvanus and his colleague Malarichus to the tribune in charge of the arms factory at Cremona, addressing him as an accomplice and urging him to 'have everything ready quickly' (15.5.59). The tribune was baffled and sent the letter on to court by the same courier who had brought it, adding that he had no idea what it meant. Whatever the truth of the tribune's protestations there is no mystery about the role of a shield factory at Cremona in a threatened military proclamation allegedly involving highly-placed generals at Cologne and Milan.

Co-ordination of the arms factories of the late empire, with their rather specialised production – in north Italy for instance, shields, bows, arrows, swords and cuirasses were manufactured in different establishments spread over the whole region from Luca to Concordia – presupposes well-organised transport facilities, both for the supply of the workshops and for the assembly and distribution of their products. One imagines the roads of north Italy and other areas as constantly busy with the 'heavy goods' service of the imperial administration, a situation evidently too banal to be mentioned by a historian with pretensions to Classical style and elevated subject-matter (cf. 26.1.1).²⁵ The imperial courier service, or *cursus publicus*, is a different question, for it will often impinge on politics. Ammianus on several occasions mentions it, as in his comment that in the time of Constantius the system nearly collapsed because of the hordes of bishops whom the emperor permitted to use it on their journeys to frequent synods (21.16.18). In a more ominous context, when Gallus Caesar was recalled from Antioch and had passed through Constantinople into Thrace, he was taken on from Hadrianople in a convoy of ten

vehicles of the public transport service, retaining only a few members of his palace staff, and hurried non-stop to Poetovio by continuous changes of horses for the successive stages of the journey (14.11.16; 19). It was a sign of his final humiliation when he was conveyed to Pola in a private carriage, wearing none of the imperial insignia (14.11.20).

The *cursus publicus* was a physical resource without which the defence and administration of the Roman empire could simply not have been conducted. Ammianus himself, with Ursicinus and his other aides, used the system to travel from the east to Milan on the emperor's orders in 354. The access of a *magister militum* and his staff to these facilities need occasion no comment; Ammianus uses the allusion rather to explain the great speed with which his party was able to hurry to its destination; 'copia rei vehicularia data Mediolanum itineribus properavimus magnis' (14.11.5). Speed was one advantage, and security for the private or 'semi-official' traveller, if he was able to gain the privilege from an influential contact. So Augustine was authorised in 384 to use the *cursus publicus* to go from Rome to Milan to take up the appointment as public orator there awarded him by Symmachus (*Conf.* 5.23). An episode narrated by Libanius shows how he had been promised use of the *cursus publicus* to travel from Constantinople to Athens on his way to take up studies there. When he got to Constantinople he discovered that the friend on whose influence he had relied had fallen from favour; he was unable to provide the service he had promised, and Libanius had to continue by boat, paying the captain to put to sea in the close season (*Or.* 1.14f.).

We encounter from time to time in Ammianus the 'roving officials' whom the public transport service delivered with such efficiency into the unsuspecting lives of the inhabitants of the empire – like the *agens in rebus* who attended a dinner given at Sirmium by the governor of Pannonia Secunda, heard treasonable comments uttered there under the influence of drink and informed the *princeps* of the administrative staff of the praetorian prefect. The *princeps*, bearing the news 'as if carried on wings' to the imperial court, brought down the governor and his associates and secured for himself two further years in his evidently advantageous employment (15.3.8f.).²⁶ Another *agens in rebus*, a guest at a dinner-party in Spain, wilfully or through excess of zeal misinterpreted a harmless custom of the house – slaves calling 'vincamus', 'may we conquer', as they lit the lamps for the evening – and destroyed a noble house of the province (16.8.9). The episode provides another instance of the unpredictable, and no doubt to its recipients inexplicable, impact of the law of treason on men whose social position exposed them to its more far-reaching operations.

The most disquieting illustration of the impact on local communities of the imperial bureaucracy 'at large' takes the form of a successful parody of the real thing. It is that of the Maratocupreni, bandits from a village near Apamea in Syria who impersonated merchants and officials in order to plunder estates and towns, and the houses of the wealthy (28.2.11ff.).²⁷

On one occasion they came to the walls of a town disguised as the *rationalis* of the province and his staff, and made a proclamation through a herald that they had been sent by the emperor to confiscate the property of a wealthy citizen. The ploy worked like a dream: the bandits got inside the town, ransacked the fine mansion of the local worthy, and made off with their booty before being suspected. It was evidently, give or take a little, the behaviour to be expected of the *rationalis* and his staff. On another occasion described by Ammianus, an official of Constantius, sent to recall the *magister equitum* Silvanus immediately before his usurpation, in the event joined forces with the *rationalis* of the province in order to undermine Silvanus' position among his dependants by pretending that he was already condemned and his property marked down for confiscation (15.5.8). The references make ominously clear one of the functions of the *rationalis*, to supervise the confiscation of proscribed property. As for those bogus officials the Maratocupreni of Syria, a comparison at some points is provided by the journey, recorded in a papyrus dossier, of the *scholasticus* Theophanes from Egypt to Antioch and back around 320.²⁸ He too travelled, evidently on public business and so using the public transport service, with a retinue of officials and slave assistants and a considerable amount of baggage. Theophanes, like the Maratocupreni, had a 'herald' (*praeco*) among his staff (*P. Ryl.* IV.644). The Maratocupreni, and so presumably the *rationalis* and entourage whom they impersonated, were a substantial body of men; 'impiorum hominum globus', as Ammianus describes the bandits (28.2.13). As an individual the *rationalis* was evidently an imposing figure. Julian could use him as a symbol of glamorous ostentation when commenting on the appearance of a barber whom he had summoned; 'ego ... non rationalem iussi, sed tonsorem acciri' (22.4.9).

The operation of part of the provincial administration – possibly again that of the *rationalis* – is seen in a not dissimilar perspective in an episode involving Martin, bishop of Tours, as told by his biographer Sulpicius Severus (*Dial.* II.3). During a tour of his diocese, Martin encountered on the public high road an official carriage of the Gallic treasury (*fiscalis raeda*), drawn by a team of mules and carrying a party of military men or civil servants (*militantes viri*). Passing them on his donkey, Martin somehow startled the mule team of the imperial carriage – 'those long lines into which, as you often see, the poor animals are yoked together' – making them shy away and causing a holdup while their traces were untangled. In annoyance at the delay, or perhaps fearing that they had fallen into a trap set by bandits, the officials leapt down and set about Martin, beating him with rods and lashes until he fell unconscious, to be picked up by his companions as they followed along the road a little way behind.

The *rationalis* (and similar officials) and their staffs made up considerable retinues, whose progress through the provinces of the empire was a familiar sight to their inhabitants; but they were as nothing compared with the emperor himself when on the march.²⁹ The impact of

the arrival of an emperor with all his assorted impedimenta is well illustrated in the preparations for the battle of Hadrianople in 378. The Goths were drawn up to besiege the city, having heard from deserters that the emperor was there with his high officials, the treasuries and the insignia of the imperial office; 'potestatum culmina maximarum et fortunae principalis insignia thesaurosque Valentis' (31.15.2). All had been left there before the great battle, together with the prefects and members of the imperial consistory, protected by the walls of the city while the baggage and pack-animals were left outside with a military guard (31.12.10).

It is perhaps surprising that this is the only occasion on which Ammianus gives any true impression of the sheer scale and physical impact of the emperor and his *comitatus* when on the move. It is a scene that he must simply have taken for granted, as must we in other, less specifically detailed descriptions of late Roman emperors on the march from city to city. It was one of the most distinctive sights of the later empire. We may think of the impact on the city of Antioch of the preparations for a Persian campaign, and of Libanius' remark that it was a sign of his recovery from illness when, on the arrival at Antioch of Valens and his army in 371, he could stand the 'glint of arms and standards and the raucous blare of trumpets', though previously he could not have borne even to hear them mentioned (*Or.* 1.144). Ammianus wrote of the triumphal arrival of Constantius at Rome in 357 that, inappropriate as it was for the Eternal City, the home of freedom, Constantius' conduct was as it was often seen in the provinces; it was as though he were off to intimidate Euphrates or Rhine by a demonstration of armed strength: 'tamquam Euphratem armorum specie territurus aut Rhenum' ... 'talem se tamque immobilem, qualis in provinciis suis visebatur' (16.10.6; 9). Ammianus here leaves out of account in favour of its ceremonial aspect the more mundane side of the emperor's arrival – the crowds of officials, columns of horses, mules, carriages and wagons that conveyed the imperial administration and its accessories around the provinces. In the course of one such attempt to 'intimidate Euphrates by a demonstration of armed strength' the Persian campaign of Julian, the press of men and wagons entering Hierapolis caused a portico by the city gate to collapse, with the loss of fifty men marching under it and many injured (23.2.6; cf. p. 144).

So far we have considered the emperor and his supporters as at various levels and in various ways they impinged upon the lives of provincial communities. It is natural that a history devoted so largely to the Roman emperors and their activities should reveal much also of the institutions and procedures of the central government itself. Although the circumstances in which they arise in Ammianus' narrative are usually exceptional, it does not follow that the institutions themselves are seen in such a way as to distort or falsify their character; government, after all, largely consists of reducing the exceptional to the manageable by the use of regular procedures, in dealing with crises without sacrificing the

essentials. The institution closest of all to the emperor, the imperial consistory (*consistorium*), features in several episodes. Some of these concern formal circumstances, as when Julian passed a sarcastic comment on an *agens in rebus* who, summoned on a ceremonial occasion of some sort ('quadam sollemnitate') to the consistory to receive a payment of gold coin, cupped both hands to receive it rather than take it in a fold of his mantle, as was more usual; 'agentes in rebus know how to grab, not how to receive', said the Caesar (16.5.11). Other occasions were more contentious, sometimes pressing to its limits the pervading atmosphere of formality. An embassy of senators, sent to court to protest at the imposition of torture on their colleagues at Rome, is admitted to the consistory to speak its case, to be met by loud complaints from Valentinian that he had made no such order as was alleged and was being calumniated. This could have been awkward, had not the emperor been contradicted by the quaestor Eupraxius and induced to restore the immunity, which he was perhaps not aware of having removed in instructing Maximinus to conduct his prosecutions under the heading of the law of *maiestas* (p. 213). It was an act of bravery on Eupraxius' part, for which Ammianus praises him warmly (28.1.24f.). On another occasion Eupraxius, with equal skill and courage, dissuaded Valentinian from ordering the execution of the *curiales* of three towns, on the obviously calculated grounds that the victims would be venerated as martyrs (27.7.6).³⁰

One particularly well documented meeting of the consistory has already been described in some detail, the occasion on which Ammianus' patron Ursicinus was restored to favour and instructed to bring down Silvanus at Cologne (p. 37). The meeting was summoned to consider the crisis at the dead of night, and Ursicinus introduced to it by the *magister admissionum*, a formal mark of honour on which Ammianus specifically comments. Granted the renewed privilege of kissing the purple, Ursicinus began to embark on a speech of self-defence against the suspicions entertained of him, but was mildly prevented by Constantius: now was not the time for recrimination, when all should be restored to their former concord. This 'diplomatic' prelude was followed by a long discussion as to what should be done; 'habita igitur deliberatione multiplici ...' (15.5.18ff.).

Apart from his description of the actual conduct of the consistory, a notable feature in Ammianus' account is the effectiveness with which he evokes its atmosphere – the meeting summoned in the depths of night, Ursicinus' tension, resolved by his sudden change of prospects, his over-anxious attempt to justify himself, the emperor's calm rejoinder. The most dramatic of Ammianus' descriptions of the *consistorium* is however the death of the Emperor Valentinian while hearing an embassy from the Quadi. The barbarians are brought into the consistory and embark on an unconvincing defence of their compatriots' actions. Stirred to anger, Valentinian accuses them of ingratitude, his voice resounding with contempt and abuse. He then subsides and seems more inclined to be

considerate, but is suddenly overcome by his fatal seizure. His voice and breath fail and the emperor is hurriedly taken out by attendants to a private room, 'lest he be seen falling in the presence of so many men of low estate' (30.6.3). After struggling massively for his life, the emperor died some hours later (30.6.6). Less sensational though no less vivid is Ammianus' portrayal of the scene in which Julian's general Marcellus, replaced by Constantius for failing to relieve the Caesar when besieged at Sens, went to court to accuse Julian of 'higher ambitions' than was proper. Arriving at Milan in an agitated state of mind ('strepens et tumultuans') Marcellus was admitted to the consistory and there accused Julian, as he put it, of 'fitting out more powerful wings for himself'. These accusations he made with great vigour, at the same time gesticulating 'with huge movements of his body' (16.7.2). 'Ita enim cum motu quodam corporis loquebatur ingenti'; Ammianus' words are precisely intended to connect Marcellus' metaphor with his physical gesture. He pictures Marcellus (and Ammianus had an eye-witness of the scene, the eunuch Eutherius who was there to defend Julian) as standing before Constantius and his officials in the consistory, mightily waving his arms about in imitation of the flight of a bird! It is not exactly how one would expect to imagine the conduct of this solemn and formal assembly.³¹

The imperial *consistorium* is normally visualised as dominated by formality and protocol. This it no doubt was, but it is clear at the same time that there was another aspect to the conduct of its meetings, as participants get involved in intense exchanges of conversation and dispute, in which matters of substance are under debate, their outcome genuinely in doubt. To judge by Ammianus' descriptions, the meetings might be lively occasions, in which opinions are exchanged without inhibition, an emperor may be criticised and change his mind, and will conduct himself, not with the timeless 'tranquillitas' of much official language and iconography of the period, but with strong emotion, a sense of the needs of a specific situation, and a preparedness for the unexpected.

From the emperor's point of view, ceremonial and protocol offered a positive advantage, in their capacity to function as a mode of defence against over-insistent subjects. The usurper Maximus sought to gain tactical advantage by insisting on receiving in the consistory Ambrose of Milan, who came as envoy from the Italian court of Valentinian II in 384, to ask for the return of the corpse of the murdered Gratian. In his letter to Valentinian on the subject (*Ep.* 24) Ambrose gave an extremely interesting account of the exchanges between himself and Maximus, beginning with a combat of rival forms of protocol when the bishop refused, despite the exhortations of *consistoriani*, to receive the kiss of greeting offered by the emperor. In the exchanges that follow, Maximus at one point 'burst out' angrily ('erupit') in response to a provocative remark by Ambrose, the bishop replying 'gently' ('leniter') before embarking on his prepared speech. Allowance must be made for Ambrose's apologetic purpose in composing his account for Valentinian,

to whom Ambrose had to justify his conduct of the embassy; yet the exchange of opinions, spontaneity and contrasts of manner between the participants in the proceedings are what we have come to anticipate from Ammianus' descriptions of meetings of the consistory.

One wonders whether it was before the assembled *consistorium*, though we are not specifically told this, that another outspoken bishop, Martin of Tours, brought off a notable *coup* over (or under) Valentinian I. Excluded from the palace by Valentinian's order, Martin gained access with the help of an angel after no less than seven days and nights of fasting and prayer. Upon his unexpected appearance in Valentinian's presence, emperor and bishop are, like Ambrose and Maximus, locked in a conflict of dignities. Each refuses to yield to the other, Valentinian by rising to his feet or Martin by doing obeisance to the emperor. The impasse was resolved when Valentinian's throne miraculously burst into flame under him, forcing him abruptly to his feet (Sulpicius Severus, *Dial.* II.5.5f.)! At Martin's first entrance Valentinian is described as 'roaring' ('frendens') his demand to be told how he had come to be admitted. We are left to imagine for ourselves what noise he uttered at the climax of the scene.

Even as described by a hagiographer, seven days and nights of prayer is a considerable tribute to the inaccessibility of the emperor to the most insistent of his subjects, if he should decide that to be in his best interests. Apart from his privileged access to the power of prayer, a courageous or obstinate bishop was in a position to challenge protocol with protocol, to match his dignity against the emperor's. This was however exceptional. In normal circumstances, an emperor might often be glad to use the ceremonious formality of the *consistorium* to bring discussion to a close and maintain his dignity in the presence of his associates; even so, as we have seen, the members of the consistory were quite used to frank exchanges of opinion and substantive discussion of matters of genuine importance. For all his powers as an autocrat and his remoteness, enshrined in protocol and ceremony, an emperor was capable of and accustomed to taking the advice of his associates, and of receiving correction from them.

*

Among the virtues recognised by Ammianus in the Emperor Constantius was his observance of correct principles of good government, notably in his selection of high officials. In this matter he was very sparing and allowed few new increases in administrative powers (21.16.1). Most of the other emperors described by Ammianus merit similar praise. Jovian would have shown good judgment, as was apparent from the few appointments he made in his short reign (25.10.15). Valentinian and Valens were similarly cautious in bestowing high office. Valens indeed was hesitant to a fault in doing so, though it was much to his credit that he allowed no one to claim advantage because of a connection with the

imperial family (31.14.2). Whether this observation is entirely borne out in Ammianus' narrative is open to question (p. 193); this does not affect the importance of the principle as ground for praise in a regime. Valentinian prohibited that common abuse of flourishing bureaucracies, the sale of office – except at the beginning of his reign, a time when, through the distractions of a new emperor and in the hope of impunity, certain improper things do happen (30.9.3).³² Constantius in particular observed one central canon of late Roman government; he restrained the power of the military classes and confined their influence to the spheres proper to them. All officials, military as well as civil, respected the praetorian praefects as the 'summit of all honours' according to the ancient custom; 'honorum omnium apicem priscae reverentiae more praefectos semper suspexere praetorio' (21.16.2). Ammianus cited personal knowledge in affirming that under Constantius no military commander of the rank of *dux* was admitted to the clarissimate, nor was a *magister militum* received by the civil governor on arrival in his province or allowed to interfere in any matter of civil administration – all necessary safeguards in a system open to the extension of improper forms of patronage (21.16.1f.). Of Valentinian on the other hand it is noted that he controlled his minor military officers well but was weak in restraining the powerful; from which ensued disaster in Britain, Africa and Illyricum (30.9.1).

It would not have occurred to Ammianus or his contemporaries to deny the propriety of influence – *suffragium* – in the promotion of perceived and reliable virtue.³³ Indeed, his own early advancement to the rank of *protector domesticus* surely owed something to a personal connection with the *magister militum* Ursicinus (pp. 78ff.). A corrupt or unjust appointment, for Ammianus, was not one in which all possible candidates had failed to be considered before an appointment was made; it was one in which an individual was promoted ahead of the specific claims of a better candidate. On his dismissal from service, Ursicinus was replaced by Agilo, at that time only a tribune. This, thought Ammianus, was an 'excessive leap' to high command; 'Agilone ad eius locum *immodico saltu* promotus ex ... tribuno' (20.2.5). When Julian met at Naissus two senators who had been sent as envoys to Constantius, he passed over the 'better man', Symmachus, and made Valerius Maximus prefect of Rome. This was to please the latter's uncle, the influential Vulcacius Rufinus (21.12.24). There was of course no objection to the proper exploitation of opportunity, such as was provided for instance by participation in an embassy to the emperor. From the point of view of Julian's encounter with them, it was entirely by chance that either senator was at Naissus; it was simply that, of the two men, Julian ought to have chosen Symmachus.³⁴ Ammianus approved entirely of Julian's appointments of three senators, sent to him as envoys to Antioch in 363, to various high offices (23.1.4), and of Vettius Agorius Praetextatus, whom he had earlier happened to find at Constantinople on private business, as proconsul of Achaia. This appointment was specifically attributed by Ammianus to

Julian's personal initiative; 'arbitrio suo'. Julian had evidently found the senator congenial, for obvious reasons given his religious tastes, and Ammianus had no complaint, for Praetextatus was a man of 'true excellence and ancestral gravity'; 'praeclarae indolis gravitatisque senator' (22.7.6). The case of Praetextatus is to be distinguished from such as that of Terentius, a baker from the city of Rome who owed promotion under Valentinian to his successful denunciation of a former prefect of Rome for embezzlement. Terentius' arrival as governor of Tuscia was portended in the town of Pistoria by a donkey that ascended the public tribunal and proceeded to bray loudly, to the amazement of all who saw it (27.3.1f.).

Elsewhere Ammianus shows the system of advancement by patronage at work at lower levels of the political system. The plot against Silvanus was hatched by one Dynamius, an *actuarius*, or accountant, in the imperial baggage department (one imagines him, in different circumstances, checking inventories and lists in preparation for one of the emperor's departures on campaign or on a tour of some frontier region). Dynamius had forged his incriminating letters over Silvanus' signature, having earlier requested from him letters of recommendation to certain friends, which he then retained in the hope that he might one day put them to some ulterior purpose; 'commendaticias ab eo petieret litteras ad amicos, ut quasi familiaris eiusdem esset notissimus' (15.5.3). The ninth book of Symmachus' letters, largely containing just such letters of recommendation, was so labelled by its early editors: 'continens commendaticias' (ed. Seeck, p. 235). Dynamius' action in retaining the letters from Silvanus was not in itself especially remarkable. The papyrus dossier of the travelling official Theophanes mentioned earlier contained two copies of a Latin letter of recommendation from a superior official, probably the *rationalis*, addressed respectively to the governor of Syria and the prefect of Egypt. Theophanes evidently hoped to put them to use as opportunity arose but for some reason never did – for they survive in the dossier.³⁵

No less revealing than the case of Dynamius is Ammianus' account of an unsuccessful case of patronage. One Africanus, who had been a lawyer at Rome, obtained a provincial governorship but wanted to change it for another, no doubt of a more exalted rank. A petition was presented to Valentinian on his behalf by Theodosius, then *magister equitum* at the imperial court and so, one would have thought, a man of unimpeachable influence. The general, who is described by Ammianus as Africanus' 'suffragator', was met with an unexpected reply: 'Go, general, and change his head, since he wishes to change his province!' This, remarked Ammianus, was the end of an eloquent man whose only fault was in hastening, like many, to secure his advancement; 'ad potiora festinans, ut multi' (29.3.6).

It was on the foundations of patronage, or *suffragium*, that cliques and factions were able to form at the imperial court, of men often – though this was not the only criterion – from the same provincial background.

The most obtrusive case presented by Ammianus is that of the Pannonian compatriots of Valentinian, men taken to possess that temperamental brutality exemplified by Maximinus and Leo, successive *vicarii* of Rome. An exception, Viventius from Siscia, is described as an 'honest and wise Pannonian'; 'integer et prudens Pannonius' (27.3.11).³⁶ It is not clear whether Ammianus simply regarded Viventius as unlike other Pannonians whom he knew, or whether he intended to imply that his origin and virtues somehow presented a contradiction in terms. Viventius was certainly an unusual case. He rose to the prefecture of Rome in 367, having been *quaestor sacri palatii*, and so, given the duties of that office in drafting legislation and imperial replies, was a man of some literary cultivation. Maximinus' patronage brought in also Simplicius, a Dalmatian from the city of Emona (modern Ljubljana). Before his elevation to the vicariate, Simplicius had been an adviser of Maximinus; he was a former schoolmaster 'Maximini consiliarius ex grammatico' (28.1.45). Another of Maximinus' promotions was Festus from the north Italian city of Tridentum (Trento), a man in Ammianus' view of the very lowest birth; 'ultimi sanguinis et ignoti' (29.2.22). He reached the peak of his notoriety in the trials conducted by Valens at Antioch; but he too was a man of at least some literary pretension, if one can judge by his modest *Breviarium* of Roman history, dedicated to that emperor in about 370.³⁷

Maximinus' son, Marcellianus, was *dux* of the Pannonian province of Valeria – an appointment that did not turn out very well – while Maximinus himself held the praetorian prefecture of Gaul (29.6.3f.); and a brother of Maximinus, by name Valentinus, having been exiled to Britain for some serious offence, was executed by order of the *magister militum* for subversive conduct there (28.3.3ff.). This family of such varied distinction came from Sopiana (modern Pécs) in Valeria. Ammianus described Maximinus as descended from a refugee Dacian people settled by Diocletian on the Roman side of the Danube; unless he is writing with more imagination than factual material, this will have been after the occupation of Dacia by the Goths (cf. below, p. 318). Maximinus' father had been a minor official (*tabularius*) on the staff of the provincial governor of Valeria, and Maximinus himself had after a modest literary education become an undistinguished pleader of cases at law (28.1.5f.). His career is a paradigm of social mobility in the imperial service, of political influence built up from small beginnings – and, one may add, of native talent obscured by prejudice and laid waste by circumstance.³⁸

Though that of the Pannonians was the most notorious, it was by no means the only provincial cabal to be found, even in the time of Valentinian and Valens. Under the latter emperor there was an outcrop of Cappadocians at the eastern court, men revealed to us not by Ammianus but by the writings of the famous Cappadocian bishops with whom they were connected. In the time of Valentinian there were the 'Galli qui aderant in commilitio principis' who in 367 produced an imperial candidate when Valentinian fell ill and seemed likely to die

(27.6.1).³⁹ This was the *magister memoriae* Julianus Rusticus, who in his later proconsulship of Africa behaved in his province with the 'savage fury of a wild beast' (above, p. 259). He was also a friend of the poet Ausonius and, through him, of Q. Aurelius Symmachus (cf. *Epp.* 1.32; 3.6). Possibly still more remarkable than this variety in his characterisation, is his survival of a period in which he was presented as a possible candidate for the imperial throne. The prominence of Gauls under Valentinian, symbolised if not led by Ausonius, yielded an outright dominance when Valentinian died and was succeeded by his son, the more pliable Gratian. Ausonius is one of the more intriguing omissions from Ammianus' history; his son Hesperius gains a single, purely incidental mention when, as proconsul of Africa under Gratian, he helped produce the report that found in favour of the Lepcitanian upper class against the former *comes Africae* Romanus and his associates (28.6.28; p. 386f.).

It seems likely also that the group of military men and court officials with Spanish connections, whose influence lay behind the selection of Theodosius as imperial candidate after the battle of Hadrianople in 378, had first formed in the time of Valentinian. Its members included Theodosius' father, the famous *magister militum*, and one Cl. Antonius, a relative by marriage who held under Valentinian the office of *quaestor sacri palatii*.⁴⁰ Theodosius himself, 'princeps postea perspectissimus' as Ammianus calls him on his one appearance in the history, was in 373 *dux* of the province of Moesia, evidently benefiting from his father's patronage; he was at that time a mere twenty-six years old (29.6.15). We should also include in the group a Spanish relative (in what degree is not clear), Magnus Maximus, who after serving with the elder Theodosius in Africa (29.5.6; 21) and Britain, declared war against the regime of Gratian while commander in Britain in 383; he was probably hoping for recognition from Theodosius' son, then eastern emperor. The combination of civil and military offices among members of the group, connections of marriage among themselves and with other factions in court circles – and indeed the alternations of good and bad fortune which they suffered – present a pattern not unlike that of the family of the Pannonian Maximinus. He, like the elder Theodosius, was executed in the political turbulence of the time of Gratian, when Theodosius' son thought it prudent to retire to the family estates in Spain (28.1.57; cf. p. 382).

Viewing the possibilities in another perspective, one wonders about the group of Africans (a good half-dozen of them, including relatives and the women of the group) surrounding the orator of Milan Augustine at the court of Valentinian II.⁴¹ Augustine himself, the son of a modest *curialis* from Thagaste in Numidia, had been educated at Madauros and Carthage. He had practised rhetoric at Thagaste, and at Carthage and Rome, and was then recommended to the city of Milan by the *praefectus urbi* Symmachus, having delivered a sample oration before him (*Conf.* 5.23). His fellow-townsmen Romanianus was a wealthy citizen of Thagaste – he was a generous benefactor of that city – now in Italy to

pursue litigation (6.24). Another member of the group, Alypius, who came from a town near Carthage, gained appointment as an assessor on the staff of the Italian department of the *comes sacrarum largitionum* (6.16), and Augustine himself was able to contemplate an advantageous marriage arranged by his mother, and the prospect of a provincial governorship (6.19; 23ff.). At one point the group was visited by a fellow-African, an *agens in rebus* named Ponticianus, who came to them with tales of life at another great imperial capital, Trier (8.14ff.).⁴² It was this arrival that with other events turned the minds of Augustine and his friends from politics and secular concerns. But for this, we can reasonably ask whether, had any of the more important members of the group – Augustine himself, Romanianus, Alypius – been offered an opportunity and broken through to a position of real political influence, we might have found ourselves able to talk of a ‘faction of Africans’ at the court of Valentinian II, as the recipient of good fortune took good care to spread it more widely among his friends. But this is a remote contingency; more likely the party, had it remained in politics, would like most others have done so obscurely and on the fringes of court life – in the spreading foothills, as it were, of the bureaucracy. In those regions took place a vast, largely unsung competition for small advantage and minor promotion. At any time a man might, through random opportunity but at some danger to himself, ascend near the very summit of the system from an origin hidden in its lower reaches; but these – men like Maximinus, Leo, or some of the great praetorian prefects recorded by Ammianus – are a tiny proportion of the total numbers of those who worked in the imperial service. It is at the same time clear that considerable power and influence were exercised at much lower levels of the system, and Ammianus’ narrative is remarkable for what it shows of this, and of the workings of patronage and favour at all levels, not merely the highest, of the apparatus of government.

In contemporary eyes, the most scandalous case of improper influence at the imperial court among those described by Ammianus was that of Constantius’ eunuchs.⁴³ Ammianus viewed this aspect of the late Roman system with undisguised prejudice. He shared the conventional notion, much aired in rhetoric, that the absence of normal sexual and family affections disposed eunuchs, in compensation, to an overwhelming love of riches, ‘which they embrace, as if they were their little daughters’ (18.5.4). ‘Lizards and toads’, bishop Basil of Caesarea called eunuchs, in a rhetorical onslaught on their character of a most un-Christian ferocity (*Ep.* 115); while legislation issued in the name of Arcadius described the influence of Eutropius, who had disgraced the consulship, as the ‘stigma of our age’, the sight of whose portraits might ‘pollute the sight of those who look at them’, and so on (*CTh* 9.40.17, of 399). Such imagery is a pale reflection of the abuse poured on Eutropius by Claudian in his long poem of 399 denouncing the eunuch. At the head of Constantius’ palace eunuchs was the *praepositus sacri cubiculi* Eusebius ‘with whom, if the truth may be told, Constantius possessed much influence’, as Ammianus

remarked in a memorable expression; 'apud quem, si vere dici debeat, multa Constantius potuit' (18.4.3).⁴⁴ Eusebius' activities were, indeed, manifold and delicate, requiring both subtlety of touch and confidentiality. Ammianus records how in 354 he averted a revolt in the Gallic army by judicious payments to the ringleaders (14.10.5). Earlier in his career it was maintained that he had in 337 concealed the will of Constantine the Great, and that through him the Arians had first won over Constantius to their cause; through him also that they later plotted against Athanasius of Alexandria. These are rather unlikely, and certainly polemical, allegations. Better founded are his role in negotiations between Constantius and the Catholic bishop of Rome, Liberius, in 354 and, in the same year, his appearance at Pola as one of the judges of Gallus Caesar (14.11.21).⁴⁵ The death sentence passed on Eusebius himself at the trials of Chalcedon in 361 was welcomed by Ammianus as the belated operation of all-seeing Justice (22.3.12). He had devoted his influence to enriching himself (16.8.13), and to harming others by weaving webs of calumny and suspicion (14.11.2). In particular, he had prejudiced Constantius' receptive ears against the excellent Ursicinus, Ammianus' patron.

With Eusebius very much in his mind, Ammianus referred favourably to a law of Domitian prohibiting castration; but for this, he wondered how mankind could have borne the swarms of eunuchs that would have existed, when even their relative rarity was so hard to bear (18.4.4)! His view implies both prejudice and excessive faith in the influence of legislation in the field of social control; and Ammianus should in any case have conceded that the presence of eunuchs was not a mere personal failing of some emperors, but a normal aspect of the imperial office of the period. Ammianus mentions eunuchs also in the personal entourage of Valens (30.4.2; 31.13.12), and the eunuch *praepositi* assigned by their emperors to the Caesars Constans, Gallus and Julian, by name Gorgonius (15.2.10) and Eutherius (16.7.1ff.). The former was guilty as an instigator of Gallus' crimes, from the consequences of which he was protected after Gallus' fall, in an interesting exercise of group solidarity, by the concerted action of the other eunuchs in court service (15.2.10). Eutherius on the other hand provided Ammianus with material for a digression showing how, by way of a preternatural exception to the normal rule, there might be such a thing as a good eunuch. Even a wild beast, he reflected in a passing allusion to a range of metaphors much used elsewhere, may be tamed, and a rose grow among thorns (16.7.4)! Brought into the empire in childhood from Armenia – eunuchs were imported from the east as castrated children – Eutherius advanced at the court of Constantine the Great by his sharpness of intelligence and phenomenal memory (16.7.5). Appointed to the staff of Constans, he would have restrained that Caesar's excesses had he been listened to, just as he corrected the excessively 'Asiatic' manners and inconsistency of Julian; and he loyally defended Julian when he was criticised at court by one of the generals set over him by Constantius. This is the occasion when

the general Marcellus is glimpsed in the *consistorium*, flapping his arms like the wings of a mighty bird (above, p. 268).

In their employment of eunuchs, the emperors were reflecting, if they were not initiating, a more general custom in aristocratic Roman society. Ammianus described how Roman matrons were attended in public by columns of eunuchs, ranged young and old in order of age; 'multitudo spadonum, a senibus in pueros desinens' (14.6.17): it is a facet of social conduct mentioned also by Jerome, in an exhortatory letter to a young ascetic devotee, telling her what contemporary forms of conduct she should avoid (*Ep.* 22.16). A single reference in Ammianus specifying the 'adulti', the grown-up eunuchs at the imperial court (18.4.4), shows by implication that here, too, were cadet eunuchs, awaiting their turn in palace training establishments to serve the emperors' and empresses' private domestic needs and to become their confidants.

The importance of the eunuchs in late Roman court life may be viewed in various ways. They may, it has been suggested, have functioned as a 'lubricant' at points of friction in the late Roman system of government, popular distaste for their physical deformity enabling them to absorb resentment between conflicting interests at the imperial court and thereby to avert the weakening of the structure that would otherwise have ensued.⁴⁶ Though this is a rather schematic view, there is much to be said for it. To 'personalise' differences of opinion by assigning them to envy or dislike has the salutary effect of neutralising, of rendering subject to social control, what might otherwise be divisive issues of principle.⁴⁷ To make an enemy of a court eunuch might pose short-term difficulties, but, given the traditionally envious character of that breed and the relative insecurity of their power, it need neither reflect badly on oneself nor have damaging permanent consequences. From the emperors' standpoint, the eunuchs were a group among their supporters with whom they were able to establish confidential personal relations without the risk of their being able to form dynasties of officials occupying the most sensitive and intimate positions of power – an advantage the emperors will have appreciated the more keenly, the more they made themselves inaccessible to other sources of advice. The most convincing explanation is in a combination of these factors. The sexual indifference of eunuchs enabled them, in an age of high official morality (above, p. 262), to serve emperors and empresses in their most intimate personal and domestic requirements without suspicion of impropriety; while their physical condition, by convention repulsive to most Romans, and their lack of family connections, rendered them unable to transform their personal intimacy with the emperors into a firmly based and lasting political influence.

Eunuchs were able to dispose as they wished of the wealth and property they had acquired through their influence (*CJ* 6.22.5, of 352), and there is no denying the reality of this influence, at least in the limited sphere of court politics, while it lasted.⁴⁸ They were sometimes able, like Eutherius, to win for themselves a respected social position – though this,

in Ammianus' view, was an exception, most eunuchs hiding themselves away 'like bats' from the eyes of an offended public (16.7.7). But their position was unlike that of the founders of the great dynasties whose growth and consolidation through political influence is a central aspect of this as of any other period of Roman history – men such as Constantius' praetorian prefect Fl. Philippus, mentioned once by Ammianus (19.12.9), a new politician whose virtues of industry, loyalty and vigilance in the emperor's service are elaborately praised by Constantius in an inscription in his honour, and whose descendants formed one of the great senatorial dynasties of later fourth- and fifth-century Constantinople.⁴⁹ The eunuchs did not bring to political life the interests of any great families to which they belonged; it was the essence of their position that they came into the empire from outside in childhood, grew up and were trained in the imperial palace, and lacked known family connections, with all that this implies as to the intrusion of entrenched forms of influence into the imperial administration.

Ammianus gives a classic example of this form of influence in his description of the senator Sex. Petronius Probus, who died in about 390 after holding four praetorian prefectures and, in 371, the consulship; he was a rare exception to Valentinian's almost exclusive promotion of the military, and members of his own family, to this supreme office. Ammianus' account of Probus is justly admired both for its portrayal of personal ambition and character, and (less commonly) for its exact appreciation of the 'structural' aspects of his position as representing the interests of a great senatorial family at the imperial court (27.11.1-6).⁵⁰ Probus' yearning for political power left him miserable – as Ammianus says, gasping like a fish out of its natural element – when deprived of it. Yet even while enjoying the peak of wealth and political power he was always anxious and troubled and suffered 'therefore' (Ammianus makes just this connection) from minor illnesses; '*ideoque semper levibus morbis adfectus*' (27.11.6). Overbearing to the weak, Probus was easily intimidated by those who stood up to him, and, depending on whether he was confident or afraid, varied in manner between extremes of arrogance and humility. Never the man to instruct a client or slave to commit anything illegal, he would nevertheless support them through thick and thin, and with no regard for right and wrong, if they were caught in illegal acts of their own devising (27.11.4). He possessed immense power as long as he lived, by the scale of his largesse, and by holding continuous prefectures; '*largiendo et intervallando potestates assiduas*'. Into these he was forced, says Ammianus in a penetrating phrase, by the insistence of the senatorial clans to which he belonged and which pursued unrelentingly their quest for ever-greater possessions, never innocent in their immense acquisitiveness; '*familiarum ... numquam innocentium per cupiditates immensas*'.⁵¹ It was to preserve their impunity in doing so that they immersed their 'master' ('*dominum suum*') in affairs of state (27.11.3). Ammianus does not deny that Probus possessed huge wealth 'throughout almost the whole Roman world', on the justice of which he

affects to reserve judgment; 'iuste an secus, non iudicioli est nostri' (27.11.1). Yet the most striking aspect of his presentation of Probus' influence is in his location of the initiative for his public career, not so much with Probus himself as with the families whom he represented. One of the 'familiae' in question, the Anicii, had already arisen in Ammianus' narrative. They were mentioned, in an unfortunately damaged passage of the text, among those who benefited from Constantius' enrichment of his associates at the expense of the provinces, Constantine the Great having set the pattern by 'opening the jaws' of his supporters. These members of the latter-day nobility, Ammianus seems to have said, in trying to match their famous ancestors were never content with what they had, though their possessions were actually far greater; 'satiari numquam potuit, cum possessione multo maiore' (16.8.12f.).⁵²

It is significant, and may be deliberate on Ammianus' part, that he presents the economic ambitions of the Anicii at a point in his text before he comes to the personal political ambition of their 'dominus' in the next generation. The modern historian will surely agree with him, in seeing Petronius Probus not merely as an example of personal power, but as the representative of aristocratic influence on an imperial regime that required the support of the landed classes in order to survive, and was then unable to break free of the political influence to which their dependence exposed them. Valentinian was astonished to learn from a provincial ambassador of the extent of Probus' depredations in Illyricum, but was obliged to proceed against him with such circumspection that he was unable to remove him before his own death (30.5.10).⁵³ It is an ominous sign of the ascendancy which, despite their apparent political subjection, the great landed families enjoyed in the late empire, and which enabled the strongest of them to survive into the fifth and sixth centuries, long after the power of the Roman emperors had declined and, in the end, had been replaced by that of barbarian kings.

CHAPTER XIII

The Practice of War

The central characters of Ammianus' history are the emperors and their supporters. That its central subject is war is obvious, defies summary and requires little explanation. It is clear not only in the narrative emphasis given to the subject, which far outweighs any other in the text, but in the deployment of some of Ammianus' most substantial digressions – on Gaul and Persia (among his longest), on Thrace, on Huns and Alans and, preceding Julian's Persian campaign, on artillery and siege machinery. All are presented as relevant to war, an emphasis which is not simply a matter of Ammianus' own background and experience, but of the place of war in the Roman mind.¹

If war is at all times an expression and a determinant of social organisation, in the case of the Romans of all people, war, and the systematic application of its results, were the specific achievement of their social order, and the central feature of their history and ideology. For Ammianus, the subjection by Rome of 'proud and savage nations' was the precondition for her gift of laws, the 'eternal foundations of liberty', to the peoples of her empire; 'post superbas efferatarum gentium cervices oppressas, latasque leges, fundamenta libertatis et retinacula sempiterna' (14.6.5). The process, beginning with the 'circummurana bella' of early Rome and the conquest of her local enemies, had passed in her maturity through the expansion of Roman power in the Mediterranean and the north, to the defence of the massive, embattled system of empire that Ammianus knew, while Rome and her senate grew old in tranquillity.² It was to maintain this condition of sustained and necessary war that Rome had in advanced years transferred her inheritance to the Caesars, 'as to her children', being content to conquer from time to time, in Ammianus' day, 'by name alone'; 'nomine solo aliquotiens vincens' (14.6.4).

Apart from their contemporary application, there is nothing very original in these sentiments. They are reminiscent of, and may be intended to evoke, Vergil's famous lines written four centuries earlier, conceding to 'others' (that is, to Greeks) the finer things of life and reserving for Rome the arts of government and war and a more solemn duty, the imposition of peace and the subjection of pride:

tu regere imperio populos, Romane, memento
 (hae tibi erunt artes), pacisque imponere morem,
 parcere subiectis et debellare superbos. (*Aen.* 6.851-3)

For Ammianus, the eternity of empire was symbolised by the eternity of Rome, expressed in a sort of providential pun, 'victura, dum homines erunt, Roma' (14.6.3). 'Victura': 'which will live'? – or 'which will conquer'? – as long as there are men; Ammianus can hardly have been unaware of, or failed to intend, the ambiguity. There is also an irony in the historical pattern, one known to Ammianus no more than to Vergil, in fact beyond all but the most speculative of fourth-century visions. Just as the history of Rome began with 'circummurana bella' against her Latin neighbours, so it was with 'circummurana bella', the sieges of Alaric the Visigoth in 408-410 and of Geiseric the Vandal in 455 that it would come full circle, survival in Italy replacing foreign conquest as her main preoccupation. In a final irony, the arts of government and war were left to the Byzantines, those 'Greeks' to whom Vergil would have denied them; but that part of Vergil's prophecy – it has rather been seen as a renunciation – was already falsified by the second century.³

The dominance of war, with all that this implies, in Greek and Roman historiography had been established by its founders, Herodotus and Thucydides, in the first case in terms of the cultural identity in defence of which the Greeks overcame their weaknesses and went to war against barbarians, in the second for its exposure of the deepest truths about human nature and society. By the time that Livy had documented the emergence of Rome in the Italian peninsula and Polybius the growth of Roman power in the eastern Mediterranean, the centrality of war had been established in such a way that no future historian would be able to ignore; or, if he did so, it was by adopting a new genre of writing, the biographical, against which, whether (in its various forms) philosophical, erudite, or scandalous, Ammianus firmly set his face (p. 459). For the traditional historian an age without war would be, as Gibbon wrote of the reign of Antoninus Pius, an age without history.⁴

For the Roman, war was then a cultural and a historiographical issue of central importance, in both respects as a legitimate expression of his culture. The converse of this observation is that war and warfare, as the proper subject of history, are to be described in the literary manner appropriate for the broader cultivated audience; that is to say without undue use of technical language. Ammianus' expression in his epilogue that he had written 'as a soldier and a Greek' can be read on many levels, of apology and of justification. One of the latter is surely that he had felt entitled, in his choice of history as a mode of writing, to subject military history to the conventions of a literary style.

Apart from its cultural and historiographical role, no one will doubt the actual significance of war in the structure of the late Roman state and the preoccupations of its rulers. One might even define the state, without gross exaggeration, as a system for the financing of war. Finance and taxation are not in themselves enticing subjects for a historian with

Classical literary ambitions. That is no reason to exclude them as they arise, however, and Ammianus is too circumstantial a writer not to allow them their relevance to the events he describes. We saw how the comment of the *comes sacrarum largitionum* Ursulus before the ruins of Amida earned him the enmity of the military classes and his execution at the trials of Chalcedon;⁵ he contrasted what he saw as the lack of spirit with which the military were defending the cities with the economic exhaustion of the empire in face of the military budget; 'en quibus animis urbes a milite defenduntur, cui ut abundare stipendium possit, imperii opes iam fatiscunt' (20.11.5). The vast expenditure of Julian on the Persian campaign was argued by some to justify the financial severity of Valentinian, again with reference to the need to provide soldiers' pay, 'ut militi supplementa suppetere et stipendium' (30.8.8). The same justification is not explicitly offered for Valens, although it could have been, for the cost of the Persian campaign fell both on east and west, and Valens too was known, at least initially, for the harshness of his financial exactions (p. 193). When at the end of his reign Valens was persuaded to accept the settlement of Goths in the Roman empire, he was attracted by the argument that with these new recruits he could cease to levy peasants for military service, taking cash in lieu from landowners who had had to supply men. Although Ammianus presents this as an argument offered by court sycophants to please the emperor, it is in the circumstances of the late Roman state an extremely important consideration (31.4.4). Manpower was a constant problem, and the claims of military need and agricultural production were not always easy to reconcile; given the frequent comment that the Roman empire suffered from an excess of idle mouths, it is hard to blame an emperor for trying to turn consumers into producers, to return the peasantry to the land and recruit soldiers from outside the system.

The relationship between taxation and war, explicitly stated in these passages, is implied in all references to the furnishing and transport of supplies, and to such matters as the billeting of troops in local communities. Julian's soldiers at Antioch were not only responsible for disgraceful scenes as they were carried through the streets to their lodgings drunk and incapable (22.12.6); they were unedifying beneficiaries of another of the many varieties of direct taxation in the late Roman state. Further, the presence at Antioch of many thousands of extra mouths to feed, of people connected with the court and army, had an adverse effect on two occasions in the mid-fourth century upon the food supply of the city, leading to shortages affecting the local population, and to civic unrest (p. 409). An issue of taxation lies behind the dispute between the *comes Africae* Romanus and the citizens of Tripolitania who requested his help against the inroads of desert tribesmen. Romanus demanded 4,000 camels before he would undertake the campaign, and departed without offering help when they were not provided (28.6.5f.). The demand seems, and perhaps was, excessive, but inscriptions have shown the obligation, going back to the time of Constantine, of

landowners in the vicinity of the Roman frontier in Africa to provide it with supplies.⁶ We cannot say how conscientiously the obligation had been met in a period of peace for the province – a law on the subject addressed in 365 to the *vicarius Africae* ominously mentions collusion by ‘*tabularii*’ (CTh 11.1.11) – nor whether the provision of camels had ever been envisaged rather than simply supplies of grain; but it is by no means impossible that Romanus, in making his demand, was reminding the provincials of years of neglect of their legal obligations. Initially supported by the emperors (CTh 11.1.11) and of course by his soldiers in the province (28.6.23), he maintained his innocence to the end of the affair, and claimed that the enquiry which ultimately closed it was biased in favour of the provincials (28.6.29). Modern historians, excited by the episode as a case study of corruption in the late Roman administration, have been reluctant to consider it from the commander’s point of view.⁷ Circumstances were different when the *magister militum* Theodosius promised to support his campaign against the rebel Firmus by using the enemy’s own resources; his announcement was greeted with gladness by the landowners of the region: ‘*laetitia possessorum*’ (29.5.11). The expression is significant for what it implies of the alternative, the requisitioning of supplies from ‘*possessores*’ and the widening of the gulf of economic interest between the landowning and military classes.

Roman generals naturally supported themselves, when they could, on the profits of their campaigns. It was a frequent preoccupation of Julian in his Alamannic wars – sometimes frustrated by circumstances or errors of judgment, as when his attack was made so early in the year that the crops in barbarian country were not ripe for Roman use (17.9.2f.). Otherwise grain supplies – the product of taxation – were brought to the German front from Aquitania and from Britain, and (in the latter case) stored in granaries rebuilt by Julian (17.8.1; 18.2.3f.). It was clearly for reasons of supply rather than military capability in the narrow sense that the normal campaigning season in the north-west began only in July (17.8.1). Supplies for campaigns, as is obvious, had to be arranged to make sure they were adequate for predictable contingencies, depots set up and properly guarded, and severe penalties threatened (the Theodosian Code is full of examples) to inhibit the massive opportunities that existed for maladministration. Ammianus tells of a minor official executed by the praetorian prefect of the east (who was in charge of taxation and supply) because some supplies promised by him for the Persian campaign of Julian had not arrived when he said they would; they turned up the following day, too late to save the poor man’s life (23.5.6). The Persian campaign needs no special mention at this point. Apart from the thousand or more ships devoted to the transport of supplies, weaponry and siege machinery, stockpiles were laid down for the army’s use along its routes of advance into and predicted withdrawal from Assyria. Supplies were also taken as opportunity arose from captured fortresses, and from Persian lands not damaged by flooding or fire. It was the latter, together with constant harassment in the districts

east of the Tigris, that reduced the Roman army to extremes of starvation on its journey home, until they were met by an army bringing provisions from Roman Mesopotamia (p. 186).

That the role of the emperors was in the first instance a military one is made clear at all turns of Ammianus' narrative. The military setting dominates their lives, from their earlier careers, their selection by cabals of officers, their presentation to and acclamation by the assembled troops, through the events of reigns spent tramping the frontiers of empire from one scene of warfare to another, to their deaths in camp (or in battle) and escort for burial by squads of selected officers. What is true of legitimate emperors is also true of usurpers, whether (like Julian and Procopius) they are proclaimed by soldiers, in camp or passing through at a timely moment, whether in the end (like Silvanus) they are murdered by troops suborned for the purpose or (like Procopius) are abandoned by them on the field of battle.

It is natural to find military expertise among the central virtues, and a deficiency of it among the shortcomings, of the emperors described by Ammianus. 'Scientia rei militaris' was the first of the practical virtues assigned to Julian in his obituary, ranging in specific terms from his skill at siege warfare and arranging lines of battle, to the selection of safe places for encampments and the posting of advance (or frontier) guards and pickets (25.4.11). It was a measure of Julian's 'fortitudo' (the last of the cardinal virtues assigned to him, immediately preceding military knowledge in the text) that he was willing to expose himself to danger in the front line of battle, and of his 'auctoritas' that because he shared the dangers faced by his men he could discipline cowards, control his soldiers even when (because of Constantius' policy to him) he had no pay to give them, and raise their morale by addressing them in speeches (25.4.10; 12f.). The survey which introduces the obituary of Valentinian concerns his suppression of the various military threats posed to the Roman empire, beginning with his fortification of strongholds and cities on the Rhine frontier and his increase in the military establishment there against the threat of the Alamanni (30.7.5ff.): in addition to which, he was excellent in preserving military discipline and most skilled in the practice of war (30.9.1; 4). He also invented new kinds of military equipment (30.9.4). The reference in this passage to the maintenance of frontier defence recalls Ammianus' statement, under the year 369, that Valentinian re-fortified the entire Rhine frontier from Raetia to the North Sea with camps, forts and watch-towers (28.2.1).⁸ Ammianus thereby sets out under a single year the policy of Valentinian's entire reign, shown also by epigraphic and archaeological evidence on the middle Danube frontier – though only once mentioned for this region by Ammianus, in explanation of Valentinian's wars against the Quadi (29.6.3f.). All this was a 'great and useful enterprise' of Valentinian's; 'magna animo concipiens et utilia' (28.2.1). Ammianus' judgment is supported by a careful and very interesting description of the construction of a fort on the banks of the river Neckar by the efforts of soldiers and hydraulic

engineers, with the emperor's personal encouragement. At times the men had to work chin-deep in the water in order to secure the piles on which the fort rested (28.2.2-4).

Although it was among Valentinian's virtues that he was a strict guardian of military discipline, it could be said against him that this was more evident in his treatment of the lower ranks, the emperor allowing complaints against the high-ranking to go unchecked (30.9.1): whether Ammianus has in mind more than the specific cases of Romanus in Africa and of Marcellianus the son of Maximinus in Valeria (for his inhospitable murder of king Gabinius of the Quadi) is not clear, but he remarks elsewhere as a general truth that Valentinian was the first emperor to raise the military to a pitch of untrammelled insolence, to the detriment of the common interest (27.9.4). It was of course difficult, given their awareness of their own importance, to keep the military in check, but Constantius had achieved it, maintaining a strict separation between military and civil powers and – a point Ammianus could certify from his personal knowledge – always confining 'duces' to the rank of 'perfectissimus'; he did not allow them to achieve senatorial rank (21.16.2).

The separation both in central bureaucracy and in provincial administration of civil and military powers, is a hallmark of the late imperial system. The process, described in Chapter XI (p. 248f.) in connection with the growth of ceremony as a mode of communication between the new military ruling classes and a civilian society from which they were potentially alienated, has many implications for the reading of Ammianus, and for the general understanding of the Roman empire of the fourth century. As far as concerns Ammianus, it has meant that the vast amount of evidence which he provides for the military power-structure and personnel of the empire has tended to be studied in terms of the specialist history of the late Roman army and high command rather than for its more general interest.⁹ As for the late empire itself, the polarisation of social classes and culture implied by this specialisation is well illustrated by the visit to the court of Valentinian in 369-370 of the senatorial orator and envoy, Q. Aurelius Symmachus. The episode is not mentioned by Ammianus, and there is no particular reason why it should be, though there is an intriguing convergence in the fact that the year of Symmachus' journey to Trier was also that under which Ammianus placed his general assessment of Valentinian's frontier policy in the north (28.2.1ff.): almost as if it had somehow been agreed that this would be an appropriate year in which to commemorate this aspect of the emperor's work.

Symmachus attended court to present to the emperor the anniversary gold voted by the senate to celebrate the completion of his first quinquennium in power, and (politely passing over the cost to the senate) to express hopes of more.¹⁰ His second panegyric, addressed to Valentinian on New Year's Day 370, can be compared with the history of Ammianus for its explicit and detailed recognition, rare in a civilian

writer, of the military aspects of Valentinian's government. One reads in this panegyric the sorts of thing that constantly occur in Ammianus: fortified posts, bridgeheads and landing-stages built, river-fleets equipped, Alamann tribesmen settled on the land, Burgundian embassies received with petitions of peace, forays into unsafe barbarian country. Symmachus, like Ammianus, described the emperor's personal contribution to the building of a new fort at the junction of two rivers (*Or.* 2.18ff.). On topographical grounds, this should be a different fort from that described by Ammianus, again lending support to the notion that there was some calculation of a public response in the presentation of Valentinian's policy, as the emperor symbolically associated himself, surveying instruments in hand, with its implementation. Symmachus departed from Trier with the honorary rank of 'comes ordinis tertii' and could refer in a letter to a court friend, the poet Ausonius (and be similarly flattered in reply), to the days when he had 'attended the imperial standards', and to the fine dinners they had enjoyed when they had been together 'at headquarters' in the frontier region (*Epp.* 1.14; 32; cf. Ausonius, *Griphus*, praef.). Ausonius, in his best and most famous poem, the *Mosella*, describes a journey made while returning from campaign with the emperor, from Bingen via Neumagen to Trier, and composed two epigrams in honour of the sources of the Danube in territory once, but no longer, held by the Romans (*Epigr.* 28, 31). The 'discovery' of the Danube sources, allegedly 'unknown in Roman annals' (*Mosella* 424), by a Roman visiting party corresponds with the rebuilding by Julian of a 'Trajanic fort' beyond the frontier, described by Ammianus (17.1.11f.), and with the visit, mentioned also by Symmachus in his second panegyric, to the Roman 'ghost town' of Lopodunum (Ladenburg), in an area of earlier occupation long since abandoned (*Mosella* 423; *Or.* 2.16). In a strange glimpse of a 'post-Roman' future in the west (below, p. 308f.), remains of its buildings and inscriptions could still be seen there; 'Romanae coloniae antiqua vestigia et tituli' (*Or.* 2.16). Valentinian could have restored the city, but preferred not to, being content with the implication, suitably conveyed by Symmachus, that it had been unwisely founded in the first place!

Such documents are more than unreal attempts to associate their writers with a world of warfare and action to which they did not belong. They are part also of the efforts made by remote and ill-understood military rulers to represent themselves and their activities favourably to a civilian society on whose financial resources their continued efforts depended, and in whose interests they undertook them. After his reception at court and promotion there (known most explicitly from his inscriptions, and so clearly a source of pride to him) Symmachus was no doubt intended to convey to the senate the reassurance that the emperor was indeed devoting his crown gold and the proceeds of other taxation to the defence of the frontiers of the empire. In Symmachus' speeches, delivered and circulated at Rome, senators could hear and read accounts of the background and earlier career of their emperor, and of the virtues